



ANGLIA RUSKIN UNIVERSITY

FACULTY OF BUSINESS AND LAW

Exploring CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing: Evidence from UK SMEs

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A thesis in fulfilment of the requirements of Anglia Ruskin
University for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy

Submitted: 18th July 2024

Acknowledgement

My eyes used to glaze when I read the writers' acknowledgement, but that was just before I had written this valuable piece of research, which would not have been possible without support. Undertaking a PhD in Fintech with considerable substantial working experience in education management and distinctive grades in my previous degrees was an ever-challenging but exciting experience. Besides the knowledge I gained from PhD, I also learned how to think critically and independently, cope with pressure situations, self-assess and improve, and maintain the balance of work and study to ensure successful completion of the project.

First of all, I would like to express my sincere gratitude to Dr Ying Wang – my PhD supervisor, for her continuous support over the past five years, from the development of the research topic and timely review of work with encouraging and constructive feedback. I had an opportunity to learn from Dr Ying's immense knowledge through great discussions in our frequent meetings. I would like to dedicate this research to Dr Ying Wang and keep the sound knowledge that I have gained for the rest of my life to become a successful entrepreneur.

I would also like to thank our faculty PGR team for arranging panels for key milestones. I met with various panel members for insightful comments that motivated me to work during my PT PhD journey. I am deeply grateful and thankful to Professor Chris Land and Dr John Webb, particularly Dr Ying Wang, for providing their time on my draft thesis and critically reviewing my thesis, whose invaluable suggestions have significantly helped me to improve on my thesis.

Specially, I thank all the participants of this research, who voluntarily helped to participate in this study. This research could not reach its aims without them. I believe if they read this in the future, they will appreciate my findings and the level of ethical professionalism to produce useful knowledge.

Finally, I am thankful to my family for keeping me motivated with their encouraging gesture, comments and allowing me sufficient time to study without interruption. Special thanks to my mother, who always prays for my career, progress and health. I am grateful to all those people who encouraged and supported my study.

Abstract

The recent COVID-19, Brexit and current inflation made access to credit harder for UK SMEs. The innovation in financial services such as financial technology (Fintech) designed to redefine the delivery of financial services which dramatically influence and transmute the financing system. However, how CEOs make their Fintech financing decisions is not fully investigated. This research aims to fill in this gap.

To capture different characteristics of CEOs, this research interviewed 20 CEOs from UK SMEs to explore CEOs' Fintech financing decision at the individual (micro), organisational (meso) and country (macro) levels. Results, supported by the cognitive theory of decision-making, confirm that CEOs make rational decisions and significantly rely on their leadership attributes to choose the best financing option for the benefit of their organisations. Results support the pecking order theory of financing indicate that CEOs prefer Fintech financing due to its flexibility in funding options, low costs and fewer regulations. Further findings suggest that the effects of micro factors on CEOs, such as family, vision, values, education level and prior experience, positively support CEOs to make Fintech decisions. Interestingly, at the meso level, results indicate that CEOs' networking and the board's collective decisions play an important role in Fintech decision-making. In addition, the organic organisational structure stimulates Fintech financing. Lastly, the complexities of macro factors to navigate CEOs in their Fintech financing decisions uncovered that there is no specific Fintech law, forum or guidelines from the government to create awareness.

This research contributes to the extant knowledge by providing compelling evidence that most SME CEOs make rational decisions, underpinned by their transformational leadership approach, which are influenced by factors at the micro, meso and macro levels. These findings provide insights to government policies, International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the World Bank initiatives aimed at fostering innovation in finance.

Keywords: Financial Technology (Fintech), CEO Leadership, SMEs, decision making, Financial Regulations

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List of Abbreviations

AI – Artificial Intelligence

CEO – Chief Executive Officer

CRM – Customer Relationship Management

SME – Small and Medium Enterprise

Fintech – Financial Technology

OBIE - Open Banking Implementation Entity

PSR - Payments Systems Regulator

P2P – Peer to Peer Lending

RQ – Research Question

IMF - International Monetary Funds

GDP – Gross Domestic Product

IoT - internet of things

BNPL - Buy Now Pay Later

FCA - Financial Conduct Authority

ICO - initial coin offering

DLTs - Distributed Ledger Technologies

OECD - Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development

P – Participant of this research

HMRC - HM Revenue and Customs

Declaration

I confirm that the thesis is all my own work and does not include any work completed by anyone other than myself. I also confirm that any sources of information are clearly acknowledged by using recommended referencing system.

Signed: *Arsalan*

1. Introduction

Fintech is designed to redefine the delivery of financial services using technology with better, decentralised and efficient business models (Godfrey, 2018; Mention, 2019; Suryono, et al., 2020). The technological advancement has transformed the financial sector (Yan, et al., 2021). Fintech has eased access to financial services through online payments, savings and investments, mobile financial services, crowdfunding, and peer-to-peer lending (Mention, 2019; Suryono, et al., 2020; Yan, et al., 2021). Factors such as rapid evolution in technology, performance expectation, security perception, price value, changing consumer expectations, and government regulations influence the adoption of Fintech in SMEs (Jayalath & Premarathne, 2021; Najib, et al., 2021; Moreira-Santos, et al., 2022). The FinTech market has grown around the world during the last decade. In the UK only, the FinTech adoption rate is 42% compared to 33% in the rest of the world (Department for International Trade, 2019). China, India, the UK, Brazil, and the USA are among the early adopters of FinTech worldwide (Bloomberg News, 2019). Fintech, through lower operational costs and increased convenience (Chuen, et al., 2015; Arner, et al., 2015), is massively revolutionising how financial services are conducted. Evidence suggests an emergence of FinTech in the global market (Wei, 2017; Sung, et al., 2019; Ghazali & Yasuoka, 2018; Huei, et al., 2018; Haddad & Hornuf, 2019).

The innovative features of blockchain technology as effective security measures to safeguard customers' privacy (Ducas & Wilner, 2017; Saimima & Patria, 2021; Aldboush & Ferdous, 2023) is central to the growth of FinTech include cryptocurrencies, crowdfunding, and peer-to-peer (P2P) lending (Philippon, 2016). Evidence from the growth trend suggests that FinTech has become one of the main players as an alternative source of funds for SMEs to fulfil their business funding needs. For example, Peer to Peer (P2P) lending, serving as online platforms that unite lenders and borrowers, is one of the applications of FinTech to offer digital financial solutions (Arjunwadkar, 2018; Hamarat & Broby, 2022; Gu et al., 2022). With a potential growth of 1.6% in 2023, reaching a total value of £376.6 million (Gaw, 2023), the

innovative platforms link up potential investors with individuals seeking finance needs (Mattarocci & Gibilaro, 2016; Yan & Zhou, 2023). Crowdfunding is a collective process where individuals pool resources or funds through online sites to support an organisation or a project (Arjunwadkar, 2018; Bao, et al., 2022). The resources and the people are mobilised to achieve a given objective, such as equity capital, donation, start-up capital, etc. (Mohamed & Ali, 2019). Crowdfunding is also known as social media fundraising since the entire fund generation process occurs through an online platform (Lynn, et al., 2019). Crowdfunding covers the various donation, equity and loan-based online models (FCA, 2023). The more commonly used crowdfunding for SMEs is equity-based, where the crowd funders invest to seek a potential return on the business shares in exchange for equity (Arjunwadkar, 2018; Chu et al., 2017). Equity-based crowdfunding is widely used by SMEs in the UK (Wachira & Wachira, 2022; Erasmus et al., 2022; Li, 2022) for start-up businesses and capital expansion. The global crowdfunding market is growing continuously, and it is projected for \$1.41 billion in 2023 from \$1.25 billion in 2022 (Fortune Business Insights, 2023). Cryptocurrency is a digital currency that funds individuals and businesses with a secure and efficient blockchain technology (Lee, 2019; Tredinnick, 2019; Hashemi Joo, et al., 2020). Even though cryptocurrency is unregulated, it is likely to become mainstream in the upcoming years. The current law, such as the Financial Service and the Market Act 2000, was updated in 2023 to increase the power of the UK government to support cryptocurrency activities in the UK. Therefore, the UK government has already taken steps to safeguard the organisations that trade cryptocurrency (HM Treasury, 2023). Increasing the growth from £0.1 billion US dollars in 2019 to £1.9 billion US dollars in 2023, the cryptocurrency market is projected to be £3.8 billion US dollars in 2027 (Statista Market Insights, 2023).

Not only the growth but also trends of accepting Fintech in the UK are also increasing (Keary, 2020) than any other country in Europe despite the economic challenges, especially the use of crowdfunding, P2P and crypto assets (OECD , 2019). The trends show that the funding increased through crowdfunding from 2020 to 2023 (Statista Market Insights, 2023), P2P

lending (Research Reports World, 2023) and also cryptocurrency (Statista Market Insights, 2023). This is because of distinct crowdfunding models (Brown, et al., 2015), which require less information from the SMEs and little time in the contract negotiations between the borrowers and investors (Macht & Weatherston, 2014). The other driving factors are lower interest rates, bringing borrowers and lenders to secure and transparent platforms with the highest accessibility by Fintech. Initially, all forms of traditional funding were conducted offline. This was challenging for the SMEs, as they consumed more time to access financing. Conversely, Fintech funding deploys technology to conduct verifications and other measures, resulting in a more flexible process. Flexibility proves significant to UK SMEs in saving time. Furthermore, Fintech funding provides higher efficiency to the SMEs through automated and customised transactions.

One of the key questions that academicians, policy players and practitioners have grappled with is whether the FinTech industry would displace the traditional banking industry in the same way digital technology has disrupted traditional advertising and publishing (Chiu, 2016; Zetzsche, et al., 2017). There is no definite answer because FinTech is in the early stages of evolution. The banking system started thousands of years ago, and in the UK, banknotes were first introduced in 1661 (Richards, 2019). Financial services institutions have robust systems in the world, and their history is rooted in centuries. Financial institutions have an essential role in providing their services to individuals and businesses in any economy (Swift, 2020). The UK financial sector employs 1.1 million people (Cherowbrier, 2020) and contributes £132 billion to the UK economy (Rhodes, 2019). In addition to professional bodies, almost every UK University offer undergraduate and postgraduate degrees in Banking and Finance and trains learners to become managers and CEOs of leading financial institutions. On the other hand, FinTech firms employed 76500 people in 2019 (Cotton, 2019), and these firms also contributed £6 billion to the UK economy (KPMG, 2019). Many leading UK universities have started to offer FinTech qualifications to prepare learners for future managerial positions. That indicates that managers and leaders of FinTech firms will have healthy competition with the

traditional financial sector in the UK. The demand for traditional financial institutions, such as banks and Fintech, will continue to grow due to their unique features and economic roles.

1.1. Problem statement and key research questions

SMEs play a significant role in the UK economy in terms of tax revenue, employment opportunities, and economic output generation. According to the UK National Statistics, the UK has approximately 5.83 million SMEs, accounting for 99.9 per cent of all the businesses in the UK (Department for Business, Energy & Industrial Strategy, 2020). These SMEs include small and medium-sized organisations established per the UK Companies Act 2006. A small company has a number of employees not more than 50, and the turnover should not be more than £10.2 million with a balance sheet of £5.1 million or less. For medium-sized companies, the turnover should not be more than £36 million, not more than 250 employees and the balance sheet should not be more than £18 million (Lu, 2018). The UK SMEs also employ approximately 60 per cent of the total number of private employees in the UK and contribute 49.8% of the total GDP in the economy (Lu, 2018).

Despite the vital role that SMEs play in the UK economy, a large body of literature has explored the various challenges that the UK's SMEs face in accessing finance (Hughes, 1997; Cassar, 2004; Udell, 2015; Dheer & Salamzadeh, 2022). However, financial institutions strive to provide better services due to robust regulatory frameworks (HM Treasury, 2019) after the 2008 financial crash and the Covid-19 disastrous effects on the economy (Machkour, 2020; Chenguel, 2022; Alkayed, et al., 2023), SMEs, unlike the larger businesses, may not have the audited financial statements, thus increasing the informational friction between the lenders and the borrowers (Berger & Frame, 2007; Lee and Brown, 2017). On the other hand, Fintech funding provides lower barriers, quicker transactions, and enhanced security and privacy features (FinanceFeeds, 2023) that favour the customer immensely. Unlike traditional financing, which often requires stable employment history from senior officers of SMEs or collateral to seek a loan, Fintech funding provides loans based on credit rating that do not

require collateral and stable employment history. Consequently, Fintech funding is more accessible to various CEOs in SMEs. Higher accessibility enhances the reliability of these loans among the SMEs in the UK. Additionally, Fintech funding may be cost-friendly when compared to traditional financing. Most FinTech companies seek to compete against traditional financing companies. Consequently, they strive to provide lower interest rates to attract customers. This process favours SMEs. Fintech funding is better than traditional funding methods, such as bank loans, but it faces several limitations. For instance, Fintech funding lacks adequate regulations in the UK. Additionally, Fintech funding requires effective security measures such as blockchain technology to safeguard customers' privacy (Ducas & Wilner, 2017; Saimima & Patria, 2021; Aldboush & Ferdous, 2023).

Due to the innovative features of Fintech, funding through Fintech is more accessible, making it more readily available to a variety of businesses led by CEOs, thereby enhancing the credibility of these loans. This prompts a question: How are the decisions made in these businesses regarding funding preferences through traditional financial institutions or Fintech, especially under the leadership of their respective CEOs? Meanwhile, evidence suggest that the leadership in the organisation is crucial for the funding decisions (Jonas, et al., 2011; Kline, 2019; Strielkowski, et al., 2022; Putra & Adawiah, 2023) for its sustainability (Metcalf & Benn, 2013; Howieson, et al., 2019; Haque, 2021) in the competitive market. However, there are many tiers of leadership in the organisation. The organisational tiers are levels of authority or hierarchical levels from lower management to the top-level management. The level of tiers depends on the organisational functions and the size of the organisation.

The leadership at the CEO level is the top-level leadership in the organisation (Miao et al., 2019; Ren et al., 2021), who ultimately provides the overall leadership to the organisation. The lower-level tiers are generally first or middle-level managers who provide leadership to their subordinates. The existing literature argue that leadership styles change at each hierarchical level of the organisation (Zenger & Folkman, 2019; Mansaray, 2019; Fries, et al., 2021). Because CEOs' decisions travel from the top to the lower level of organisations, they impact

managerial positions by adopting the relevant leadership style to fulfil organisational decisions. In other words, management supports and implements CEOs' decisions. CEOs expect timely and accurate information from management to make Fintech financing decisions. These decisions are based on different decision-making models and theories such as cognitive decision-making (Wu, 2020; Andrade, 2020; Featherman, et al., 2021), rational decision making (Gabor, 1976; Doyle, 1999; Certo, et al., 2008; Cabantous, et al., 2010; Acciarini, et al., 2021; Sáenz-Royo, et al., 2022), and others such as the casual decision, game, evidential decision, and Bayesian theories (Ahmed & Omotunde, 2012; Peterson, 2017; Icard, 2021; Ahmed, 2021; Harper, 2022). It depends on the nature of their decisions whether such decisions are strategic, tactical, and operational (Lucey, 2004; Bello, et al., 2022; Laganà & Colapinto, 2022) to meet the funding requirements for their organisations. Therefore, the CEOs' roles in SMEs are essential due to their highest-ranked executive position in the organisation to make key decisions for their stakeholders' benefit. The SME CEOs' leadership role in the organisation includes the financing decisions (Naseem et al., 2019; Schopohl et al., 2021) to promote innovation (Cortes & Herrmann, 2020; Akbari et al., 2021; Bagheri et al., 2022). Financing decisions can involve funding organisations' operations via traditional financing through banking channels or FinTech. It could be both, depending on the organisational financing choices. In the financing theories, the CEO's decision-making is based on two main financing theories – the trade-off and the pecking order (López-Gracia & Sogorb-Mira, 2008; Kokeyeva, 2019; Martinez et al., 2019; Jarallah et al., 2019; Agyei, et al., 2020; 28 Hoang, et al., 2021; Frank et al., 2021). Empirical evidence have mix findings, for example, some organisations financing decisions support trade off theory (Mukherjee & Mahakud, 2012; Mazen, 2012; Moritz et al., 2015) and take external debt while others follow Pecking order theory (Shyam Sunder & Myers, 1999; López-Gracia & Sogorb-Mira, 2008; Degryse et al., 2009; Godke Veiga & McCahery, 2019) and avoid external debt as their first choice for funding decisions. In Fintech financing, CEOs try to achieve Fintech benefits while dealing with the challenges and barriers of traditional financing.

However, many unexplored areas exist regarding FinTech financing, its revolution, and its long-term impact on SMEs' performance. Especially in this period of COVID-19, where FinTech firms and other financial sectors are facing economic crises, it is tough for SMEs to finance their business operations. In the previous financial crash of 2008, almost 1.8 million small businesses were closed, and 8.7 million jobs were lost (Weltman, 2020). In the current period, the Covid-19 damages are worse than any previous financial crash, and the UK GDP has already fallen by 20.4% in June 2020, the most significant fall since 1997 (Office for National Statistics, 2020). The impact of these falls will be seen in all the UK's financial and non-financial sectors. Therefore, leadership is crucial at the country level to lead the economy with better decisions. At the organisational level, CEOs are the main executive officers who deal with such situations to ensure the smooth running of their businesses. There is no single research in recent years to confirm how SMEs' top leadership, such as CEOs, make decisions to support their business growth with financing decisions; what alternative sources of funding are available to them at start-up, maturity or growth stage of SMEs; how their leadership and factors associated with their financing decisions and its impact on SMEs.

Empirical evidence suggests that several factors play significant roles in influencing the financing decisions made by CEOs (Daniele, 2017), such as personal attributes like beliefs and values (Slovic, et al., 1977; Teräs, et al., 2020), risk-taking personality (Glaser & Weber, 2007; Cronqvist, et al., 2012; Cain & McKeon, 2016), education (Hambrick, 2007; Soriano & Castrogiovanni, 2012; Herdinata, et al., 2019), experience, ability, age, leadership qualities, and socioeconomic status (Dietrich, 2010; Corbett & Spinello, 2020; Van Laar, et al., 2020; Anastasiou & Garametsi, 2021), which lead them to make the rational decisions (Oliveira, 2007; Jonassen, 2012; Sáenz-Royo, et al., 2022). As CEOs work with a wide range of stakeholders in and outside their organisations, their networking contributes to their financing decisions, for example, the professional networking (Xiaowei & Zhang, 2010; Wang & Tu, 2016; Eze, et al. 2018), the board of directors (Dunne & Morris, 2008; Leardini, et al., 2013; Cummings, 2018) and the organisational structure (Carzo & Yanouzas, 1969; Meltzer & Salter,

1962; Chehade & Vigneron, 2007; Nieuwenhuizen, et al., 2012; Muthukannan, et al., 2020). These factors can be categorised into three categories: micro-factors are directly related to CEOs' subjective characteristics, such as their leadership, vision, values, family, beliefs, education, experience, and risk-taking attitude; meso factors are forces around CEOs in their professional practice, such as professional networking, the Board, and the organisational structure, and macro factors are external to micro and meso factors and may directly or indirectly influence their financing decisions, such as government policies and regulations. With increasing trends of crowdfunding, P2P, and cryptocurrency financing from 2020 to 2023 (Statista Market Insights, 2023), it is essential to explore what contributes to CEOs' decision-making on Fintech financing, especially after COVID-19, economic recession, high inflation, and interest rates. To fill in the gap, the researcher has the following research aim and objectives.

Research Aim:-

Explore the CEOs' decision making relating to Fintech financing in UK SMEs

Research Objectives:-

To achieve the aim of this study, the researcher has the following research objectives,

Research Objective 1 - Exploring the perceptions of CEOs regarding their financing choices at the UK SMEs.

Research Objective 2 – Exploring the micro factors such as CEOs' personal leadership traits, vision, and risk-taking attitude to navigate their Fintech financing decisions at the UK SMEs.

Research Objective 3 – Exploring the influence of meso factors such as professional networking, board of directors, and organisational structure in CEOs' Fintech financing decisions at the UK SMEs.

Research Objective 4 - Exploring the complexity of government support and regulations as macro factors to navigate CEOs' perceptions to make Fintech financing decisions at the UK SMEs.

The following four key research questions help to achieve the research objectives,

Research Question 1 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?

Research Question 2 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude, on their Fintech financing decisions?

Research Question 3 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, the board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level?

Research Question 4 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?

1.2. Key findings and contribution

The present research focuses on semi-structured face-to-face interviews to collect data from CEOs who are participants of this study. The interviews were conducted from February 2021 to 3rd August 2023, leading to the analysis and presentation of the findings. The participants were recruited from non-financial SMEs with an age of more than one year and at least two people with other criteria that they should have used fintech or at least know about fintech financing. The researcher focused on the constructivism paradigm to explore the reality of CEOs' financing related decisions with assumptions that realities are multiple (Pale & Lilford, 2011) and based on the individuals subjective stance (Kusch, 2020; Krol, 2021; Merlo & Pravato, 2021). Therefore, the ontological stance of this study is relativism. CEOs have their own opinions and perceptions when making decisions about Fintech financing because of

their unique social structure (Archer, 1995; Archer, 1982; Gorski, 2013) in which they work and interact with others in society. The epistemological stance is social constructivism with assumptions that knowledge is constructed through social and cultural practices (Young & Collin, 2004; Cohen et al., 2004; Stead, 2004; Richardson et al., 2009) and the subjective stance of CEOs' financing decisions will uncover many truths (Stead, 2004). The study follows the grounded approach (Gligor et al., 2016; Charmaz, 2000; Charmaz, 2006; Charmaz, 2017) based on inductive reasoning (Pope, et al., 2000; Ketokivi & Mantere, 2010; Bendassolli, 2013; LUKENCHUK, 2017; Zeithaml et al., 2020) to get detailed insights into CEOs' views through interviews and explore the influence of factors to navigate their decision-making relating to Fintech.

The result from the first research question of how CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment supported three themes: (a) CEOs in the UK prefer Fintech to traditional financing, (b) Increasing demand and banking challenges necessitate Fintech financing options, and (c) limited awareness about the Fintech options. Results show that CEOs in the UK SMEs prefer Fintech over traditional financing. Specifically, 70% of CEOs prefer Fintech financing through crowdfunding, P2P lending and Cryptocurrency. 15% of participants prefer traditional financing through banks, while the remaining 15% prefer both. In the first theme, the findings confirm that CEOs prefer Fintech because it provides more financing options at a lower cost and with fewer regulations. The results of more funding options are supported by the outcome of the current research by Haddad & Hornuf (2019) and Bollaert et al. (2021). The result that the Fintech provides lower cost is consistent with the research report published by the European Central Bank (Eça, et al., 2022) and the previous studies by Carlin et al. (2017), Najib et al. (2021), Kumari & Devi (2022), Ornelas & Pecora (2022) and Elliehausen & Hannon (2023). The study results of CEOs' decisions for Fintech financing due to its lower regulations are consistent with the findings of Magnuson (2018), Alam et al. (2019), and Chorzempa & Huang (2022). In addition, due to COVID-19 and the history of the financial crash, CEOs have

more intention to use efficient funding platforms rather than rely on banks. However, the second theme emerged because participants preferred traditional financing and switched to Fintech if they found that banks did not offer such services—for example, access to investors to invest in their business for expansion or payment gateways. That increases the demand for Fintech services, including the increase of its adoption rate due to benefits, and also poses challenges for banks to improve their services. The study results are congruent with the findings of Razzaque and Hamdan (2020), Ahern (2021), and Abdul-Rahim et al. (2022) that CEOs' preference for Fintech is because of its benefits and advantages. The third theme, limited awareness of Fintech, led CEOs to choose traditional financing. This is because of low digital financial literacy, awareness of cyber security risks, and online fraud with Fintech financing. The limited awareness about Fintech options is supported by the findings of existing research by Das and Das (2020), Niu et al. (2020), and Basar et al. (2022), who emphasise literacy and awareness. CEOs have concerns about the government's limited support of Fintech options, which barred them from funding through Fintech.

The themes obtained from the second research question of how CEOs in UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude, on their Fintech financing decisions include (a) leadership traits, (b) using vision to guide Fintech decisions, (c) using values to guide decision-making, (d) incorporating family members' perspectives in making Fintech decisions, (e) using personal beliefs to reinforce Fintech decision-making, (f) use educational knowledge to improve Fintech decision making, and (g) use prior experience to improve Fintech decision making (h) risk approach to making Fintech decision. The first theme at the micro level factors revealed that CEOs have leadership traits that reflect ethics, morality, dedication, and integrity in their work. They focused on their SME's long-term vision by promoting collaborative teamwork, accountability, and innovation to achieve shared organisational goals. These results are similar to the findings of Waldman, et al. (2001), Simsek, et al., (2010), Kaplan, et al. (2012), Chen, et al. (2013), Haas & Speckbacher (2017), Huang, et al. (2019), and Ibarra et al. (2020). The second theme at the

micro level includes CEOs having their vision to guide their Fintech decisions are consistent with the findings of Nwokedi (2015), Collins (2020), Slåtten et al. (2021), Maran et al., (2022), Yuanyuan et al. (2022) and Ji et al. (2023). CEOs work as visionary leaders to look for the future impact and the benefits of Fintech financing, which contribute to the long-term success of their SMEs. Their vision promotes innovation decisions to deal with the competitive environment of their organisations. The third theme confirms that CEOs have personal values, and they consider their values of transparency, kindness, integrity, and honesty to lead them to make ethical financing decisions. These findings are supported by Vitt (2004), Berson et al. (2008), Gorgievski et al. (2011) and Lofving et al. (2023) outcomes of the research where researchers concluded that CEOs' leadership styles in their organisations are guided by their values. Values further promote their innovation decisions by attracting investors to fund their business. The four themes at the micro level revealed that incorporating family members' perspectives in making Fintech decisions positively influences their financing decisions because it provides them with emotional support and enables them to make decisions with confidence. The significance of family involvement with the business is consistent with the findings of Anderson & Reeb (2003), Chrisman et al. (2004), Jonathan (2021), and Buchanan et al. (2022) that it has positive impacts the organisation success. However, in this research, the organisation's success is not measured; instead, the focus is only on the support from family involvement as the influential factor contributing to CEOs' financing decisions. In addition, CEOs don't discuss their professional matters with their families because of privacy and confidentiality issues, and they are bound not to share their organisational matters with them. The fifth theme is that CEOs believe that the future period is with information technology and belongs to innovation to remain successful in the competitive business environment. That is their personal belief in reinforcing Fintech decision-making. Personal beliefs are associated with religion, trust, risks, and their perception of the Fintech financing benefits and advantages. The study findings are congruent with Baxamusa & Jalal (2016) that religious beliefs affect decisions and also with the findings of Setiawan et al. (2021), Mascarenhas et al. (2021), Abdul-Rahim et al. (2022), Gupta et al. (2023) that the personal beliefs are based on trust

including perceived risks and benefits to affect their perceptions and intentions to accept FinTech. The sixth and seventh themes at the micro level confirm that knowledge through education and prior experience improve their Fintech financing decisions. The education and experience help enhance their decision-making capacity to identify better financing options, assess risks, and lead them to make innovative financing decisions. Education further enables them to understand regulations, costs and benefits, advantages and disadvantages of financing options. Results are coinciding with the findings of Hambrick (2007), Soriano & Castrogiovanni (2012) and Herdinata, et al. (2019), Xiaowei & Zhang (2010), Moritz, et al. (2015), Zheng & Piao (2019), Mohd Thas Thaker (2019) and Duréndez, et al. (2023). The final theme at the micro level confirms that CEOs have a risk-avoider and taking attitude, which influences their decision-making. CEOs have opinions that the Fintech market is volatile, uncertain, and unpredictable and prefer not to take risks. The study findings oppose the literature of Jianakoplos & Bernasek (2006), Steinberg (2007), Mitsopoulou (2019), Breivik et al. (2020), and Gunier et al. (2022) that younger people are more risk takers. However, the fact that can't be ignored is that this study deals with CEOs who are all educated and experienced in their profession and Fintech financing, which does not have a long history as already established traditional financing; therefore, the literacy and experience of Fintech are the determinants to establish their risk attitude. The 55% of participants who are middle-aged CEOs believed they were risk takers, which is consistent with the findings of Melović et al. (2022) that experienced individuals make risky decisions. In addition, age and gender are micro factors determining the CEOs' financing preferences. The study demographic statistics show that 45% of young CEOs, 15% of middle-aged CEOs, and 5% of older CEOs prefer Fintech financing. While 64% of males and 67% of females prefer Fintech as their preferred financing option. However, age and gender demographic representations of the data do not firmly constitute the CEOs' financing preferences due to their age and gender. Other micro, meso and macro-level factors should be considered, along with the demographics of age and gender statistics, such as CEOs' perceptions of Fintech financing and their leadership style.

The findings relating to the third research question of how CEOs in UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, the board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level revealed three major themes: (a) incorporating professional advice and contributions, (b) consulting the board, and (c) the organisational structure's impact on Fintech decisions. Within the board of SMEs, the researcher also found the role of the Chairman to be a significant influencing factor for CEOs' financing decisions. In the first theme at the meso level, CEOs develop professional networking with their team in their organisations and outside experts, including investors, which helps them enhance their awareness of financing solutions. The results of the influence of the professional networking factor in this study are consistent with the findings of Xiaowei & Zhang (2010), Wang & Tu (2016), and Eze et al. (2018) that opinions through professional networking assist in decision-making. The second theme at the meso level reveals that SMEs have a board in their organisations, which influences CEOs' Fintech financing decisions. The board includes executive and non-executive directors to bring a wealth of experience to SMEs who also elect their chairman for important board-related decisions such as strategic financing choices. The board is a separate body from the management, a further tier of decision-making at the CEO's top, usually called the Board decision. There are many reasons for having a board, such as the requirements of the organisation's constitution and or to show external lenders for their SMEs' good governance. The researcher found that some SMEs have CEOs dual roles as chairman and CEO simultaneously, but some SMEs have a separate role of Chairman from CEO. SMEs that are not listed bodies and, therefore, don't have regulatory or legal requirements to have an independent chairman on the board as per the UK Governance Quality Code requirements. The study findings are consistent with the results of Croci et al. (2011), Xiang et al. (2018) and Gurdgiev and Ni (2023), which state that diverse boards create good governance. Also, the independent role of the Chairman from the CEO minimises the conflict between the shareholders and management. The third theme at the meso level is the impact of the organisational structure on influencing CEOs in their financing decisions. The researcher found that the organisational structure, if it is not complex, such as organic,

supports innovation in CEOs' financing decisions, and the mechanistic structure, which is based on the level of hierarchies, supports less innovation and traditional financing. These results are aligned with the findings of Chaston (1997), Bai et al. (2017) and Su et al. (2019), which emphasise the significance of organic organisational structure as a factor to influence CEOs' decisions to respond timely by responding to the change in their business environment.

The results of the final question of how CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions found that UK SMEs prefer to work within rules, laws, and regulations because that increases their confidence and protects their decisions within the laws. CEOs are aware of the economic situations, recessions and negative politics. CEOs align their decisions with the laws, consistent with the findings of Dwivedi et al., 2021; Ng and Pan, 2022 and also government policies and laws promote their adoption of Fintech, which is consistent with the findings of Chen et al. 2014; Kiwanuka, 2015; Rosavina & Rahadi, 2018; Ghazali & Yasuoka, 2018; Owen, et al., 2019; Rosavina, et al. 2019; Goo and Heo, 2020; Ahern, 2021; Zarrouk et al., 2021; Makki and Alqahtani, 2022; Ng and Pan, 2022. However, CEOs expect the UK government to take considerable measures regarding the enhancement of Fintech, awareness of Fintech financing and further laws or regulations to ensure the confidence of their decisions in Fintech financing.

This is the first empirical research on CEOs' decision-making for their Fintech financing preference. There are several studies that are closely related to the subject. For example, external sources of funding by SMEs in China by Wei, 2017, promoting SME finance in the context of the Fintech revolution: A case study of the UK's practice and regulation by Lu (2018), Fintech education and training in the UK by Sung, et al. (2019), awareness and perception of Fintech Financing of SMEs in Malaysia by Ghazali & Yasuoka (2018), the emergence of global Fintech market by Haddad & Hornuf (2019) and the real effects of Fintech lending on SMEs: evidence from loan applications by European Central Bank (2022). So, it contributes to the extant literature in Fintech financing, particularly regarding the CEO's

decision-making in SMEs. The emerging themes contributing to CEOs' decisions to fund their businesses with Fintech financing are that it provides more financing options, such as crowdfunding, P2P lending, and Cryptocurrency; it also offers lower financing costs and has lower regulations. CEOs' decision-making supports the cognitive theory of decision-making to make rational decisions. CEOs establish business relationships and partnerships, work with ethics, morality, dedication, and hard work, and align their values and vision to achieve the organisational goals by developing and engaging their team. This contributes to the transformational theory of leadership (contribution to Bass & Riggio, 2006 and Baškarada et al., 2017). Their vision, values, family members, personal beliefs, experience, and risk-taking personality influence CEOs' decisions to accept Fintech. They work collectively with other board members to ensure integrity is reflected in their financing decisions. The study reveals that middle-aged CEOs are more risk takers to accept Fintech than younger CEOs. These findings oppose the literature that older people are less risk takers (Okun, 1976; Vroom & Pahl, 1971; Bellante & Green, 2004). This is because Fintech is comparatively new in England, and the older CEOs know more about Fintech financing due to experience. The study results contribute to the Agency theory of corporate governance (contribution to Samuel, 2013; Renders & Gaeremynck, 2012; Nguyen et al., 2020; Tibiletti et al., 2021) to the extent that CEOs work for the interest of their shareholders that reduce agency costs and bring expertise to the board due to the independent factor of non-executive directors. The findings contribute to the literature on the organisational structure, specifically Chaston (1997), Bai et al. (2017) and Su et al. (2019), to the extent that the organic structure of the organisation supports innovation for SMEs to accept Fintech financing. The findings are also consistent with the Pecking Order Theory and contribute to Degryse et al. (2009) that the SMEs prefer to use their internal funds in their first preference to meet their business funding needs. Further, CEOs prefer alternative funding through Fintech because of its fewer regulations, lower cost and more funding options. At the practical aspects of the contribution, the current study supports that CEOs follow and comply with the country's laws to avoid non-compliance. They expect support and knowledge through networking and more guidance from the government. The

study further informs government policymakers to encourage a fairer legal environment favouring SMEs' adoption and use of Fintech.

1.3. Structure of the thesis

The structure of this study includes the following sections.

Chapter 1 provides a general introduction to this research, including a brief review of existing literature, research gaps and rationales, research aims and objectives, methodology, overview of findings, impact and the scope of limitation and the structure of the thesis. Chapter 2 discusses the literature review. The literature review has three parts. Part 1 includes the theoretical background of decision-making theories and models, leadership theories in decision-making, and financing theories. Part 2 includes Fintech in practice – history, recent development, the role of technology in Fintech, Fintech financing, government support and the challenges of Fintech in the economy. Part 3 includes the development of research questions supported by extensive literature to develop the conceptual framework. Chapter 3 contains the data and the research methodology. The research methodology is based on the approach, methods and procedures. This section includes the data collection and analysis. Research ethics are explained in detail to maintain the confidentiality of information before, during and after the interview. Chapter 4 contains results within the emerged themes and sub-themes based on the interview questions to CEOs to understand their decision making relating to Fintech financing in UK SMEs. Chapter 5 includes a general discussion of findings and recommendations. This chapter comprises the conceptual framework from the research results, supported by empirical evidence. Chapter 6 is a conclusive part to confirm the CEOs' preferences toward Fintech financing and the role of CEOs in SMEs when it comes to decision-making, e.g. where they stand, what contributes to their decisions when it comes to choosing between Fintech and traditional financing. It includes the summary of the findings and contribution to the knowledge, literature, practice, and policies with reflection and

limitations in addition to the future agenda for conducting research. Chapter 7 includes references, and Chapter 8 contains Appendices.

2. Literature review

The study deals with CEOs' decision-making regarding their financing preferences and factors influencing their Fintech financing decisions. The literature review is centred on CEOs' leadership, decision-making theories and models, Fintech development and its options for financing, and the considerable empirical evidence to support the development of the research framework. CEOs' leadership is crucial to making important decisions because they are critical in managing and leading their organisation in SMEs (Kuntz et al., 2019; Alade & Windapo, 2021; Barrett et al., 2021). The first section includes the theoretical background of decision-making, leadership, and financing theories. These are significant in understanding CEOs' leadership styles and decision-making roles in SMEs in determining the suitable financing option. The second section includes Fintech's development, history, and various recently developed technology-enabled financing options to support funding needs. The literature review's final section includes key factors influencing CEOs' decision-making at the individual, organisational, and country levels in funding their business through FinTech. These factors are categorised as the CEOs' micro, meso, and macro levels to explore how these factors navigate CEOs in their FinTech financing decisions. The current research uses three layers (micro, meso and macro) to identify CEOs' factors. The concept of three layers is from the sociology literature. Sociology is a subject that aims to understand the people, culture, human interactions, forces, and factors that stimulate human behaviour in society (Thompson et al., 2016; Spillman, 2020; Plummer, 2021). Sociologists divide society into three layers, namely micro, meso and macro (Bruhn & Rebach, 2007; Stebbins, 2020; Fillieule, 2023), to understand society (Johnson, 2008; Thompson et al., 2016). The micro level represents a subjective interpretation of individual characteristics and courses of action (Alexander et al., 1987; Bruhn & Rebach, 2007; Bhaskar, 2020). That relates to human factors and the influence

of the other layers at meso and macro within which they act within the society (Alexander, et al., 1987). The researcher uses terms of three layers to understand CEOs' micro, meso and macro factors. The micro factors include the CEOs' characteristics, meso factors include networking, group, and all those forces around CEOs in organisations, and the macro factors fall external into meso and micro, such as the government policies that influence their decisions regarding their financing preferences. A research framework facilitates the conduct of research supported by the empirical evidence at the micro level, such as personal leadership traits, values, family, beliefs, education, experience, and risk-taking attitude and at the meso level, such as the board of directors and the organisational structure and at the macro level such as the government policies and support. The micro, meso, and macro-level factors further support them in making FinTech decisions in the needs of funds backed by leadership and decision-making theories.

2.1. Theoretical Background

2.1.1. Decision Making Theories and Models

In literature, studies on decision-making often seek to describe the decision-making theories, models and practice, the kind of decisions, and the process of decision-making among other related topics. While addressing the issue of decision-making theories in the management and leadership of how CEOs utilise decision making models, various authors have different perspectives to differentiate the decision-making models from decision-making theories. The decision theory entails the study of the principles and algorithms used in making decisions (Ahmed & Omotunde, 2012). Even though there are many decision-making theories, however, the current study involves the identification of the values and uncertainties, among other factors, that navigate CEOs' decisions. Because making a decision in an organisation is one of the major attributes and a core skill of a leader (Ahmed & Omotunde, 2012; Kane, et al., 2019). Decision-making in the management context describe the nature of identifying alternatives and picking the best among them (Ahmed & Omotunde, 2012; Herrera-Viedma,

et al., 2020). In the most organisations, the three levels of decision-making include strategic, tactical, and operational, and each level has different implications on the entire organisation (Lucey, 2004; Bello, et al., 2022; Laganà & Colapinto, 2022). Strategic decisions are made by senior executives such as CEOs, they are long-term and have an impact on the entire organisation (Recendes, et al., 2022). Tactical and operational decisions are shorter term (Bello, et al., 2022) and normally performed by lower management in the organisation. However, most studies on the decision-making theory and practice acknowledge that in the business context, it is mandatory for the senior executives to make numerous decisions, both simple and complex (Marchisotti, et al., 2018). The point herein is to show that decision making is perhaps the most critical management function in the organisation (Brunsson, 2019; Hums, et al., 2023; Fanelli, et al., 2023). Therefore, the only relevant decision theories closely aligned to this research are considered such as rational decision making (Gabor, 1976; Doyle, 1999; Certo, et al., 2008; Cabantous, et al., 2010; Acciarini, et al., 2021; Sáenz-Royo, et al., 2022), bounded rational theory (Turpin & Marais, 2004; Tarka, 2017; Gigerenzer, 2020; Morales Burgos, et al., 2020), the casual decision, game, evidential decision, Bayesian theories (Ahmed & Omotunde, 2012; Peterson, 2017; Icard, 2021; Ahmed, 2021; Harper, 2022), naturalistic model of decision making (Turpin & Marais, 2004; Boyes & O'Hare, 2011; Carmody-Bubb, 2023) and the cognitive theory of decision making (Wu, 2020; Andrade, 2020; Featherman, et al., 2021).

The rational decision-making theory is one of the most common theories. The key aspect of this theory is that the decision-maker analyses the various alternatives from given scenarios before making a choice (Oliveira, 2007; Jonassen, 2012; Sáenz-Royo, et al., 2022). In this theory, scenarios are weighted by probabilities for decision makers to select the best alternative. In this theory, the rational and informed decision maker selects an alternative by following three basic steps: 1) Establishing the feasibility, 2) Determining the desirability and 3) Combining both feasibility and desirability to select the best choice.

The rationality model is deemed somewhat traditional and a model that can be made more practical, and hence the emergence of the bounded rationality model (Grüne-Yanoff, 2007; Ballester & Hernández, 2012; Sáenz-Royo, et al., 2022). While bounded rationality is a model on its own, it is described herein as a refinement of the traditional rationality theory. The bounded rationality model of decision-making is based on the notion of satisficing – that is, selecting the alternatives that justify implicitly and explicitly the minimum criteria (Turpin & Marais, 2004). This model is also based on the observation (Geng, et al., 2022) in which the decision-makers are not always rational. As a refinement of the rationality model, the bonded rational loosens the assumption of rationality and makes the decision-making theory look more practical.

The causal decision theory is founded on the principle of rational choice, meaning it is part of the rational model of decision-making (Ahmed & Omotunde, 2012; Opp, 2019). The rational model of decision-making is based on logic (Grandori, 2010; Kornberger, et al., 2019) and it is not essential for a CEO to know everything to make decisions. This model is founded on the neoclassical economic theory (Rizzo & Whitman, 2018). Based on this model, the decision-making process begins with intelligence – that is, finding the occasions for the decision-making. The process involves developing, inventing, and analysing the courses of actions followed by a review to select the best choice.

The game theory is a mathematical study of strategic decision-making and that takes into account the conflict and cooperation between intelligent and rational decision makers (Tang, et al., 2019; Choi, et al., 2020; Leyton-Brown & Shoham, 2022). This theory is normally help to understand collective decisions (Rossi, 2014). The evidential decision theory asserts that the decision is chosen among the alternatives with the best outcome (Ahmed, 2021; Huttegger & Huttegger, 2023). Again, this can be seen as having some similarities with the bounded rationality model that seeks the best outcomes and a more pragmatic approach to decision making.

The Bayesian is a probability theory, often considered as an extension of logic that allowing reasoning with prepositions (Zhou, et al., 2020; Acree & Acree, 2021). The Bayesian theory is also associated with the risk management model (Ardia, 2008; Iberraken, et al., 2019; Martínez-Sánchez, et al., 2023). Risk Management models are used by CEOs in the SMEs to identify, measure, mitigate, monitor and report risks for better decision making (Zoghi, 2017; Crovini, et al., 2021).

There is an interesting leadership model is termed as the naturalistic model of decision making which is normally focused on identifying, understanding, and then investigating all information available to decision makers in the natural context (Turpin & Marais, 2004; Boyes & O'Hare, 2011; Carmody-Bubb, 2023). An example of decision-making approaches and models based on the naturalistic model is Klein (1998)'s Recognition-Primed Decision-Making Model that is founded on the capability and skills of decision-makers to identify a situation and set decision goals appropriate to that situation. It requires real-time decisions from CEOs in the dynamic changing business environment in the natural settings.

The cognitive theory of decision-making is based on human individual perceptions, beliefs and knowledge as important factors to contribute to their decisions (Wu, 2020; Andrade, 2020; Featherman et al., 2021). In this theory, the decision making is a mental process, and it is based on the choosing the best or the preferred option from set of alternatives (Wang & Ruhe, 2017). Decision making is fundamental part of human life in day-to-day routine. The economic, social, and technological factors play significant role for humans to make decisions in relation to their family, personal and professional decisions (Crozier & Ranyard, 1997; Sima, et al., 2020), for example, education, careers, management of personal finance, development and deployment of resources and acceptance of technology.

In the cognitive decision making, the behaviour and expected utility theories are common to make a rational choice from the set of actions. Expected utility theory depends on the rational decision making to seek the expected outcome of the decision (Ruggeri, et al., 2020). In this theory, decision makers' personal attributes are key contributors for their decisions to choose

between risky, unpredictable or uncertain outcomes (Daniele, 2017). On the other hand, behaviour decision making theory provide insights of how people make judgements in reality under uncertain conditions (Takemura, 2014) and decisions are closely linked to their belief and values (Slovic, et al., 1977; Teräs, et al., 2020). Decision makers in the cognitive process model, first identify the problem, make different choices by outweighing them, compare alternatives, and then make the final decision (Reehuckin, 2017). Factors such as expertise and personal beliefs influence the decision making (Dietrich, 2010; Corbett & Spinello, 2020; Van Laar, et al., 2020; Anastasiou & Garametsi, 2021). The same sentiments are evident by Stanovich & West (2008) and Acevedo & Krueger (2004) that expertise, cognitive favouritisms, beliefs, and personal preferences are common factors in human psychology to influence their decision-making capabilities. These decisions making theories are summarised below in the following diagram.



Figure 1 Decision Making Theories

2.1.2. Leadership theories in decision-making

Leadership and management are often discussed as separate concepts, each with different theories. Leadership is the process where a person (the leader) inspires others (the followers) to work together towards the achievement of a common goal (Kazeem, et al., 2014; Giddens, 2018; Ciulla & Ciulla, 2020). While management is simply the process used to accomplish organisational goals. For the purpose of this literature review, the focus will not be on differentiating leadership and management, but examining how leaders and managers make

decisions paying attention to the various theories. In many studies, leadership theories in the context of decision-making have been outlined often highlighting how different types of decisions are facilitated by different leadership styles.

In the theoretical concepts of leadership, it has been expressed that the leadership theories describe the leaders' behaviour and their decision making as consequences of their leadership styles (Kazeem, et al., 2014). The leadership theories determine the leadership styles to guide the decision making. The behavioral theory of leadership decision making for leaders to make decisions are based on reasons and it relates to their beliefs, attitude or behaviour (Westaby, 2005; Westaby, et al., 2010; Sahu, et al., 2020). In this theory, leaders adjust their behaviour based on the situation and according to the demand of their stakeholders as they need a reason to justify their decisions to them. The servant theory of leadership emphasises listening, empathy, and stewardship to serve the needs of followers (Greenleaf, 2002; Parris & Peachey, 2013; Bavik, 2020). This focuses on leaders ensuring financial decisions are made fairly to benefit various stakeholders. Authentic leadership prioritises building trusted relationships and leading by example with transparency and integrity (Iszatt-White, et al., 2021; Turman, 2023). They foster transparency and accountability in financial matters. Ethical leadership involves demonstrating and promoting values-based conduct (Bavik, et al., 2018; Bai, et al., 2019; Bazerman, 2020). This provides an ethical framework for financial decisions. In the organisational context where group of people work to achieve the organisational goals, there are two types of leaders – called assigned and emergent (Simoff & Sudweeks, 2010; Petridou, et al., 2016; Hoch & Dulebohn, 2017; Hickman & Akdere, 2018). Assigned leaders are given top management positions, whereas emergent leaders emerge over time as more influential due to their behaviour and leadership characteristics (Northhouse, 2016; Hoch & Dulebohn, 2017; Hickman & Akdere, 2018). Assigned and emergent leaders have the potential to influence others' attitudes and course of action within the organisation because their followers believe in their knowledge and follow their good role models. The theoretical consideration of CEOs' leadership and their decision making has often been based on the

upper echelons theory (Waldman, et al., 2004; Hambrick, 2007; Bromiley & Rau, 2016; Ma, et al., 2022). The upper echelons theory indicates that the personality, attitude, experience and the background of top management play an integral part to contribute in their decisions in organisations (Hambrick, 2007; Altarawneh, et al., 2020; Ma, et al., 2022; White & Borgholthaus, 2022).

The key theories of leadership styles are transactional and transformational leadership (Hoxha, 2019; Cho, et al., 2019; Ugwu & Okore, 2020; Purwanto, 2021). Within these theories, leadership styles are participative, delegative and autocratic (Ejimabo, 2015). Leadership styles have different implications on the decision-making process and models. The leaders in the participative leadership encourage and involve their subordinates or team to participate in the major decisions (Khassawneh & Elrehail, 2022) that increase the participants creativity (Li, et al., 2018). The leaders play the role of facilitator while the team is the responsible for outcome of their collective decisions. In the delegative leadership, leaders set directions or goals, believe in the skills of their team and delegate the tasks to them (Cismas, et al., 2016). Team have freedom to make their own decisions that foster the accountability and innnovation in the organisation (Ziegert & Dust, 2021; Djafar, 2023). In the autocratic leadership, the leader makes authoritative decisions often associated with their complete control and ownership of the organisation in the making of decisions (Sievert, 2018; Tang & Tang, 2019; Alblooshi, et al., 2021). The leaders do not consult with or request for ideas from subordinates. This style of decision-making is often hailed as being effective in situations such as emergency because the decisions are made quickly. The naturalistic_decision-making model can perhaps fit in here as the model means entails making decisions based on situations.

In examining leadership of CEOs in decision-making, transformational leadership involves inspiring followers to adopt the organisation's vision and goals while providing intellectual stimulation to enhance innovative thinking and individual development (Bass, 1985; Burns, 1978). Transformational leaders exhibit charismatic behaviours that generate enthusiasm (Pawar, 2016; Chitiga, 2018; Tintoré, 2019) and commitment to collective objectives (Ribeiro,

et al., 2018; Sosik, et al., 2018; Faupel & Süß, 2019; Amankwaa, et al., 2019). They are role model of integrity, which builds trust and respect (Avolio & Yammarino, 2013; Khan, et al., 2020; Liborius, 2021; Lee, et al., 2023). This leadership approach aligns well with financial decision-making that requires stakeholder buy-in, shared vision, and motivation to implement funding requirements. It is a broad-based perspective encompassing several facets and dimension of the process of leadership. Transformational leaders empower others (Koh, et al., 2019) to participate in finance-related processes and contribute ideas (Men, 2014; Son, et al., 2020). They encourage prudence, rational analysis, and objectivity in budgeting or funding requirements while appealing to emotions and values to gain support for decisions. These leaders help frame spending choices and investment trade-offs as opportunities for growth and advancement (Sashkin, 2004). By promoting collaboration (Jiang & Chen, 2018), transformational leaders can integrate diverse perspectives into financial planning to find optimal solutions (Bass and Riggio, 2006). However, potential downsides include followers depending too much on the leader's vision or overemphasising ideology over practical financial considerations. The key characteristics of transformational leaders relevant to financing requirements include articulating a strategic vision to guide funding decisions. They outline a purposeful future state and link monetary priorities to achieving that vision. This visionary guidance clarifies how budgets, expenditures, and investments should advance organisational goals. Rather than getting mired in short-term constraints, the leader's vision compels forward momentum. Transformational leaders motivate their teams by linking funding-related decisions to long-term goals. They stimulate their sub-ordinates working in the financial department of the organisation with their positive and sound decisions specific for the benefits of their organisational long term financial plans. Monetary decisions are seen as more than numbers; they are innovative (Pieterse, et al., 2010; Khalili, 2016; Hui, et al., 2018) to make those decisions which have a significant impact on their organisation. Such brings accountability within the organisation through their team commitment across all stakeholders to the financing requirements of the organisation. Their charismatic personality and rational arguments at the top management encourage their team to work collective towards their

visionary and innovative decisions (Van Knippenberg & Sitkin, 2013; Thoroughgood & Sawyer, 2018; Hawkins, 2021; Carreiro & Oliveira, 2019).

While the transactional leadership style, leaders decisions are based on the available information and that relies within the organisational rules and regulations without considering their personal factors to influence their decisions (Berkovich & Eyal, 2021). The main objective is to achieve the organisational target and a reward is offered by leaders to their followers in the exchange of such targets (Ma & Jiang, 2018; Kalsoom, et al., 2018; Baškarada, et al., 2017). Transactional leaders put practicality ahead of insight when it comes to money matters. Their concentration is on enhancing operational efficiency (Deichmann & Stam, 2015; Afsar, et al., 2017; Suong, et al., 2019), eliminating inefficiencies (McCarthy, et al., 2008; Liu, et al., 2011; Wen, et al., 2019), and seek rewards (Ma & Jiang, 2018; Puni, et al., 2018; Nurlina, 2022) by adopting proven financial methods financing within their organisational established policies and regulations. However, this approach can sometimes over-emphasize transactions (Jermias, et al., 2018; Robin & Sendjaya, 2019; Juliana, et al., 2021) themselves versus long-term vision or a plan. Without inspiration, transactional leadership can struggle to gain commitment for decisions with diffuse or uncertain benefits. Their financial judgments are grounded in rationally assessing facts, projections, comparisons, and financial implications. This approach, which is evidence-based and analytical, seeks to accomplish highly compassionate monetary related financing decisions. Both transformational and transactional leadership styles help leaders to choose their funding preferences. That can lead them to make decisions within the decision making theories, the assumption is that the decision-makers are intelligent and properly informed. Being an informed decision-maker means that there has been a prior process of gathering and analysing information. The following table includes the key comparison between both leadership styles.

Table 1 Comparison of Transformational and Transactional Leadership

Leadership Styles	Key Characteristics	Financial Decision-Making Approach	Key Theorists
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Transformational	Articulates vision and links it to values. Motivates through inspiration. Fosters creativity and innovation. Develops followers to their full potential. Leads by example with integrity.	Aligns financial decisions with strategic vision and purpose. Encourages new ideas to financing. Appeals to emotions and values to generate commitment. Promotes prudent analysis and collaboration.	(Burns, 1978) (Bass, 1985) (Bass & Riggio, 2006)
Transactional	Sets goals, metrics, and expectations. Monitors and controls through systems of rewards and punishments. Values analysis and objectivity over vision. Focuses on efficiency and established processes.	Sets budgets, forecasts, and targets. Monitors expenditures and performance. Leverages incentives and penalties to achieve money-related goals. Enforces compliance with policies and controls.	(Bass, 1985) Bruce Avolio Francis Yammarino William Howell

From the definition of leadership given earlier on, it is clear that leaders are faced with situations that require them to make vital financing decisions that may bring change to the organisation. The literature presented herein discussed the models and theories of decision-making with respect to CEOs' leadership styles. It has been expressed that leaders have one critical role – making decisions. How leaders make their decisions, solely depends on their leadership styles and information available to them. Therefore, the leadership theories provide useful lenses for connecting a leaders' style to financing decisions. While transformational leadership inspires vision, innovation and motivation, transactional leadership levers concrete incentives and oversight. Other leaders are focused on ethics, stakeholder needs and transparency. In summary, within the leaders styles, the leaders decision can be rational based on factual data (Uzonwanne, 2016; Groeneveld, et al., 2017; Gati, et al., 2019), or as per beliefs, attitude or perception as per cognitive theory of decision making (Wu, 2020; Andrade, 2020; Featherman, et al., 2021) and upper echelons theory (Hambrick, 2007; Altarawneh, et al., 2020; Ma, et al., 2022; White & Borgholthaus, 2022) or in the natural context (Turpin & Marais, 2004; Boyes & O'Hare, 2011; Carmody-Bubb, 2023) or these decisions can be based on the logic with reasoning (Zhou, et al., 2020; Acree & Acree, 2021). The fact that

the leaders deal with various factors and situations in and outside the organisation and adopt suitable leadership styles to make financing decisions.

2.1.3. Financing Theories

The concept of financing theory includes the study of various ways by which SMEs raise funds for their businesses. In the corporate finance, it is important for an organisation to understand how funds are raised and allocated to various projects, operations and organisational tasks while considering the risks factors. There are two types of sources of funds, internal and external for the SMEs (Abdulsaleh & Worthington, 2013; Allen, et al., 2013; Eniola, 2021). Internal sources of finance are cash that is retained from the business profit after paying interests, taxes and dividends, assets financing or owners' own investment while the external sources include debt or equity financial contribution to the businesses (Watson & Head, 2007). External finances are normally classified into short-term (less than a year), medium (usually one to five years) or long-term (more than five years) debt or equity finance (Watson & Head, 2007). Financing decisions for SMEs are crucial for their smooth run of the business by keeping in view the benefits of such funding for both business and shareholders. These decisions are based on what portion of debt and equity should be used to increase the value of organisation (Baker & Martin, 2011) and enhance the shareholders' worth (Rappaport, 1998; Hakimah, et al., 2019; Liu, et al., 2022).

There are two main financing theories applicable to SMEs – the trade-off theory and the pecking order theory (López-Gracia & Sogorb-Mira, 2008; Kokeyeva, 2019; Agyei, et al., 2020; Hoang, et al., 2021). The trade-off theory implies that organisations set a target debt-to-value ratio and work towards it (Myers, 1984; Aidoo, et al., 2022; Nawir, et al., 2023). The value in this theory means the worth of the organisation. In other words, the organisation uses mixture of debt and equity by balancing the cost and the benefits of debt (Baker & Martin, 2011; Kontesa, 2015; Alan & Gaur, 2018). In the trade-off theory of financing, top management set target debt to value ratio of the organisation, take advantage of tax benefits over loan against the cost of financial distress. If the company increase its debt amount or percentage ratio

against equity, it gets more tax benefits. In simple words, they prefer debt over equity and believe that current value of the debt provides tax shield which ultimately increase the value of the organisation (Baker & Martin, 2011; Ezirim, et al., 2017). The pecking order theory is opposite to the trade-off theory where there is no exact target debt to value ratio (Agyei, et al., 2020). In this theory, organisations prioritise their sources of funds, the first option is internal financing, then borrowing and the last option is equity (Myers, 1984; Serrasqueiro & Caetano, 2015; Simatupang, et al., 2019). In the pecking order theory of financing, internal generated funds e.g. retained earnings of the business is more preferred option for SMEs over external funding, and so external debt over equity investment. In this case, SMEs prefer loans or external sources of finance if they lack internal funds (Baker, et al., 2020) and still not prefer external investors or any outsider equity to be invested in their businesses if there is no option.

The empirical study on trade-off and pecking order theories has mixed results. For example, Newman et al. (2012) found that larger SMEs are more inclined to use external financing due to their lower cost of financial distress, and they also found a negative relationship between profitability level and debt financing, which supports the theory. Their results were also consistent with the Pecking Order theory, especially for profitable SMEs with sufficient internal retained funds. Profitable SMEs tend towards internal funding options that rely less on external debt or equity financing to support their business financial needs. The findings of Shyam-Sunder & Myers (1999), Hussain & Matlay (2007), López-Gracia & Sogorb-Mira (2008), Degryse et al. (2009) and Godke Veiga & McCahery (2019) confirm that SMEs' financing decisions support the pecking order theory. The smaller or growing SMEs with limited financing credit history prefer to fund their business with internal sources of funds such as retained earnings or personal finance. If they have limited resources, they will prefer external debt. The above findings oppose the results of Mukherjee & Mahakud (2012), Mazen (2012) and Moritz et al. (2015) that SMEs' financing decisions support trade-off theory due to several factors, e.g. the economic recession where SMEs prefer to fund their businesses with external debt. In addition, some SMEs' financing decisions support both pecking-order and trade-off

theories, such as the findings of Hashemi (2013), Serrasqueiro & Nunes (2014), Michaelas et al. (1999) and Sjur et al. (2008).

2.2. Fintech Development

FinTech is technological innovation designed to provide the financial products and services (Legowo, et al., 2020; Lagna & Ravishankar, 2022; Xu, et al., 2023). The technology is designed to incorporate computer programs and the financial configurations to drive efficiency in the financial services. FinTech was developed to offer the needed competition to the traditional financial delivery methods. The technology and the financial aspects are combined to produce a revamped and leveraged financial model that ensures efficiency in the delivery of financial services. The emergence of FinTech is a financial crash 2008 (Puschmann, 2017; Alt, et al., 2018; Giglio, 2021; Gopal & Schnabl, 2022) that increased the lending opportunities to small businesses via alternative sources of finance such as P2P lending, crowdfunding and Cryptocurrency.

FinTech has now become a game changer that took the traditional banking by storm during the period of reluctant to change after the global economic recession. The funding through Fintech is efficient due to digitalisation and the use of technology. According to Godfrey (2018) the Fintech is evolving and enhancing users experience with better and efficient business models. The evolution of Fintech industry to FinTech 3.0 is underpinned by the changes in the consumer mindset where they view the FinTech as a legitimate and resourceful alternative source of finance in the delivery of financial services (Arner, et al., 2015). However, it is not known when an economy is fully slumped, will FinTech survive. For example, in 2019, it was predicted that 2020 would be another big year for FinTech due to projected deals to issue number of digital banking licences, product expansions, open finance and increase in cybersecurity features (KPMG, 2019). However, in the reality, the first quarter of 2020, the FinTech funding dropped to \$6.1 billion since 2016 due to effects of Covid-19 (CBInsights, 2020), the lowest in the history and in the last three years (Lloyd, 2020). That does not mean

that the SMEs funding through traditional banks have increased, in fact, that have also decreased to its lowest level in the history (Canocci, 2020). With 30% contraction in UK economy by the mid of 2020, banks like HSBC, RBS, Barclays and many others have already seen a sharp falls in their shares since 2008 financial crash (Mustoe, 2020) which in turn has increased opportunities for FinTech financing. The International Monetary Funds (IMF) and the World Bank have also endorsed the innovation in Finance due to spread of digital technology around the world. In 2018, IMF and World Bank have issued FinTech guides for policy makers where main elements of digital finance are encouraged, risks and threats are highlighted and FinTech initiatives around the world are encouraged (International Monetary Fund, 2018).

2.2.1. History of Fintech and Evolution

The use of technology in financial services can be traced back since 1965 when Giovanni Caselli invented pan telegraph to verify signatures in banking transaction (Zimmerman, 2016; Gray, 2022). The pan telegraph was the first Fintech, but it was much slower in speed to process 25 words in 108 seconds to complete the financial transaction (Teler, 2023). In 1866, the telegraph introduced the trans-Atlantic cable to provide infrastructure for financial services (Fari, 2016). Trans-Atlantic cable was much better in speed to process financial transactions due to its efficiency features and the scope of market. In late 1800s, goods were exchanged with credits (Bindseil, 2019).

In 1918, Morse code system was introduced to connect all Reserve banks and to transfer funds in between them (Hockett, 2022; Sreekala, et al., 2023). Following the invention of credit cards in 1950 (Kahf & Mohomed, 2016), Quotron System was introduced in 1960 – a first ever electronic system (Novocin, 2022). In 1993, financial technology was coined with the creation of Financial Services Technology Consortium (FSTC) (Schueffel, 2016). In 1998, internet banking was introduced in the United State (Furst, 2000) which further revolutionised the world's financial system. The following the financial crash in 2009, the world evident the

release of Bitcoin Cryptocurrency as a result of financial innovation (DeMartino, 2018). However, the term FinTech was first used in 2014 (Anyfantaki, 2022). The following timeline chart further illustrate the whole evolution of FinTech since 1866.

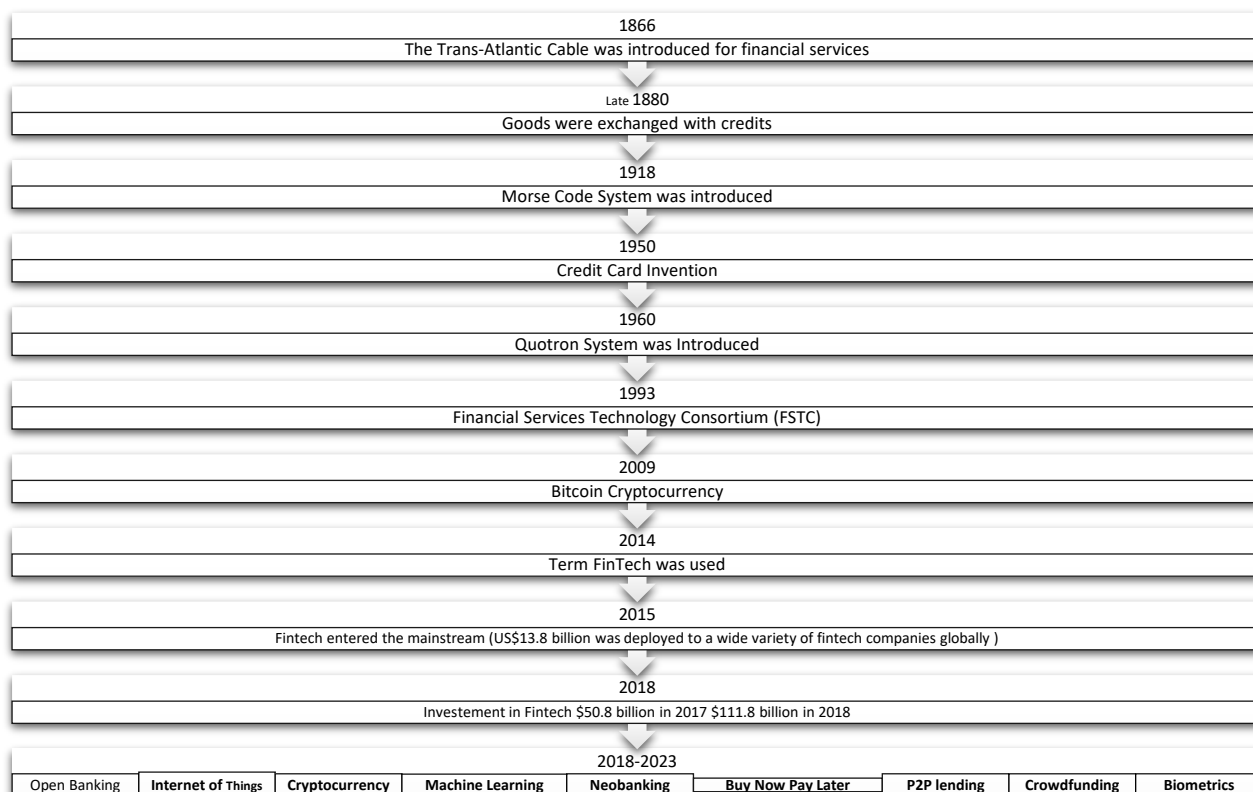


Figure 2: FinTech History and Evolution

One of the most referred triggers of Fintech development was the financial crisis in 2007. The Financial crash of 2007-2010 almost paralysed the global banking system. A dark cloud was cast on the global financial market. Several banks were closed, Stock market nosedived considerably as well the property prices in the global economy slumped. The downfall of Lehman Brothers in 2008, a global banking giant sent the greatest shock waves in the global financial system. The financial crash was unpredicted and as a result of it hundreds of financial institutions in the USA and Europe were closed and some merged with stronger partners to keep them alive (Lybeck, 2011). The economy was much down as compared to 1930s depression and GDP fell 4.9 percent in the UK that affected businesses and individuals (Lybeck, 2011; Liuhto, 2020). The collapse of large financial institutions and the tremendous decline of international stock markets – together with the subsequent economic crisis has

been in the centre of debate among financial policymakers, economists and the central bank. The profound regulation and economic issues after the crisis also catalysed the growth of FinTech to solve the economic problem (Allen, et al., 2014; Jakšič & Marinč, 2019; Yadav, 2020).

In 2019, the Covid-19 pandemic affected people and organisations around the world, and it ultimately unsettled the world economy. In the UK, Covid-19 affected more than the global financial crash because its GDP fell by 19.8% in early 2020 due to national lockdown (Office for National Statistics , 2023) and that brings the household expenditures down to over 20% as compared to 4.8% of the 2007 global financial crash (Office for National Statistics , 2023). During the Covid-19 pandemic the demand of Fintech applications increased to confirm the higher adoption of Fintech (Le, 2021; Khan, et al., 2021; Fu & Mishra, 2022; Tut, 2023). The UK Fintech investment has increased over the years £21.9 billion in 2021, at least 90% higher than the previous year 2020 which represents £2.2 billion (KPMG , 2023). However, in the first half of the 2023, these Fintech investment decreased to £4.6 billion due to high inflation, higher interest rate and war conflict between Russian and Ukraine (KPMG , 2023). The first half of the 2023 investment is still 52% higher than the 2020. The remarkable development which emerged recently are use of open banking, internet of things (IoT), artificial intelligence, biometric and buy now pay later. In the open banking individuals (people and businesses) share their financial data securely with third parties with their consent to compare improved financial services offered by banks (Ramdani, et al., 2020; van Zeeland & Pierson, 2021). Internet of things improve the customers' experience e.g, the contactless payment where customers can pay bill using the mobile application without carrying the actual cash or bank cards (Kvartalnyi, 2023). The use of Chatbot's by financial institutions to answers customers queries without by break (Zoi, 2021), face recognition (Satuluri, 2021) and fingerprints are all artificial intelligence in FinTech to enhance customer's experience (Kumar, et al., 2021). The biometric in FinTech is widely used to verification and identification of the person accessing the sensitive financial data or banking (Dubey, 2019). The commonly used biometrics methods

in Fintech to support the banking app or other financial services are the verification by the use of SMS, authentication by face or fingerprints, voice, and hand geometry (Dubey, 2019; Ganesh, 2021). Buy Now Pay Later (BNPL) in Fintech has recently become popular in the UK with 17 million customers (Money Expert, 2023) to get short term finance and pay the full cost of the product and services in equal monthly instalments with zero interest rate (Koesworo, et al., 2019; Gerrans, et al., 2022; Guttman-Kenney, et al., 2023).

2.2.2. Recent development of Fintech around the world

The FinTech market has grown during the last decade around the world. Financial institutions have invested heavily to increase their market size, growth and to provide efficient services to the customers in this digital age. In 2010, more than 24 billion US dollars were invested in FinTech start up worldwide (Desai, 2015). In 2014, investment on FinTech business venture was 12.21 billion US dollars while in 2015 it was 11 billion US dollars which has resulted into total global growth of 201% (Nicoletti, 2017). In 2017, investment on FinTech start-up was around 27 billion US dollars, 18% more than of 2016 investments (Novack, 2018).

In the Europe only, the remarkable growth of Fin-tech market took place in 2014, with Europe experiencing substantial growth - UK and Ireland were experiencing above 40% growth (Accenture, 2015). The massive progress in financial technology was marked in 2015, where profound progress has been recorded by companies, especially PayPal, First Data, and World Pay. In 2018, Stripe and Square are great examples of Fin-tech with amass valuations of \$9.2 and \$18.9 Billion (Gefferie, 2018). Recently, triggered by little access to credits based on collateral securities and credit ratings, the FinTech innovative has moved to mitigate the financial obstacles faced by entities and individuals through lending via FinTech P2P system (Conner, 2013). The investment size and the global growth rate rely on the lifecycle of the FinTech evolution. A product, system or a process has normally four stages in its life cycle. In the introductory stage, the cost is higher, and the return is lower due to less customers, demand or public confidence. The growth stage is characterised by a good investment, sales

and customers. The maturity stage is more competitive stage due to stable and well-established technology in the financial services while at the decline stage FinTech may have further innovation to attract new customers and retain existing market. FinTech initiatives around the world still not in its maturity stage (Nicoletti, 2017). In 2023, the Fintech has overall 2% shares of the global financial services and it is estimated to reach 25% by 2030 (Boston Consulting Group, 2023). However, evidence from growth trend suggest that FinTech has become one of the main players in the financial world. In the recent years, the FinTech has developed a lot across the world such as in the UK and EU (Appendix 2), USA (Appendix 3), Asia (Appendix 4) and the rest of the world (Appendix 5).

Organisations have unique financing needs to operate their business functions, the majority of which are not currently addressed by the traditional financial institutions, such as the banks. Due to such unique needs, many organisations are currently turning to the Fintech financing as a means of meeting such financial needs. Techniques, such as improved customer experience and efficient IT enabled models offer opportunities for FinTech - challenger banks, and other non-financial institutions to provide funds for businesses (EY, 2018).

Forbes Magazine noted that the global banking industry are facing challenges from Fintech financing due to the growing usage and popularity of technologies, such as Blockchain as well as the dominance of millennial (Sorrentino, 2015). Fintech has significantly changed the way financial services are offered and consumed; through greater convenience and lower costs of operations (Arner, et al., 2015). The different technological innovations that have been central to the Fintech growth include cryptocurrencies, blockchain, crowdfunding, and peer-to-peer (P2P) lending amongst others. The Fintech industry has grown to be one of the most accessible for the businesses in the UK (EY, 2018) due to their ability to meet the unique needs of the organisations. Revolutions, especially the movement towards Fintech 3.0 has allowed new and established businesses to acquire financial products and services through Fintech. Due to this evolution, the Fintech financing is viewed as a resourceful and legitimate source of financing (Arner, et al., 2015). These financial services are delivered to the

businesses through the application and usage of technology. Catalini, et al. (2017) noted that Fintech refers to the movement towards decentralisation, disintermediation, as well as digitisation that is enabled by information technologies, such as peer-to-peer networking, machine learning, Blockchain technology, and Open APIs. The use of Fintech financing through P2P lending, Crowdfunding, Neobank and cryptocurrencies for the businesses are explored below.

2.2.2.1. P2P Lending

Peer to Peer lending is one of the applications of the FinTech to offer the digital financial solutions (Arjunwadkar, 2018; Hamarat & Broby, 2022; Gu, et al., 2022). These are online platforms that unite lenders and borrowers that would otherwise not exist through the traditional banking models. This innovative approach links up potential investors with individuals seeking finance needs (Mattarocci & Gibilaro, 2016; Yan & Zhou, 2023). The investor is assured on high returns with low risks being involved. The borrowers with good credit history can access credit at lower rates. The platforms have enablement that can analyse past loan history and the social media interaction patterns. In the UK, Zopa was the first Peer to Peer platform, introduced in 2005 (Coulter, 2018). Later, hundreds of other online platforms sprung up to have a share of the demand for the online lending needs by the customers in need of finance. These platforms offer affordable and convenient P2P connections to the customers in the UK financial market.

In the process of P2P lending as illustrated below in the figure 3, in which borrowers and lenders first register to the P2P online platform. Borrowers are either individuals or companies who seek funds in terms of loan for their personal or business use while lenders are investors who seek a good deal to get return on their investment. Investors usually get interests on their principal loan amount. In the process of registration, borrowers have to provide their IDs, bank account and other personal information for their credit report. Borrowers are group of people who initiate the lending procedure by indicating the amount they want to borrow with

information of how much interest they will on the principal loan amount. On the other hand, lenders are group of people who choose borrowers and fund them loan.

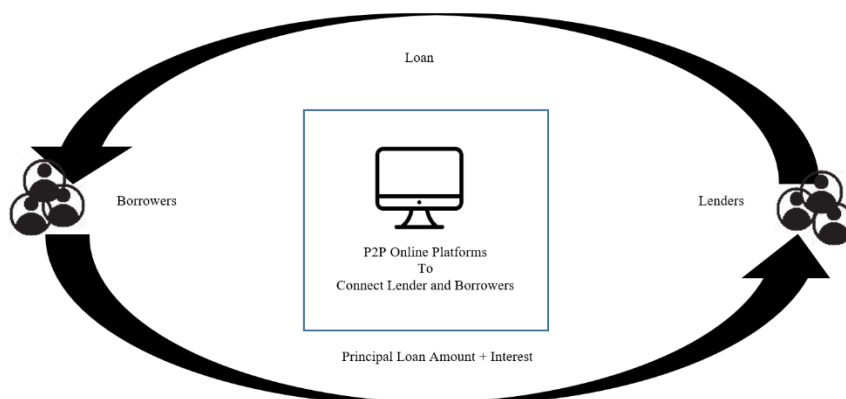


Figure 3: P2P Lending a conceptual process – An illustration

Peer to Peer lending is a major source of funding for the SMEs in the UK. It is estimated that out of €2.9billion issued out through the online lending platforms in 2017, €1.9billion went towards the improvement of SME businesses in the UK (Matarrocci & Gibilaro, 2016). Therefore, the system is salient towards SME growth. In the current financial crises of 2020 with uncertain future, the UK government is supporting SMEs with its new schemes of Coronavirus business interruption loan and bounce back loan in which P2P lenders are also eligible to get accreditation the British Business Bank. In fact, the British Business Bank already work with various P2P leaders to support government backed loan schemes for businesses and SMEs (Gaw, 2020).

Race setter is an online P2P platform that was introduced in 2009 (Orca, 2018). It was developed on the concept of "provision fund" whereby internal insurance is maintained to cushion against borrower default. The platform became operational in 2010. By the month of May 2017, over €2 billion loan amount had been processed through the platform and about 400,000 lenders and borrowers had been connected. Peer to Peer lending ensures access to higher returns with lower risks on investment (Mach, et al., 2014). The risks in investment are spread through the provision of diversified and smaller units of loans advanced to the

borrowers. The investors earn interest faster since the period of loan repayment is shorter (Mohamed & Ali, 2019). The initial capital invested can easily be recovered on demand from the online platform. This online platform has the drawbacks such as the risk of default by the borrower hence loss in the capital if there is no insurance on the amount invested. The interest earned from the loan advanced are taxable hence reduces the margins realised. Borrowing may not be processed immediately since the customer data has to be analysed before approval of a loan request.

Peer to peer (P2P) lending platforms act as intermediaries between the borrowers and the lenders (Arjunwadkar, 2018); thus, taking the previous roles of banks. Since P2P is made up of a number of lenders, the lenders are able to pool their risks across the various SMEs. The first UK P2P lending platform Zopa started operations to connect individuals with lenders (Arjunwadkar, 2018). However, P2P lending expanded to businesses, especially SMEs in the UK. As of 2015, P2P financing of SMEs stood at £1.5 billion, which is equivalent to 6 per cent of all financing of the SMEs in the UK. P2P financing for the SMEs accounted for 22 per cent of all the new loans to small businesses in the UK. Zhang, et al., (2016) noted that the average P2P financing indicate that it is mostly focused on the small businesses market. The UK P2P sector is likely to grow in 2023 up to 1.6% to reach total value of £376.6 million (Gaw, 2023).

The growth in the P2P SME financing has been driven by the various demand and supply factors in the UK. According to Atz & Bholat (2016) the argument that the supply side of the P2P SME financing in the UK may have witnessed the strong growth may be ideological, for instance, the lenders are focused on ways through which they can have control over the manner in which their financing is invested. Baeck, et al. (2014) noted that the most important motivation in the supply side of P2P SME financing is the financial gain as the survey indicated that 82 per cent of the P2P lenders offered the SME financing as a means of gaining financial returns on their investment.

On the demand side, the most important motivation for the SMEs to use P2P financing is the competitiveness in the interest rates as well as the increased speed of access to the financing.

P2P also caters for a segment of the market that would remain unsatisfied (Baeck, et al., 2014). A majority of the SMEs in the UK, especially the newer businesses cannot satisfy the conditions for traditional bank financing, for instance, the inability to provide collateral or even have long-term relationships with the banks. To such SMEs, P2P lending is the only alternative that they can use to get financing for their business activities.

2.2.2.2. Crowdfunding

Crowdfunding is a collective process where a group of individuals pools resources or funds through online sites to support an organisation or a project (Arjunwadkar, 2018; Bao, et al., 2022). The resources and the people are mobilised to achieve a given objective such equity capital, donation, start-up capital etc. (Mohamed & Ali, 2019). Crowdfunding is also known as social media fundraising since the entire fund generation process occurs through an online platform (Lynn, et al., 2019).

Crowdfunding process involves few steps to raise funds (Harrer, et al., 2023) and it usually involves a project (Arjunwadkar, 2018). A project can be a new idea, product, service, event or a campaign with a clear purpose and an outcome to raise funds or the project can be based on sourcing funds for existing businesses. Fundraiser, through crowd funding platforms, raise small amount of money from large number of peoples by using crowd funding FinTech platforms. The entire process is illustrated in the figure 4.

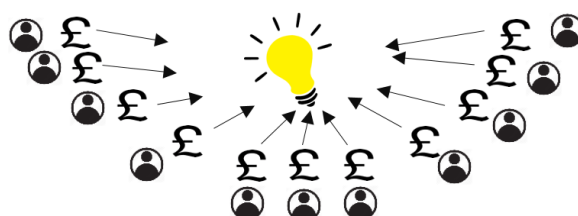


Figure 4: Crowdfunding a conceptual process

The crowd funding differs from traditional financing because fundraises do not require to present a business plan or have to go through due diligence and credit checks to raise funds. In this process, fundraisers just create a new product, idea, service, event or any campaign which has a clear funding amount and a targeted specific date. Once it is decided that the specific amount to be raised, fundraises normally create a video or specific document with description about the project for the audience. Once the project is advertised to the crowd funding sites, then funds are raised from number of peoples or businesses around the world. These people or businesses represent the term 'crowd' in the crowd funding and they have their expectations, desires and independent decisions to finance the project. In the UK, crowdfunding sites such as Crowd cube, Kickstarter, seedrs, crowd funder, fundit.buzz are some of the commonly used crowdfunding platforms. These sites also charge their own commissions which is a percentage of the specific fund.

While the crowdfunding market is still small in the UK, in terms of financing of the SMEs, there has been significant growth from the time of the financial crisis of 2008. Online platforms facilitated £3.2 billion of donations, investments and loans to the SMEs in the UK in 2015 (Zhang, et al., 2016). The global crowdfunding market is growing continuously and it is projected for \$1.41 billion in 2023 from \$1.25 billion in 2022 (Fortune Business Insights, 2023). According to the UK's Financial Conduct Authority (FCA), crowdfunding covers the various donation, equity and loan-based online models (FCA, 2023).

The more commonly used crowdfunding for SMEs is equity based where the crowd funders invest to seek a potential return on the business shares in exchange of equity (Arjunwadkar, 2018; Chu, et al., 2017). The main benefits of investors are the return on equity. Equity-based crowdfunding allows investors to be able to purchase shares in SMEs and other unlisted firms. The main motivation of the investors is to share the returns from the SMEs. Equity-based crowdfunding is mostly used by the SMEs in the UK (Wachira & Wachira, 2022; Erasmus, et al., 2022; Li, 2022) for capital expansion, start-up or seed capital; an indication of the breaking of the pecking order theory of funding preferences (Baeck, et al., 2014). The theory holds that

SMEs would traditionally prefer internal financing from family, friends and founders before the SMEs can even consider the use of external financing.

Appendix 6 provides the details of different types of crowdfunding in the UK.

2.2.2.3. *Neobanks and Challenger Banks SME Financing*

Neobanks are Fintech driven technology (Banga, et al., 2023) or digital lenders who offer specialised financial services for the SMEs, especially since such SMEs are underserved by the incumbent traditional lenders (Lu, 2018). The reasons for the existing underservice of the SMEs is explained above under the Traditional SME financing subtopic. Despite the Neobanks being authorised by the Prudential Regulation Authority (PRA) and regulated by the FCA, the Neobanks have changed the way SMEs in the UK use bank financing. Some prominent examples of Fintech Neobanks in the UK include Atom, Monzo, Starling, OneSavings, Aldermore and Tandem amongst others (Lu, 2018). Some of the neobanks in the UK have concentrated their services on offering specialised financing for the SMEs. Further, SMEs in the UK also use neobanks financing as such banks are customer-centric in terms of ethical culture adoption and fairness. Since the neobanks are mostly online-based, they have developed distinct distribution systems that allow them to reach many SMEs as opposed to the current practice of many traditional banks that still focus on the traditional brick and mortar branches.

Even though the neobanks, just like the traditional banks, take deposits from the public and then lend the loans to the borrowers, they tend to offer tailored financing options to the SMEs (Erel & Inozemtsev, 2022), for instance, SME mortgage, invoice and asset finance (Lu, 2018). Taking the example of asset finance, the UK SMEs are able to gain financing for the purchase of a relevant asset and then make affordable monthly rents or payments. Further, invoice discounting offered by the neobanks to the SMEs in the UK allow the SMEs to maintain credit control as well as the collection facility (Lu, 2018).

Due to the online operations of the neobanks, there are lower costs of operations that are passed on to the SMEs in terms of competitive interest rates for the financing. The financiers, the neobanks, are also able to achieve higher profit margins due to the lower costs. Aldermore, one of the challengers/ neobanks in the UK, recorded 3% of the total asset financing to the SMEs in the UK in 2015 (Lu, 2018). While in 2020, The UK challenger Starling bank raised €44.3 million to support SMEs (Tucker, 2020). In 2023, UK neobank Revolut is the most funded bank of worth of \$1.71 billion funds (Fintech Global, 2023).

The significance of the digital-based neobanks to the SME financing in the UK is twofold. First, the neobanks play an important role in the channelling of credit from the depositors to the UK SMEs through bespoke loan services, such as commercial mortgages, invoice discounting, and asset financing; thus, providing the necessary financing for the operating cash and credit for the SMEs. Secondly, through the market niche, the neobanks have recorded significant growth and have become very profitable. As of 2014, the neobanks that were listed in the FTSE All-Share Banks Index outperformed the traditional lenders thus generating significant returns to the lenders (Lu, 2018). The specialised market target coupled with the cost-effectiveness in their operations has enabled the neobanks to compete and even outperform the traditional banks.

2.2.2.4. Cryptocurrency

A cryptocurrency is a form of disruptive currency (Burniske, 2015) that involves encryption of information thread to represent a currency (Hafishina, et al., 2023; Lo, 2022; Valdez & Hernandez, 2022). It is a digital and decentralised currency (Nafis, et al., 2019). The currency is reviewed and monitored through a Peer to Peer network called Blockchain (Mohamed & Ali, 2019). The blockchain is a digital ledger that ensures a secure and an easy mode of maintaining the transactional data, agreements and contracts (Lansiti & Lakhani, 2017) and generate cryptocurrencies (Arjunwadkar, 2018) . Cryptocurrency is formed through a cryptographic algorithm that is verifiable and stable through the mining process (Zhang & Xue,

2019). Examples of this currency include Bitcoin, ether, Litecoin etc. Companies in the UK are investing in blockchain following recognition by the parliament as a digital financial product (Monaghan, 2018). The currency is gaining popularity in the UK. The UK has immense potential of being the FinTech hub because of the advanced progress in the use of the digital financial product (Monaghan, 2018).

Forbes noted that cryptocurrencies have a great potential for the UK SMEs to gain borderless financing access (Clarke, 2018). The expansion of blockchain has led to the SME financing on the condition of invoices ensuring that payments are prompt. The first successful initial coin offering (ICO) called Debitum was launched in September 2018; raising \$17 million that would be available for the financing of SMEs. ICO entails the use of blockchain technology to create digital tokens by SMEs to investors (OECD , 2019). The digital tokens are then exchanged for first-generation cryptocurrencies, such as Bitcoin. ICOs are enabled through the use of Distributed Ledger Technologies (DLTs), such as blockchain that allows for the value exchange without the need for a trusted intermediary or central authority. The DLTs allows for improvement in efficiency due to the disintermediation.

Although presently not used for the SME financing in the UK, there is a significant potential, especially the potential for profit-making. ICOs have the potential to create value through the potential network effects and efficiency gains enabled through blockchain technology. However, there is limited legal clarity in the use of cryptocurrencies in the UK; thus, can pose some risks to the SMEs that participate in the ICOs. In theory, the use of cryptocurrencies as an alternative Fintech financing model would lead to the democratisation of the SME financing, as well as distributing the control amongst the token holders and the SMEs; rather than concentrating the power of decision making in the hands of the traditional financiers for SMEs (OECD , 2019). Cryptocurrencies will also allow the SMEs in the UK to be able to diversify the financing options (Phạm, 2022) by appealing to the financiers in terms of the characteristics of the projects that the SME is engaged in as well as the profitability. Through the use of DLTs,

there would be significant efficiency gains from innovation and automation application thus further driving the disintermediation.

In theory, the SMEs will share in the efficiencies with the investors; thus, leading to lower costs of financing as compared to the use of IPOs. Further, cryptocurrencies would also provide SMEs in the UK with access to a large pool of investors that increase the potential for the SMEs to gain funding. However, in practice, there would be some risks to the investors as the lack of central control or authority can expose such investors (OECD , 2019). ICOs have a significant potential to overcome some of the challenges that SMEs in the UK face at the initial stages coupled with the unwillingness of the SME owners to give away the equity in their firms at the early stages of the firm's existence. ICOs is an example of how cryptocurrencies can be used as an alternative financing model for the SMEs.

The main benefits of cryptocurrencies in the financing of the SMEs in the UK include cost efficiencies in terms of the efficiency gains from the automation and use of blockchain, and the cost savings as a result of disintermediation (Miller, et al., 2023; Alshater, et al., 2022; OECD, 2019). The advantage is the inclusive SME financing through the unrestricted access to investors, active participation of the SMEs in the investor networks as well as the SME financing democratisation. The other benefits of cryptocurrencies in the SME financing are speed, liquidity and flexibility (Busayatananphon & Boonchieng, 2022; Harris, 2023; Daidai & Tamnine, 2023) through faster execution speed, almost immediate liquidity, as well as the ability of the SMEs to invest in a fraction of the token. The other potential benefits include direct access and diversity due to unlimited access to global investor pools (OECD , 2019). The other benefits that SMEs in the UK would gain from the use of cryptocurrencies in the financing include value creation through network effects monetisation as well as no dilution of rights or even the conferring of the entrepreneur's ownership rights.

Despite the existence of the potential benefits from the use of cryptocurrencies in the financing of SMEs, there are also a host of limitations. First, there is uncertainty with regards to the regulation. Since the regulatory framework for the ICOs is not clear in the UK, the SMEs and

other participants (investors) would be exposed to significant risks (Zetsche, et al., 2018). Regulatory uncertainty exists in the DLTs in terms of the enforceability of the contracts as the UK is yet to develop standard laws on Smart Contracts. Further, there is limited investor protection due to the volatility in the prices of the crypto-assets thus raising concerns about the suitability of the instruments to the investors. Finally, there is also a general lack of regulatory compliance and corporate governance. Regulatory reporting is significantly lacking and due to this, the large investors and stakeholders can have great space to manipulate the prices (OECD , 2019). Despite this, SMEs in the UK have increasingly been drawn to the use of crypto assets in the financing of their activities due to the lower costs, associated with the financing, the faster speeds as well as the limited requirement for long-term relationships before funding can be offered.

2.2.2.5. *The role of technology in Fintech*

The FinTech market is expanding rapidly throughout the world due to the increase in the usage of smartphones and the digital transformation of financial service organisations to innovate their systems (Anifa et al., 2022; Guo, 2023; Chin et al., 2023). FinTech has introduced new business models where digital platforms are used to meet the needs of customers or businesses. These platforms are technology-enabled, such as peer-to-peer, crowdfunding, and cryptocurrency. The world has invested a lot during the last decade in FinTech to meet users' needs. According to EY Global (2017), 48% of users worldwide, especially the young generation aged 25-34, prefer technology-enabled Fintech platforms to make payments and transfer money. The technological changes in the world economy have led to massive variations in structural financial management by different organisations. Technology has a significant impact on the economy and influences organisations' financing decisions. That is because technology provides efficiency way of interaction to exchange of information between the financial providers and the companies (Chang, et al., 2012). The blockchain in finance is well known technology to confirm the secure monetary transactions for P2P and

cryptocurrency (Onyekwere, et al., 2023). It is based on machine learning, a branch of Artificial Intelligence (AI), where system learn from the raw data, perform specific tasks, and make decisions without minimal human involvement. In summary, the blockchain and technology embedded models facilitate FinTech financing. The main triggers of FinTech are the excessive use of technology in this digital world (Kasiewicz, et al., 2023; Langley & Leyshon, 2023; Rupeika-Apoga & Wendt, 2022) to deliver financial services (Natarajan, et al., 2017). Due to this technology enable features in Fintech, it reduces the high cost of funding by traditional banks has led SMEs to consider Fintech financing. The challenges experienced during the global financial crisis, the highest inflation, Covid-19 disasters, and the highest inflation are addressed by technology enabled FinTech. For example, during the period of Coronavirus outbreak in the world, the use of social media has increased in the UK and Europe as compared to previous years (Johnson, 2020). Social media such as Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn and interactive platforms such as P2P and crowdfunding enable people interact online for their financial needs. In the recent report published by eMarketer (2018), there are estimated 2.55 billion users use social media and mobile applications and due to this, mobile commerce is estimated to reach \$278.9 billion in 2018. The mobile e-commerce has reached to \$2.2 trillion in 2023 to accumulate 60% of all e-commerce sales in the world (Buchholz, 2023).

Keeping in view the threat of Fintech, the financial sectors such as banks have started to use software solutions offered by FinTech which are easily integrated by application program interfaces (API). Banks started to partner with FinTech companies without relying on heavy investments to overcome their existing hurdles and enhance their payment and lending innovation. The prominent examples are Barclays partnership with MarketInvoice and rainmaking, Lloyds with Nayaone, HSBC with monese, Natwest with Vodeno (Kumar & Chakraborty, 2022). Accepting new and modern technologies depends on several factors, including user-friendliness, easy access to funding and efficiency to influence users' behaviour to use of Fintech platforms.

2.3. CEOs' decision making on financing and the research framework development

2.3.1. CEOs' funding preference

CEOs of organisations, including SMEs, often focus on achieving sustainable competitive advantage (Srivastava, et al., 2013; Kumar, 2016; Kahupi, et al., 2021; Quan, et al., 2021). Being the driving force of SMEs, CEOs' financing decisions are essential to their organisations' success in the competitive market. The sustainable competitive advantage is a significant point of concern in SME financing (Sadalia, et al., 2020; Peprah & Ayaa, 2022), especially in the face of substitution and disruptive innovation (Ghemawat, 2006; Christensen, et al., 2015) due to FinTech (Chen & Li, 2019; Zhao, et al., 2019; Reyes-Mercado & Reyes-Mercado, 2021). FinTech entails various technologies, such as big data analytics, blockchain technology, machine learning, open APIs, and peer-to-peer networking (Catalini, et al., 2017) to provide innovative financing solutions (Puschmann, 2017; Rajeswari & Vijai, 2021; Giglio, 2021). Traditionally, SMEs seek financing solutions from financial institutions, for instance, using credit cards, bank loans, leasing, asset finance, and commercial mortgages. Alternative traditional finance includes grants and government schemes to support SMEs in the UK (EY, 2018). However, many SMEs rely on their internal funds, such as savings (Hussain, et al., 2006; Jiang, et al., 2014; Rao, et al., 2023), and many, at least 36%, seek finance from their directors and family members at their first instant before moving to traditional financial institutions (British Business Bank, 2021).

In the competitive market, CEOs' financing preferences can be their strategic choice or the role of technology to influence their behaviour as to which mode of financing should be preferred for their organisations. For example, in the SMEs that traditionally relied on traditional financing by banks, the rise of FinTech in the financing space can adopt several possible strategic responses (Ghemawat, 2006). The response can be in the form of not

responding at all, where an organisation maintains the traditional financing options they have always used. Organisations which don't respond to the change are less innovative (Chan, et al., 2019). The other strategic direction is combining financing from both traditional financing sources while adopting FinTech's new financing. Switching strategy, which entails the shift to the exclusive use of FinTech financing stimulates innovation (Trabucchi & Buganza, 2019). Closely linked to substitution is the concept of disruption (Kivimaa, et al., 2021). Christensen, et al. (2015) identified that disruption refers to the process when the new entrants with limited or fewer resources challenge the existing companies. The majority of CEOs face a dilemma about whether they can maintain the status quo or adopt radical changes to the financing (Christensen & Raynor, 2003). The main considerations are regarding the risk and potential opportunities in the new financing options available under FinTech. However, these strategic choices depend on the business life cycle (Madhani, 2014; La Rocca, et al., 2011; Johnson, et al., 2020), e.g. at the cycle of their business start-up, growth and maturity stage. The sources of funds for start-up businesses are particularly related to entrepreneurial finance (Alemany & Andreoli, 2018; Anwar, et al., 2020; Da Rin & Hellmann, 2020), where decisions can be based on borrowing from friends, family, crowdfunding, incubators, accelerators, business angels, venture capital and through private equity. Meanwhile, the existing businesses have challenges to grow and sustain in the competitive business environment. The sources of funds (appendix 1) for established businesses depend on the unique needs (Keary, 2020), strategic decisions (Johnson, et al., 2020), funding strategies (Shepherd, et al., 2015) and many other reasons such as cost and efficiency of transactions. For example, SMEs use Fintech financing due to the efficiencies gains from the use of blockchain (Pizzi, et al., 2021; Alshareef & Tunio, 2022; Bag, et al., 2023) and the cost savings as a result of disintermediation (OECD , 2019; Pasterny, 2021; Muda, et al., 2021). Since the banks are not involved in such financing, the costs for the SMEs are lower, thus leading to greater affordability of the funding. Another reason is that SMEs fear that using traditional bank loans would lead to a loss of control (Burgstaller & Wagner, 2015; Yazdanfar & Öhman, 2015; Jude & Adamou, 2018). In this sense, SMEs prefer to use alternative financing through Fintech to

ensure they maintain control of their businesses. Further, the use of FinTech financing offers unrestricted access to the investors for quick cash in flexible negotiated terms, which traditional financing does not offer (Fenwick, et al., 2018; OECD, 2019; Bollaert et al., 2021). However, despite the benefits of Fintech financing, the published corporate reports such as Small Business Market Report 2018-19 confirmed both funding through traditional banks and Fintech also increased over the years (British Business Bank, 2018) and gross lending to SMEs by banks increased every quarter up to 14 billion since 2014 to 167 billion in 2018 (OECD, 2019). The current survey report suggests that the external funding for SMEs was higher during COVID-19 due to business support, and it significantly dropped to 30% in 2023 from 59% in 2021 (British Business Bank, 2024) . According to the report by British Business Bank, SMEs' awareness of alternative external funding sources increased since 2012 such as P2P lending 24% to 53% in 2017 and crowdfunding 13% to 60% in 2017 (British Business Bank, 2018). The awareness for alternative sources of funds such business angels, marketplace lending, crowdfunding remained consistent in the past four years (British Business Bank, 2024).

The technological changes have led organisations to move towards innovative funding options. Decision-makers such as CEOs have the capability to prefer technological innovation if it provides them with better facilities such as convenience, efficiency and sustainability for competitive advantage. With regards to the alternative sources of Financing via Fintech, Bruton, et al. (2015) undertook a study that investigated the new financing options available to SMEs and entrepreneurs to start and grow their ventures, such as P2P lending and crowdfunding, through a systematic approach framework. The research has often focused on the risks and opportunities of the technologies; for instance, Lindman, et al. (2017) explored the risks and opportunities of blockchain in payments. The research by Lindman, et al. (2017) explored risk and opportunities based on three sets of issues: technological design, organisational and competitive environment issues. The opportunities have been explored by the research undertaken by Lemieux & Lemieux (2016), who explored the value of blockchain

technology in preserving and creating trustworthy digital records. The trustworthiness of the records is an important consideration for the CEOs who explore the financing options for their SMEs. On the other hand, Chuen, et al. (2015) explored the elements of digital technologies through the use of the LASIC acronym (Low margin, Asset Light, Scalable, Innovative and Compliance easy) as the most essential principle for FinTech success. The research explored M-PESA (a payment solution developed by Safaricom PLC, a subsidiary of Vodafone) and Alibaba by examining how they aid financial inclusion (Chuen, et al, 2015).

Systematic and rigorous research on FinTech is still at a very infant stage due to lacking a robust empirical and theoretical base. Most of the existing research has been undertaken by banks, government bodies and consultants, with the exception of a few researchers. However, the bulk of theoretically grounded research is found in crowdfunding, an important financial capital source for SMEs and other nascent entrepreneurs (Bruton, et al., 2015). There is a significant gap in the literature as most of the existing literature focuses on adopting e-banking as opposed to FinTech and the available financing models, such as crowdfunding, P2P and cryptocurrency. A number of research undertaken in the past explored the adoption of mobile banking due to the advancement in technology (Lule et al., 2012; Aboelmaged & Gebba, 2013; Ooi & Tan, 2016; Marakarkandy et al., 2017; Hu et al., 2019). Much existing research focuses on different aspects of Fintech, including its benefits and its adoption due to a number of competitive advantages it offers. For example, research by Piyananda and Aluthge (2023) identifies the increasing trends in Fintech acceptance due to COVID-19, considering the opinions of CEOs. The outcome confirmed that a number of factors such as trust, Fintech features and awareness are key factors for the positive trend of Fintech in the market. A similar study identifies easy-to-use and perceived benefits as the main drivers influencing consumers towards Fintech (Singh et al., 2020; Nangin et al., 2020; Hasan et al., 2021). The other existing research have mixed results regarding the adoption of Fintech over traditional mainly because it offers the reduction of financial cost (Carlin, et al., 2017; He, et al., 2017; Najib, et al., 2021; Kumari & Devi, 2022; Ornelas & Pecora, 2022; Elliehausen & Hannon, 2023), saves time

(Setiawan, et al., 2021) and provide safety and trust (Hasan, et al., 2021). Emerging markets where Fintech is preferred mainly because of the higher financial literacy (Nugraha, et al., 2022). Further, Fintech advancement poses risks to commercial banks due to its influence on CEOs to get alternative sources of funds (Vasiljeva & Lukanova, 2016). In the competitive market, CEOs' roles have become crucial for their businesses' competitive advantage and long-term sustainability by considering their financing preferences, which include opportunities and challenges, either through traditional financing routes or Fintech. The research question relating to the CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the changing economic and financial technology environment is still unexplored. Therefore, the first research question is proposed below: -

Research Question 1: How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?

2.3.2. Key micro factors in FinTech financing decisions making

Research on SMEs have been undertaken for a number of decades, especially on the role of leadership in making important decisions in organisations. Literature from the early 80s to date have indicated that the success of a firm is highly dependent on the possession of top management skills and capabilities (Hambrick & Mason, 1984; Analoui & Karami, 2003; Ahn, et al., 2013) that reflects CEOs' productivity in their decisions. Scholars such as Ahn, et al., (2013) have theorised that since the majority of SMEs are highly centralised, i.e., the CEO has a larger and more critical role in the making of various important decisions such as finding suitable funding sources. The CEOs' decisions are based on their leadership styles (Hoxha, 2019; Cho, et al., 2019; Ugwu & Okore, 2020; Purwanto, 2021) and underpinning leadership and decision-making theories to make financing decisions. As the leadership qualities of CEOs play a central role in the adoption or non-adoption of innovations, The main focus of the following section is to identify the closely related literature and the empirical evidence on CEOs' factors in navigating their decisions.

2.3.2.1. *Personal Leadership Qualities*

Leadership is a process or attributes of multidimensional skills (Sadler, 2003; Shakeel, et al., 2019; Benmira & Agboola, 2021; Kwiotkowska, et al., 2022) and a relationship between those who desire to lead and those who are willing to follow (Gallos, 2008; Tannenbaum & Schmidt, 2017; Kouzes & Posner, 2023). There is substantial literature and empirical research focused on identifying the leadership qualities for CEOs to make essential decisions in different organisational situations. These attributes of CEOs are primarily personal and related to their honesty, integrity, inspiring others, good communication, creativity, reliance and vision (Hasan, 2019). According to Northhouse (2016), the personal traits of leaders are those characteristics which individuals possess to influence others to achieve organisational goals. For example, achieving financing preferences for the benefit of their organisations in the long run. Scholars also describe leadership as inborn qualities of individuals (Morkes, 2009; Singh, 2012; Toh & Ruot, 2019), and due to those inborn attributes, individuals are comfortable to inspire and lead others in the organisation. In the organisation, the most common functions of leadership are establishing a vision, setting strategies, communicating goals with people, building teams, and motivating, aspiring and empowering followers (Northhouse, 2016; Sumayya, 2023). That also includes power as one of the personal characteristics of leaders to influence others within the organisation (Spence, et al., 2013). For example, CEOs have the power to make important funding decisions. According to Ross (2015), there are several personality dimensions of leadership, such as self-esteem, how people feel about themselves as leaders and their personal values to serve as a code of conduct to develop their leadership qualities. Individuals' feelings about themselves are consistently dominant by their self-confidence. Self-esteem is associated with leaders' self-motivation and attributes such as attitudes, beliefs and actions (Ross, 2014; Axelrod, 2017; Anninos, 2018). In today's world, organisations prefer to have people perform different tasks, such as managing and leading people and projects (Morkes, 2009; Leal Filho et al., 2020; Malhotra, 2021). These organisations, regardless of their size, offer training to improve their employees' leadership

skills so they can make important decisions. That is evident from the UK Department of Education's current management and leadership apprenticeship scheme for management (Department of Education, 2020) to enhance the people's leadership skills in the organisation. Whereas CEOs' personal leadership qualities are important factors in influencing their decision-making (Connie & Cull, 2018). Differentiation between different types of leaders and their leadership styles is essential to identify the contribution of their personal leadership traits to justify their financing preferences. This has been ostensible from the following empirical evidence, closely linked to the literature relating to the CEO's personal leadership qualities to influence their decisions to accept innovation and make financial decisions.

Kaplan, et al. (2012) found that CEOs have leadership traits that include respect, efficiency, and development of people, personal integrity in their work, calmness, strategic visions, pro-activeness, oral communication, and interpersonal and intellectual skills. These leadership traits contribute to their decisions and are positively linked to organisational success. Chen et al. (2013) identified CEOs' transformational leadership styles as personal qualities of dominance, self-confidence, desire to influence others and strong moral values. This is consistent with the charismatic leaders' qualities of being fighters, intellectuals, persuasive in communication, entrepreneurs, and strategic in having long-term visions (Avolio & Yammarino, 2013). However, it is opposed to the traits of transactional leadership, which are considered to have the qualities of being logical decision-makers, practical, directive and responsive to their followers (Anastasia, 2018). Nadkarni & Herrmann (2010) identified CEOs' personal characteristics include emotional stability, openness, extraversion, and conscientiousness. Haas & Speckbacher (2017) identified controlling as the dominant personality factor of CEO leadership. In the other empirical evidence by Huang et al. (2019), the researchers emphasised CEOs' power as a leadership trait is positively linked to organisational innovation. On the other hand, Simsek et al. (2010) identified that the self-esteem and emotional self-control traits of CEOs' leadership contribute to their decisions.

To conclude above, the success of SMEs is largely dependent on leadership. According to Ibarra et al. (2020), CEOs make creative and innovative decisions in organisations as per their leadership styles. Every style has different effects on the culture and effectiveness of an organisation. Leadership affects employee morale and productivity and sets the organisation's tone. CEOs of SMEs must embrace leadership styles consistent with their company objectives and grasp the subtleties of the position. The existing literature support leadership traits as inborn qualities (Nadkarni & Herrmann, 2010; Simsek, et al., 2010; Kaplan, et al., 2012; Chen, et al., 2013; Han, et al., 2016; Haas & Speckbacher, 2017 Huang, et al., 2019; Ibarra et al., 2020). CEOs' leadership traits are more related to their confidence, personality, leading teams, integrity, and many other attributes that influence their decisions and are linked to the organisation's performance. Mixed findings by leading researchers confirm that leadership traits are either positively linked to the organisation's performance or that some traits, such as the CEO's power, are negatively associated with the firm's performance. However, these leadership traits help CEOs to make entrepreneurial decisions (Simsek, et al., 2010), which leads to financial innovation (Block, et al., 2021).

The main emphasis of the above empirical evidence and literature is that leadership traits are multi-dimensional qualities of CEOs and characteristics they acquire during their career. These traits contribute to their organisational decisions, including financing, and these are associated with their leadership styles.

2.3.2.2. *Personal Vision*

CEOs are responsible for making decisions, leading their executives' teams, and ensuring the organisation achieves the set goals. CEOs align the organisation around set priorities and shared goals and use their vision to guide their decisions. The CEOs' characteristics and personalities influence the strategic decision-making process of an organisation. A vision is an idealised goal that an organisation's CEO envisions to achieve in the future (Men, et al., 2020). Based on upper echelons theory, an organisation's top management influences

financial and strategic decisions (Collins, 2020; Ji et al., 2023). As strategic and visionary leaders, CEOs are better positioned to understand the organisational strategic direction through their strategic vision and choices that reflect their characteristics and use their influence to guide the decision-making process. There is congruence in existing findings that top executives of organisations play significant roles in creating and communicating a clear vision to stakeholders and employees when making strategic decisions (Ji et al., 2023; Men et al., 2020). Therefore, CEOs use their visions to enable organisational change toward achieving strategic and financial goals. Much research has been conducted on the CEO's vision and organisational performance. When a particular CEO has a vision, they will make decisions aligned with the strategic vision. The success of the organisation depends on the vision of its senior managers, aligning their vision with the organisational vision (Berg, 2015; Slåtten et al., 2021) that improves the employee's performance in work. According to Maran et al. (2022), leaders use their visions to influence employees as part of ensuing goal achievement. As such, CEOs who lead with vision and give employees autonomy are better placed to make effective decisions that shape the company. Evidence suggests that communication with a clear vision allows leaders to influence decision-making and set goals aligned with long-term strategic objectives (Collins, 2020; Maran et al., 2022). Prabhu and Srivastava (2023) associate transformational leaders who are visionary with better performance of SMEs. Transformational leaders communicate their vision to their subordinates and use that information to develop solutions faced by SMEs. These leaders can inspire employees, fostering a shared vision in an organisation. Based on empirical evidence, transformational CEOs communicate their vision, encourage their team to develop innovative solutions and mentor them to realise high-performance standards (Prabhu & Srivastava, 2023). Therefore, a transformative leader's vision is integral in promoting successful decision-making, including strategic changes within SMEs (Ng & Sears, 2020; Prabhu & Srivastava, 2023). The role of CEOs is to ensure the sustainability and competitiveness of organisations, which can be achieved by communicating their vision. Evidence suggests that CEOs have considerable influence and power within companies and are responsible for determining the

direction (Ji, et al., 2023). CEOs use their power during decision-making to motivate, inspire, and guide team members toward the set organisational goals. Unlike Men et al. (2020), Ji et al. (2023) established that although CEOs have power and influence, they use their position to communicate the organisation's visions. Therefore, organisational vision is vital in guiding the decisions held by CEOs because they have a responsibility to different stakeholders.

Several studies have explored the impact of CEOs' vision articulation on a firm's sustainability (Ashford, et al., 2018). CEOs are essential in SMEs since they lead their growth through strategic decision-making (Li, et al., 2020). The research by Lee et al. (2022) associates the CEO's vision for CSR with better-performing SMEs. Cognitive CEOs will improve organisational performance and promote CSR activity (Li, et al., 2020). Better organisational performance will be achieved when the CEO has a clear vision. Yuanyuan et al. (2022) affirmed that a CEO articulating a strong vision goes for innovative strategies and takes calculated risks. Notably, this gives an SME a competitive advantage. The capabilities of a CEO enable a firm to achieve a competitive advantage (Huang et al., 2019; Shahab et al., 2020). Friedman and Carmeli (2022) noted that although executives might struggle to form a coherent vision when a CEO has great implementation capacity, they can transform an organisation into a better position. The role of CEOs cannot be underestimated; they are seen as the drivers of an organisation's success through their decisions. The CEO's role is becoming complex and very demanding. Therefore, they should envision where they want to take their company (Citrin, et al., 2019).

According to Neely et al. (2020), numerous studies have explored how executives' traits affect their actions and how these influence an organisation's performance. A visionary leader develops a good relationship with the employees in an organisation, which acts as a source of inspiration (Nwokedi, 2015). The personality traits of a CEO are essential in dictating the effectiveness of a company. CEOs better understand their traits to motivate employees and achieve organisational goals and objectives. Since vision is a vital element in CEOs' leadership, a leader's vision gives a clear and compelling picture of the future, and this acts as a source of inspiration for employees (Kurdyukov, 2023). Kurdyukov (2023) noted that

through a clear vision, employees have a better understanding of the purpose of the organisation they are working for and the strategic direction the organisation is taking. Preller et al. (2020) noted that effective vision communication guides a team in an organisation towards a common goal, a significant characteristic of effective leadership behaviour. A leader's vision guides the allocation of resources in an organisation. A CEO with a clear vision allocates resources in a manner that leads to efficient and effective usage of resources. Visionary leadership leads to organisational agility (Yilmaz, 2023). All the above empirical studies have supported the idea that an organisation's CEO's vision influences decision-making, leading to better organisational performance, employee motivation, innovation, and effective resource allocation. However, it is not known whether vision helps in their financing preferences.

2.3.2.3. Values, Family and beliefs

Values are general principles that guide human actions, in particular, provide direction to their attitudes, beliefs and behaviour (Connie & Cull, 2018; Duréndez, et al., 2023) and integrity (Liborius, 2021) in their decision-making (Schmoldt, et al., 2001; Pasewark & Riley, 2010; Sutherland, 2022). The empirical evidence to justify this claim is reflected through the closely related study of Löfving, et al. (2013). They found that personal values guide CEOs within the organisational culture. That organisational culture works on a set of beliefs to influence CEOs' ways of thinking and action, which ultimately influence their decision-making. Gorgievski, et al. (2011) concluded with similar findings that there is a positive relationship between small business owners' values and their organisational success. The findings of Gorgievski, et al. (2011) and Löfving, et al. (2013) are aligned by the research of Berson, et al. (2008) who found that CEOs' values include self-direction of creativity, safety, independence in decision-making, kindness, and security values, and these values provide them with a framework or self-code of conduct in their roles within firms. The results of the study support that the value and creativity of CEOs result in positive outcomes for the organisation, such as the adoption of innovation.

Further, CEOs with high values also create an innovative and supportive culture in the organisation. Yang & Lee (2019) investigated the inhibitors and enablers of the adoption of crowdfunding by SMEs. The research findings confirmed that the values are important and critical for the success of the innovation or the technology acceptance. The empirical evidence indicates that inhibitors such as complexity, operational costs as well and reputational risks have a negative impact on the value alignment of the CEO towards the adoption of crowdfunding in the financing of SMEs. The findings are similar and supported by Ryu (2018) research on Fintech users with regard to the impact on the adoption and the continuance usage of Fintech financing. Further, Gannon and Hieker (2022) also found that the internal stakeholders in Fintech SMEs are believed to focus on environmental, social, and governance for long-term financial stability, attract investors, and align with their values. In addition, Gannon and Hieker (2022) found that the participants wanted to be part of a firm that shared their values. A significant study by Vitt in 2004 confirms that individual financial decision-making involves personal values (Vitt, 2004). Therefore, personal values play a crucial role in shaping an individual's corporate decisions; however, due to limited research, it is not known whether values could be one of the micro factors navigating CEOs in their Fintech decisions, on which the current study will focus.

The involvement of family members reflects the family's strategic decision-making but is less explored in the literature (Buchanan, et al., 2022). There are mixed findings in the literature regarding the impacts of family members on the productivity of SMEs. For example, some researchers found that involving family members in the management of SMEs increases firms' performance while others found that relying on family members instead of professional managers could lead to inefficiencies in decision-making (Buchanan, et al., 2022). According to Irdiana et al. (2022), factors such as the presence of a reference group, family, and role and status are among individuals' considerations in taking a loan. The higher influence of family members and reference groups increases an individual's decision to take a loan (Irdiana, et al., 2022). Jonathan (2021) conducted a study and found that family background, financial

technology, perception of risk, and financial literacy influence investment decisions among millennials. Specifically, family background had positive effects on investment decisions. In this study, CEOs who shared their firm's information with family members would be more likely to incorporate family members' decisions when making Fintech decisions. Anderson & Reeb (2003) found that their family has an impact on the CEOs, and there is a positive association between the family CEOs and the financial performance of companies. The findings of Anderson & Reeb (2003) were supported by Chrisman, et al. (2004) research on small private US family and non-family-run businesses. Chrisman et al. (2004) found that family involvement in businesses positively impacts the firm's ability to achieve its economic and non-economic goals. The empirical evidence and literature signifying the role of the family.

CEOs' roles, particularly behaviour and confidence level, impact their corporate decision-making (Malmendier & Tate, 2015), including their religious belief (Baxamusa & Jalal, 2016). The prior research by Osoba (2003) confirms the significance of the beliefs on human actions. Osoba (2003) concluded that risk-avoiders people attend more churches than risk-takers. The results of Osoba (2003) are consistent with research by Hui & Hilary (2008) who found that firms in the most religious areas are risk avoiders in their decision-making. In the study of CEOs' religious affiliation to influence their decision-making, Baxamusa & Jalal (2016) indicated a solid religious implicate of CEOs in their decision-making. Results of the study further confirmed CEOs' actions and decisions due to beliefs impact the firm's performance.

In the causal study conducted by Setiawan et al. (2021), user attitude is influenced by the social factor which is the most critical factor in predicting Fintech adoption. There are three approaches to influencing an individual's behaviours to social influence, including (a) internalisation, (b) identification, and (d) compliance (Alkhwaldi, et al., 2022). Internalisation and identification amend an individual's beliefs based on subjective norms or social status. Compliance involves an individual's amending their belief. In the context of this study, social factors guide CEOs in their Fintech financing decision-making, which can contribute to their beliefs about preferring Fintech financing. The FinTech solutions focus on factors directly

associated with CEOs' personal beliefs when making the funding choice. For example, a study by Mascarenhas et al. (2021) regarding the benefits and risks of using Fintech financing options can be based on technological innovation to provide perceived benefits and risks that could influence their personal beliefs. Mascarenhas et al. (2021) assessed four diverse types of perceived risks associated with the personal beliefs of the consumers: Legal, financial, operational risks, and security. The researcher stated that FinTech monetary losses are inversely related to continued use intent due to the inadequate operation of the financial transaction structure, money laundering, ethical risk, and excessive transaction charges related to the cost of early adoption. Given that the FinTech sector has no market precedents, the absence of regulation involving monetary losses or safety concerns might cause consumer worry or distrust (Mascarenhas et al., 2021). Gupta et al. (2023) stated that perceived beliefs, such as the trust of the consumer, affect the intention to adopt FinTech solutions. Fintech usage is connected with a relatively high risk of loss (in terms of privacy, personal data, and transactions), thus enhancing the perceived risk (Mascarenhas et al., 2021). In summary, personal belief becomes more robust if there is less risk and more benefits associated with technological innovation (Mascarenhas, et al., 2021; Abdul-Rahim, et al., 2022) that can also influence perception or attitude (Setiawan, et al., 2021) to use Fintech.

The empirical evidence above confirms that religious beliefs influence human behaviour and organisational corporate decisions. These corporate decisions are related to financing decisions such as funding through Fintech, debt, equity, or other sources of finance - diversification or investment (Baxamusa & Jalal, 2016). The current study will focus on drawing questions to identify the contribution of the belief and its impact on CEOs' perception or attitude to use FinTech because the prior research doesn't confirm the personal beliefs' impact on the SMEs making Fintech financing decisions. It is also not known whether religious beliefs negatively or positively impact the organisation.

To conclude above, values, family support, and beliefs held views are important factors that significantly impact CEOs' decision-making. These factors have greater significance for CEOs

to shape decisions in organisations. Stronger, more resilient businesses are always created by CEOs who diligently match their values with the objectives of their enterprises (Astrachan, et al., 2020). When CEOs' values align with the organisational goal and vision, it fosters a culture of integrity and purposeful decisions. Furthermore, a CEO's approach to decision-making depends on their support from family support and beliefs. There are a number of findings to confirm that values (Vitt, 2004; Berson, et al., 2008; Gorgievski, et al., 2011; Löfving, et al., 2013; Ryu, 2018; Yang & Lee, 2019; Gannon and Hieker, 2022), family (Anderson & Reeb, 2003; Chrisman et al., 2004; Jonathan, 2021; Irdiana et al., 2022) and beliefs (Osoba, 2003; Hui & Hilary, 2008; Baxamusa & Jalal, 2016; Mascarenhas, et al., 2021; Abdul-Rahim, et al., 2022) navigate CEOs in their decisions. However, it is not known whether all these factors contribute to CEOs' decisions regarding their financing preferences.

2.3.2.4. Educational level

Financial literacy contributes to effective decisions making (Kumar, et al., 2023; Duréndez, et al., 2023). Several scholars have studied the impact of CEOs' educational backgrounds on effective decision-making. Education has been explored to measure the individual's competence and knowledge base (Hambrick & Mason, 1984; Hitt & Tyler, 1991; Lassnigg, 2017; Bauman & Lucy, 2021). The prior research indicated that the CEOs with higher levels of professional and academic education as well as those with business degrees are generally expected to generate a more significant and wide range of creative solutions when faced with challenges thus, the level of education has been linked with firm performance (Norburn & Birley, 1988; Berberoglu, 2018; Mehralian & Nazari, 2018) and the innovation levels (Bantel & Jackson, 1989; Shanker, et al., 2017; Demircioglu & Audretsch, 2017; Lenihan, et al., 2019). Empirical evidence suggests that education is a significant factor for CEOs to help in their decisions and for their organisation. For example, Garnier (1982) found that CEOs and managers with high educational achievements are better at decision-making. Even though the research was undertaken when the FinTech industry was not developed, the views resonate

with the FinTech industry, especially concerning the view that better-educated CEOs are more open-minded to adopting new technologies. Jorissen et al. (2002) found that education significantly predicts a person's values, cognitive preferences, and perceptions. Soriano & Castrogiovanni (2012) argued that education plays a vital role in the survival of a business. Further, the high levels of CEO education indicate a higher ability of the CEO to develop various strategic decisions and engage the company in innovation, such as innovative financing options as well as the development of strategic options (Xiaowei & Zhang, 2010). A prominent study by Loukil & Yousfi (2022) found that CEOs' educational background and the type of academic degree are significant for them to bring innovation to their organisations. Education brings expertise to CEOs to make decisions, which are not limited to financing preferences but in many business areas. For example, Ali et al. (2022) found that education is a CEO's attribute that influences their organisation's performance and contributes to their financial decisions. The findings of Ali et al. (2022) are supported by the study of Gupta et al. (2021), who have similar results that CEOs' education is a contributing trait to their decisions. These decisions are related to the investment (Gupta et al., 2021; Ali et al., 2022). In their study, Herdinata et al. (2019) explore the decision-making in SMEs and how it impacts the adoption of Fintech financing. They found that organisational productivity, especially the educational achievement and levels of leadership of the SMEs, plays a significant role in adopting Fintech. Herdinata et al. (2019) thus point to the need to develop the quality of human resources regarding training and other programs to ensure greater success in adopting Fintech financing by SMEs. The findings of Herdinata et al. (2019) were consistent with (Duréndez, et al., 2023), who emphasised the CEOs' literacy to implement technological innovation.

To summarise, the CEOs in the organisations come from a wide range of educational backgrounds, which reflects the variety of routes to leadership style. Some CEOs of SMEs are self-made business people (O'Brien, 2009) who pave their routes to success with unwavering perseverance and real-world experience (Jokinen, 2023). Some have advanced degrees from

prestigious universities and are knowledgeable to make decisions relating to their organisations' financing preferences. It is important to remember that education certainly plays a role in CEOs' decisions (Bhagat, et al., 2010; Hmieleski, et al., 2015; Bai, et al., 2020). However, the influence of education on CEOs' decisions as leaders is shaped by several elements, for example, the industry environment (Chen, et al., 2019; Lin, et al., 2019; Cortes & Herrmann, 2020) in which the CEO works is crucial, first and foremost. Advanced degrees can greatly benefit some industries where highly specialised knowledge is required, but flexibility and practical experience are valued more highly in others. SME CEOs balance their natural abilities and educational backgrounds while customising their leadership style to meet the financing needs of their company. Although education has many benefits, only one contributing micro factor of the complex puzzle defines a CEO's decision-making in their SME environment. Considerable existing literature support that education level support CEOs to make decisions (Garnier, 1982; Hambrick & Mason, 1984; Hitt & Tyler, 1991; Soriano & Castrogiovanni, 2012, Lassnigg, 2017; Herdinata et al., 2019; Bauman & Lucy, 2021; Gupta et al., 2021; Ali, et al., 2022; Loukil & Yousfi, 2022; Kumar, et al., 2023; Duréndez, et al., 2023). Undoubtedly, education improves humans' skills and abilities to contribute to SMEs' adoption of financial technology. However, the literature lacks clarity regarding the significance of education or financial awareness for navigating SMEs' CEOs in their financing decisions.

2.3.2.5. Experience

Research has indicated that professional experience contributes effectively to the decision-makers (Alkhwaldi et al., 2022; Duréndez et al., 2023). Experience is crucial in determining a CEO's efficacy, especially in SMEs. CEOs with experience and industry-specific knowledge are frequently better suited to lead their companies toward success (Ng'ora, et al., 2022). The assumption is that senior managers who have professional experience place greater emphasis on making better decisions than those who lack professional experience. Peni (2012) argued that firms can significantly benefit from the experience based on the long tenure

of the CEO, especially if the CEO has been in the same position for an extended period. Such long tenure allows the CEO to develop more comprehensive and richer knowledge about the company (Finkelstein, 1992; Peni, 2012). Extending on the work by Peni (2012), the experience contributes as an integral part of the CEO's understanding of the funding needs of the SME as well as dealing with the challenges and opportunities in the competitive market. The high levels of CEO experience indicate a higher ability of the CEO to develop various strategic decisions and engage the company in innovation (Xiaowei & Zhang, 2010).

CEOs make critical strategic decisions regarding the firm's direction (Ahn, et al., 2013). Daily & Dalton (1992) found that the CEOs of SMEs face more significant challenges and have more opportunities to make decisions than large firms, such as multinational companies. Further, CEOs of SMEs can have greater scope with experience than CEOs of large companies (Daily & Dalton, 1992). However, the research by Hambrick & Mason (1984) found that CEOs tend to make decisions that favour them based on their experience. A study by Zheng & Piao (2019) explored FinTech financing decisions from P2P and found that the experience of the CEO's human capital plays an essential role in adopting Fintech financing. The results suggest that new ventures and SMEs can use multiple ways based on the experience of the CEO to get financing through Fintech financing. Similarly, Mohd Thas Thaker (2019) found that CEO experience indicates greater knowledge that influences their behavioural intention to use crowdfunding. A research study by Moritz et al. (2015) found that the CEO's experience reduces the informational asymmetries between the financiers and the SME, thus increasing the adoption and the use of crowdfunding in SME financing.

Therefore, experienced CEOs have the capacity to make well-informed decisions in organisations (Gordon & Martin, 2019; Woo, 2019; García-Pérez-de-Lema, et al., 2021). With the help of their extensive experience, they can confidently traverse challenging business environments, seeing opportunities and dangers in a wider scope than less experienced CEOs. They often possess a more sophisticated strategic vision as well, enabling them to meet the funding goals for their businesses that are reasonable and doable. Their ability to

successfully reduce risks is even more important. CEOs with experience can see possible problems and create backup plans (Ballaro, et al., 2021). Since they have faced comparable difficulties previously, they can apply the knowledge they have gained to steer clear of costly blunders. More evidence of the beneficial relationship between CEO's experience and SME success has come from recent studies. These results highlight the importance of learning from past mistakes to improve leadership effectiveness (Ng'ora, et al., 2022). Leading researchers explored the phenomenon of CEOs' experience as a contributing factor in their decisions (Hambrick & Mason, 1984; Xiaowei & Zhang, 2010; Peni, 2012; Ahn, et al., 2013; Moritz et al., 2015; Zheng & Piao, 2019; Mohd Thas Thaker, 2019). Different outcomes from these research confirm that experience improve the CEOs' ability to make important decisions for the organisational growth and sustainability. Essentially, experience continues to be a key factor in SMEs' success, proving the proverb that "wisdom comes with time" to be true. The above empirical evidence confirm experience as a contributing factor to navigate CEOs in their decisions.

2.3.2.6. Risk Appetite

Risk taking is one of the factors that CEOs possess as an ability or feature to perform their managerial work (Shapira, 1997; Benischke, et al., 2019), such as financing decisions. The risk in decision theory distinguishes between certain and uncertain situations (Yoe, 2019). In certain situations, managers are aware of outcomes compared to uncertain situations where the probability of a desired outcome is unknown. For example, flipping a fair coin has known outcomes (heads or tails) and their probabilities, except the final result is uncertain. Therefore, psychologists consider individuals' personality includes dynamics of risk perception and the risk taking appetite (Wallach, et al., 1964; Hampson, et al., 2006; De Bortoli, et al., 2019; Akhtar & Das, 2020; Dhellemmes, et al., 2021).

There are few empirical studies on the risk-taking attitude as a factor for CEOs to influence their decision-making, ultimately affecting the firms' performance. Cain & McKeon (2016) investigated the sample of 4012 CEOs from firms listed on the S&P 1500 index and found a

significant association between CEOs' risk-taking attitude and the firm's overall risk. A risk-taking attitude also positively impacts the firms' value to complete high-value projects. Attitudes are internal human mental processes that assist people in choosing the best position as per their understanding of different situations (Hillson & Murray-Webster, 2007). The findings of this research are supported by Cronqvist, et al. (2012), who found that CEOs who never take loans in their personal life are low-risk takers and have less or no leverage for the firms they work for.

Risk-taking is also related to the confidence level of the CEOs, which may lead CEOs to become overconfident in their career. Overconfidence in decision-making is one of the factors that CEOs possess in their belief and has a positive relation with their risk-taking attitude (Glaser & Weber, 2007). Overconfidence is a quality in individuals' personalities that puts weight on their judgements (Gray & Carlisle, 2013). Many studies establish that overconfident people are high-risk takers (Bernardo & Welch, 2001; Glaser & Weber, 2007; Sheffer & Loewen, 2019; Burkhard et al., 2023). An empirical study by Galasso & Simcoe (2011) on 627 CEOs from 290 US firms from 1980 to 1994 found that overconfident CEOs are more innovative in accepting technology. Overconfident CEOs think their likelihood of failure in making major organisational decisions is less due to their risk-taking approach and wealth of experience. Due to this, their organisations benefit from being more involved in innovative projects and initiatives.

Unquestionably, taking risks is ingrained in the personality of CEOs who embrace risk frequently (Salehi, et al., 2022; Ma, et al., 2022; Ingersoll, 2023) and play a key role in expanding their businesses. When others might only see barriers, these visionary leaders have the natural capacity to identify opportunities and are eager to take decisive action to make these opportunities a reality. However, the careful balance between taking risks and managing them determines whether such activities are successful. The significant consequences of CEOs' risk-taking behaviour on the expansion and viability of SMEs are shown by research. CEOs who take measured risks provide their companies with creative

energy and push the envelope of feasibility (Benischke, et al., 2019). CEOs encourage innovative thinking among their staff members (Bagheri, et al., 2022), creating a climate supporting disruptive ideas' growth. This innovative culture promotes exponential growth and helps SMEs quickly pivot and adapt to changing market conditions. However, there is a danger associated with taking chances. In order to make sure that the risks they take are well-considered and in line with the firm's goals. The empirical evidence supports the significance of a risk-taking personality in navigating CEOs in their decisions (Bernardo & Welch, 2001; Glaser & Weber, 2007; Galasso & Simcoe, 2011; Cronqvist, et al., 2012; Cain & McKeon, 2016; Sheffer & Loewen, 2019; Burkhard et al., 2023). However, it is yet to explore whether it plays an important part in adopting FinTech and what contributes to CEOs becoming risk-takers or avoiders in their financing decisions.

The earlier literature indicates that dimensions of personal leadership (section 2.3.2.1), vision (section 2.3.2.2), values, family, beliefs (section 2.3.2.3), education (section 2.3.2.4), experience (section 2.3.2.5), and the risk-taking attitude (section 2.3.2.6) are micro factors. These factors are CEOs' own characteristics, which work as input for CEOs to contribute to their decision-making. The question relating to how CEOs in UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro factors to navigate their decisions regarding Fintech financing is unexplored. Therefore, after reviewing literature, the proposed second research question is: -

Research Question 2: How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude on their Fintech financing decisions

2.3.3. Meso factors in FinTech financing decisions making

There are a number of meso factors external to CEOs to influence them in their FinTech decisions, such as professional networking, the board of directors in SMEs, and the organisational structure.

2.3.3.1. Professional Networking

Professional networking is an essential resource for CEOs' technical knowledge in SMEs (West & Noel, 2009; Hmieleski et al., 2015; Aaboen et al., 2016; Margherita, 2022). It functions as a potent instrument that can provide access to a wide range of relationships, resources, and possibilities that may substantially impact these companies' expansion and prosperity (Adomako, et al., 2021). Networking offers significant advantages to SMEs, highlighting its critical role in overcoming the unique obstacles that these businesses frequently encounter. With professional networking, SME CEOs can access an extensive reservoir of information and experience, which is one of its main benefits, and that helps them to make financing decisions (Kvasov, et al., 2021). They can access many best practices and insights that can aid them in navigating the challenging business environment by establishing connections with other entrepreneurs, business leaders, experts and possible mentors. Additionally, these networks can help the SME community develop a culture of continuous improvement (Sigala & Chalkiti, 2015; Darwin, 2017) by facilitating the exchange of creative ideas and answers to shared difficulties.

CEOs of SMEs create strategic alliances and partnerships through networking (Vanags, et al., 2018; Agostini & Nosella, 2019; Vătămănescu, et al., 2022). These collaborations enhance the knowledge of executives working in the SMEs to make informed decisions, such as creating joint ventures and approaching more accessible markets for capital expansion. Furthermore, conferences, networking events, and industry get-togethers give SME CEOs a stage to present their goods and services to prospective customers and investors (Adomako, et al., 2021). Professional networks can provide good support to CEOs in their organisations. Peer-to-peer experience-sharing and advice-giving might facilitate SME CEOs' ability to address challenges like personnel acquisition, regulatory obstacles, and finance limitations. Furthermore, belonging to a support network can help entrepreneurs feel less alone, positively affecting their emotional and mental health. Extant literature has indicated that professional network involvement is significant in the CEOs' strategy-setting regarding the expansion of

financing sources. The general assumption in the knowledge is crucial in the imperfect market for the senior leadership of SMEs to make financing decisions (Brahmana, et al., 2022). CEOs work with people in their professional networks to develop formal financing strategies. SMEs can gain massive benefits from the professional networks of the CEOs because they provide them with appropriate knowledge and information critical for meeting funding needs.

The empirical study by Wang & Tu (2016) focused on professional networks by exploring the element of herding behaviour in informing the decisions of CEOs in the adoption of Fintech financing by SMEs. The study considered the online peer-to-peer (P2P) lending platform, explicitly considering the herding behaviour and the rationality of the herding behaviour in making decisions regarding adopting Fintech financing. Wang & Tu (2016) study indicated that herding behaviour leads to a significant increase in the take-up of the Fintech financing by the SMEs. To support Wang & Tu (2016), the findings of Xiaowei & Zhang (2010) confirm that the high quality and levels of professional networks of CEOs enhance their ability to develop various strategies that allow organisations to engage in innovation as well as the adoption of innovative financing options. The study found that CEOs can make significant and strategic decisions regarding the direction of funding based purely on the information gained from professional networks. The findings of the empirical evidence from Eze, et al. (2018) have similar results that CEOs and managers of SMEs seek and use relevant funding information through their professional networking to guide their decision-making regarding technology adoption. The involvement in networks has received greater attention in recent years (Aaboen, et al., 2016; Minai, et al., 2012; Al-Busaidi & Olfman, 2017; Margherita, 2022) due to the sharing of knowledge in the global marketplace and for the benefit of the business (Zizah, et al., 2007; Carmeli & Paulus, 2015). Rather than relying solely on traditional financing methods, globalisation has led to developing new financing models in the international market, such as FinTech financing. The networks' involvement is highly linked to social media and technology, especially accessibility and ease of use to influence people's behaviour (Jaradat & Faqih, 2014) and provides a competitive advantage to organisations (Jorissen, et al., 2002).

Existing studies do not confirm that CEOs' involvement in professional networking can contribute to their Fintech financing decisions. However, the empirical evidence demonstrates that increased CEOs' involvement in professional networking has been seen as a significant predictor of a greater need for information for their decisions to achieve financial innovation (Langeland, 2007; Wainwright, 2015; Gruin & Knaack, 2020; Chang et al., 2022).

2.3.3.2. Board of Directors

Within SMEs, the board of directors is crucial in shaping the financial decision-making processes of the CEO. Empirical studies have emphasised the significance of the board's makeup and level of engagement (Topak, 2011; Samuel, 2013; Godos-Díez, et al., 2018; Thottoli, et al., 2019; Agarwal, 2020). An active and diverse board can significantly impact SMEs' governance and strategic decision-making (Zheng, et al., 2022). Fundamentally, the board serves as an essential internal check and balance system. It serves as a safety net, guaranteeing that the CEO and other leadership team members conduct themselves honestly and responsibly. Because resources and operations are frequently deeply entwined in SMEs, it is essential to have this monitoring because it makes it easier for choices to lack the appropriate checks and balances (Zheng, et al., 2022). The actively involved board members contribute many skills, industrial expertise, and varied viewpoints to the group. This variety of views encourages lively debates and more thorough decision-making procedures. A well-organised board also helps to push the business on the right path and avert any problems by offering the CEO supervision, mentorship, and counselling. A board of directors is a group of experienced people who provide leadership, strategic direction and overall governance to their organisation (Calder, 2008; Stamm, 2019; Dicke & Ott, 2023). Directors perform their duties by following the company's constitution, which includes decision-making as per their ability in the company's best interest (Companies House, 2019). The board of directors' structure varies as per the constitution and the organisation's size. The board rely on the information it receives from the CEO (Boggs, 2006) to set and implement its plans for effective governance (Croci,

2018). Therefore, the communication is vital for board success; the CEO mainly acts as a bridge to connect the board to the management by providing all information relating to day-to-day operations or short-term goals through board meetings with board members (Price, 2018). The term 'Governance' is widely used in research, corporation websites, governance standards and literature. However, there is no single common definition of governance. It is described as a mechanism to guide company actions (Nordberg, 2011), a system to direct and control companies (Financial Reporting Council, 2014), a process to exercise power (Lynn, et al., 2001), and a relationship between company management, a board, shareholders or stakeholders (OECD , 2004; Price, 2018). Corporate governance requires a difference between the board members and the executive management (Price, 2018) where board members don't perform daily duties except the organisational management.

In the UK, the evaluation of governance traces its roots in a sequence of corporate collapses and scandals in the late 1980s. In 1992, the Cadbury Report highlighted significant governance issues, which laid down the basis of the corporate governance code in 1998 (Financial Reporting Council, 2010). It is a mandatory framework for the sustainable business success of listed companies on the London Stock Exchange to provide effective rights and accountability to shareholders. Even though there is no mandatory corporate governance framework for SMEs in the UK except regulatory obligations from Companies House. However, SMEs follow general practices of governance codes or similar frameworks as an inspiration to achieve good governance (Institute of Directors, 2017). However, the board works for the interest of the company's stakeholders by defining the organisation's mission, developing plans (Leardini, et al., 2013) and working for the organisation's long-term survival by satisfying its stakeholders' needs (Rolstadås, 1995). The board controls, monitors and leads the organisation internally and maintains compliance with external regulations to achieve accountability, transparency, quality or improvements. Therefore, the composition of the board and its governance framework are significant factors for SMEs to accept FinTech.

Within the board of directors, non-executive directors are individuals appointed to heighten the performance of the board and the company (Dunne & Morris, 2008) with their impartial and independent decisions (Institute of Directors, 2018). The roles of non-executive directors are very distinctive in SMEs because they are independent of the company management and hold considerable experience and knowledge to perform their duties (Cummings, 2018).

To understand the role of non-executive directors, it is essential to understand the following three fundamental aspects of the Board as proposed by Dunne & Morris in 2008.

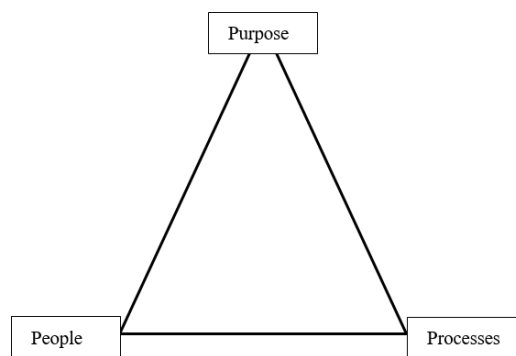


Figure 5: Three fundamental aspects of the high-performance board, Source: (Dunne & Morris, 2008)

According to the above figure, Dunne & Morris (2008) proposed that the high-performance board members know the board's purpose, the processes through which it performs its functions, and a good composition of people to bring expertise and decision-making qualities. These three fundamental aspects of the board achieve proper governance for the organisation. Another reason to appoint non-executive directors to the organisation is that UK corporate governance and unlisted organisation corporate governance codes suggest that there should be an independent element to the board for impartial decisions, which is suitable for effective governance.

Due to the above reasons, non-executive directors in SMEs are appointed to bring expertise to the board to help other executive directors develop, deploy, and implement strategies for the company's long-term success. It is also worth mentioning here that non-executive directors

have the same legal obligations, duties and liabilities as their executive colleagues on the board per the Companies House Act 2006. Therefore, non-executive directors' role is crucial to the organisation with their independent decisions because they perform their duties as agreed at the time of their appointment and by the law to ensure their actions add value to the board on its excellent governance (Dunne & Morris, 2008). Non-executive directors bring their personal qualities to the board, such as honesty, creativity, leadership, impartiality, communication styles, aptitude, flexibility (Dunne & Morris, 2008), influence, and strategic thinking skills. This helps the organisation not only to bring outside experience to the board (NHE, 2019) but also SMEs prefer to have them to add credibility and commercial introduction to their businesses (Hurley, 2010). Therefore, including non-executive directors on the board is also one of the factors that affect the adoption of FinTech.

Evidence from the prior research confirms the significance of the board of directors and its influence on the CEO's decisions and the firm's performance. For example, Thottoli et al. (2019) found that the board of directors' roles are essential in directing and controlling the company, and they impact the overall performance. The researchers further confirm that the board of directors influences CEOs, which results in the reduction of agency costs. The arrangement of the board creates little control of the shareholders in the management, which decreases the agency cost (Katti & Raithatha, 2018; Baysinger & Butler, 2019; Vitolla, et al., 2020; Uyar, et al., 2021; Kyere & Ausloos, 2021). An important finding of Samuel (2013) confirms that the large board size brings more expertise and financial stability to the organisation because the influence of such a board on CEOs has a more significant impact. The large board size is suitable for governance because it enhances the organisation's value (Samuel, 2013). The findings of Samuel (2013) are opposed to the results of Topak (2011), who found no link between the firm's financial performance and the board's size. However, evidence from previous research found a negative relationship between the board size and the financial performance of the firms (Florackis, 2005; Irina & Nadezhda, 2009; Nanka-Bruce, 2011). The results of the empirical research are inconclusive regarding how the board affects

CEOs in their decision-making, especially in the case of UK SMEs. This is because the board structure in different organisations varies, including its impact and the flow of information between the board, the CEOs, and the shareholders for CEOs to make financing decisions.

2.3.3.3. *Organisational Structure*

Organisations are groups of individuals interconnected to the external environment and have structured and coordinated systems to achieve goals (Daft, 2008; Mills, 2011; Sessa & London, 2015; Baltaci, 2017; Valeri, 2021). Groups of people are linked to each other as social entities; they work together to design, develop, and follow rules and regulations to achieve specific tasks in line with their purpose. Top Managers of the organisation intentionally create the structure into different units and departments, allocate their resources and ensure that the structure is fit for managing the business operations (Daft, 2008; Daft, 2015; Valeri, 2021). The organisation's structure helps to organise the organisational activities, and employees are differentiated from each other based on their skills to perform those activities (Freeman, 1999). Thus, the operations are based on the pattern of activities within those structures that members perform to achieve the organisational goals (Aquinas, 2010).

It is essential to understand the organisational structure because if it is responsive to the external environment, it can work more proactively towards accepting financing innovation such as FinTech. The rationale of the structural design is based on the assumption that structure has its purpose and usually relies on the hands of individuals who govern the organisation to create differentiation and a line of authority between workforce so that that they work for the organisation (Dow, 1988) and bring innovation (Zammuto & O'CONNOR, 2018). These differentiation processes create distinctive coordination between operational and managerial roles in different units and departments based on their high level of expertise per their job description (Janićijević, 2013). Therefore, the organisation's structure balances its external and internal environment through its distinctive features of job design, the line of

authority and the differentiated units, and the coordination between them and the external environment.

Suppose the structure is designed with little interaction between people and the external environment. In that case, these types of organisations find it hard to accept change or to accept change or technology. It is necessary to understand different types of SME organisational structures. Top management typically follows two kinds of models to design the organisational structure. These are mechanistic and organic organisation structure models (Mills, 2011; Ahmady, et al., 2016; Parthasarthy & Sethi, 2018). These structures are illustrated below as

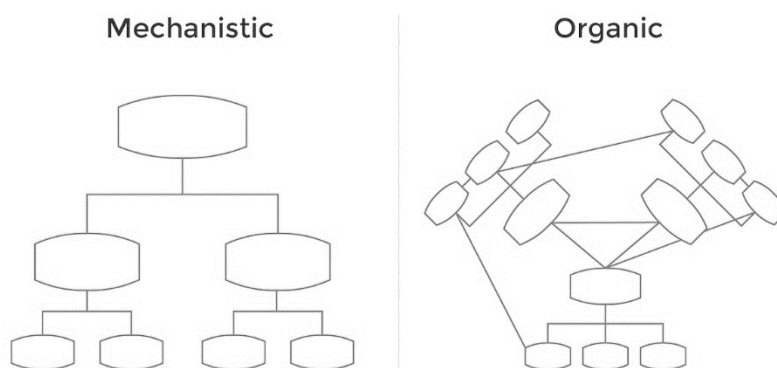


Figure 6: Mechanistic and Organic models of Organisation design, Source: (Weaver, 2019)

In the mechanistic structure, the organisation is divided into different departments with a clear line of control from the top management or departmental line managers. Information flows from the bottom of the structure to the top management for decision-making. Therefore, these organisations are considered more challenging to accept new changes, innovation, or technology (Daft, 2008; Valeri, 2021). The information flows from the top managers to the bottom at the departmental line managers as orders or instructions to perform specific tasks. In these structures, organisational work is divided into smaller pieces at the departmental level and allocated to employees who are specialised and closely supervised by their top management to perform their jobs (Nieuwenhuizen, et al., 2012). These organisations are less

risk takers to accept change and have less networking between employees across different departments, and control of tasks is centralised at the organisation's top (Daft, et al., 2010). In the organic structure, the organisation group of people work collectively flexibly with a high span of control and in a high centralisation environment to accept innovation with their shared set of values and knowledge to accomplish the specific task (Nieuwenhuizen, et al., 2012). Top management of SMEs set up this organisational structure to create a high level of networking, quick problem solving, promote flexibility (Aquinas, 2010) and decentralised decision making (Daft, 2008; Valeri, 2021). The workforce within these types of structure encourages teamwork, employee autonomy, new ideas, creativity, entrepreneurship and innovation to compete efficiently in the business environment (Daft, et al., 2010).

The impact of the organisational culture and types of organisational structures are significantly essential factors for SMEs' Top managers in decision-making to accept financial innovation, i.e. FinTech. This is because CEOs need timely information for their decision-making (Ada & Ghaffarzadeh, 2015; Wang, et al., 2016; Porter & Nohria, 2018; Alsmady, 2018; Liem & Hien, 2020). If the structure is complex, getting information from lower management takes time to make timely decisions. All data and information go through different units and departments, while organisations with organic structures and CEOs get data and information directly from their employees. The decision-making by CEOs is less productive if the organisation is structured in such a way that it has many departmental levels (Carzo & Yanouzas, 1969). At each departmental level, there is a senior manager, followed by an executive team, to process the information for the top manager (Ou, et al., 2014; Child, 2015; Burke, 2022). In such structures, managers don't have sufficient time to solve the problem and prefer to delegate their decision-making authority to their subordinates. The top managers of organisations with fewer levels of administrative departments have a wide span of supervision to control and process the information for effective decision-making that has an overall impact on the organisational performance (Chaston, 1997; Claver-Cortés, et al., 2012; Tran & Tian, 2013; Child, 2015; Ahmady, et al., 2016; Bai, et al., 2017; Dewar & Hage, 2018; Su, et al., 2019). A

similar study by Meltzer & Salter (1962) identified that more hierarchical levels in the organisational structure impact the CEO's productivity. In their research, Chehade & Vigneron (2007) found a positive relationship between banks with a decentralised structure and the SME's information transparency. This is because SMEs need funding from various sources, including FinTech platforms (Temelkov, et al., 2018; Dai, 2020; Sanga & Aziakpono, 2023). Meltzer & Salter (1962) further concluded that SMEs face more credit restraints due to their age, size and structure than banks with complex hierarchical organisational structures. The success of SMEs is essential to the economy (Prasanna et al., 2019; Gherghina et al., 2020; Epede & Wang, 2022), and depends on their organisational structure (Seetharaman, 2020; Rodrigues, et al., 2021). SMEs possess the adaptability to implement diverse organisational frameworks, which can profoundly impact the efficacy of their CEOs and, in turn, their organisations' overall achievements. According to Gherghina et al. (2020), organisational structure significantly affects SMEs' performance. This emphasises the significance of matching the organisation's design to its strategic goals. In organisational structures, employees are assigned to perform specific tasks based on their specialised knowledge or roles. This helps CEOs to be more productive by enabling them to concentrate on their primary skills and expedite departmental decision-making (Gherghina, et al., 2020). A divisional or matrix organisation can support a multi-dimensional approach to business, where many product lines or geographical areas function semi-independently. Although this can foster creativity and adaptability, CEOs may need varied skills to navigate the associated complexities.

Evidence from the literature suggests that there are several factors including people and forces around CEOs such as professional networking (Xiaowei & Zhang, 2010; Minai, et al., 2012; Jaradat & Faqih, 2014; Eze, et al., 2018), board of directors (Dunne & Morris, 2008; Leardini, et al., 2013; Cummings, 2018) and the organisational structure (Carzo & Yanouzas, 1969; Meltzer & Salter, 1962; Chaston, 1997; Chehade & Vigneron, 2007; Su, et al., 2019; Muthukannan, et al., 2020). These factors are meso - falls external to CEOs' characteristics

(micro) and have a direct link to CEOs as top-level executives in the organisational hierarchy and board members. Meso factors significantly contribute to CEOs' decision-making; however, no prior research confirms that these factors navigate CEOs in their FinTech financing decisions. Therefore, the third question is proposed as

Research Question 3: How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level?

2.3.4. Macro factors in FinTech financing decisions making

Similarly, macro factors such as government policies and support pose that adopting new and risky practices in the organisation bound CEOs to some extent by law, politics or government initiatives to make effective decisions (Chen et al. 2014; Kiwanuka, 2015; Hu et al., 2019; Ahern, 2021; Ng and Pan, 2022). UK political system and policymakers fully support the FinTech revolution and understand its importance for economic growth. Therefore, the government stands its position to the UK FinTech as a global capital of FinTech. The UK government published its policy paper on the Fintech Sector Strategy in March 2008 to meet the needs of the FinTech sector by removing barriers from entry to the growth of FinTech firms, supporting international expansions and investments, stability of FinTech after Brexit and encouraging the FinTech benefits for everyone by promoting literacy, digital economy and financial innovation. Numerous government programmes, policies, and tax systems are operating to deal with digital currencies and peer-to-peer lending to FinTech (HM Treasury, 2016). In December 2019, HM Revenue and Customs (HMRC) published a policy paper to describe its position on cryptocurrency and provide guidance on paying income tax and national insurance contributions on cryptocurrency (HM Revenue & Customs, 2019).

In the UK, the Financial Conduct Authority also started to establish a relationship with financial services sectors, including FinTech companies, to support the better use of technology, which ultimately benefits the public and ensures compliance with international financial standards.

Agility and an improved customer experience are critical success factors for FinTech (Capgemini, 2018). Due to government support, FinTech has raised nearly \$110 billion since 2009, as per Capgemini's World FinTech Report 2018 (Capgemini, 2018), and it is growing with more success and initiatives worldwide. The global investments in FinTech in 2015 were \$26.8 billion, which was higher than \$19.9 billion in 2014, and hereafter it increased by 11.9% in 2016 (Fintech Global, 2018). The global investment in Fintech was \$111.8 billion in 2018, 120% higher than the total investment of \$50.8 billion in 2017 (KPMG, 2019) and \$23 billion in the first half of 2023 (S&P Global, 2023). Despite the heavy investment in Fintech, technology-enabled financial services have their limitations and challenges, too; for example, there are key challenges that IT can be compromised. The major challenges for Fintech to date are dealing with the issues of privacy, cybercrimes, and non-compliance with industry regulations (Naz et al., 2022; Kravchuk & Lutsyshyn, 2022). These threats are IT systems capabilities to manage the number of users worldwide and data security issues. To underpin security issues, cyberattacks have become very common these days and are a key threat to the sector. The IMF working paper highlighted that Cyber-attacks on Fintech firms have increased with an estimated \$1450 million in losses due to fraud since 2013 (Bouveret, 2018). Apart from the government policy papers or guidance mentioned above, there are no specific UK FinTech regulations. However, there are few laws to prevent Fraud or abuse of financial transactions, such as the Financial Services and Market Act 2000, the Fraud Act 2006, the Theft Act 1968, and Money Laundering. FinTech companies are subject to these statutory frameworks to deal with financial crimes. Any company that wishes to undertake regulated provisions in the UK is subject to authorisation from the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA). Therefore, the financing preferences of CEOs are significantly influenced by government support, the threat of IT and legislation, especially in the quickly changing FinTech sector. These regulations may serve as impediments to growth opportunities or as catalysts that make it easier to obtain funding. Examining government actions and the regulatory environment is essential to understanding their impact. In a FinTech-dominated era, governments throughout the globe are being forced to review their regulatory frameworks. Some have adopted a

progressive approach, creating an atmosphere of trust that allows SMEs to apply for loans through alternative lending sources and digital platforms (Cumming, et al., 2023). These governments have frequently accelerated financial inclusion efforts, supported FinTech firms, and expedited regulatory procedures, giving SMEs better access to various funding sources. Conversely, SMEs may find it easier to secure funding and carry out their expansion plans if there are onerous laws or an absence of helpful programs. Fintech innovations can be impeded by high regulatory barriers, compliance burdens, and a reluctance to accept them, which can apply to SMEs needing financing.

Empirical research indicates that government support, user-friendly regulations, and policies are essential to SMEs' acceptance of Fintech financing. Several scholars have explored the impacts of government support in creating credibility for Fintech products, such as peer-to-peer (P2P) lending, neobanks, crowdfunding, and others. Yee-Loong Chong et al. (2010) found that government support is the biggest driver of Fintech adoption since the government significantly improve the reliability and credibility of the Fintech products, which makes them more acceptable to consumers. Government support positively influences the adoption of Fintech among customers (Kiwanuka, 2015). Governments must focus on developing and formulating appropriate policies to support SMEs' uptake of Fintech financing (Kiwanuka, 2015). Regarding government support, Hu et al. (2019) have similar results closely related to Kiwanuka (2015) and Yee-Loong Chong et al. (2010) that it increases the adoption of Fintech financing, especially P2P and crowdfunding. Support from the government is critical to building trust in SMEs to use Fintech (Marakarkandy et al., 2017), and it increases the adoption of Fintech (Hu et al., 2019). Marakarkandy et al. (2017) also undertook a study and emphasised that the government is critical for building the trust of SMEs in Fintech products. A similar result by Rosavina et al. (2019) and Chen et al. (2014) indicated that the government's role is significant in building trust between customers and lenders. The study found that trust is one factor that affects SMEs' use of P2P lending platforms (Rosavina, et al., 2019). According to Chen et al. (2014), governments, intermediaries and P2P lenders play an essential and

concerted role in ensuring the development of trust by providing high-quality information and adequate security information about the lenders to improve the uptake. Rosavina & Rahadi (2018) have also explored the issue of trust and the role of government regulation. They noted that P2P lending players enhance SMEs' access to financing, especially those with limited access to traditional funding. They found that the preference of SMEs for P2P financing is based on several factors - regulatory measures and the government can focus on easing the factors to ensure greater uptake of P2P lending by SMEs.

In the study to identify the competitive strategies and their fitness to ensure the FinTech platforms' performance, Ng and Pan (2022) found that CEOs make Fintech decisions that conform to government regulations. According to Zarrouk et al. (2021), financial barriers, regulatory environment, and legal issues can negatively impact the initiation and growth of Fintech ventures. According to Ahern (2021), regulatory burden has cost and influences decisions. Entrepreneurs seeking to invest in Fintech innovations in Europe should understand the potential impacts of domestic laws and the European Union's regulations for each member state (Ahern, 2021). Makki and Alqahtani (2022) conducted a study to evaluate critical factors that enable Fintech innovations. Zarrouk et al. (2021) have similar findings that regulation is among the favourable factors that support and promote Fintech. According to Goo and Heo (2020), excessive regulations often impact the innovative ability of the firm and the ability to compete in the market. They reported that regulations often hinder FinTech firms' business. Therefore, Fintech regulations are essential in guiding the adoption and running of Fintech innovations. The government's role in building trust in FinTech also requires creating awareness and perception of FinTech in SMEs. For example, the findings of the study by Ghazali & Yasuoka (2018) suggested that external environmental factors, such as the government's role, are critical in enhancing the awareness levels of SMEs for P2P and crowdfunding opportunities. They also indicated a positive relationship between financial literacy and the success of entrepreneurs for SME growth and business expansion. The study findings indicate that SMEs have low awareness of Fintech financing models such as P2P and

crowdfunding. The study suggests that there is an opportunity as well as a need to engage in the raising of the awareness of the SMEs with regards to the use and adoption of Fintech financing in the financing of their activities. Similarly, the findings of the Owen et al. (2019) study confirm that the successful adoption of financing strategies in SMEs is emerging in the UK due to the combination of escalator funding, collaboration and bootstrapping that are all supported by the government's interventions.

Empirical evidence (Chen, et al. 2014; Kiwanuka, 2015; Rosavina & Rahadi, 2018; Ghazali & Yasuoka, 2018; Owen, et al., 2019; Rosavina, et al. 2019; Goo and Heo, 2020; Ahern, 2021; Dwivedi et al., 2021; Zarrouk et al., 2021; Makki and Alqahtani, 2022; Ng and Pan, 2022) suggest that the macro factors such as the government regulations, policies and support are linked to the greater levels of adoption of Fintech financing. These factors fall external to CEOs' micro and meso levels to influence their decisions. However, the complexities of government support and laws as contributing factors to navigate CEOs in their Fintech financing decisions are still unexplored. Therefore, the research question 4 is proposed as

Research Question 4: How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?

2.3.5. The Research Framework

In the development of the research framework, it is important to understand that humans make judgments in daily life based on a combination of cognitive processes (Newen, 2017; Blanchette & Richards, 2010; Pisano & Sozzo, 2020) and environmental factors (Harding, 1998; Nahavandi, 2019; De Groot, 2019). Decision-making is generally integral to human existence, affecting our actions and determining our future. Individuals make daily decisions, ranging from trivial decisions such as what to wear or consume to those with far-reaching personal and professional consequences. Understanding how we make decisions and influencing factors is essential for numerous disciplines, including psychology, management,

and organisational behaviour (Sahu et al., 2020). Factors such as personal leadership, vision, values, family, beliefs, education, experience and risk-taking attitude, professional networking, organisational structure, governance, government laws, policies, and further the use of decision-making models and tools greatly influence decision-making depending on the setting. According to Morelli et al. (2022), everyday decision-making is frequently influenced by heuristics, cognitive biases, and emotions. Heuristics are mental shortcuts or rules of thumb that people use to facilitate decision-making, resulting in accurate but occasionally erroneous decisions (Raue & Scholl, 2018; Shah, et al., 2018; Gigerenzer, et al., 2022; Pathak, et al., 2023). Individuals may, for instance, rely on the availability heuristic, basing their decisions on readily accessible information instead of all pertinent factors. Additionally, cognitive fallacies play a role in daily decision-making (Juárez Ramos, 2018; Laureiro-Martínez & Brusoni, 2018; Newell, et al., 2022). Confirmation bias, for instance, causes people to search for information confirming their beliefs while ignoring contradictory evidence. This bias can influence decision-making by limiting the contemplation of alternative options or points of view. Emotions also influence daily decision-making (Taffler, 2018; Sheppard & Levy, 2019; Sattar, et al., 2020; Goodell, et al., 2023). According to studies, emotions can influence decision-making by altering risk perceptions and preferences (Zhao, 2006; Foo, 2011; Tang, 2016; Diener, et al., 2020). Positive emotions, for instance, may encourage individuals to take more risks, whereas negative emotions may induce risk aversion. Therefore, the decision-making of CEOs heavily relies on the cognitive theories of decision-making to make rational decisions. As the research is based on professional decisions in SMEs where the CEOs play a leading role to manage and lead the organisation, their professional decisions do not solely rely on their job descriptions. They consult with family, friends, and people in their personal and professional networks about what they do in their professional jobs and make decisions in the best interest of their organisations. Their professional decision-making typically entails more intricate processes and considerations. Expertise, education, and experience all play a role in making informed decisions. According to Gati and Kulcsar (2021), such professionals rely heavily on analytical decision-making models and instruments when making choices.

Decision-making models and tools are frequently used in SMEs to facilitate structured and systematic decision-making. These models, such as rational decision-making, risk management, and funds management, seek to reduce subjectivity and bias by providing a logical framework to assess alternatives, weigh risks, and choose the best course of action. Decision-making tools, such as decision matrices and cost-benefit analysis, assist CEOs in evaluating and comparing various funding alternatives to make informed judgments. The study aims to explore CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing and how they perceive the influence of micro, meso, and macro factors in their Fintech financial decisions. For these reasons, the four main research questions are proposed as

- How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?
- How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude on their Fintech financing decisions?
- How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level?
- How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?

The following research framework is drawn based on the empirical evidence of CEOs' factors as an input to their financing decision.

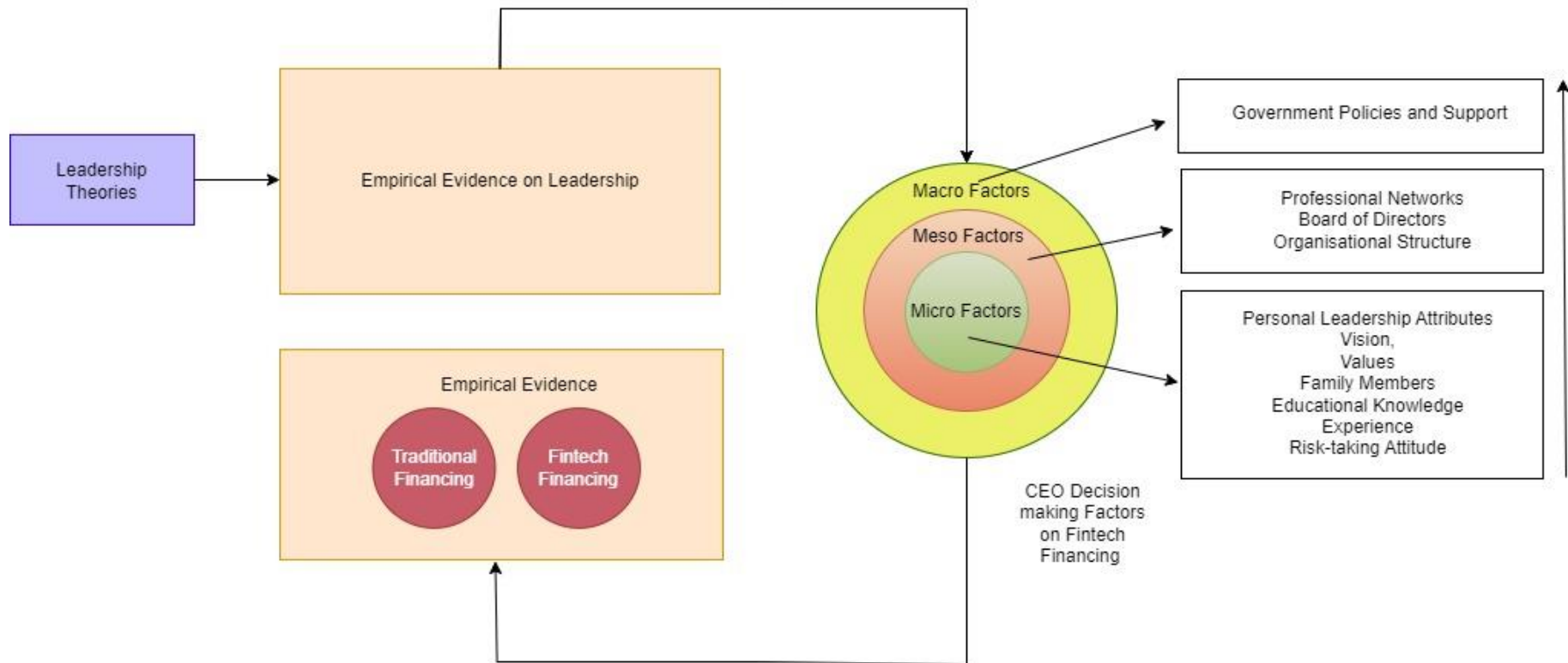


Figure 7: Research Framework: Micro, Meso and Macro Factors affecting CEOs' decisions on Fintech Financing

3. Data and Research Methodology

3.1. Introduction

Research is the art of seeking new facts through a process or an academic activity (Kothari, 2007) to generate new knowledge (Gerrish & Lathlean, 2015). Planning the research design concerning any feasible route, such as design by questions, methods of analysis or data collection, is an important part of the success of any research (Braun & Clarke, 2013). The research design includes a plan, process, or way of knowing by which we develop common sense to understand the problem (Leavy, 2017). This involves identifying philosophical paradigms (Khatri, 2020), and using suitable and valid research techniques to collect and analyse data (Rahi, 2017; Allemang et al., 2022). The process provides a useful model to guide in planning and executing the research to produce valid results. Each stage in the research process is linked to the other stage and has a specific role in formulating the research methodology. The methodology is a term to cover all steps involved in the research (Van Meter, 1994). The researcher illustrates the whole process with a unique approach to ensure that the effectiveness of the study remains consistent throughout the research methodology. The concept of the research approach is based on the criteria for the research and the participants to ensure the research will remain within the parameters to answer the research objectives. The criteria for the research include the researcher's position within the research philosophies, the participants' criteria, and the choice of the research methodology as a structured approach to collecting, analysing, and interpreting data within the research context and ethical constraints to complete the thesis. It includes the criteria for the participants ensure that the research produces purposeful results, identifies limitations and gaps to produce generalised results, and allows future development of the existing research. The remaining stages of the research are analysis through data collection, findings as results and discussion to reach a conclusion. All this information that emerges from the collection of data to analysis

and results are based on the participants' criteria. If anything changes in the participant criteria, the results will emerge differently. These boundaries as criteria are set to guide the whole research process as illustrated below: -

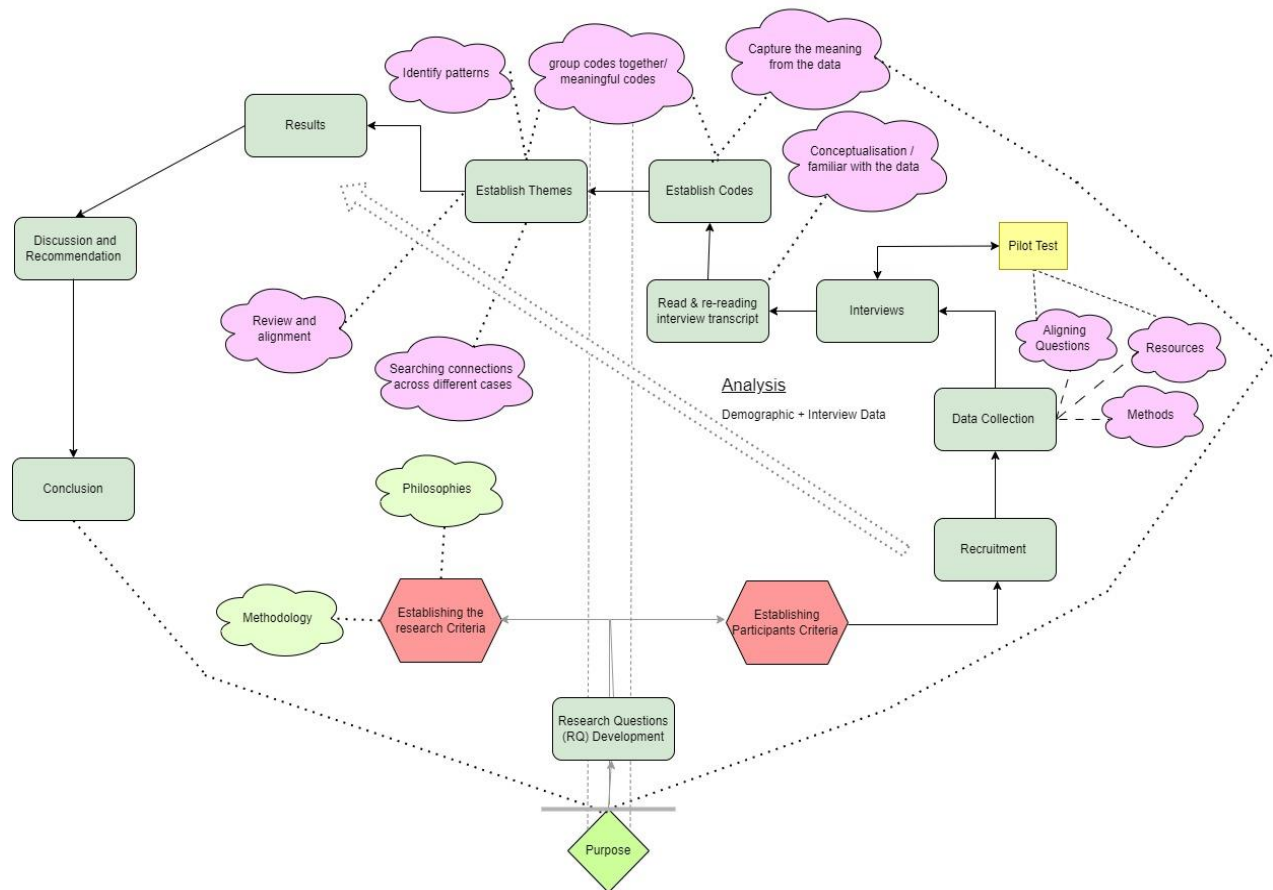


Figure 8 The Research Process (Author's own Illustration)

The purpose of the research is to explore CEOs' decision-making in Fintech Financing. The research process is illustrated in the shape of the research tree; in general, the tree grows from the seed to produce its intended result; the purpose of the research within the research process is to make valid and reliable results.

3.1.1. Establishing the research design

The first point of the research tree is to establish a criteria for the research design which is based on identifying the researcher's position in the research philosophies and rationales for

choosing of the appropriate research methodology as an approach, fit for purpose, to conduct the whole research.

3.1.1.1. *Research Philosophies*

The research process is based on underlying research philosophies to understand research assumptions about the nature of reality and the researcher's position, approach and stance towards that reality. Research philosophies are beliefs that guide the planning, design and execution of the research (Tamminen & Poucher, 2020; Porot & Mandelbaum, 2021; HR & Aithal, 2022). These philosophies help the researcher identify his position during the research. Not all philosophical paradigms apply to every type of research; they have different goals and natures to define the problem and guide the researcher in developing the research process. In each research philosophy, there are several philosophical assumptions, such as the researcher's stance towards the nature of reality (ontology), sources and the construction of the knowledge (epistemology), the role of values and beliefs in the research (axiology), the research language (rhetoric), and choice of the suitable methods (Creswell, 2007; Creswell & Poth, 2016). In the following section, the researcher critically reflects on research philosophies with rationales to choose the most suitable research philosophies for this research.

The research philosophy explores the CEOs' decision-making in Fintech Financing and how they perceive the influence of micro, meso and macro level factors to navigate their financing choices. CEOs are human beings, and they have their thoughts, experiences, educational backgrounds, family, networks, and friends within their social context. They have leadership qualities and decision-making power and work for their SMEs under contract or employment. Decision-making is a mental state of human beings considering all those factors in and around CEOs. This also includes the reality of their existence in society to reflect in their decisions due to social environment (Bruch & Feinberg, 2017) or social structure (Archer, 1995; Archer, 1982; Gorski, 2013). Human identities and decision-making differ and vary from one situation to another; therefore, exploring the reality of how they think and work may bring multiple views about their perceptions of Fintech financing. Thus, the constructivism paradigm is more

suitable for exploring the reality of the phenomenon of CEOs' financing-related decision-making. In constructivism, the assumption is that realities are multiple (Pale & Lilford, 2011) because individuals construct the meanings of the realities they experience through their cognitive process (Young & Collin, 2004). Decision-making is one of the basic cognitive processes of human behaviour (Newell & Bröder, 2008) as per the cognitive theory (Wu, 2020; Andrade, 2020; Featherman et al., 2021), where CEOs deal with various situations in their professional practice to choose the best financing option. Constructivism is a more focused individualistic approach (Young & Collin, 2004), which is more aligned with this research because CEOs are vital decision-makers and construct knowledge through their subjective meanings of the phenomenon (Putnam & Banghart, 2017; Bleiker et al., 2019; Ugwu et al., 2021). The reason for choosing the constructivism paradigm is that the researcher does not know what is happening in the CEO's mind when making decisions. It helps to identify how CEOs work in the social context (Schneider, 1985) and construct their knowledge through their individual minds (Crotty, 1998) to address problems when dealing with various troubles or situations in complex organisational environments. For example, it may be possible that SMEs try to finance their business monetary needs through bank loans but are rejected, and they decide to use FinTech. This situation or the context of their decision-making may differ for other SME CEOs, who may be inclined more towards de-regulations or dislike heavy paperwork to comply with banking regulations. Therefore, the researcher's use of the constructivism paradigm helps identify participants' views on their financing decisions. This approach is the basic stance in the dynamic environment where multiple realities exist, and the researcher has his views and articulates CEOs' context to answer the research objectives.

In the constructivism paradigm, the researcher's stance involves fixing his ontological and epistemological positions to the context, which will ultimately determine the contents of the research to address research objectives. Ontology is a study of reality whose existence is confirmed by explicit theories, views, opinions or thoughts (Porta, 2008; Baskerville et al., 2020; Krzanowski & Polak, 2022). It concerns the nature of reality and our understanding of

its existence. Therefore, the researcher needs to work within its ontological parameters. The ontological position enables the researcher to capture clear, understandable, secure and convincing accounts of context and experiences of the situations where understanding occurs (Hamilton & Pinnegar, 2009). This study deals with the ontology that is dynamic and changeable by human beings. CEOs who are participants in this study have different points of view, interpretations, experiences, opinions, and thoughts while making decisions using FinTech. It is because CEOs, as human beings, have their own identity in society and in the organisations in which they work. They have their perceptions about reality and the circumstances in which they make decisions. The factors of education, experience, social or professional networking, organisational structure and culture, including its rules and regulations, and the country's laws shape their decision-making. Therefore, the ontological stance of this study is relativism due to the subjectivity (Kusch, 2020; Krol, 2021; Merlo & Pravato, 2021) that CEOs have their views and perceptions in their social structure to make decisions. The point here is that several factors influence human decisions, including their personal experiences and identities within organisational culture and society. Therefore, their subjective stance due to their unique leadership qualities, experience, knowledge, values, beliefs, networking, people around them, friends or family or other influential factors such as government policies and the organisation, its culture and governance shape CEOs' decisions for their financing choice. This brings multiple realities to the phenomenon of understanding the CEOs' decision-making.

The other philosophical paradigm such as positivism is not a suitable paradigm for this study because it tests the hypothesis where the researcher observes the situation and predicts the research (Dubé & Paré, 2003; Piekkari & Welch, 2018; Park et al., 2020). In this approach, the knowledge is tested by scientific methods (Braun & Clarke, 2013), and the researcher's role is independent but limited to the observation during the collection, testing and interpretation of data (Hassard, 1995). In other words, it is all about the discovery of knowledge. Similarly, the post-positivist approach is mainly suitable to explore the reality of

CEOs' Fintech-related decision-making phenomenon by admitting that empirical observations alone could not capture the full reality (Salzmann-Erikson, 2024), which is accompanied by many layers and complexities. It mainly seeks details of shortcomings left in strict positivism (Clark, 1998; Groff, 2004; Petroski, 2011). Meanwhile, pragmatism emphasises that realities are external and have multiple meanings due to the practical implications of actions in a particular context (Creswell, 2007; Morgan, 2014; Ivanova et al., 2019). In this kind of philosophical approach, many approaches, mixed or multiple methods, are used to collect and analyse data, particularly those research in which events happened in the past, in social or political contexts (Creswell, 2007). The philosophical approach to realism relates to the scientific assumptions of discovering the truth that already exists anywhere around the world (Braun & Clarke, 2013; Gronda & Gronda, 2020) but is independent of human understandings and beliefs (Callaghan & Mitchell, 2023; Willis, 2023). Idealism suggests that reality is based on ideas in the mind (Foster, 2021).

When it comes to the criteria for the validity of the knowledge, the researcher needs to define its epistemological position. Epistemology is a study of criteria or philosophy to constitute valid knowledge (Johnson & Duberley, 2000; Bonaccorsi, 2022; Younus & Zaidan, 2022). Epistemology deals with the ways of knowing and the researcher's belief system about the knowledge's origin, interpretations, meanings and sources (Klenke, et al., 2016). In the epistemological position of the researcher, the most common question is to identify the relationship between the researcher and the topic of the study to make it clear that the subjective stance of the researcher may influence the research. However, in this case, the researcher is not working in the FinTech industry but is an ordinary researcher interested in understanding SME financing using FinTech. The epistemological stance is social constructionism, meaning knowledge is constructed through social practices (Young & Collin, 2004; Cohen et al., 2004; Stead, 2004) or social interactions (Mir & Watson, 2000). In social constructionism, social and cultural practices such as interaction or conversations with people help individuals to construct their knowledge (Richardson et al. 2009). In this study, the CEOs

interact with friends and family at the micro level and gain education or experience within their social environment. At the meso level, they work in their respective organisations, which includes people to make their organisational culture and further establish their professional networking in and outside their organisations. At the macro level, they socially interact within their country's social environment, where they learn and gain knowledge to make their own decisions within the country's political system, laws and regulations. That leads towards the relationship between self at the micro level to socially construct meanings of their decisions coupled with influencing factors at the meso and macro levels. This philosophical stance of social constructivism enables the researcher to delve deep into how CEOs make Fintech decisions. This is particularly significant as it considers their engagement with people as a form of social practice, thereby providing a comprehensive understanding of their decision-making processes. As a researcher, it is imperative to maintain an ethical and collaborative approach with the participants. This ensures a respectful and considerate understanding of their perceptions of similar research questions. Social constructivism, in this context, enables the researcher to identify how CEOs construct their knowledge of a particular phenomenon through social interaction and experience, which will uncover many truths (Stead, 2004), particularly due to the participants' subjective perceptions of their financing decisions.

In summary, the constructivism paradigm helps the researcher to know participants' subjective perceptions and decision-making of their financing preferences. The ontological and the epistemological stances influence the work due to the researcher's subjectivity, beliefs, values and approaches to methodology. The researcher's ontological approach towards the research philosophical assumptions is relativism with a social constructivism epistemological stance to explore the research phenomenon.

3.1.1.2. Methodology

Research methodology is an approach that provides the researcher with a way (Sileyew, 2019) to establish a plan, procedure, or direction (Creswell, 2014) to conduct the research.

Research methodologies include methods and techniques (Dubey & Kothari, 2022) to collect data consistent with the philosophical assumptions to accomplish research objectives. These methods focus on different aspects of reality to examine the rich understanding of the phenomena through gathering and collection of the data (Miller & Tsang, 2010). Methods are rules, techniques or tools to collect evidence (Hesse-Biber, 2016). Research methods are classified into qualitative or quantitative and linked to the inductive and deductive reasoning approach, depending on the research design, research questions, and prior knowledge and theory in the subject area.

It is essential for a researcher to identify the most suitable research methodology per the research tree process to establish the criteria for the research, including following the appropriate research methodology. In the current research, what influences or affects CEOs' decision-making is unknown, and there are limited academic theories and evidence on FinTech financing. Therefore, the qualitative research method is more suitable to examine the research questions. In qualitative research, the researcher's approach to writing is inductive. The inductive approach of reasoning in the qualitative research method is suitable for getting detailed insights if there is no or little existing theory or literature about the problem (Pope, et al., 2000; Domegan & Fleming, 2007; Hayes, 2005; Ketokivi & Mantere, 2010; Bendassolli, 2013; LUKENCHUK, 2017; Kyngäs, 2020; Zeithaml et al., 2020). It includes subjective reasoning and focusing on underlying assumptions that reality is constructed through the social phenomenon. The inductive approach is also called bottom-up (Hayes, 2005), explanatory and reverse to the deductive approach (Tuomela, 1981; Zalaghi & Khazaei, 2016; Okoli, 2023). The deductive reasoning approach is unsuitable for qualitative research but is more appropriate for quantitative research where the process starts with the research theoretical framework, the creation of hypotheses, and then data collection, developing themes (Tracy, 2020) and testing the theory (Creswell & Creswell, 2018).

There are many research methods to address the research questions, such as an experiment, case study, survey, action research, grounded theory, ethnography, phenomenological and

narrative research inquiry which provides a framework for design, structure, philosophical assumptions and approach to meet the research objectives (Morse, 2016; Muurlink, 2018; Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Ng, et al., 2018; Tracy, 2020; Yin, 2013; Maulina, et al., 2022; Holloway & Galvin, 2023). In the current research, while using qualitative methods, the researcher's philosophical assumptions are primarily based on constructivism to understand the subjective meanings of CEOs' decision-making relating to their Fintech financing decision making. In the process, the researcher gathers data through interviews, including participants' views and opinions, to establish the meaning of the research phenomenon (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). Considering inductive reasoning and its consistency with philosophical paradigms, the researcher establishes a grounded approach as a suitable method within qualitative research to collect and analyse the data. This is because the current research deals with CEOs who hold professional positions at the highest level of their organisational hierarchies to make critical decisions. Considering their senior executive positions, it is argued that their decisions are primarily strategic with a long-term impact on their entire organisation (Recendes, et al., 2022) that includes power and politics as dominant paradigms to influence their decisions (Eisenhardt & Zbaracki, 1992). For example, the senior executives and non-executives on the organisational board can have conflicting objectives to reach a consensus on their decisions. That is because strategic decisions' power and politics paradigm views organisations as political systems where decision-makers have conflicting objectives (Eisenhardt & Zbaracki, 1992). Power dynamics are crucial, and political manoeuvring influences individuals' decisions (Eisenhardt & Zbaracki, 1992). Similarly, CEOs' distinctive leadership characteristics distinguish them from other senior offices in organisations and help them compete with their competitors by responding to changes in their dynamic business environment. They also consider their country's political system and laws in their financing decisions. The context of financing preferences requires detailed insights to get the true meanings and the actual cause of CEOs' decision-making by investigating their subjective stances within the complex organisational systems and dynamics of their business environment. Therefore, the ground approach is more suitable for this research. The grounded

approach in this qualitative research helps the researcher establish the unique practice used in grounded theory research; however, it does not focus on the grounded theory itself (Gligor, et al., 2016). The grounded approach allows flexibility to use an iterative process of data collection and analysis (Gligor, et al., 2016) as per the nature of the research to engage actively with participants of how they create meaning within their context (Charmaz, 2000; Charmaz, 2006; Charmaz, 2017). The data collection and analysis process in the grounded approach allows participants to freely express their opinions, experiences and views through interviews, which are analysed by the researcher through coding, leading to the development of themes and patterns (Gligor, et al., 2016). The main emphasis of this approach is that the data is grounded in the participants (Creswell & Creswell, 2018; Cullen & Brennan, 2021) to gain an in-depth understanding of a particular phenomenon (Beck, 2021). Getting views of CEOs through similar research questions in the grounded approach enables the researcher to identify multiple realities (Stead, 2004) within the social constructionism paradigm (Young & Collin, 2004; Cohen et al., 2004; Stead, 2004). Such studies are exploratory in the qualitative research context (Ponelis, 2015), which leads to revealing or unpacking the experiences of CEOs about their financing preferences and the results into more generalised conclusions to meet the research purpose (Yin, 2014).

The rationale for not considering other methods is that if the researcher considers the experiment research, that requires consideration of hypotheses - the causes and effects of dependent and independent variables to test theories (Srinagesh, 2011). Experiments are usually conducted in the lab or natural environment and have different design features, feasibilities, and complexity regarding the cost and time of academic research. Experiments are further classified into true and quasi-experiments and follow deductive reasoning. Survey methods are primarily quantitative (Nardi, 2018), but they can be qualitative (Braun, et al., 2021) - exploratory and descriptive, and the data is collected through responses from the selected participants (Check & Schutt, 2012). Survey results may limit the participants' views with close-ended questions (Story & Tait, 2019) which does not fit the project. The current

research does not include the researcher and practitioner working together in a field to solve a problem, as the action research strategy suggests. It is also called a field experiment (Krishnaswamy, et al., 2009) to learn truths relating to the research objectives. This research also does not include the researcher's experience as a philosophical approach criterion mentioned earlier. Then, it focuses on the stories of an individual's experience (Given, 2008) as per the framework of the Narrative research methods. Similarly, case study methods are considered powerful qualitative research tools (Gerring, 2016) but do not fit because it is mostly focused on single or multiple cases (Hancock, et al., 2021) or events (Mfinanga, et al., 2019) and these methods are not aligned with the current research philosophical paradigm. Similarly, the phenomenology research strategy aligns more with humans' lived experiences (Salazar et al., 2015) of a particular situation. This is more suitable if the research requires identifying and learning participants' live experiences in an actual situation (Van Manen, 2017; Williams, 2021). Further, the current research does not fall into ethnographic research because the researcher has to become a part of a group or a culture to whom they practically observe in the social context through observations (Lichtman, 2011). Therefore, the grounded approach (Gligor, et al., 2016) to understand the subjective meanings (Charmaz, 2000; Charmaz, K., 2006; Charmaz, 2017) of CEOs' decision-making is more aligned with this study. This approach fits well with the philosophical paradigm of social constructionism (Young & Collin, 2004; Cohen et al., 2004; Stead, 2004). In the grounded approach, the researcher adopted an open approach (Bryant, 2017) in its questions to allow participants to provide detailed insights into their decision-making relating to Fintech financing. The point herein is that CEOs have various situations in which they make financing decisions. Due to the varied nature of humans and influential factors at the micro, meso and macro, the results may bring multiple realities (Stead, 2004) to explore CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing.

3.1.1.3. Interviews as Data Collection Method

Data collection depends on the research methodological approach. There are two sources of data: primary and secondary. The primary data is collected directly from people by using questionnaires, surveys, and interviews, while the secondary sources are existing publications, reports, books and libraries (Ajayi, 2017; Largan & Morris, 2019; Sileyew, 2019; Watkins, 2022). As semi-structured interviews encourage two-way communication and open-ended discussions (Lavrakas, 2008), it allows the interviewer to talk about sensitive issues and questions in detail (Rabionet, 2011). The researcher collected the data from CEOs by using semi-structured interviews as a primary source of information, which facilitates the researcher to collect qualitative data that can be compared to future and previous data to produce an accurate research outcome (Draper & Swift, 2011).

During the interviewing process, participants were asked open-ended questions after consenting to participate in the study. The research questions are related to their financing practices and how they make FinTech financing decisions at the micro, meso, and macro levels. They were asked to answer the questions based on their views, opinions, and experiences and were also asked to highlight any concerns they may have had regarding the financing method. Data from interviews support the researcher in providing detailed beliefs and opinions of the CEOs' factors in their decision-making. The participants are given sufficient time to explore questions and express their opinions and views. The first interview was conducted in February 2021, with a follow-up to three participants' interviews for the pilot study by 27th April 2021. During that time, the researcher participated in research training, aligned interview questions and analysed the pilot data. Due to COVID, The remaining interviews were conducted between 20th October 2022 and 3rd August 2023. The data from CEOs was gathered only once to complete the research in six years. It is essential to mention that the fitness for interview questions and ethical issues are important aspects of conducting good interviews. Ethical issues in interviewing include the safety of participants in a protected

environment, data protection requirements, a guarantee of participants' anonymity and non-traceability, and privacy issues.

3.1.2. Establishing the participant criteria

In this research, the availability of the potential participants and the study's selection criteria are considered during the research design phase. The criterion sampling is used in this research which perfectly fits with the qualitative methods of the research (Barusch, et al., 2011). According to Palinkas et al. (2015), the selection of the participants for the interview is based on the predetermined criteria that help the researcher identify the potential participants and their characteristics. The views, assumptions, and opinions of selected participants are according to the sampling criteria to generate more generalised outcomes (Patton, 2015). The criterion sampling includes only working CEOs of UK SMEs in the non-financial sector who use FinTech or have experience or knowledge of FinTech. Other criteria include that the SMEs' age should be older than a year and the company size should not be less than 2 people. The rationale for selecting SMEs aged more than 1 year is that new companies always face credit problems due to their age, and they may shift their financing preferences towards FinTech. Two-person criteria will restrict sole traders and encourage participants' involvement that may have the board for collective decisions from limited companies. There are no restrictions on the CEO's age, experience or education, as these are the micro-level factors that this research establishes to achieve its research objectives.

In qualitative research, a sufficient sample size matters a lot to reach a reliable and valid research outcome (Burmeister & Aitken, 2012; Marshall et al., 2013; Cleary et al., 2014; Malterud et al., 2016). In grounded research, the ideal size is a data saturation for value-added insights to conclude (Glaser & Strauss, 1967; Thomson, 2010, COI, 2016; Sebele-Mpofu, 2020). Therefore, the researcher's stance is to continue gathering data to reach data saturation for valuable findings and conclusions. The current research reaches the sufficiency of data at the 20th participant. Even though the researcher does not have gender criteria in

this study. However, six females and fourteen males participated in the research as a fair representation of the sample to provide diverse views, opinions and perceptions of their financing decisions. The research design facilitates the researcher's analysis and examination of the actions and opinions of the individuals given in response to the interview questions to generate patterns, themes, and accurate outcomes.

3.1.3. Data Collection: Participant Recruitment

Most of the SMEs incorporated in the UK have their profiles available on the internet, such as incorporation information in the Companies House and their CEOs' profiles on LinkedIn, membership, or federation platforms. CEOs' profiles are not readily available and accessible by the researcher through the Internet. At least 250 profiles on LinkedIn, companies and other professional membership websites were searched, and the invitation was sent. The invitation includes the participant recruitment criteria so CEOs can self-assess themselves if they meet the criteria to participate in the study. 60 CEOs responded, and further information was sent to ensure they met the research criteria. The reason for sending more invitations was to choose the eligible participants in the study. Many of the 250 contacted participants did not respond. At the same time, a few refused to join the research as they were either busy or had no interest in the study. The researcher also felt that the invitation letter did not get a response due to the current COVID-19 pandemic, where most CEOs have started to work from home, and gatekeepers do not provide access to their CEOs. The eligible participants were selected. The research also obtained consent from each participant, in which the purpose of the study and the importance of their participation were explained clearly.

The researcher emailed an interview guide to the participants (Appendix 11). The interview guide included the necessary project and ethics details and an outline of the research the researcher would like to cover during the interview. The participants were advised to go through the guide to understand the purpose of the study and how their participation is helpful and meaningful for the researcher in generating generalised outcomes. Participants needed

to review the guide and confirm their participation before the interview. A few participants reviewed and agreed to the details of the guide and the participation in interviews in their working schedules.

3.1.4. Participant demographic information

Before the interview, the participants were given an interview guide. The participant information sheet (Appendix 10) records useful information about participants, including their SMEs, to help the researcher shortlist against the participant recruitment criteria and gain sufficient information for the demographic data analysis. It is to be noted that the data in the participant information sheet is processed in line with the ethical and legislative data protection requirements, where it was mentioned to CEOs that no data will be used to identify the person or the organisation and that confidentiality is maintained. Therefore, the information that the researcher gets through the participant information sheet is not sent to the third party to validate, for example, the identity of CEOs or their organisation, turnover and number of staff, CEOs' age, qualifications or experience in SMEs and Fintech which is against the data protection clauses to keep the information confidential. Further data collection through participant information does not constitute any agreement between the researcher and the participant to validate the information either by the researcher or the third party on behalf of the researcher. Therefore, the demographic data only represents the information gained from CEOs based on their true faith and knowledge, which is considered correct and helps to justify their fair participation in the research. Microsoft Excel sheet records the participant demographic information to statistically represent them in tables as percentages. This information includes gender, age group, education level, experience as CEO and experience within the industry, knowledge and understanding of using Fintech, further sector, turnover, and number of directors in the organisation. The following table provides the representation of the demographic data.

Table 2 Demographic Data

Demographic Data (N = 20)	
Age	18-35 (25%) 36-55 (60%) 56+ (15%)
Gender	Male (14) – 70% Female (6) – 30%
Education Level	Below Degree (10%) Undergraduate Degree (35%) Postgraduate Degree (40%) Doctorate Degree (15%)
Experience within Industry	1-3 Years – 15% 4-5 years – 40% 6-10 years – 20% 11-20 years – 25%
Experience as a CEO	1-3 Years (40%) 4-5 Years (30%) 5-10 Years (25%) 11-20 Years (5%) 20+ Years – None
Experience to use Fintech	None – 15% Little – 20% Some – 55% A lot – 10%
Knowledge of Fintech	None – 0% Little – 50% Some – 40% A lot – 10%

The demographic data of participants confirm their age as 18-35 years old (25%), 36-55 years old (60%) and 15% above 55 years old. Gender includes 6 females (30%) and 14 males (70%) of the sample. The education level as Doctorate level (15%), postgraduate (40%), and undergraduate (35%) while 10% participants hold qualifications less than undergraduate degree. All participants are well qualified, out of which 90% CEOs hold degree or the higher level postgraduate qualifications. At least 40% of participants have CEOs' experience of less than 4 years and 30% between 4 and 5 years. The study confirms that only one participant which represents 5% of the sample hold experience 11-20 years' experience while 25% (n=5) hold up to 10 years' experience as CEOs. Most participants (95%) hold at least 10 years of experience as CEOs. The study further confirms that 65% participants' organisations currently or previously used Fintech to funds their operations. Also, at the individual level 61% CEOs

were personally involved in the transactions while 100% CEOs have considerable knowledge of Fintech.

Table 3 Employees and Turnover

Employees		
1-10	n=9	45%
11-50	n=8	40%
51-250	n=3	15%
Total	20	100%
Turnover		
Under £50000	N=1	5%
£51000 - £85000	N=7	35%
£86000 - £500,000	N=10	50%
Above £500,000 – below £50 Million	N=2	10%
Total	N=20	100%

The above table represents the SMEs number of employees and their turnover as per information gained from the participant information sheet before the conduct of interview. This helps the researcher to not only choose the qualifying participants but also represents demographic data of the participants. It is to be noted that SMEs are further divided into micro, small and medium sized businesses (OECD, 2017). At the micro level, the number of employees are less than 10, at the small level, employees are less than 50 but higher than 10 while medium SMEs have employees less than 250. The current study represents the highest level of micro SMEs. The medium sized SMEs are 15% as compared to small SMEs (40%) and micro represents 45% of total population (n=20). This study excludes the large sized businesses of employees more than 250 (OECD, 2017) which represents only 0.1% of total businesses in the UK (FSB, 2022). As indicated in the table 3, 90% SMEs have turnover less than £500,000 and only 10% have higher than £500,000 and less than £50 million. This also indicate that at least 50% of CEOs work for the companies with turnover over £85K and less than £500K. These businesses provide the highest level of employment with 45% of the sample.

3.1.5. Virtual Conduct of Interviews

The researcher conducted the interviews virtually because of two potential reasons. One is that it was necessary to take the precautions and maintain the social distancing due to the current pandemic of Coronavirus (World Health Organization, 2020). Secondly, the CEOs of the SMEs in the UK were distributed across the country and it was not feasible for every participant to physically join the interview session due to the government guidance in addition to precautionary measurement taken the researcher. Therefore, the researcher opted for Zoom, which is a video communication application, providing chat and video telephony services to the consumers. The multiple formats of communication are supported in Zoom which include video chatting, instant messaging, texting and meeting and participant can securely join Zoom with user ID and password (Gal, 2020). Recording of interviews in the qualitative research is preferred but not essential (King & Horrocks, 2010). However, Zoom also has features of recording meeting (Zoom, 2020). This recording feature in Zoom facilitates the researcher to record the answers of each participant which can be formulated, analysed and compared to the opinions of other participants to generate the outcomes of the research. Zoom also captures the participants' gestures and body language during the interviews, which is an extra feature over audio/telephone interviews; the video determines the accuracy of the information being gathered from the participants. According to Iserson, et al. (2019) the video recording without consent from both parties is unethical and illegal. Therefore, before suggesting joining the Zoom meeting, the researcher took the consent from each participant to confirm the recording of the video session while highlighting its importance to the research outcomes. It was also ensured that participants had an uninterrupted internet facility so that they could join the meeting on time. Zoom has provided efficient, convenient and cost-effective methods to conduct the virtual meetings, which are feasible for everyone and recording facility made it more convenient for the researcher to collect the data easily (Archibald, et al., 2019). There are many other video conferencing tools to conduct interviews, one of such applications is Skype with improved features of video meeting, but for this

research, the Zoom was selected because it provides a great reliability and the quality of streaming video. Therefore, using Zoom and taking consent from each participant is suitable for collecting the online data in this research.

3.1.6. Pilot Study

Pilot study is very important for any kind of research either quantitative or qualitative. It helps the researcher to identify problems at the early stage of the research such as revision and modification of research questions before the broader plan is implemented and support the researcher to get some skills (Gorman & Clayton, 2003). The pilot study was beneficial for this research. It aimed to gain insights, understanding, and descriptive and exploratory responses from CEOs regarding their decisions relating to FinTech financing.

Through obtaining information directly from the CEOs, the acquired answers were based on numerous years of experience in their respective fields and first-hand observations made by them on the financing. The answers led to a detailed understanding of the SME financing through FinTech using different methods. The answers and subsequent analysis were imperative for the study. Other reasons to conduct pilot study was that qualitative methods to be time-consuming and highly specialise job for the researcher to arrange participants, conduct interviews and then use Nvivo software to analyse their interview transcripts. Pilot study helped the researcher to ensure the fitness of interview questions, research philosophical assumptions and the preparation of the main study. The researcher also uses the pilot study to identify any gaps and limitations in the design and enable the researcher to improve. The following steps were used to conduct the pilot study

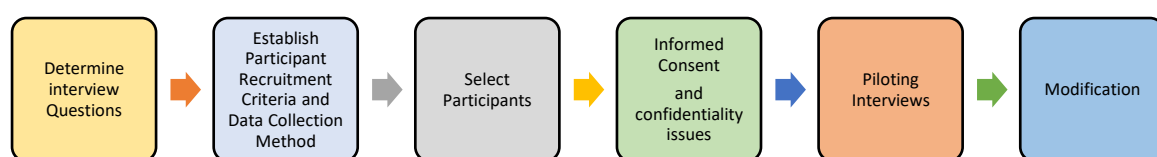


Figure 9: Steps to conduct the pilot study

In the pilot study, the researcher determined four main interview questions to cover topics of the study. In order to encourage participants to explore their views, the questions design features include all elements of purposeful and open-ended questions. The semi structure interview guide was developed as an interview framework, based on phases suggested by (Kallio, et al., 2016) to increase the questions effectiveness and participant involvement and motivation to the research. In the pilot study, three participants were selected, only those who meet the participant recruitment criteria. Zoom was used to conduct interviews during Feb-April 2021. The researcher provided details about the aims, objectives of the research and the scope of the interview and seek informed consent from participants.

In the phase of piloting the interview, the researcher ensured that confidentiality of information is maintained that includes ensuring that the personal data is protected while using Zoom as per Data Protection Act. This was also confirmed to the participant before the start of the interview. The ideal interviewing time varies, depends on the research questions and the participant interest (Gillham, 2007). However, the researcher ensured that the interviewing timing last sufficient to get detailed insights, keeping in view the important time of CEOs and their other commitments. During the interview, the audio of the online meetings was transcribed and notations were made in a transcript with the visual cues which were recorded to evaluate their meanings next to the spoken words and to further understand the recordings (Keeney, et al., 2011). The data was analysed by using Nvivo software after the transcription was reviewed by the researcher. The responses gathered during interviews were not termed as right or wrong answers because opinions were objective and based on personal experience, yet the answers were used as guidance for the researcher to make conclusions and organise them according to the identified themes (Geist, 2010).

The lessons learnt from the pilot study helped the researcher to plan better to organise timely interviews, re-ordering the interview questions, test Zoom meetings and the researchers' skills requirement to conduct the better interview and the proficiency level to use Nvivo. In the major study, open-ended questions are used with an improved interview guide. The time allocation

would be 50 minutes. There would not be any change in the participant recruitment criteria and Zoom meeting software to capture meetings.

3.1.7. Reflexivity and the researcher role during the interview

Since the research is based on the collection of the primary data through semi structured interviews to achieve the research objectives. The researcher felt the complexity at different stages in exploring how various factors navigate CEOs in their financing choices at the micro, meso, and macro levels. For example, understanding the subjective stance of CEOs in their organisational context, where they faced various challenges in making financing decisions, required a deep understanding of their organisational environmental factors and, more importantly, the governance issues. The researcher reviewed different literature on management and leadership, power, and politics in governance and legal documents relating to SME incorporation and senior officers' roles on the board to understand the context of CEOs' decision-making. The researcher maintained the learning log throughout the project to reflect upon the positive experience and impact on the research outcome. The purpose of maintaining the log of learning was to gain a deep awareness of the study's literature to make meaningful findings in the project. According to Waterhouse et al. (2020), there is always a probability of obtaining biased responses from the participants during interviews, which has the potential to make the outcomes redundant if the responses are not honest. To eliminate the biased responses from the participants, the researcher's role was to maintain ethical discussion in a friendly and comfortable environment throughout the interview. During the interview process, there was the possibility that the participant could belong to different ethnicities, religions, or colours. Hence, the researcher ensured that his questions promoted equality by avoiding discriminatory terms or unethical language. Ethical reflexivity promotes good relationships between parties involved in the research (Clarke, et al., 2016) and maintains moral accountability (Cunliffe & Ivaldi, 2021). The discussion was made relevant and ethical as much as possible so that hatred and biased responses from the participants

could be eliminated. Further, various strategies were used to avoid personal discussions with participants, which could compromise the confidentiality of participants, and their associated parties' personal information. In the constructionism paradigm, in-depth interviews were essential to allow participants with assumptions to explore their subjective stances of what they feel, think and experience (Marvasti, 2019) in their social world (Archer, 2007). Therefore, the researcher appreciated the participants' opinions by allowing maximum time. These strategies also included adjusting the research questions without changing the context of the actual research questions so the participants could understand and respond accordingly.

3.2. Analysis

The purpose of this study was to explore how micro, meso, and macro factors influence the way CEOs make Fintech financial decisions. The researcher focused on four research questions to guide this study. Interviews with CEOs were conducted to collect data for the study. After recording the interviews, the researcher transcribed each interview of the participants into a Microsoft Word document. The researcher used alphanumeric codes to name the transcripts based on the sequence of interviews. For example, the first transcript for the first interview participant was named as "P1". After transcribing all interviews, the researcher gave each participant a copy of the transcript to confirm the accuracy of the collected data. All the transcripts were accurate, as there were no participants who indicated changes to the transcripts. After confirmation of the transcripts, the researcher read each transcript several times to develop his understanding of each response and the research question. This is called the conceptualisation as per the analysis step of the research tree. Conceptualisation is a process of understanding the texture meanings (Ravitch & Carl, 2019; Palacios, et al., 2021) of the interview transcript to familiarise oneself with the research data. The researcher began data analysis by importing all the transcripts into Nvivo software. Nvivo was used to record interview transcripts. Nvivo was developed by QSR International, and it is

one of the most popular software for business, psychology, sociology, and other disciplines, especially for qualitative research. Nvivo helps the researcher store, organise, and analyse data using in-built programming through codes and the development of themes. Nvivo's main aim is to facilitate the researcher to organise and analysis of the data. Once a project is created in Nvivo, it can create, explore, share, and import documents.

The researcher followed the six steps outlined in the literature for conducting thematic analysis (Byrne, 2022; Campbell et al., 2021; Xu & Zammit, 2020). The first step of thematic analysis is data familiarisation (Byrne, 2022). The researcher utilised the first step to gain a comprehensive understanding of the participants' responses by reading and re-reading the transcripts. It is important for the researcher to understand the true meaning of CEOs' responses in the interview data to reflect the correct understanding of the phenomenon. The researcher related the participants' responses to the research questions and highlighted the phrases and some words that were linked to the research questions while reading the transcripts. The researcher used the features of Nvivo software to highlight the phases and some words relating to the research questions.

The second step of thematic analysis is the generation of initial codes (Byrne, 2022; Campbell et al., 2021; Xu & Zammit, 2020). Coding is important to analyse data and helps the researcher work towards achieving the research aims. After understanding the participants' responses comprehensively, the researcher started developing codes relevant to answering the research question. The gathered data of transcripts were coded using Nvivo (Bazeley & Jackson, 2013), and a backup copy was created to ensure that no data was lost until thoroughly utilised for the study (Stuckey, 2014). The copies were stored on a separate device and placed in a protective location to prevent misuse, while in addition to electronic copies, hard copies were also made. The researcher developed the initial codes by labelling and organising data into meaningful groups using Nvivo software. Specifically, the researcher identified a chunk of words relevant to answering the research question and highlighted them within Nvivo. The researcher created nodes, which are coding categories, in Nvivo to store and organise the generated codes. The

researcher conducted the coding process systematically, meaning he read through each transcript at a time and highlighted the chunks of words that were relevant to answering the research questions. While developing codes, the researcher kept on revisiting the research questions to ensure that the initially developed codes were relevant to each question. For example, for the first research question (What are the financing preferences for UK SMEs in the changing economic and financial technology environment?), the researcher looked for phrases and words that expressed CEOs' preferences or non-preferences to Fintech and traditional financing. Examples of the codes that were generated for the first research question include prefer, secure, more efficient, cheap, and easy access to funds. These codes represented the rationale given by most CEOs for preferred Fintech.

In the grounded approach, the data analysis starts with open coding to identify, name and categorise the phenomenon found in the data (Gligor, et al., 2016). The researcher used an open coding technique to develop codes based on the participants' responses without the biases and preconceptions of the researcher (Vollstedt & Rezat, 2019). The researcher used an open coding technique to avoid making assumptions about the objective reality of the CEOs' experiences. It is important to mention here that the researcher did not develop the codes based on his knowledge, preconceptions or available literature knowledge related to each research question. The open coding technique enabled the identification of emergent themes objectively, unlike pre-determined themes in priori coding.

The third step in the thematic analysis was generating the initial themes (Byrne, 2022; Campbell et al., 2021; Xu & Zammit, 2020). The researcher used the third step to develop initial themes by combining and sorting codes into initial themes and identified the meanings and relationships between the initial codes (Campbell, et al., 2021). The researcher conducted the third process by grouping and regrouping the codes that were developed to generate initial themes. Just like the code-developing process, the researcher read the sentences containing the codes and identified the relationships with the research questions. The researcher revisited the research questions every time to combine initially developed codes to develop

initial themes. The Nvivo software enabled the researcher to organise the initial codes and themes that were developed. For example, for each identified code, the software enabled the researcher to link codes to their respective themes. The researcher was able to see all codes for each theme using the NVivo software.

The fourth step in the thematic analysis is reviewing the generated themes (Byrne, 2022; Campbell et al., 2021; Xu & Zammit, 2020). The researcher used the fourth step to refine the initial themes which were developed in step three. In the fourth step, the researcher made some other considerations and activities while refining themes. For example, the researcher ensured there was sufficient data to support themes. The researcher retained the themes that were supported by more than two participants. The researcher also collapsed overlapping themes in the fourth step. Further, the researcher checked for coherence and consistency of themes.

The fifth step in the thematic analysis is defining and naming themes (Byrne, 2022; Campbell et al., 2021; Xu & Zammit, 2020). The researcher utilised the fifth step to finalise the themes that were relevant to answering the research questions. In the fifth step, the researcher ensured that the name of the themes succinctly captured the essence of the theme in answering the research question. According to Byrne (2022), the fifth step involves expressing each theme in relation to data and research questions. In addition, the researcher used the fifth step to support each theme with the participants verbatim. Specifically, the researcher linked the identified themes with participants' responses that contained codes and phrases supporting the theme. The last step in thematic analysis is producing a report. The last step involves presenting a concise account of the data and themes by writing compelling arguments that answer the research question (Campbell et al., 2021). The researcher utilised the last step to write research results about the study. The report contained the research questions and the themes that emerged to support each question. In the report of results, the researcher explained the themes and linked them with participants' responses and research questions.

The screenshot shows the NVivo Coding interface. On the left is a sidebar with navigation options: Quick Access, IMPORT, Data (Files, File Classifications, Externals), ORGANIZE, Coding (Codes, Relationships, Relationship Types), Cases, Notes, Sets, EXPLORE, Queries, Visualizations, and Reports. The main area displays a table of codes with columns for Name, Files, References, and Created on.

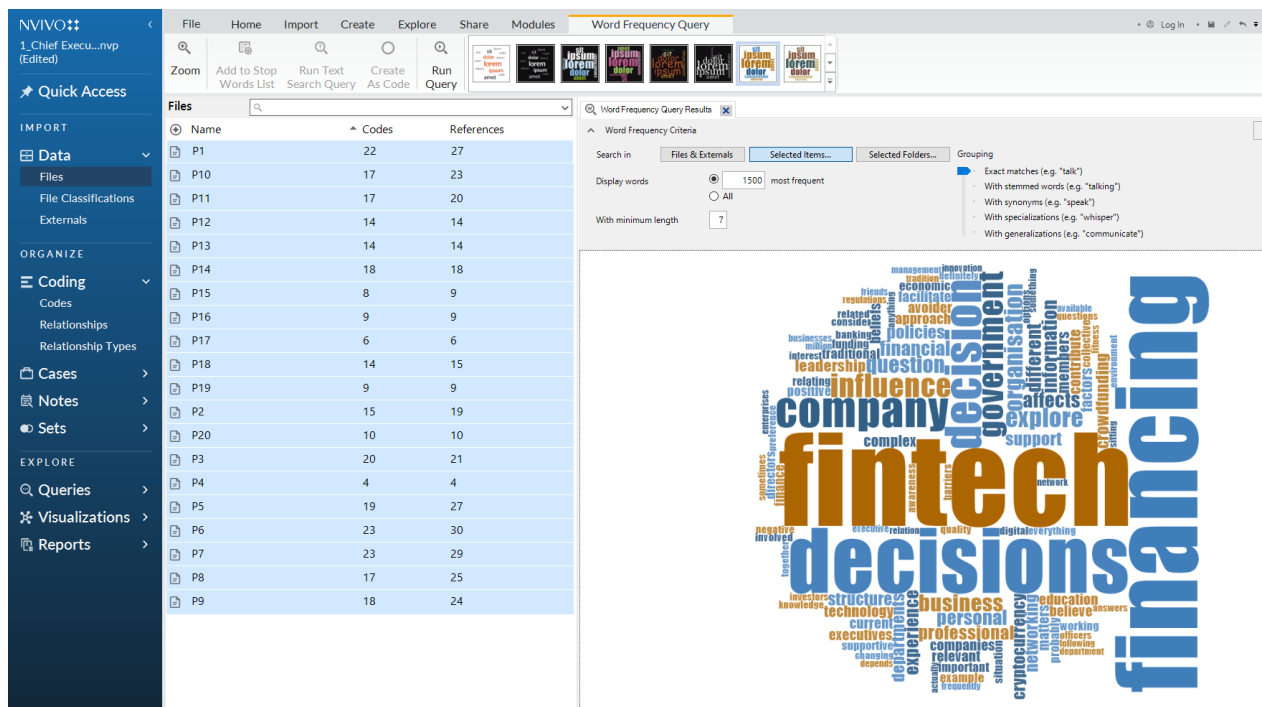
Name	Files	References	Created on
Education Improves Competencies	8	10	27/04/2023 13:44
Effective Flow of Information Facilitate Making Fintech Decisions.	7	11	28/04/2023 09:42
Experience with FinTech	2	2	27/04/2023 13:56
FinTech is cheap	6	7	27/04/2023 18:00
FinTech if Flexible	3	8	27/04/2023 19:10
FinTech Provides more Financing Options	5	7	27/04/2023 13:45
Fitech is secure	2	2	27/04/2023 19:22
Governance	0	0	08/07/2023 16:24
Consults Board in Makig Fintech Decisions	9	11	28/04/2023 09:15
We have a board.	16	19	08/07/2023 16:41
Incorporate advice and contributions from other professionals	14	18	28/04/2023 09:40
Incorporate Family Members' Perspectives in Fintech Decision Making	10	12	27/04/2023 13:53
Increasing Demand and Banking challenges necessitates Fintech Options	4	4	28/04/2023 09:44
Insufficient informationa and policies about Fintech limits Decision making	8	10	28/04/2023 09:26
Laws Discouraing Fintech Options	4	4	28/04/2023 09:29
Laws that guides Fintech Decisions	4	4	28/04/2023 09:55
Leaders instill work ethics	3	3	27/04/2023 18:21
leadership qualities	17	19	18/05/2023 15:53
Leadership Qualities Improves Business Relations	5	5	27/04/2023 13:50
Limited Awareness about Fintech	9	11	28/04/2023 10:06

Figure 10 Nvivo Coding

The screenshot shows the NVivo Statistics Coding interface. The left sidebar is identical to Figure 10. The main area displays a hierarchical tree of codes. The 'Statistics' code is selected and highlighted in blue.

Code
Prefer Fintechs
Risk Approach
Both
Risk Avoider
Risk avoiding approach helps in selecting the best option
risk taker
Risk-taking approach improves chances of success
Security concerns
Statistics
Macro - Government policies and support affects fintech decisions
No
Yes
Macro - UK laws faciliate fintech financing
Meso - Organisation structure affects fintech decisions
Meso - Professional networking affects your fintech financing decision
Meso - working with board members affects your fintech decisions
Micro - Do you think vision affects Fintech decision
Micro - Do your belief affect your fintech decisions
Micro - Education affects your fintech decision
Micro - Experience Affects your fintech decisions
Micro - Family members affect your decision on Fintech
Micro - Is your Fintech Guided by your values
Micro - Risk taking attitude affects your fintech decisions

Figure 11 Nvivo Statistics Coding at Micro, Meso and Macro



Internet or network service providers always have access to conversations between parties. Therefore, the researcher took several steps to protect the confidentiality and anonymity of the participant, such as using a random user ID and the removal of headers and tags during messaging over the internet. That assured the highest level of confidentiality to the participant. Therefore, in this way, the privacy of the participants was maintained in the research along with creating a comfortable, friendly environment so that the discussion flowed smoothly.

3.3.2. Ethical Standards

In the grounded approach, the ethical consideration includes maintaining confidentiality and obtaining informed consent from the participants (Gligor, et al., 2016). This research is a personal activity that requires hard work, dedication, and the highest standards to maintain its integrity and validity. This integrity requires following rules, regulations, industry codes and applicable laws. The current research involves the researcher and participants and includes the organisations where participants work, the institution where this study is undertaken, and all those connected persons who are directly or indirectly involved in the research. Therefore, the researcher tries to ensure that the current research should not harm any parties and should follow rules of ethics at each stage of the research process. If the rules of ethics are not followed, then the outcome of the research may damage people in a psychological or materialistic way. It will also damage the credibility of the research. Therefore, ethics are an integral part of every research study and, as such, were the foremost task of importance before beginning the research into the topic and approaching the selected participants. This qualitative research has its unique characteristics as an open-ended character, unlike quantitative research, where the hypothesis is tested. It also has its limitations because the researcher will not have control over the people who may misuse the publication of the findings. The researcher's ethical stance in this research is that of a deontologist. This is to ensure that the researcher will focus on his action during the research process and take all those reasonable steps to assess the likelihood and the severity of the harm that this current

research may bring to the participants and involved parties. The School Research Ethical Panel (SREP) approved the research under the terms of Anglia Research University's Research Ethics Policy Ver 1.7 (Appendix 9). Therefore, the researcher understood and complied with the University's highest standard of research ethics (ARU, 2021), the code of practice for the research (UKRIO, 2009) and the Data Protection Act 2018 regulations to confirm the research integrity. That also ensures the participants' privacy, confidentiality, and anonymity.

The considerations undertaken for this study were regarding maintaining ethics involving voluntary participation in the study, obtaining their consent and then their views through interviews for the analysis, and drawing conclusions to meet the aims and objectives of the study (Ponterotto, 2010). Maintaining the participants' anonymity and confidentiality was of the utmost importance while ensuring there was no risk of harm to them, for which the ethical considerations, policies and research guidelines were followed to reduce risk. During the virtual interviews, privacy was the key issue, and it was solved with unique coding. Privacy properties were adjusted so no one could listen and have access to the electronic recording.

To maintain the highest level of integrity and the confidentiality in the study, the consent forms (Appendix 10) were distributed to the participants through email so they could go through the form and respond appropriately. They were then asked to return the form with their signature, signalling their agreement to participate in the study (Connelly, 2014). To further ensure that the research was conducted ethically, all the participants were treated equally regardless of their characteristics to ensure no bias. No identifying information was asked from the participants that could potentially risk their anonymity, and as such, no private data was shared in the findings and discussion of the research study (Hallowell & Gambatese, 2010). Confidentiality was ensured throughout the interview process, even before and after the research, with steps to ensure participants did not disclose their personal information. Audio and video recordings were stored in data storage, and a backup was created on the secure server. Both physical and virtual copies were protected in a safe location for unauthorised

access. The researcher further took steps and did not share any data with other academic colleagues. The researcher also maintained the participants' anonymisation by replacing their names with random invented names and using their initials instead of full names to record data. As mentioned before, the researcher took all reasonable steps to identify the likelihood and impact of the research that is also valid for the storage, backup, and security of the data in computers and networks. The researcher used drop box premium for the entire research. Dropbox is a file hosting service to store, synchronise and share files. Dropbox files are encrypted using 256-bit Advanced Encryption Standard (AES). At the same time, the application creates a secure tunnel protected by 128-bit or higher Advanced Encryption Standard (AES) encryption and Two-step verification for an extra layer of security. That also meets the ISO ISO/IEC 27001 security arrangement to store and backup the data. The researcher will store data for at least five years before it is securely discarded. That ensures that the highest ethical standards were followed throughout the research.

4. Results

The findings of the research include interviews with twenty CEOs of UK SMEs to gain detailed insights about Fintech financing decision-making. The semi-structured interviews were conducted, meaning the questions' sequence and phrasing were not followed strictly (Kallio, et al., 2016). Despite the benefits of Fintech financing to provide improved and innovative financial service delivery as a disruption for traditional financing, the factors influencing CEOs to make such decisions are not explored. Therefore, this study aims to understand the CEOs' decision making relating to Fintech financing in UK SMEs. The results are based on the following four main research questions based on the research objectives to achieve the research aim.

Research Question 1: How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?

Research Question 2: How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude on their Fintech financing decisions?

Research Question 3: How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level?

Research Question 4: How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?

4.1. How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?

The first research question was used to explore the perceptions of CEOs regarding their financing choices at the UK SMEs. Three themes supported the first research question are (a) CEOs in the UK prefer Fintech to traditional financing, (b) Increasing Demand and Banking

Challenges Necessitate Fintech Financing Options, and (c) limited awareness about Fintech options.

4.1.1. The CEOs in the UK prefer Fintech to Traditional Financing

Consumers are more willing to adopt or use digital services that offer them added value, such as time-saving, improved efficiency, and less effort (Daragmeh, et al., 2021). Information technology is one of the significant drivers due to its benefits, such as the adoption of mobile technology (Hassan, et al., 2022). Consumers prefer technology-enabled services that provide efficiency or more benefits at a lower cost and with less complexity to meet their needs. In this study, the CEOs in the UK indicated their preference for Fintech over traditional financing options. The rationale for the preference includes that Fintech provides more options, cheap financing options and fewer regulations. For example, the preference for Fintech is a key interest of UK CEOs in SMEs, although Fintech is relatively new to them in the current market.

The statistics from the sample confirm that 70% of UK CEOs from SMEs prefer Fintech financing to traditional financing, while 15% are into traditional financing. 15% of CEOs don't want to prefer FinTech to traditional or traditional to FinTech, and they prefer both. When we further narrow down statistics concerning the male and female CEOs' preferences, 83% of female CEOs prefer FinTech financing and 17% prefer traditional financing. The statistics from male CEOs confirm the highest preference for FinTech financing. 57% of male CEOs prefer FinTech as opposed to 14%, while 29% don't want to prefer any method of financing; they prefer both for the benefit of their organisations.

A series of questions were asked to CEOs, starting with "What are your financing preferences – traditional or fintech financing?" and follow-up questions about why and the fitness of their preference in the current economic and digital age. The results bring three sub-themes regarding their FinTech financing preference, as illustrated in the following diagram.

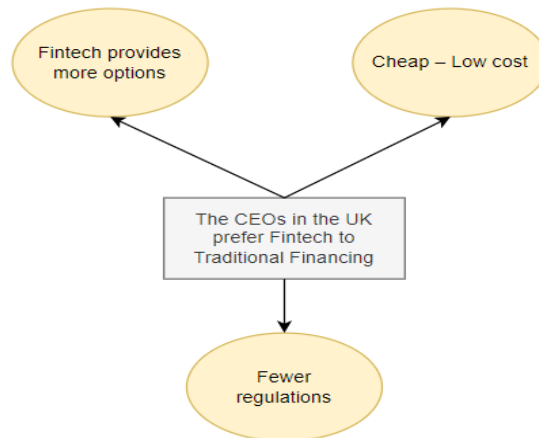


Figure 13 - Patterns Supporting the First Theme

For example, P12 prefers Fintech over traditional financing with opinions that it is secured and centralised financing. In addition, P12 supported his preference for Fintech by stating that it is easy and enables collaboration with experienced people. P12 stated,

I prefer Fintech financing to traditional. It is easier, you find experienced people to work with you and it is centralised and secure.

Also, P3 preferred Fintech because of its simplicity and quick process of obtaining finance compared to traditional funding. P3 supported his argument by stating,

I think it is good for our company not to go through complex and lengthy traditional financing options, so we can be more open to the current economic situation.

The rationale for preferring Fintech, as given by P14, was based on the cost comparisons of both financing options. P14 stated that traditional financing, such as banks, imposed high interest rates on loans. P14 stated,

Now I prefer Fintech financing due to high-interest rate on the business loan by banks.

Unlike P14, P6 and P18 have similar views except for adding further rationales for their Fintech preference, which is that Fintech financing has a simple process and fewer regulations. P18

further adds that Fintech financing has cheaper interest rates than banks. P18 supported his argument by stating,

They're both good options, but I would prefer fintech. Because fintech has a good process and less regulations and cheaper interest than banks.

P19 gave his rationale for Fintech's preference for a more secure financing method.

You know, I think this [Fintech] is the most secure, for more money. For example, if I go to a wallet full of currencies, I would be become scared, maybe someone will take away from me. But if I go bitcoin in my wallet, you know, I'm not scared, because I know it is secure, 100 percent secure. So, I think, is secure, and the other thing is non-regulated.

P9 preferences for Fintech are based on efficiency and ease of accessing funds. P9 stated that banks refused to lend them money. However, P9 did not specify reasons for the refusal by banks. Still, it went on further, saying that their SMEs secured funding through Fintech despite banks' refusal, and the process for such alternative sources of funds was efficient, which means quicker than they expected. P9 stated,

Our business was two years old. We wanted to import equipment. Our bank rejected to lend us. We used a funding exchange, and it was quick; we received a positive response.

In addition, P1 supported the preference for Fintech financing, which was the same as others by highlighting the factors of efficiency, fewer regulations, and lower interest rates, similar to P6 and P18. P1 supported her rationale of Fintech preference by stating,

I certainly go for Fintech finances because it is a quick process, fewer regulations, cheaper interest rate and easy to use.

P7 also supported the theme of preference for Fintech over traditional financing by giving several benefits perceived to be associated with Fintech. P7 described the Fintech preference because of its features, such as transparency, security, and convenience. P7 has views similar

to P1, P6, and P18 regarding Fintech having fewer regulations, which is positive for their SME. Using the terms Fintech financing through investors suggests they have more options than only going to the traditional banks for loans, P7 stated,

I prefer Fintech. It is because of transparent and secure funding options and fewer regulations. Less paperwork is better for us to convince investors to fund us.

Similar views to P7, P1, P6, P8, P12 and P18, the rationale for preferring Fintech for P9 is

Fintech financing is quicker. We will use Kickstarter. It is easy to post a project.

P12 supported the theme by acknowledging that features of technological advancement and the use of cryptocurrency are essential in prevailing in the current market. P12 indicated that cryptocurrency is secure and is associated with high returns. P12 stated,

Digital technology and cryptocurrency are the country's future. Our company, like others, will take advantage of cryptocurrency. Its valuation price is higher, and it is secure to trade, and the exchange rate is high.

Also, P2 preferred Fintech options because of the simplicity and financing options associated with Fintech. P2, like P7 Fintech, gives rationales that their SME has more options for funding through Fintech and is not associated with complicated processes like those required by banks. P2 stated,

It gives us more options or whenever we need money for the business to inject in its new projects. We don't need to look for difficult banking criteria to borrow money. I prefer for it cheaper interest rate negotiated with parties and quick process.

P11 further supported the theme of preference for Fintech by describing that traditional financing is associated with challenges in obtaining funds. The participant highlighted the challenges of the pandemic and the crisis of fewer sales. P11 provided a rationale for his

preference as banks do not give them support when they need it and do not lend money when they do not make sales. That leads to the impression that banks only lend to financially healthy businesses. P11 gave a comprehensive response supporting her argument by stating:

In our industry, artists and creative illustrators struggle with traditional financing. Our premises remained closed during COVID-19, and we did not get enough finance to pay rent. We don't have great support through traditional financing from banks. They don't give money if you don't make sales.

The summary of the three sub-themes that supported the theme of UK CEOs' preference for Fintech over traditional financing is given in the following table, along with the patterns and examples of participants' views and perceptions. Patterns describe each subtheme's most frequent use of rationales for Fintech preference.

Table 4 Sub-Themes and Patterns Supporting the First Theme

Sub-theme	Patterns	Example of Participants' verbatim
Fintech provides more financing options	More options, cryptocurrency, crowdfunding, Gofundme, Kickstarter, and more investors	"We found Seedrs, Gofundme, and Indiegogo have many opportunities for our business".
Fintech is associated with low costs	low-interest rates, Low cost, Good profit, and Cheaper rates	"It is a low cost and gives us a good profit."
Fintech is associated with fewer regulations	No strict regulations, fewer regulations, fair trading standards, lending criteria, and flexibility in payments.	"It is not as strict and regulated as the traditional banking sector is"

These three sub-themes are explained in the following sub-sections.

4.1.1.1. Fintech Provided More Financing Options

Fintech offers diverse financial options, such as insurance and payment systems, and scalable services across the globe. There are six Fintech business models, including (a) insurance

services, (b) payments, (c) crowdfunding, (d) lending, (e) capital markets, and (f) wealth management (Suryono, et al., 2020). Each helps businesses adapt to guidelines efficiently and resourcefully (Kumari & Devi, 2022). As a technological modernisation in the financial industry, Fintech provides alternative funding with more options. Patterns that supported the first sub-theme, the UK CEOs' preference of Fintech over traditional financing, include more options, cryptocurrency, crowdfunding, GoFundMe, Kickstarter, and more investors. These electronic platforms increase convenience and access to financial services because of their reliability, easy accessibility, and high speed (Kumari & Devi, 2022). Not only this, but due to accessibility features, these funds are accessible to clients in different parts of the globe. For example, P11's rationale for FinTech preference is that it is associated with more financing options they can use to acquire funds needed to run their business. According to P11, Fintech has options like crowdfunding, where their SME can quickly get money. Other Fintech options identified by P11 include GoFundMe, Indiegogo, and Seedrs. P11 identified the Fintech financing options by stating,

We found Seedrs, GoFundMe, and Indiegogo have many opportunities for our business.

P11 supported the first sub-theme by stating,

I support emerging artists and illustrators. They know it is a difficult time for them to survive. Our team goes through their artwork. If we need money to order equipment for mass printing, then we will go for crowdfunding.

Similar to P11, P5 mentioned that Fintech has many financing options to meet the financing needs of their business. P5 stated the use of Fintech - crowdfunding by stating,

I have crowdfunding experience. We raised money for our business using crowdfunding. We know how important it is for a business to have more financing options for the project.

Additionally, P5 supported her views about crowdfunding as the best financing option by stating it involves investors through the pools of funding, and they invest in SMEs to get good returns. P5 stated,

We fund our project with crowdfunding. It is a good option for investors to be involved in such a project, which gives them a good return.

P9 works in the care sector, and during the pandemic, they faced a high demand for patience and needed money for their business expansion. P9 supported the sub-theme of more options associated with Fintech by complimenting the investors' support to show interest in their business. Specifically, P9 stated they planned to use Kickstarter (Fintech) to get investors to meet their financial needs and support plans to open franchises in other locations. P9 supported his argument by stating,

COVID-19 disrupts businesses, and we have high demand; patients are in the queue. We are thinking of expanding our business to other towns. We are working on a franchise agreement. Our team is considering publishing the project on Kickstarter to bring investors in.

P6 maintained the sub-theme of more financing options that investors in crowdfunding (FinTech) fund their business through an online platform. Specifically, P6 stated that many investors in Crowdcube (a crowdfunding website) could lend them money on their preferred terms. P6 stated,

In Crowdcube, we have different investors who lend money on terms they prefer, and if your project is acceptable, then they also listen to you and fulfil your needs and payment into the business.

P6 expanded on the number of investment options available in Fintech. When asked about rationales for more options, P6 mentioned that if you are retiring and have extra money, you can be an investor through Fintech to lend money on your agreed or negotiated terms to those who need it. P6 supported her argument by stating,

Some people in their retirement investments and those who have more money they also invest while in banks you only have one option to borrow and repay with high interest or sometime it could be lower.

In addition, the context of P10's perception and opinions about Fintech provides more financing options. Not only does this funding option help with the monetary requirement for the business, but it also brings investors into the business as experts to make the company successful. As per P10, the business's chances of success could be increased by inviting experienced investors through Fintech options. P10 stated,

If you don't have much success in your business, then you can invite investors with experience through Fintech. They will support your business.

4.1.1.2. Fintech is Associated with Lower Costs

The second sub-theme that supported the theme of UK CEOs' preference for Fintech over traditional financing was that Fintech options are associated with low costs. It is to be mentioned here that the price value is a consumer's cognitive characteristic whereby they decide to purchase a product based on the cost incurred and the associated benefits (Najib, et al., 2021). Fintech transactions are far more convenient, affordable, and secure than other funding (Yan, et al., 2021). Therefore, the cost is a significant factor influencing consumers' decision to adopt Fintech, and CEOs would prefer financing options at a lower cost. This study's patterns supporting the second sub-theme include low interest rates, low cost, good profit, and cheaper rates. Cheaper rates signify lower transaction and annual fees with low-interest rates to protect from the higher prices caused by inflation (Sager, 2021). When asked why they prefer Fintech to traditional financing options, P11 provided his opinion that Fintech is associated with low cost and is profitable for their SME. P11 stated

It is a low cost and gives us a good profit.

Also, P14 supported the sub-theme of the low cost associated with Fintech, which is that banks have higher rates, making them consider Fintech with low rates. P14 stated,

Fintech funding options have become very important for our business. The high-interest rate by banks pushed us to get funds through Fintech.

In addition, P5 supported the theme that banks have high-interest rates on loans during the period of high inflation and further of opinion that Fintech is a cheap alternative funding source. P5 stated,

Thinking inflation is very high so as the interest rate is very high on loan so all priority is not to use more debt in over company seeks funds through Fintech. These days I think that almost all businesses are suffering to fund their business, and if you have already borrowed money from the banks and when the interest rate is so high, it means you have to pay more to cover up the balance.

Similar to P5, P6 stated that Fintech has more options due to investors don't have strict regulations such as charging high interest on loans those imposed by banks. P6 stated,

In Fintech, you get lower interest rates and many options from investors who just want a return on their investment and when they lend money to the business that is not very strict regulations as bank offer.

P9 supported the sub-theme of the low cost associated with Fintech options that Fintech has cheaper rates. Additionally, P9 mentioned the funding through banks was not an easy experience for them which changed their preferences to Fintech. P9 stated,

We have a supplier in China. We needed mobility machines. The number of items costs roughly £14000. Our bank asked for three years' accounts and was not willing to lend even though it was not a big amount. We got a cheaper rate with this Fintech.

4.1.1.3. *Fintech is Associated with Lower Regulations*

A third sub-theme that supported the theme of UK CEOs' Fintech financing preference was that Fintech is associated with lower regulations. In the UK, there is no specific regulatory framework for Fintech companies subject to financial regulations (Giglio, 2021). However, Fintech firms are regulated like other companies based on the regulated services they provide (Giglio, 2021). The CEOs of SMEs confirmed the absence of specific regulations governing Fintech financing by arguing that there are lower regulations associated with Fintech as compared to traditional financing options. The patterns supporting the third sub-theme include no strict regulations, fewer regulations, fair trading standards, lending criteria, and payment flexibility.

Table 5 Patterns supporting lower regulations

<i>Lower Regulations Pattern</i>	<i>Keywords</i>
	<i>No strict regulations</i> <i>Fewer regulations</i> <i>Fair trading standards</i> <i>Fair lending criteria</i> <i>Payment flexibility</i>

For example, P6 stated that the Fintech regulations are not strict and are associated with lower regulations than banks.

In fintech you get lower interest rate and many options from investors who just want return on their investment and when they lend money to the business that is not very strict regulations as bank offer

P7 supported the subtheme that funding through Fintech requires less administrative work to persuade investors to invest in their business. P7 further expounds on the sub-theme of low regulations associated with Fintech: financial markets have several regulations, unlike Fintech, with fair trading standards. P7 stated,

Less paperwork is better for us to convince investors to fund us. Financial markets have many regulations, and the Fintech market works on the fair-trading standard. If we get funds with fewer regulations and the least financial constraints, then it is good for our business to go for the best funding options.

P7 believes that the current financial situation, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the effects of war make banks impose more regulations and difficult lending criteria. P7 gave a comprehensive response supporting the sub-theme by stating:

I think we are currently in a difficult financial situation due to COVID-19 and war effects; banks have more regulations and difficult lending criteria. If they lend us money, then it has a high interest rate. As a CEO, I have to consider all of them to make a suitable decision.

P3 has a similar perception of taking advantage of Fintech financing by referring to the current economic situation as not in favour of getting loans from banks. P3 has an opinion that banks or similar financial institutions' processes to approve funds are complex because of regulations.

I think it is good for our company to not to go through complex and lengthy traditional financing options, so we can be more open to current economic situation.

Flexibility in loan repayment is a factor supporting the preference for the Fintech option identified by P7. Interest rates and repayment flexibility are among the factors considered by P7 in sourcing funds from financing options. P7 stated,

It is my role and my decision impact on the other people who work for the company. If I have to invest in a project and get funds either through banks or Fintech, I will choose the best interest rate and flexibility in the repayment.

P1 preference for Fintech financing is similar to others, but it has more factors of the process being quicker than traditional and easy to follow.

It is quick process, less regulations, cheaper interest rate and easy to use.

P18 prefer both financing methods but prefer Fintech due to less regulations as

They're both good options, but I would prefer fintech. Because fintech has fintech as a good process and less regulations and cheaper interest than banks.

P20 likes both financings, but when asked to choose the preferred one with rationales to support the decision despite mentioning other benefits of cheap interest rates and quicker financing, the P20 mentioned the regulations could be one of the factors in choosing Fintech. P20 stated

it depends. You know, if I want to, you know, how I should explain as being a being myself is the very conventional kind of person. I would like to go for conventional banking. But sometimes a fintech is very, you know, good fintech gives cheap interest rate and it's very easy to use. It has less regulations. It's very quickly, you know, it's very quick to finance. So it depends.

P19 works in the property sector, which needs funds for mortgages and other projects. P19 believes that his preference is based on the current time when everything will be digital, and digital funding is his preference for many reasons, such as regulations when normal financial institutions have strict rules. However, P19 is also perceived that Fintech is risky financing due to the fluctuation of digital currency [particularly bitcoin] in a short time, and that is due to fewer regulations. P19 provided a comprehensive answer to the preference by justifying the elements of fewer regulations as

You know, the Bitcoin market is down. And in 2020. You know, I'll just give you the example. In 2018 or 17, you know, the Bitcoin value was around

100,000. But if you look at that 27,000, something is equal to one Bitcoin. Why the value is very high. Because I hear something like that, you know, and why the value is high just because of the risky market, you never know. You know, after two weeks that after two years, that after three years, you know, it will become back to the bond again. So you can say it is highly risk market at the moment just because of non-regulated. If any country will regulate this currency the value would be very high and stable.

To extend the regulations factor, P19 further stated that digital money transactions in the business don't require a complete check on the organisation's financial stability, including checks on the identity and registered firm address that a normal bank has to consider to approve funding and that adds slow down the funding through banks.

If we go to the bank to open an account, you know, they have to go through a form. You know, your client will, in that form, they will be checked for money laundering, I.D., and address, if this. This would be based on the fintech. Look, they don't need to check because the money coming and going would be based on the intact technology. There is no traditional money. So you know they do a lot of work which banks or other financial institutes have to do they don't need to do.

4.1.2. Increasing Demand and Banking Challenges Necessitate Fintech Financing Options

The theme that emerged in the questions confirms that the increasing demand and banking challenges make CEOs consider Fintech financing options. P3 leveraged the advantages of Fintech and Bank options while making financial decisions. For example, P3 reported using a Fintech gateway because banks do not provide payment lending methods. P3 mentioned that

Both financing methods have their pros and cons. For example, the bank does not offer payment lending methods, and we use a Fintech gateway, while we use traditional banks to manage current and savings accounts.

Also, P6 supported the theme that they consider the Fintech option whenever they encounter problems or challenges with the traditional banking systems. P6 supported the argument by stating,

If we face problems with any difficulties through banks, then I personally, with the team, find other funding options that could be Fintech.

In addition, P9 supported the theme by arguing that the increasing demand necessitated seeking an alternative option, Kickstarter, to bring more investors needed to expand their business. P9 stated,

COVID-19 disrupts businesses, and we have high demand, patients are in the queue. We are thinking of expanding our business to other towns. We are working on a franchise agreement. Our team is considering publishing the project on Kickstarter to bring investors in.

P15 provided an answer by focusing on the established standing of the business as one of the factors that banks consider to lend, such as assets a business possesses. In the Fintech financing option, a business, if it has an innovative project or needs funds and has fewer assets, can choose many funding options such as P2P and crowdfunding. That suggests that there is no absolute and only option for traditional financing through banks in the presence of FinTech. According to P15,

Generally speaking, you have more assets. So traditional finance is more likely to lend to you. So you're more likely to get a funding contribution to finance and less reliance on things like a sort of crowdfunding, like as a young business which doesn't have a lot of credit, then probably P2P or crowdfunding, those types of channels will be more attractive.

4.1.3. Limited Awareness about Fintech Options

A third theme that supported the first research question was the lack of adequate awareness about Fintech options. Most participants who preferred traditional financing options over Fintech reported some lack of adequate awareness about Fintech. The common reasons are less government support and insufficient information in the news, websites and literature.

For example, P13 stated that they do not prefer either Fintech or traditional financing options because of low confidence and skills in using Fintech. P13 stated,

I don't have any preference, but I am not confident about using Fintech; you need many skills, particularly IT and security skills.

When asked about the level of Fintech awareness, P8 implied a lack of adequate awareness about Fintech by recommending that government should encourage using Fintech. P8 stated,

I think the government should help small businesses with financial support, reduce tax, and encourage using Fintech. They should allow IT companies and focus on creating more employment.

P9 and P2 also indicated that there is not enough awareness about Fintech in UK SMEs. P14 supported the lack of adequate awareness about Fintech by indicating that it is still new to them, and it necessitated furthering his education to learn more. P14 supported his opinion by stating,

Fintech is really new for us. I decided to get more education in financing options, which helped me in my decisions.

Also, P5 supported the theme of limited awareness about Fintech among SMEs that Fintech has little support for some of its options, such as cryptocurrency are not famous in the U.K. P5 stated,

There is little support available in Fintech for SMEs. That is true for private companies which encourage crowdfunding, peer-to-peer lending, and

cryptocurrency in the UK cryptocurrency is not a famous source of funds for businesses.

P1 has the perception that there is inadequate awareness about Fintech because of limited coverage in the news, unlike other options. P1 stated,

I don't think so. Not because we use Fintech but because it's not in the news as other financing options are available these days.

P2 has different views because of different backgrounds before joining CEO and confirming the limited awareness as,

This technology is new, and no one even knows about it [Fintech]. I have my education in Psychology, and I think that was the best time to learn how to identify others, not only limited to individuals but my financing decisions.

In addition, P3 supported the theme of limited awareness about Fintech, stating that there is insufficient information about Fintech financing in the literature and government websites. P3 stated,

I don't find awareness literature on government literature on the government website except for policies and initiatives.

P15's perception of the limited awareness was that it should be the role of the government to help with the innovation and offer grants to bring innovation to their business. P15 has the following views

Government grants to use the technology. So the government, give me money. It's it happens. I don't think it happens in fintech, but they, for example, government to have a subsidized to sustainable energy, for example, for people to install solar panels. Government gave money to them to do that. I'll be very interested if the government wants us to adapt to technology and give incentives. I will be happy to use that as well.

4.2. How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude, on their Fintech financing decisions?

The second research question was used to explore the micro factors such as CEOs' personal leadership traits, vision, and risk-taking attitude to navigate their Fintech financing decisions at the UK SMEs. The major themes that supported the research question include (a) leadership traits to guide FinTech decisions, (b) using vision to help Fintech decisions, (c) using values to guide decision-making, (d) incorporating family members' perspectives in making Fintech decisions (e) using personal beliefs to reinforce Fintech decision-making, (f) use educational knowledge to improve Fintech decision making, (g) experience and (h) risk taker or avoider approach to make Fintech decisions

4.2.1. Leadership Traits

Leadership in the organisation's context refers to the senior officers holding the key positions to manage, organise and lead staff and contractors. They perform their day-to-day work to fulfil their responsibilities. CEOs, presidents, directors, managers and supervisors are the most prominent positions. As a multidimensional term with multiple meanings of leadership, personal leadership in this research refers to CEOs' traits to make FinTech financing decisions. The CEOs' role in the organisation is not as easy as described in their job responsibilities. They have to make complex decisions, and they stand out for being more decisive by inspiring their team members, with great impact and reliability to drive performance in their organisations (Botelho, et al., 2017). When leaders make decisions, their internal thoughts, intelligence and feelings greatly influence their effectiveness (Bryant & Kazan, 2012). Inner behaviour individuals relate their leadership, emotions, skills, knowledge, understanding and habits (Scouller, 2011).

CEOs as leaders take responsibility for their actions and understand the consequences of their decisions. Their decisions in the organisations are not only to perform their roles up to a

certain level to achieve the organisational objectives, but they also consider their feelings and thoughts at the individual level. Being leaders of their organisations enables CEOs to be more engaged, cooperative and dedicated to their team (Bryant & Kazan, 2012), which improves their work productivity (Farcht, 2007) and creates a meaningful impact on the organisation's performance (King, et al., 2011). Over the years, scholars have built extensive literature on leadership, particularly on the leadership of CEOs, who are known to substantially impact organisational performance (Nohria & Khurana, 2010). CEOs act as change agents and introduce new approaches to achieve the organisational vision. Several pieces of literature support the leadership traits as trusting, focusing on the matters (Anderson, 2012), taking action in critical situations (Kruse, 2019), being practical to solve problems (Grint, 2010), and leading change (Bird, et al., 2013) and work with integrity, courage and vision (Al-Azami, 2019). So what does the CEO's leadership include, especially at the personal level, and how do they make informed decisions at the organisational level? The emerging themes have concluded a detailed insight into CEOs' perception of their thoughts and opinions of what they think of their leadership and its link to financial decisions. P10 emphasis is more focused on the partnership development as

Leadership promotes business partnerships.

During the interview, it was identified that P10's role as a CEO is to establish commercial partnerships to deliver and implement its wider organisational partnership strategy. It could be one of the reasons that the CEO considered promoting business partnerships as one of the leadership qualities to perform commercial activities. P13 mentioned a similar kind of context that personal leadership is

Crucial for business growth and success.

P6 mentioned that personal leadership greatly impacts the company's success, and it is related to "Business relations". While P11 considered personal leadership to be associated with

Ethics, morality, dedication, and hard work to lead a team

As for CEOs, these are essential traits to lead a team, which generally require dedication and morality to ensure work commitment with high integrity and ethics. P14 used “integrity and dedication” as leadership qualities, while P15 provided a comprehensive opinion of the personal leadership relevance to the Fintech decisions,

If you look at the leadership, don't really understand FinTech or have very little knowledge of FinTech, then it can be quite a daunting task. And as I said before the business, the core of the business is not really to make money from FinTech. So it depends. So many digital property will feel that urgency and that they don't have the resources or the understanding to prioritize them. So hence the leadership quality in that sense is important.

As per P15, leadership quality is associated with decision-making and is an important factor in making financing decisions. P15 emphasises the personal leadership quality to make FinTech decisions as

Before the company's financing decisions, for example, crypto currency or any other options are available to you. So I think the severity before you as a CEO, you have your own quality leadership qualities to make decisions.

Also, P19 gave similar sentiments regarding personal leadership about making FinTech decisions:

*yes, because we have good leadership , you need to understand where you're financing , which , where you buy it and how will you finance both ?
Yes, I would say it's really important*

Fintech matters are related to the funding for the organisation's operations, so they are more related to the operations to fulfil strategic objectives. Any wrong decisions can lead to financial disruption, so P15 and P19 consider it a vital quality for CEOs. According to P15, these leadership qualities are linked to their roles in making “strategic decisions” on which the

company's future relies. P12 provided a detailed answer on the importance of personal leadership traits because CEOs work with other staff in organisations where different subordinates provide them with data to make Fintech decisions. They ensure their staff's accountability for the information they receive for accurate decision-making. It could be tricky for them, especially in the case of Fintech financing, because Fintech is not as widely used in the UK as other banking funding options. According to P12

I am optimistic when it comes to my work. We have a small team. We set weekly goals for our staff and I make them accountable. My team described me friendly because I listen to them. Leadership in finance and technology financing [Fintech] is not easy. You have to make bold decisions.

Leadership traits to make Fintech financing decisions - It is important for a CEO to remain positive, create a culture of friendliness in the organisation, and ensure the staff's accountability for the accurate information given to the CEO. According to the P12, personal leadership in Fintech require fearless decision-making traits for the CEO. P1 opinion for the personal leadership is related to "good decisions". P19 emphasises FinTech as a "new world" and states that making decisions for FinTech financing requires "legal and IT skills" as leadership traits. P16, with a background in the Military and NHS for almost 20 years, shed light on personal leadership as

It took 20 years to reach to this point where you can understand probably that or can inspire other or a good communications like the be. And you have a team where you lead them some talking, especially like these attributes of your leadership that you do over the year.

For P16, the personal leadership to make FinTech decisions includes a good communication attribute to lead a team. It requires time to understand the phenomenon of good communication associated with understanding, listening and talking to others over time. This is also justified by the existing literature on leadership, which states that leaders possess good communication skills to make high-quality organisational decisions (Singh, 2015). Participants

such as P20, P8 and P2 focus on the leadership qualities of good listeners and communicators to work with clients and others in the organisation. For example, P9's approach as a CEO is task-oriented and has leadership qualities to make FinTech decisions.

[Leadership qualities to make FinTech decisions] Confirm your distinctive role to support people who can trust on your services. I listen to staff and clients. Discuss important matters with supervisors.

For the P1 personal leadership is more related to setting the direction for the organisation to make FinTech decisions. P1 explained this as

Yes, I think so. I believe this [personal leadership] is quite important for Fintech financing and give the direction to the organization.

The direction of the organisation is related to the roadmap or a vision of where the company wants to be in the future. In summary, for CEOs personal leadership is necessary to make FinTech financing decisions. Personal leadership includes skills to make good financing decisions. These skills include communication, good relationships with people in and outside the organisation, morality, ethics, respect and caring. It also requires legal and information technology skills to make FinTech decisions. Legal skills are important because CEOs should know the laws associated with cryptocurrency, P2P lending and crowdfunding. Most CEOs are open to new things, listen to their team, motivate them, create an accountability culture in their organisation, work to achieve the organisation's vision, and don't hesitate to make bold FinTech financing decisions. Their leadership traits enable them to make rational decisions because they evaluate all financing alternatives before making decisions. CEOs are the leaders of their organisations, and they consider their leadership traits significant to making their FinTech decisions.

4.2.2. Use Vision to Guide Fintech Decisions

The development and advancement of Fintech financing options do not only depend on regulations to grow but also on user perspectives and knowledge (Setiawan, et al., 2021). Thus, user perspectives, such as vision, beliefs, and values, can influence how individuals make Fintech financial decisions. According to Klynveld Peat Marwick Goerdeler (2023), clarity of vision comes first in the 10 characteristics of a Fintech leader. Therefore, vision is a crucial attribute that organisational leaders should demonstrate for the successful running of the business. Fintech CEOs should have concrete long-term visions instead of focusing on objectives (Klynveld Peat Marwick Goerdeler, 2023). CEOs integrate their personal and firm vision while making Fintech decisions to ensure the firm's long-term focus. Most participants reported that they use their visions to guide Fintech financing decisions. Vision provides a clear picture of what an organisation wants to achieve in the future, and the CEOs play a leading role in achieving this. That includes the best possible course of action or decision, including Fintech financing. To explore this, P1 explained the importance of vision in the case of Fintech financing. According to P1

Vision is quite important for any issue. It gives the actual direction of what we want to achieve the best. Quite important in making decisions about fintech financing.

P1's opinion is backed by P12, who also emphasised that a leadership vision led CEOs to choose the best financing option. P12 carefully evaluates the available options by assessing the impacts of the decision and using vision while making Fintech decisions. P12 supported his argument by stating,

I look at the impact of my decision on our company. I carefully evaluate my vision to make Fintech financing decisions. It is my responsibility to anticipate my decision's negative outcome on the enterprise. If they are risky, I simply avoid them.

Also, P13 uses vision to consider future perspectives of the business, which influences how he makes Fintech decisions. P13 stated,

Vision makes you act for your future, and it influences my Fintech financing decision.

P6 further indicated vision improves a company's competitiveness and may necessitate alternative financing options such as Fintech. P6 stated

Vision is so important. For me, good vision makes my company work better to compete with its competitors and seek funds even with Fintech.

P7 also supported the theme that his vision is to remain the leading business influence on how he makes Fintech decisions. P7 stated,

I have a vision merely based on my job responsibilities, and that affects my Fintech financing decision. My vision is to ensure that we remain a leading business, and my work supports this.

P8 is the opinion that vision and wisdom are essential in making Fintech decisions by stating,

Yes vision is a key to making Fintech decisions. You should also have wisdom and vision couple the wisdom to make good financial decisions.

P9 further supported the theme of using vision to guide Fintech decisions by arguing that he only makes Fintech decisions that align with the company's vision of providing good services to their clients. P9 gave a comprehensive response supporting his argument by stating:

We have a clear vision to provide good services to our clients. Our staff is aware of their duties and we work to achieve our mission. I'm a visionary member that values Fintech's decision if it is in the favour of our company. I work for the best interest of my company with dedication and integrity. These values are crucial for me to make Fintech decisions. I don't make a Fintech decision if it is not in the favour of the company.

In addition, P2 views the vision that it is essential in understanding appropriate financing options for the business. The financing for the business can be of any length, depending on the organisation's needs. Also, P2 argued that vision is crucial in instilling honesty and confidence in day-to-day financing decisions for the company. P2 supported his argument by stating:

I think whatever decisions leader made, they're always relevant. Fit for company. They're. It is also very relevant to our day to day financing decisions. Whether it is a frequent of short term funds to finance equipment or ever long term plans to seek funding from lenders. It is, and that is why leaders should know what they are doing. And I think without vision or even leadership qualities, it is not that easy to make decision.

P6 supported the statement of P2 that vision helps CEOs to compete with their competitors because it provides them with the direction of what they have to achieve to align with the organisational vision and needs of financing. CEOs' leadership vision of Fintech financing not only influences them to choose the best financing for their organisation but also helps them to evaluate the Fintech via P2P, crowdfunding and Cryptocurrency – the best funding option regardless of their duration as long as it helps their organisational financial needs. For example, P10's vision focuses more on the technology-driven applications that help their organisation save costs and increase market size. P10 further stressed that due to the use of technology in their applications [products], their customer's trust increases, which results in high returns for their organisation. This emerging theme from the question relating to vision confirms that CEOs' vision provides them with a roadmap of the future, and the use of technology results in efficiency, more financial output, competitive advantage in the market and a low cost of financing.

4.2.3. Use Values to Guide Decision Making

CEOs' decisions and actions are guided by their analysis of their strategic choices, which in turn are conditioned by their values, experience, and personalities (Duréndez, et al., 2023). Therefore, values play a crucial role in influencing how Fintech CEOs make their financial decisions. In this study, CEOs make Fintech decisions that align with their values. Most participants reported that their values guide how they make Fintech decisions. For example, P10 has opinion that his values include that transparency and honesty in his decision, therefore, their SME use Google Pay and Apple Pay for transparent transactions in their business. P10 stated,

I value my decision and ensure transparency and honesty. Our warehouse order application allows Stripe, apple pay, google pay, and credit cards with transparent transaction fees.

Similarly, P14 reported that his core values of kindness and integrity guide his Fintech decisions. P14 stated,

Values could be related to the leadership qualities. My core values are kindness and integrity, and I make sure my Fintech decisions are guided by them.

For the P7 opinion, values enable the identification of priorities, and it includes identifying Fintech financing as their company's priority. P7 stated,

My values are certain beliefs, which helped me make good decisions for my company. Values help to promote priorities, and for our company, these priorities first and foremost to ensure Fintech decisions promote our business.

Also, P16 emphasises the values includes ethical decisions. P16 supported his argument by stating,

And I know, like whenever you in debt financing decisions or those decisions, any decisions, and even in your organisations are guided by your values. Values means like we do ethical decisions.

P4 and P13 supported the opinion of P16. However, they link values as something very personal and in-built human characteristics. While values and their influence on Fintech financing decisions, P4 stated

Well, there are like values. Like sometimes I think the values are very built in persons, so they always make like a big part in making some decisions. So it, it is like, um, it, it does, it does make effect on decision making [Fintech].

According to P9, having values is essential for the CEOs to work for the organisation's best interest. On the other hand, P12 believes that values enable the CEO to make careful FinTech decisions and further enable them to take responsibility for their decisions. P18 elaborated on how values guided Fintech decisions by describing that values guide leaders in financing. P18 stated:

Values are important because if you don't have an idea of where you're going, I think a leader ought to know where to go and how to finance. If I want to be trustworthy, I need to have people trust me in order to do certain things. So, I do need values.

4.2.4. Incorporate Family Members' Perspectives in Making Fintech Decisions

The statistics from the interview questions confirm that 65% of CEO participants think that their family members affect their FinTech financing decisions. This also confirms that CEOs discuss their important matters with their family members, who are believed to be their partners, and these are those matters on which they believe have a significant impact on their

organisation as well as family life. At least 83% of female CEOs from the total female participants believe that family contribution to their decisions helps them and benefits their organisation. In comparison, 17% of females don't share their financial decision-making matters with family members. On the other hand, 57% of CEOs from total male participants have similar thoughts that discussing financing matters with their family affects their Fintech decisions.

These notable findings on how micro factors influence CEOs to make Fintech decisions were that they incorporate perspectives of family members while making Fintech financial decisions. For example, P14 reported that he integrates inputs from family members while making Fintech financial decisions by stating,

I share my Fintech options with family they will certainly input in it.

Also, P6 reported family members to help him make good decisions after sharing any problem he might be having with them. P6 stated,

I'm sure I share problems with my family or any matter, then they will help me make good decision.

Also, P7 acknowledges that sometimes feedback from family members helps him make good Fintech decisions. P7 stated,

Sometimes I share the most important part of my company work, read my family members, and listen to their feedback. It does not help all the time, but sometimes it helps me to make a good choice.

P1 also acknowledged sharing information with family members, and they influence how he makes Fintech decisions. P1 supported his argument by stating,

Yes, my family is important to me. I always talk to them and listen to them, and sometimes it influences my decisions.

Sometimes, family members help CEOs if they know better about Fintech financing; for example, P8 confirmed that a family member helped him to raise funds through crowdfunding on social media, and that is something to consider that family affects CEOs' decisions. According to P8

My family supported us to raise money through on social media.

Crowdcube is the largest equity crowdfunding platform where individuals or businesses raise money financed through equity rather than loans from banks. P10 explained how he financed the warehouse through FinTech and the family's contribution to such decisions. It is noted that P10 works in the micro-SME. According to P10

Our third warehouse was funded by a FinTech company. We use molo mortgage financing and when I made this decision, my wife supported me.

However, some CEOs have mixed feelings but understand that they will contribute positively if they share their FinTech financing decision matter with their family members. Contribution to the CEO's decision is just emotional support. For example, P4 stated

I always have a backup of the family. Family always support good decisions. But if it's like if it's not a good decision or it doesn't appear like good decision in long term. So their support is always there. So that's how I think their support and they don't support and like what decision should I make or. But the support is always there. It's just like emotional support.

P17 has a similar mixed belief as of P4. P17 described that discussing FinTech matters with the family will only help in making up their minds. That is similar to emotional support but also gives good tips and direction to make good decisions. According to P17

My family helps me to make up my mind. It's normally in routine practice, but in the end it's me and my decisions. They give you some tips, some direction, but you listen to them.

On the other hand, sub-patterns from the theme also bring findings from those CEOs who believe that FinTech decisions are not influenced by their family members. These CEOs thought their organisational decisions were professional matters, and they kept that separate from personal matters. For example, P2 explored this as

I don't talk about my business matters with my families. I really can't think that family members really affect my personal decisions on FinTech financing. I keep my personal life personal. And I don't interfere in my work life and my personal life. And I'm not I'm not the sort of person to be influenced by my family members. Otherwise, they would be in in my CEO place. I don't think it is wise to talk everything to family. What I do with my family and what I do at work or with family or, you know, they may have their own interests. So why will I go for that advice? I would like to be myself. And I know my decisions can't be influenced by the family.

P13's statement supported P2 opinion but brought new information that discussing such critical financial matters with the family brings legal and confidentiality issues. These issues are not supported for his job's ethical and professional conduct. According to P13

We work within the privacy and avoid conflict of interest. We are not allowed to share business matters with family.

4.2.5. Using Personal Beliefs Reinforces Fintech Decision-Making

The benefits and risks of using Fintech financing options can be based on personal beliefs, both negative and positive (Mascarenhas, et al., 2021). Based on Net Valence Model (NVM), if perceived benefits are more significant than perceived risks, potential adopters are more likely to engage in the activity or adopt new technology (Abdul-Rahim, et al., 2022). The main components of the NVM model are perceived (a) benefits, (b) risk, (c) and net valence. Perceived benefits are expected positive impacts of the change, while perceived risks are

anticipated negative consequences. Net valence is the difference between expected positive and negative utilities (Abdul-Rahim, et al., 2022). The perceived benefits, risk, and net valence influence the behavioural intentions of individuals while making decisions (Figure-14).

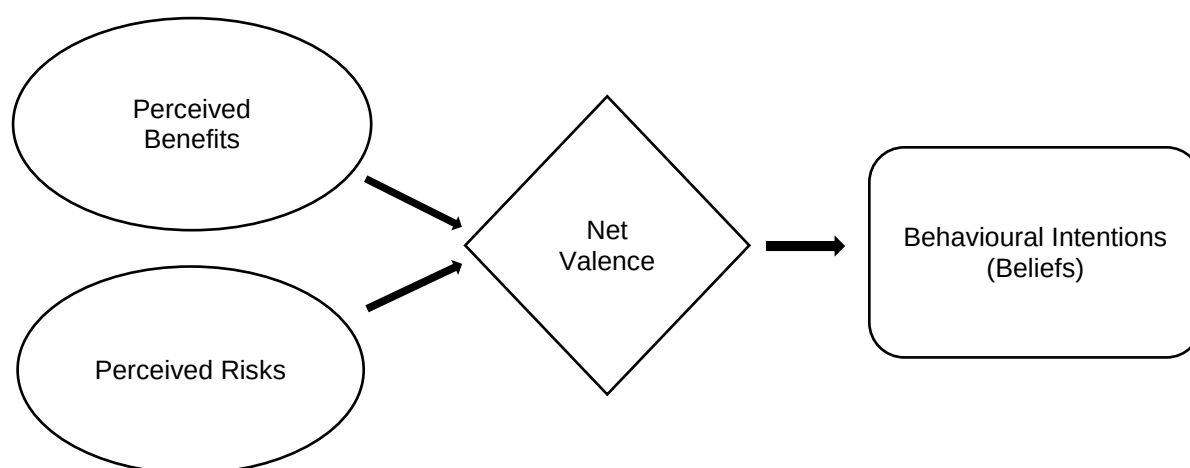


Figure 14 - Net Valence Model

In this study, perceived benefits, risk, and net valence of CEOs influence their beliefs and behavioural intentions, which, in turn, affect how they make Fintech decisions. For example, CEOs who believe that Fintech financing options are associated with more benefits than risk had a positive net valence and could prefer Fintech options based on the perceived benefits. On the contrary, CEOs who believed that there are more risks than benefits associated with Fintech had negative net valence and that would change their belief to prefer Fintech over traditional financing.

The most participants of this study reported that their personal beliefs reinforce how they make their Fintech decisions. For example, P11 indicated that caring for others and optimism are characteristics of his belief that influence Fintech decision-making.

My habits of caring for others and an optimistic about my decision affect my Fintech financing decisions.

Also, P5 indicated that his belief in making rational decisions reinforces how he endorses Fintech decisions. P5 stated,

If the return is good [belief about Fintech] then it endorses my decisions.

The personal belief of P6 is that everything is dynamic that requires the acceptance of change in the emergence of technological innovation. Therefore, the changes attributed to technological advancement influenced how P6 makes Fintech decisions. P6 stated,

My person believes that everything is not static and we have to move with the technology.

P1 personal beliefs are religious to influence how he makes Fintech decisions by stating,

Yes, my beliefs affect my Fintech decisions. Whenever I make decisions, I always pray that it should be a good one that is what it matters.

Also, some participants indicated using personal beliefs to reinforce integrity and trust in Fintech decisions. For example, P10 believes that his personal beliefs compel him to ensure moral and ethical transactions are conducted. P10 supported his argument by stating,

I only allow ethical and moral transactions in our wholesale business. Our customers are truly investors; they work with different retailers in the UK. They order on their behalf and we ensure integrity in their transactions.

4.2.6. Use Educational Knowledge to Improve Fintech Decision Making

Most of the participants in this study indicate that they use their educational knowledge to make Fintech decisions. The patterns that supported the theme of using educational knowledge to improve Fintech decision-making include skills and knowledge gained through education. For example, P10 acknowledged that education is crucial in making good decisions and indicated that educational knowledge and skills help him make good Fintech decisions. P10 stated,

I have a degree in retail management. I also studied logistics and supply chain. These skills and knowledge helped me to make good Fintech decisions.

Like P10, P14 believes his finance education helps him make better financial decisions. P14 supported his argument by stating,

I studied finance, and it equipped me with a good knowledge to make better financial decisions.

P3 further supported the theme with a view that education is essential in gaining the knowledge required to make appropriate financial decisions. P3 gave a comprehensive response by stating:

How can you make good decisions if you don't have the right education? I believe that education has no limit, and I stand with this that the more you learn, the better decision-maker you will be. I can explore this phenomenon that without business knowledge, my decisions did not have a scope of what I am now after a formal qualification.

In addition, P7 further supported the impact of education on making Fintech decisions, stating that training improves the knowledge and skills required to make better decisions. P7 supported his argument by stating,

In our company, we have training as a compulsory part of our development. Training improves our knowledge and skills. With better knowledge and skills, we make better decisions.

In addition, the P6 perception is that more information is acquired through education that helps make better decisions. P6 supported his opinion by stating,

The more information you will get through education, the better decision you will make. It is good for you and your company.

P12, while mentioning the importance of gaining knowledge and awareness of Fintech through education, stated,

I studied blockchain at Oxford University. It is an online course. I did not have much about Fintech, and it helped me with funding to open my mobile repair franchise.

Similarly, P18's view about education equips him with more financial knowledge needed to make financial decisions. P18 supported his argument by stating:

I think education is relatively needed. Because, this is like in science, if you study science, you learn like basics in like the primary and then when you go further down, you go deeper and deeper. Same thing with finances. If you go deeper into education or high level of education, you do it. You will explore more options for finance.

4.2.7. Use their Prior Experience to Improve Fintech Decision-Making

Successful adoption and implementation of Fintech financing options depend not only on financial institutions and government support but also the perception and experience of Fintech users (Alkhwalidi, et al., 2022). Also, besides education, financial background, and values, experience is among the significant factors influencing how managers make decisions regarding innovations (Duréndez, et al., 2023). Consumers integrate some existing beliefs based on their experience when making purchasing decisions. Therefore, previous experience with Fintech could influence how CEOs make Fintech financial decisions. Some participants reported using their previous experience with Fintech financing to improve their Fintech decisions. For example, P12 said that his previous experience in buying and selling cryptocurrency and using different blockchain platforms helps him make Fintech financial decisions in his current position. P12 supported his argument by stating,

I was involved in the Fintech cryptocurrency, buying and selling. I used different blockchain platforms, mainly SETL. My experience using blockchain dragged my mind to use Fintech financing decisions

Similarly, P6 perceives that sufficient knowledge and experience with Fintech helps him make sound decisions regarding Fintech financing. P6 supported his statement as,

Good knowledge of Fintech and experience help me to make good decisions. I share all this information with my peer line managers and those who work in the finance department.

Also, P7 used his experience with Fintech to make financial decisions, and he uses his expertise to make the best choice between Fintech and traditional financing options. P7 stated,

If I am given few options to finance my company with banking terms and conditions Fintech be P2P crowdfunding what do you want crypto then I use my experience to choose the best option.

Similarly, P8 supported the theme that awareness and experience with Fintech are crucial in making financial decisions. P8 supported his argument by stating,

Fintech is a new area for the business. When I was not aware of Fintech financing, I never paid attention to it. When I came to know about its existence, I felt I should have known it for years. Experience gives you an advantage over others.

Similar to P7, P6, and P12, P2 has a similar perception that lessons from experience are crucial in making valuable decisions. P2 stated,

Yes, experience teaches us lessons to learn from our past and make an informed decision [Fintech].

P2 further supported using experience to make Fintech decisions by detailing personal experience that made him consider Fintech options over bank finance. P2 reported using his

personal experience to raise money for the company through Fintech options instead of seeking bank loans. P2 gave a comprehensive response supporting his argument by stating:

My Fintech financing decisions are influenced by my experience. My company was in a huge financial crisis in 2013, we had no clue what to do. I related that situation to my personal financial crisis decisions after my graduation. I had no money to live and limited resources to survive, and I got out of that situation with wise decisions. I did not go to borrow a loan to pay my expenses but went for fundraising from family and friends, and we did the same thing to our company. We raise funds from our customers, friends, and families with some effective membership incentives from our company. So, we were not in debt, but in a relaxed situation, so I would say experience matters a lot.

4.2.8. Risk approach to make Fintech decisions

The main drivers of CEOs' actions and organisational outcomes include CEO risk-taking and financial literacy (Duréndez, et al., 2023). Risk-taking refers to the CEO's willingness to devote resources to exploit opportunities or engage in behaviours with undetermined habits (Duréndez, et al., 2023). Financial literacy refers to the financial knowledge needed to make decisions (Duréndez, et al., 2023). Therefore, risk-taking and financial literacy affect how CEOs make organisational decisions and results, including Fintech decisions and outcomes. As the risk is associated with the probability and the level of impact. It is an event that may occur. Suppose the probability of occurrence could be within the range of 0-100%. Alternatively, these values can be expressed between 0 to 1. In the normal distribution, if the event range is higher than 0.5 and less than 1, it is considered likely to happen. In the risk management framework, likelihood and the consequences are framed with numbers and their interpretation to accept, tolerate, or avoid risk. The high risk is associated with high

consequences; in return, it could be a high return or total loss or damage to the business. The CEOs were asked to provide their risk-taking and risk-avoider approach in the interview. The risk-taking approach means the CEO takes risks with a probability of higher than 0.5 in the standard distribution scale and higher consequences per the risk management framework. The risk avoidance approach means the CEO avoids a higher risk of more than 0.5 on the average distribution level, which can turn into a significant incident and, as a result, can cause poor performance of the company or related negative consequences.

In this research, 55% of participants confirmed that they are risk takers, of which 25% are females and 30% are males. While 45% of participants avoid taking significant risks and establish them as risk avoiders, out of which 5% are females, and 40% are males. It is also noted that 10% of participants confirmed that they assess the situation and anticipate higher return before they make decisions.

For example, P18 has an opinion that his risk approach depends on the level of reward, such as

It depends on how good the reward is of the risk . The high risk , high risk means higher reward , but if the reward is worth the risk , then I might do . That's the thing.

A similar answer was from participant P7 as of P18, whose focus was a higher return but less negative consequences on the organisation. P7 argues

I think I am a risk avoider, but sometimes I also take risk if the return is good and not much financial implications.

To justify risk avoider approach, P19 provided a comprehensive opinion to justify his risk avoider approach, which is mainly associated with the return, market uncertainty, regulations and history of cryptocurrency downfall in the financial crash

your current risk . Still a game like is it a risk take risk taker mistaken approach affects the integrity. It's not stable . It's no stable because you

probably heard about Tesla owners . He said , you know , he will be start taking the payment in bitcoin as well . Because of just because of his state of mind , you know , the big bitcoin currencies really scores very high . And after a few days , you know , he said , you know , probably he will not accept any payment in the bitcoin than what will be happening on the bitcoin market is done . And in 2020 , you know , I will just give you the example . In 2018 or 17 , you know , the bitcoin value was around £100 . But if you look at the twenty seven thousand , something is equal to one bitcoin . Why the value is very high . Yeah , something like that know , and why the value is high just because of the risky market . You never know , you know , after two weeks that after two years , after three years , you know , it will be come back to bond again . So you can say is highly risk game market, you know, at the moment just because of non-regulated. If any, any anyone, you know, any one a country will regulate this currency, then you will be seeing, you know, the value would be that its value would be very high and stable and the risk would be minimal.

P19's perception about the crypto market is volatile, so decisions relating to FinTech are risky. P11 risk avoider approach confirms that risky decisions are not secure and, therefore, "not stable". P14 described that

Risk avoider approach helped me to make good and right decisions for the benefits of my company.

CEO P9 works in a care organisation which is responsible for providing care to vulnerable people, so he is a risk-avoider, not particularly because of his own leadership or decision-making but because of the people around him or the work they perform in the organisation. P9 believes the risk avoider approach is good to avoid uncertainty. While P9 provided a considerable argument for his approach of being a risk avoider

You don't have to be a risk-taker if your clients are vulnerable.

Vulnerable people are disabled; they can be of any age or even young adult with or without disability. Vulnerable people also include people who need care, support, and protection due to many factors, such as age, disability, abuse, and neglect. That suggests that the risk-taking and avoider approach is directly or indirectly affected or influenced by the types of organisations and sectors.

In this research, the risk-taker CEO ratio is 10% higher than the risk avoider. Some provided helpful rationale and insights into why they think of being risk-takers. For example, P2 has an opinion that

I always go for uncertain situations, maybe mostly because my beliefs help me to have confidence to have decisions. I think if you know the probability of outcome, it is very easy for you to make Fintech decisions. But it something is so new like Fintech finance is, you really don't know the outcome and you remain unsure whether you will raise that particular amount through P2P lending or even crowd cube. And you know once you have funds it is good for your organisation.

Despite the known risk factors and consequences, risk-taker CEOs take risks to get a good return and avoid taking a complex route to earning money through other traditional lending forums.

P3 is a risk taker because of the opinion that it has a “positive outcome”. P8's risk-taking approach to funding the business through FinTech could be because of “strict regulations and lenders criteria of traditional financing”. The results further confirm that CEOs' risk-taking or avoiding approaches positively impact the company's performance as per CEOs' perceptions and opinions. CEOs with a 55% risk-taking approach felt the positive outcome of their decisions on the organisation. Further, 45% of avoider CEOs also have a positive impact on their decisions on the company's performance. The results indicate that CEOs have different perceptions about their risk approach linked to the return. The risky financing decisions may result in high returns. Still, the outcome or the process to bring that outcome may have those

consequences on the organisation, which CEOs avoid in their financing decisions. This also confirms that CEOs are potent entities in organisations, and they make careful decisions, assess the situation or the project, evaluate the risk factors and then make the decisions. The risk approach is also associated with gender, age group, and education level. For example, younger CEOs are 5% more risk-takers than avoiders. The results further suggest that CEOs' risk approach implies them to make careful decisions and ensure the positive impact of their organisation.

4.3. How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level?

The third research question explored the significance of meso factors such as professional networking, board of directors, and organisational structure to CEOs' Fintech financing decisions at UK SMEs. Three major themes supporting the third research question emerged. The first theme was incorporating professional advice and contributions, and the second was consulting the board while making Fintech decisions. The third theme was the effects of organisational structure on FinTech decisions. Each of the themes is discussed below.

4.3.1. Incorporating Advice and Contributions from Other Professionals

This study presumed that CEOs in professional organisations with professional connections with individuals in the Fintech sector would consult them while making Fintech decisions more than those with limited connections. Most participants reported that their professional networking influences how they make Fintech decisions. The networking individuals identified include investors, friends, professionals from other fields, and workmates. For example, P10 works in an SME that has a network of people such as investors, accounts and staff. Their

SME considers the reporting from these entities to be feedback to help them make Fintech decisions. P10 stated,

Our investors provide us with feedback, accountants share profitability reports, and staff help with their suggestions. They all affect my Fintech decisions.

Also, P13 acknowledged that his administrative team managing e-platforms. E-platforms has a team to discuss the main issues that contribute to his Fintech decisions. P13 stated,

My administration team manages e platform, and they contribute to my Fintech financing decision.

P14 reported that they discuss Fintech options with workmate friends, and their opinions influence how he makes Fintech decisions. P14 stated,

We discuss Fintech options and their opinions are always helpful.

In addition, P6 consults other professionals in the same situations and believes such discussions are crucial for financing decisions. P6 supported his argument by stating,

Yes, but help you in any situation that could be the scene-making situation that you see it is important to consult with professional people involved in it.

P7 acknowledged that sharing information with people from experience backgrounds, managers, directors, and board members influences his Fintech financing decisions. P7 supported his argument by stating,

When we shared information and listened to each other that may influence my Fintech decision. Yes, when we share information with each other and discuss different aspects of the business that contribute to my Fintech.

In addition, P8 reported learning from professional networks and using that knowledge to guide making Fintech financial decisions. P8 indicated that his professional networks include senior

managers and supervisors in the company and membership in a professional organisation. P1 also acknowledged the influence of professional networks in making Fintech decisions by stating,

I also consider I am being influenced by my professional network regarding Fintech decisions because I always listen to them.

P2 reported that the experience of other CEOs from his networking influenced how he makes Fintech decisions. P2 stated,

Not necessarily, except other CEOs from my networking share their experience, so sometimes it influences my Fintech decisions.

P18 also states that contributions from other professionals are essential in making Fintech financial decisions because they present more financial options and ideals. P18 supported his argument by stating,

Yes, because of professional networking, you'll have more options for financing. As well as you'll meet more people that could potentially help you and give you [CEO] ideas.

P3 argued that professional networks are crucial in making Fintech decisions and reported that he uses social media to learn from others. P3 gave a comprehensive response supporting his argument by stating:

Sometimes it influences my decisions. I feel the professional network is so important to make decisions as if it gives you a thought process. I also use social media to learn from others which also contribute to my decisions making.

4.3.2. Consulting Board while Making Fintech Decisions

In the current age, corporate governance has become critical for organisations' success, especially after the financial crash of 2008 (Calder, 2008). Corporate governance is a system by which the board directs and controls the organisation (Financial Reporting Council, 2018). In this research, all participants confirm that they have a board to make financial decisions. One of the main questions was establishing the board's composition to have a ratio of executive and non-executive directors. The executive directors perform the daily function of the organisation while the non-executive directors are independent, recruited from the industry with expertise in their areas of employment to serve the specialised work. Non-executive directors' role is to scrutinise the board's performance and oversee the financial control. The participants' SME CEOs have a board in their organisation composed of executive and non-executive directors. Having non-executive directors on the board confirms independent and impartial advice and sound decisions for the organisation's interest, especially for the benefit of stakeholders (Corporate Governance Institute, 2023). The board's composition with independent elements at the senior level increases accountability (Agarwal, 2020) and confirms the highest standard and the integrity of the decisions (Scott, 2018). According to P9,

The board members create a culture of accountability.

Institutional factors are crucial in reinforcing innovations in information and communication technologies, including adopting and using Fintech options (Setiawan, et al., 2021). For example, boards can influence firms' decisions by contributing to the decision-making process. Corporate boards and directors play a crucial role in an organisation's strategy and performance. The contribution of board members could support CEOs' decision-making in Fintech. A notable finding that supported the research question was that CEOs consult board members while making decisions related to Fintech financing. For example, P10 reported that most of his decisions are endorsed by the board members. P10 stated,

Working the board is amazing. I learn and make decisions independently.

The board has a committee. Most of my decision is endorsed by the board committee without my changes.

Despite not being part of the board, P11 reported that board decisions influence how he makes Fintech decisions. P11 stated,

I am not a part of our board of directors. They hired me for a CEO role.

Their decision and direction help me in my Fintech decisions.

P8 perception of the board work is through policies as rules to guide his decisions.

the board influences my decisions, mainly because of board policies and agenda for the work.

P1 gave a specific example of how the board influenced the selection of Fintech financing options for raising the required funds in their company. P1 stated,

Once our company needed £75000 and we decided to sell our assets, and when I spoke to my family, they told don't do it, just sell your property. But when I spoke to the board, they said, we should raise money through Fintech pools.

When asked whether board members influence how he makes decisions, P2 acknowledged that they make collective decisions and that board members influence how Fintech decisions are made. P2 supported his opinion by stating:

We all work collectively when we have to make decisions such as Fintech finances. We talk to each other, we have a lot of information from management, we use scenarios based on decisions making tools, we evaluate risks, and then our chairman makes decisions.

However, with the board, the Fintech decisions are not the final verdict of the CEO for some SMEs. This matter is escalated to the Board for financial decisions, which can be collectively

made by members or by the chair. For example, P5, a part of the board, confirms that “only the chairperson makes the final decision”. P13 stated that he is a part of the board, and they [the board] make the collective decisions. According to P13, when it comes to financial decisions,

They [the board] contribute to my fintech financing decision.

One of the findings confirmed the board-led decisions in Fintech matters such as P19 states that.

The board of directors make collective decisions and as a CEO, you know, my decision doesn't matter.

P3 who is a part of the Board but without any non-executive directors in the organisation confirmed that the decisions are made collectively. P3 stated,

Senior-level collective decisions help the company.

P4 and P7 also provided similar views on making collective decisions on financial matters. P16 also confirmed that the board contributed to the fintech financing decision. P16 supported the role of the board and its influence on the decision as

More strategic level decision making in the board and when working in a board with other members, executive knowing exactly what maybe depends on the composition like you have, isn't this influence your decision making

4.3.3. Effects of the Organisational structural to make Fintech Decision Making

The current study's number of questions to CEOs was based on their organisational structure and the impact of it on their decision-making. That includes the company's size, the information flow mechanism from the employees to CEOs, the number of departments, and the

organisation's structural composition for innovation and change to contribute to CEOs' decision-making. The valuable research results show that 50% of SMEs have their organisational structure developed in a way that is based on the different departments. For example, P6 who works in a small SME mentioned,

We work on different business operations and are divided into departments separately to consider sales and product development.

P10 described the departmental structure of their small SME as

We have a customer services and service distribution centre, Human resource, marketing and Sales, Finance Operations and Innovation Hub.

P10 further explored the concept of decision-making within such organisational structures as

All our departments have heads. They report to their line managers and the line managers to their CEO.

That shows that the number of departments within the organisation causes a higher line of accountability for information travel from the employees to the department heads and then to the CEO. That is far different from the micro-SME functions where information does not have many barriers for CEOs to make timely FinTech decisions. For example, P2 stated

We all work collectively in the same on the same floor. And our desks are very close to each other and they share information very easily. We are all so happy to work together in the same floor that help our communication and networking. So it's just like very easy to communicate and share our information.

P8 supplement the thoughts of P2 as

We work collectively, discuss and share what information is readily available to make decisions.

Some SMEs, which are micro with less than 10 people, have a smooth process to perform their daily tasks, and the CEO remains the main person for operational and oversight of the organisational activities. For example, to provide a detailed understanding of the flow of information for decision-making, the P12 stated,

I actually have technicians and suppliers. I allocate work to that to my team. They are accountable to me for the work. When they complete the task, they inform me and I contact the distributor to deliver the order.

Likewise, P20 described it as

I don't have any layers between me and my staff. So. But whenever I give them any task, they come to me directly and they, you know, respond really, really quickly.

This confirms that SMEs are clear about their organisational structure, understand their staff accountability, and CEOs remain the main decision-makers. However, when it comes to the flow of information, few CEOs went into details of how they ensure timely information. For example, P14 confirmed the use of IT applications and the role of the staff member for the information to make decisions

My subordinates provide me all information I need. We use CRM and all information is shared instantly and it's helpful to accept change.

However, when it comes to the barriers in decision-making due to complex organisational structure or the flow of information within the organisation, all CEOs (100% of the sample) don't consider their organisational structure to be complex regardless of whether they are sitting in the same floor to work together or have a number of departments. They have different opinions; for example, P6 explained the use of software and timely reports for decision his decision-making. According to P6

So I don't see any problem on the information flow. We use centralized software where reports updated by managing stocks are listed. Finance

reports are available. Account information is published every week. Staff training and development is recorded as well. Money matters and the associate reports are produced by Finance Department.

P18 explained,

Having a complex structure doesn't necessarily mean it's going to be hard for decision making because only the directors will be doing the decision making. Everyone else will do their part for the decision or out of it. So, no, I don't think it'll affect the organisation to accept change.

The statistics from the participants further confirmed that the composition of the organisation structure to facilitate the flow of information has an impact on the CEOs to make FinTech decisions as well as that also affects the SMEs to accept change. At least 60% of CEOs from micro, small or medium SMEs have opinions that the flow of information from their employees to them for timely and effective FinTech-related decision-making has causes and consequences of accepting the change. Meanwhile, 70% of CEOs confirmed that their decisions are influenced by their subordinates' or staff members' reports to make FinTech financing decisions.

4.4. How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?

Six major themes emerged in the fourth research question to explore the complexity of government support and regulations as macro factors to navigate CEOs' perceptions to make Fintech financing decisions at the UK SMEs. The themes include (a) aligning Fintech decisions to government policies, (b) insufficient information and policies about Fintech limits decision making, (c) using UK laws to guide decision making, (d) negative political and economic situations necessitate Fintech options, (e) some laws impede Fintech decision-making, and

(f) making Fintech decisions to align with the emerging technologies. Each of the themes is discussed below.

4.4.1. Aligning Fintech decisions to government policies

The financial sector and organisations plan Fintech adoption, change management, leadership commitment, and stakeholder management to effectively align with government policies to transition without resistance. Aligning Fintech decisions will improve adoption and change, competitiveness, and performance in the financial and banking sector (Dwivedi, et al., 2021). Therefore, CEOs seeking to adopt Fintech consider government regulations while making Fintech decisions. P19 gave a comprehensive response on aligning their financial decisions with government policies to avoid engaging in illegal activities such as money laundering. P19 stated,

As I mentioned, we have legal department and always follow up on government policies as they severely affect our decision. For example, one person came to me and he wanted to transfer his house on his wife name or his son's name. So, we are the source of funding. We will not look at the field. We will not look at the funding forensic technology. We looked at the government policies like we always do. We must check in on the money laundering, will checked the source of funding, We also check the other rules. So definitely, we must always follow the government regulations, which affect our decisions

The first theme that emerged to support the fourth research question was that CEOs reported that they align Fintech decisions with government policies. Almost all participants reported keenly considering government policies and regulations before making Fintech decisions. Also, most participants reported that they have a legal team that guides them on government policies and regulations related to Fintech financing. For example, P10 said they have a legal team that follows up with legal requirements before signing contracts. P10 stated,

I follow up with our legal team before I sign a contract with the distributors and investors.

Besides the internal rules, P11 reported adhering to government policies while making decisions. P11 stated,

Our board of directors makes rules for our company, and we consult with the government policies.

Also, P13 acknowledged the presence of several regulations and reported that they comply with them when making Fintech decisions. P13 supported her argument by stating,

Our sector is complex; it has many regulators, and we have to comply with them. It supports my Fintech decisions.

In addition, P5 believe working within the government policies is crucial for their business. P5 stated,

Yes, we follow government regulations, and they are very important for our organisation to work within consistent policies.

Similar to P11, P13, and P5, P6 indicated that they regularly check on different government departments' reports about Fintech. In addition, P7 supported the theme of aligning Fintech decisions to government policies by acknowledging that such regulations impact how he makes Fintech decisions. P7 stated,

Government support businesses, and they have regulations that have an impact on my Fintech financing decisions.

Like P10, P8 reported that they have a legal team that ensures they follow government regulations. P8 stated,

Our legal department ensures we follow government regulations. I make a decision by ensuring it complies with laws.

P9 further supported the first theme by reporting that they are in a highly regulated industry and must comply with different policies. P9 stated,

Our industry is very much regulated. We have to follow government policies. I follow my company's policies and the skills for the manager's code of practice to maintain my membership. I follow up with policies during my decisions.

Similarly, P1 acknowledged the presence of government policies and reported that they follow them while making Fintech decisions. P1 stated,

Government policies are guidelines for us, but it depends on how supportive they are for our business, and my decisions are influenced by them. I find them much supportive of solving my situations relating to Fintech finance.

P3 supported aligning Fintech decisions to government policies by arguing that they ensure they follow government policies while making Fintech decisions. P3 stated,

Yes, I ensure my decisions follow government policies.

4.4.2. Insufficient Information and Policies about Fintech Limits Decision Making

According to Ahern (2021), an inadequate framework in Fintech markets results in regulatory fragmentation and friction. The European Union's Fintech competitiveness in innovation is compromised if the regulatory landscape is cumbersome or incomplete for new business models (Ahern, 2021). Fintech has no single, comprehensive, and credible regulatory market. There is a demand for clear regulations to improve the development of Fintech. The lack of a comprehensive regulatory framework for Fintech firms depicts inconsistencies and a lack of standards, which could negatively impact Fintech adopters' financial decisions. A second theme that supported the fourth research question was that inadequate information and

policies about Fintech limit the CEOs' decision-making of Fintech financing decisions. For example, P12 detailed that the government does not have a digital platform for listing Fintech financing companies and suggested that they develop such systems to help them. P12 responded to the question as,

The government does not have any digital platform to list Fintech financing companies. They should work on this agenda. It will help many businesses like us.

P14 believe in the following government regulations, however, with the opinion that there is no specific support for Fintech. P14 stated,

We don't have any particular link with the government department for Fintech funding. Their policies are regularly viewed by our board.

P5 reported that there are limited policies about Fintech on government websites and there is insufficient support for Fintech. P5 supported his argument by stating,

There are not many policies about Fintech on the government websites regarding Fintech. Small business support is always an issue and support is available through local authorities, but not much support is available on Fintech.

Also, P5 stated that there is limited information about Fintech options such as cryptocurrency.

What we can see that P2P lending and crowdfunding there is some information while cryptocurrency information is very limited and if that information exists that is only on tax return related compliance.

P2 supported the theme that insufficient information and policies limit making decisions about Fintech and that the government does not have enough policies and forums. P2 indicated,

The government doesn't have many policies or even forums to help us if we go to alternative funding options other than banking.

4.4.3. Using UK Laws to Guide Decision Making

Quick and reactive Fintech regulations may hinder innovations. However, failure to impose rules may lead to innovation failure and associated negative consequences for investors and consumers. Fintech regulations are needed to minimise risk and necessary to educate customers to be knowledgeable of Fintech so that they are comfortable and safe while making transactions (Yahya, 2021). Therefore, Fintech policies and regulations provide a framework for upholding ethics and integrity that protects the concerns of both investors and consumers. Despite lacking comprehensive and specific Fintech regulations, the FCA regulatory sandbox guides Fintech operations in the United Kingdom (Everhart, 2020; Giglio, 2021). Participants also stated UK laws related to Fintech impact how they make Fintech financial decisions. For example, P10 argued that they follow laws about production insurance, anti-fraud, money laundering, and identity checks of buyers while using Fintech financing. P10 stated,

Laws relating to product insurance, anti-fraud, money laundering, identity checks of buyers, and customer due diligence are in place to facilitate Fintech financing.

In addition, P7 acknowledge the presence of financial market laws that guide how they make Fintech transactions. P7 supported his argument by stating,

Yes, we have financial market laws and fair trading that help us to make Fintech transactions.

Similar to P7, P8 reported that there are laws that guide making Fintech decisions by stating,

Yes, laws support general terms of doing business even if you use Fintech or not.

P3 supported that theme that the UK laws facilitate Fintech financing by stating,

Yes, UK laws facilitate Fintech finances, but I think a lot of work has to be done in this area for its development.

4.4.4. Negative Political and Economic Situations Necessitate Fintech Financing Options

The coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic created financial and psychological distress in different sectors and economies (Kou, et al., 2021). In response to financial distress caused by COVID-19, technological innovations were integrated into financial systems to address some of the associated challenges. Another notable theme explaining how macro factors influence CEOs' Fintech decisions was that negative political and economic situations necessitate Fintech financing options. A hostile political situation identified by one of the participants was the impact of war on the economy. Other financial situations reported by the participants were the negative impacts of COVID-19 and inflation on the economy. For example, P11 SMEs lacked enough money to pay rent during the COVID-19 pandemic because the premises remained closed. Also, P11 argued that the lack of adequate support from the banks made them opt for Fintech financing. P11 gave the comprehensive response:

Our premises remained closed during COVID-19, and we did not get enough finance to pay rent. We don't have great support through traditional financing from banks. They don't give money if you don't make sales. I support emerging artists and illustrators. They know it is a difficult time for them to survive. Our team goes through their artwork. If we need money to order equipment for mass printing, then we will go for crowdfunding.

In addition, P5 mentioned that increased inflation resulted in corresponding increases in banks' interest rates, and they had to make financial decisions by selecting options with fewer interest rates. Specifically, P5 considered seeking loans with low-interest rates from Fintech options because the banks offer high rates because of inflation. P5 supported his argument by stating,

Thinking inflation is very high so as the interest rate is very high on loan so all priority is not to use more debt in over company seeks funds through Fintech.

Like P5 and P11, P7 acknowledged the financial difficulties associated with COVID-19 and inflation and indicated that he considers options with a low interest rate when making a financial decision. P7 stated:

We are currently in a difficult financial situation due to COVID-19 and war effects; banks have more regulations and difficult lending criteria. If they lend us money, then it has a high interest rate. As a CEO, I have to consider all of them to make a suitable decision.

Also, P1 acknowledged that economic situations, such as the impacts of COVID-19, influence how he makes Fintech financial decisions.

We are still in the COVID-19 Pandemic, and I think it will help Fintech Market. My decisions are always influenced by factors such as COVID-19.

Similar to P11, P2 indicated that Fintech financing options considering the current economic situation due to COVID-19. P2 stated,

It was a feeling that COVID-19 was going to finish early 2020, but this is not the case, so I would say Fintech decisions are based on businesses situations and their need for money.

Additionally, P3 supported the theme by arguing that economic recessions, such as 2008 and the negative impacts of COVID-19, necessitated Fintech financing options. P3 stated,

We learned out of the 2008 financial crash which gave birth to cryptocurrency, and the current COVID-19 circumstances surely will bring lots of opportunities for the development of Fintech.

4.4.5. Some Laws Impede Fintech Decision-Making

Regulating all innovations in the financial sector has a limited advantage (Giglio, 2021). For example, preventive Fintech regulations increase regulatory agencies' workloads, discourage innovations, and are associated with limited benefits (Giglio, 2021). The inadequate and evolving European Union's Fintech regulatory framework has resulted in regulatory fragmentation and friction. For example, the progress of Fintech regulation in European Union member states is slow and uneven. It poses a risk to investors and consumers because the associated risks are not fully mapped (Ahern, 2021). Some of the participants reported that there are some laws and regulations that impede making Fintech decisions. For example, P10 mentioned that the government should not develop more rules and regulations for Fintech. P10 stated,

The government should facilitate Fintech. They should not need to make more laws and regulations for Fintech. They should allow banks to work on Fintech models.

Also, P7 supported the theme that the government should ensure fairness in laws and regulations guiding Fintech and traditional financing options. P7 stated,

The government should allow Fintech companies to follow the same regulations they make for the financial market. That will create equal opportunities and a competitive market for us.

P1 further supported the theme that government policies negatively impact how they make Fintech decisions. P1 stated,

Yes, we have a legal department. All departments follow government policies, which severely affects my decisions.

4.4.6. Making Fintech Decisions to Align with the Emerging Technologies

Fintech is driven by digitalisation and digitisation and is increasingly integrated into daily economic transactions (Mention, 2019). The current global technology trend necessitates financial organisations to focus on utilising digital systems to improve their services (Bhat, et al., 2023). Fintech is among the viable options in the digital landscape that incorporate disruptive technologies such as artificial intelligence and blockchain to improve financial services' effectiveness and efficiency. The emergence of new technologies and their potential to improve customer services compel financial institutions to integrate and align their financial decisions to emerging technologies. Another notable theme that supported the fourth research question was that CEOs make Fintech decisions to align with emerging technologies. For example, P12 acknowledged that digital technology and cryptocurrency would be crucial in the economic situation of a country, and they seized such opportunities. P12 stated,

Digital technology and cryptocurrency are the future of the country. Our company, like others, will take advantage of cryptocurrency. Its valuation price is higher, it is secure to trade, and the exchange rate is high.

P5 believe that positive innovations necessitate Fintech decisions in their company. P5 stated,

Yes, the Innovation department continues to work to recommend innovation in the company. It depends on whether the innovation is related to the products, services, or a specific area. We accept innovation, but it is not my sole decision. I only recommend it to the board.

P1 believes that they have to make financial decisions to align with emerging technologies to remain relevant and progressive in the market. P1 stated,

I think we are quite fit with this digital age. As I mentioned, we have to remain current and progressive and know what the economy demands, which is life with the time.

P1 also supported the theme that the emerging changes brought about by technological advancement make it inevitable for businesses to accept the changes and reduce reliance on traditional financing options. P1 gave a comprehensive response:

I feel technology is changing, new features are coming every day, and we are less reliant on traditional financing. We have to accept if something is new coming to us, who knows, that may change our life. Our company is very welcoming to new technology to support our financing decisions. We embedded new features in our payment methods like Stripe, Google Wallet, and Bitcoin.

Also, P3 supported the theme that they make financial decisions to align with the emerging changes and advancement of technology.

I think as a small SME we CEOs prefer Fintech financing. This also fits our vision of being a technological company to live with the present and future demands of changing technology.

5. Discussion and recommendation

5.1. Discussion of Findings and Recommendation

5.1.1. Research Question 1 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?

The themes and sub-themes developed in the first research question included (a) CEOs in the UK prefer Fintech to traditional financing, (b) Fintech provides more financing options, (c) Fintech is associated with lower costs, (d) Fintech is associated with lower regulations (e) Increasing demand and banking challenges necessitate Fintech financing options (f) limited awareness about Fintech options.

5.1.1.1. *Financing Preferences*

The preference for Fintech over traditional finance among the CEOs in the United Kingdom is based on the provision that it provides more financing options, fewer regulations and low cost. CEOs' financing preferences in their organisations depend on many reasons, such as their strategic choice (Ghemawat, 2006; Johnson, et al., 2020) or the associated benefits with traditional or Fintech financing for them to remain competitive in the business environment. It also depends on the organisations to accept innovation by responding to the change in their external financing environment, where they now have more funding options than a decade ago. These funding strategies (Shepherd et al., 2015) can be a switching (Trabucchi & Buganza, 2019) from traditional to Fintech financing or Fintech to traditional financing or finding the preferred substitution (Kivimaa et al., 2021) by evaluating the cost and benefits of financing options. In the current research, financing preferences for CEOs to accept Fintech are more related to their organisations' strategic choice to accept innovation to take the benefits of Fintech financing due to technology. The advantage of blockchain technology is that it provides users with trust and influences their intentions due to the transparency and efficiency features of financial transactions. The benefits of simple and user-friendly

technology-enabled Fintech platforms make financial transactions between SMEs and investors more simple and easier through phones or laptops, which is considered cheaper than traditional financing methods, enabling flexibility and accessibility, that is, consuming less time and effort compared to traditional financing. Therefore, the findings are congruent with Pizzi et al. (2021), Alshareef & Tunio (2022), and Bag et al. (2023) that efficiency is one of the factors due to blockchain for Fintech financing. The use of blockchain technology in Fintech not only creates efficiency in funding transactions but also increases CEOs' trust to prefer Fintech financing which is consistent with the findings of Lemieux & Lemieux (2016). In addition, not involving banks reduces many regulations and costs for SMEs' access to the various Fintech options to access funds. Thus, the benefits associated with Fintech are the main factors that influence its preference compared to traditional financing.

5.1.1.2. *More funding options*

It is important to note that besides the potential benefits of accepting Fintech, UK SMEs have to safeguard the industry code of practices, laws, regulations, and related standards to protect their funding through Fintech. The findings revealed that most CEOs are aware of the challenges of FinTech and would still like to accept it. Technology-based funds through Fintech facilitate investors and a fund acquiring party to link P2P lending or cryptocurrency or through crowdfunding platforms. In these platforms, investors, either individuals or organisations, choose the project they wish to invest in. According to Kumari and Devi (2022), Fintech solutions are more equipped to provide quick access to reserve cash and loans to those with low or no income than banks and other lending institutions. Kickstarter, Indiegogo, Crowcube, Seedrs, GoFundme, Funding Circle, Syndicateroom, JustGiving, Lendinvest, Zoopa, FundRazr and Crowd for Angels are widely used crowdfunding platforms in the UK. SMEs have more options to choose the best to suit their funding needs. These Crowdfunding platforms also support funding to start-up businesses with no credit history but a sound project to provide a good return on investment. In contrast, banks do not support such lending criteria. Banks or financial institutions have strict lending criteria. In the case of P2P lending, noticeable

platforms are CapitalStackers, Loanpad, Assetz Exchange, AxiaFunder, Invest & Fund, Proplend, Kuflink, and Easy Money. These P2P funding platforms provide SME CEOs with options to take funds for specific purposes such as legal cases, property, short-term projects, etc. Therefore, CEOs have more options within the P2P platforms to choose the best funding options to meet their business needs. The technologically driven P2P platforms match SMEs and investors directly without the needs of banks. Likewise, cryptocurrency platforms are limited but are also increasing in the UK; for example, crypto funds offer digital currency, coin shares, insulina, and nickel digital. Some of them, such as Nickel Digital, are regulated by the Financial Conduct Authority and offer secure and transparent access to crypto assets. The findings of the sub-theme of the first research question are consistent with the findings of Bollaert et al. (2021) and Haddad & Hornuf (2019) that FinTech provides more funding options.

5.1.1.3. Lower financing cost

The researcher found that the cost is a significant factor influencing consumers' decision to adopt Fintech, and CEOs would prefer financing options at a lower cost. Price value is a consumer's cognitive characteristic that influences their decisions based on the cost (Najib, et al., 2021). Fintech significantly contributes to the financial system by increasing customer satisfaction, ensuring quality services, and reducing costs (Kou et al., 2021). The low cost of financing through Fintech is because of many reasons. The main reason is that Fintech uses blockchain technology, which makes its transactions more convenient, affordable, and secure. Because it does not involve intermediaries such as banks or other payment processors, processing financial transactions is faster at reduced overhead costs. The other reason is that SMEs can access various funding options through Fintech without geographical restrictions. If conventional financing through banks is involved in these transactions, it also includes the cost of maintaining anti-money laundering and anti-terrorism as a regulatory burden. Therefore, financing through Fintech supports businesses and individuals through blockchain technology without cross-border restrictions, which is efficient, secure, and cheaper than traditional financial options. Furthermore, through Fintech, CEOs can access various financing

options such as P2P, Neobanks, Crowdfunding, and Cryptocurrency, where they can negotiate with investors to offer them funds at reduced rates. While at banks, due to the high cost of living and inflation, the interest rate is very high, which increases the cost of funding.

The research findings are consistent with the outcome of Carlin et al. (2017), Najib et al. (2021) and Kumari & Devi (2022) that Fintech provides lower cost, which is one of the factors for SMEs' financing preference to accept Fintech financing. As per CEOs' views, the interest rate on conventional financing through banks is higher on loans. However, with more funding options via Fintech, they can get cheaper and more negotiable rates. The study results also support Ornelas & Pecora's (2022) findings that P2P lending offers lower interest rates than traditional banks. The feature of the lower interest rate by Fintech is evident from Elliehausen & Hannon (2023), who state that Fintech offers lower interest rates that reduce funding costs. The CEOs' preference to accept Fintech to traditional financing has similar findings to the research report published by the European Central Bank, which confirmed that SMEs are actively switching to Fintech lending, which reduces their dependence on the banks. It reduces the cost of bank debt on SMEs (Eça, et al., 2022). The study findings are consistent with the IMF staff discussion notes that blockchain technology in Fintech does not involve banks, which results in cost reduction for that financial transaction (He, et al., 2017).

5.1.1.4. Lower regulations

The other reason that influences CEOs to accept FinTech is the discouraging approach by banks due to their regulation and strict lending criteria. Globally, regulators respond to rapidly evolving Fintech by implementing regulatory sandboxed regimes (Everhart, 2020). Regulatory sandboxes allow Fintech firms to test their services, products, or solutions in the market under more relaxed regulations within well-defined boundaries (Everhart, 2020). The regulatory sandbox approach enables Fintech companies to meet regulatory requirements while providing regulators opportunities to gain more understanding about financial services, products, and delivery channels that would allow them to enact Fintech regulations (Everhart,

2020). Regulatory sandboxes allow firms to safely test their business models, innovative products, delivery, or services without immediately accounting for all the regulatory consequences (Goo & Heo, 2020). The approach effectively deploys Fintech solutions that promote consumer confidence and protection. In the United Kingdom, the Financial Conduct Authority (FCA) sandbox is open to authorised firms, unauthorised firms that require authorisations, and technology businesses (Everhart, 2020). The FCA sandbox was established to determine whether delivering consumer benefits will be feasible while effectively managing the risks of Fintech solutions (Everhart, 2020). The United Kingdom was the first country to introduce a regulatory sandbox and has several competitive Fintech technologies and companies (Goo & Heo, 2020). Currently, the United Kingdom is considered one of the active Fintech markets (Goo & Heo, 2020). Traditional financing institutions such as banks and similar lenders are constrained by prudential regulatory requirements (Gao, 2022). In the initial stages, there were minimal regulatory requirements for peer-to-peer lending networks in China and the United States. However, China's financial regulatory agencies have increased the oversight of Internet financing regulations due to the concentrated breakout of risk in the industry (Gao, 2022). In the United States, there is no specific regulatory framework for Fintech in State or federal regulations (Giglio, 2021). The company may be subject to laws and regulations in the United States depending on the Fintech assessment provided (Giglio, 2021). According to Jhariya et al. (2023), most of the Fintech companies in India are not entirely regulated. The European regulatory framework does not follow a specific Fintech approach. European Fintech regulatory approach is fragmented in encompassing different pieces of legislation about various topics related to digital banking (Hanten, et al., 2022). Although banking laws have been harmonised in the European Union to some extent, there are no harmonised regulations for digital banking (Hanten, et al., 2022). The European Banking Authority (EBA) developed a roadmap, Fintech knowledge hub, and Fintech priorities in 2018 (European Banking Authority, 2017). The goals of EBA regulations were to enhance consumer protection, promote sound, effective, and consistent regulations, and ensure transparency, integrity, and orderly functioning of financial

markets (European Banking Authority, 2017). Existing research by leading researchers such as Magnuson (2018), Alam, et al. (2019) and Chorzempa & Huang (2022) findings are consistent with the current study outcome that the Fintech has lower regulations and that also attracts borrowers to use wider Fintech funding options. Also, Banks' discouraging approach is evident in the statistics that banks declined almost half a million UK SMEs' credit applications, which is 9.3% of total SMEs (Brown, et al., 2018). Further, 70% of micro SMEs failed to secure traditional funds in their first attempt (The Credit Protection Association, 2019). SMEs' traditional way of obtaining loan rejection remained at 17% or higher each year from 2012 to 2018 (Statista Research Department, 2022).

5.1.1.5. *Increasing demand and banking challenges*

The increasing demands in financial services include infrastructural, digital connectivity, the introduction of new products, regulatory burdens, and evolving finance strategies (Feyen, et al., 2021). The theme of increasing demand and banking challenges necessitating Fintech financing options. The negative consequences of the last financial crisis and the emergence of new technologies created disruptive forces in the financial markets (Kliber, et al., 2021). The introduction of Fintech financing is beneficial in meeting the demand of novice enterprises due to the cost of licensing, cards, payments, and costly activities such as security underwriting and on-balance sheet lending (Feyen, et al., 2021). Fintech has reduced the regulatory burden associated with cross-border transactions by enabling digital banking using applications or methods such as PayPal or TransferWise (Feyen, et al., 2021). Cost and efficiency concerns have accelerated the adoption of Fintech as viable options to improve efficiency and optimise cost in the financial market (Omarini, 2020).

Fintech addressed challenges associated with the traditional approaches by improving customer experience (Martinčević, et al., 2020). It creates and sustains a competitive advantage at reduced costs, manages risks, and enhances efficiency (Restoy, 2020). Fintech improves the efficiency of the traditional banking process by integrating technology. Fintech

financing enable infrastructural connectivity without a physical bank branch, thus reducing the burden of travelling from one area to another (Feyen, et al., 2021). Additionally, Fintech promotes connectivity through mobile technology that has increased efficiency and access at a lower cost. According to Ahern (2021), the COVID-19 pandemic increased the demand for digital financing services. Consumers suppressed their fears and concerns about Fintech to avoid the risk of COVID-19 infection, thereby improving the acceptance and adoption of Fintech financial options during the pandemic (Abdul-Rahim, et al., 2022). The onset of COVID-19 proved that people could gain technological literacy within a short time and forced them to use digital options to manage their finances (Setiawan, et al., 2021). Fintech solutions are adopted based on its ability to resolve the challenges associated with traditional methods. Fintech enhances the customer experience and helps to build and maintain a competitive advantage due to lower costs, risks, and high efficiency (Restoy, 2019; Martinčević et al., 2020). FinTech aims to overcome issues with traditional approaches. The findings revealed that the perception of adopting a FinTech solution is based on its benefits compared to the conventional options. Razzaque and Hamdan's (2020), Ahern's (2021), and Abdul-Rahim et al. (2022) findings were congruent with this study's results, revealing that the perception of incorporating Fintech solutions is based on its benefits and advantages. Therefore, these results are considered when advocating the adoption of Fintech solutions. Fintech resolves some of the issues associated with traditional financing and meets the surging demand in the market. Thus, the benefits associated with Fintech solutions over conventional methods are used as compelling factors to adopt digital finance. Therefore, CEOs are more focused on emphasising the advantages of Fintech financing when compared with traditional funding methods.

5.1.1.6. Limited Awareness

The limited awareness about the Fintech financing options hindered its adoption by the UK CEOs; hence, they preferred using traditional financing choices. Low digital financial literacy and awareness make it difficult for entrepreneurs to transit from traditional to digital financial

options (Basar, et al., 2022). Basar et al. (2022) conducted a study to identify the extent of Fintech adoption and the level of digital financial literacy. Basar et al. (2022) found that awareness of digital financial risk did not significantly influence the adoption of Fintech among SME entrepreneurs. Also, Basar et al. (2022) found a negative association between the awareness of Fintech risk and adoption among SME entrepreneurs. Entrepreneurs who are aware of Fintech risks such as cyber security and online fraud risk might opt for i-Fintech (Basar, et al., 2022). Knowledge about Fintech, performance expectations, safety performance, facilitating conditions, and social influence were among the factors that influence the adoption of Fintech among small food business owners (Najib, et al., 2021).

According to the Fintech Adoption Index, the adoption of Fintech doubles every two years globally (Lomachynska, 2020). In 2015, 16% of global consumers used one or more Fintech options, which increased to 33% in 2017 and 64% in 2019 (Lomachynska, 2020). In 2019, 99% of consumers were aware of Fintech's financial options. Globally, there is a high level of consumer awareness about Fintech, with money transfer and payments leading (96%), followed by insurance (86%), saving and investment (78%), borrowing (76%), and financial budgeting and planning (71%) (Lomachynska, 2020). According to Lomachynska (2020), SMEs demonstrated a high Fintech adoption rate of 25%.

The finding was similar to Basar et al. (2022), who discovered that limited literacy and awareness of digital financial services and options hampered entrepreneurs from adopting digital financing platforms. The literacy and awareness level of Fintech services influence the decision to adopt digital services. The study's finding is also similar to or perhaps consistent with the research by Das and Das (2020), who used surveys of 215 respondents to understand the adoption of Fintech by bank customers. They found the considerable benefits of FinTech, such as being user-friendly, low cost, quick, and less risky; however, they found that adoption and the use of Fintech among bank customers is very low due to limited awareness (Das & Das, 2020). Therefore, these findings suggest that increasing CEOs' awareness of Fintech services can result in a surge in the adoption of digital finance services. According to Niu et

al. (2020), an increase in the education level results in a rise in the adoption of Fintech services such as mobile banking and digital banking, credit, and wealth management. Literacy workshops can increase awareness of the benefits of using technology-enabled FinTech funding (Das & Das, 2020). Companies offering financing through Fintech can conduct training and awareness campaigns on the benefits of digital financing and how to apply it to increase the chances of adoption. These FinTech companies can improve their sustainable practices for SMEs to ensure their clients are aware of data protection measures, compliance with laws, privacy issues, and secure lending that will raise the customers' awareness of using Fintech (Global Lancers, 2023). The interesting result of this research is that most CEOs with considerable experience using Fintech. However, more awareness-related initiatives are required to spread Fintech funding.

5.1.2. Research Question 2 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude on their Fintech financing decisions?

The themes obtained in the second research questions include (a) leadership traits (b) using vision to guide Fintech decisions (c) using values to guide decision-making, (d) incorporating family members' perspectives in making Fintech decisions, (e) using personal beliefs to reinforce Fintech decision-making, (f) use educational knowledge to improve Fintech decision making, and (g) use prior experience to improve Fintech decision making (h) risk approach to making FinTech decision.

5.1.2.1. Leadership traits

The findings suggest that at the micro level, CEOs are very conscious about their personal leadership. They consider that personal leadership help to promote their organisation partnership for the business expansion that in return increases their organisational turnover to remain financially healthy. CEOs consider that personal leadership is significant to make decisions and it is linked to ethics, morality, dedication, goal-oriented vision, power, accountability, and integrity. Results are consistent with the findings of Waldman, et al. (2001),

Simsek, et al., (2010), Kaplan, et al. (2012), Chen, et al. (2013), Haas & Speckbacher (2017), Huang, et al. (2019), and Ibarra et al. (2020). Such leadership traits are associated with the transformational leadership styles because majority of CEOs are focus on the long-term vision to achieve the organisational goals, built trust in their team, engage with them, focus on the accountability as well listen others for the promotion of creativity and innovation in their organisation. Innovation in this case is the adoption of FinTech.

These CEOs also consider that personal leadership traits enable them to make innovation decisions – a characteristic of the transformational leaders. These decisions lead their organisation to achieve sustainability with innovation in the competitive market. According to CEOs, the personal leadership skills are linked to their communication skills to inspire others and foster a culture of creativity among team to achieve their organisational visions. CEOs personal leadership skills help them to lead for the better sound financial decisions. For example, these leadership attributes as discussed before enable them to make better financing choices as to where they should fund their business operations. CEOs work for the development of leadership skills, they emphasise on technology, gaining knowledge through training and formal education to make good decisions and also lead their team. They also work for the improvement of their communication skills which is believed to motivate their team and sub-ordinates to achieve their daily tasks. CEOs also think that task-oriented goals, respecting others, and caring for their clients are possible ingredients of their personal leadership. When it comes to Fintech financing, attributes such as trust, listening to their people in their personal and professional networks and a good vision contribute to their financing decisions. Due to these reasons, they work for the development of their leadership skills to make good financial judgements.

As CEOs' opinions suggest, personal leadership is significant to making FinTech decisions. Therefore, it is advised and recommended that they continue to develop their leadership skills through professional development training. Professional development courses are not formal qualifications, they are designed for managers and CEOs to update their professional development and by taking a training, they can enhance their decisions making in FinTech

financing. Professional development training boosts the confidence of individuals, prepares CEOs to perform their responsibilities with confidence, and further helps them to understand challenges in Fintech financing. The factor that can't be ignored is that the majority of CEOs, at least 70% of the sample SMEs, prefer FinTech financing that is because of the benefits of FinTech to traditional. However, the personal leadership to make FinTech decisions require considerable skills to make the right choice. Therefore, leadership training in the perspective of financial decisions, especially in FinTech is beneficial for CEOs to make the right choice.

5.1.2.2. Vision

At the micro level, the vision is a factor for CEOs which they believe to guides them in their FinTech decision making. Evidence from the sample statistics suggest that 95% of CEOs consider their vision have a significant impact on their decision making. Vision influence CEOs directly or indirectly to accept Fintech or traditional financing. When it comes to the direct influence, CEOs take several steps to visualise the future demand and benefits of the Fintech financing and make decisions. Indirect influence happens when they work in the Board of their organisations and other decisions makers influence them. In this perspective, they consider vision is related to their organisational directions and make financial decisions to achieve the strategic vision of organisations. That is also related to their transformational leadership style (Bass & Riggio, 2006). 5% CEOs consider that they have personal vision, however, their vision has no link to their companies' vision and therefore it does not influence them. Vision or visionary CEOs or the organisational vision are terms that are often used in the business literature but rarely understood or applied consistently. These terms are used in the context of the current research which is relating to the factors that influence CEOs to make financing decisions. An organisational vision is generally a written document or a statement to clarify its stakeholders about what the organisation wants to be in the future (Hoy, 2023). It also describes the long term plans or objectives or directions (CFI, 2023). The personal vision is direction to achieve the short or long goals (Davenport, 2023). According to Berg (2015), the

personal goals and purpose of the senior managers to the organisational vision confirms the success of the organisation if senior managers articulate their goals to the organisational vision. The findings confirm that CEOs have powers to make bold decisions, work as visionary leaders, empower team, and make decisions with wisdom, dedication and integrity to remain competitive with innovative strategies. However, their decisions are based on the organisational priority to seek funds. The results are consistent with the findings of Nwokedi (2015), Collins (2020), Slåtten et al. (2021), Maran et al., (2022), Yuanyuan et al. (2022) and Ji et al. (2023).

CEOs visionary characteristics are more associated with the factors in the transformational leaders where they look at the bigger picture to making financing decisions. Having a long-term personal vision is a notable factor for the CEOs especially when it comes to their decision making. CEOs with visions of integrating technology to improve a firm's efficiency and competitive advantages prefer using Fintech financing options. CEOs present a clear vision for digital transformation, showcase company leadership, and develop their business strategies (Kim & Kim, 2022). CEOs with strategic mind-sets are highly demanded at top levels of business organisations which contribute to the long-term success of the firms (Korherr, et al., 2022). CEOs should keep their personal vision forefront of what they do and that should be consistent and integrated with the organisational vision. CEOs are recommended to align their vision to shape, lead, motivate and engage with other stakeholders to make the better financial decisions. That will also give CEOs confidence that the success of the organisation has direct impact on their career related vision. Thus, vision is a vital aspect that CEOs should possess and can be used to guide Fintech decisions.

5.1.2.3. Values

The current study statistics confirm that 80% CEOs consider their values as guidance to make Fintech financing decisions. They consider that having values has positive impact on their organisational performance for Fintech related decisions. CEOs provided various definitions

of values, some of them were considering values at the personal level. CEOs think that their values are very personal and consider values to be inbuilt features inherited from their background, family, or perhaps religion, and they do not relate to their financing decisions. It was noted that many CEOs think out of box to distinguish their personal values to the organisational values. These CEOs were more focused on their organisational values, which provide a code of conduct and general principles for performing their jobs. In other words, CEOs think their organisational values guide their personal and business-related matters.

This result is consistent with the research outcomes of Vitt (2004), Berson et al. (2008), Gorgievski et al. (2011), and Lofving et al. (2023), which concluded that CEOs' leadership styles are guided by their values and positively contribute to their organisations' success. The findings are also consistent with the results of Ryu (2018), Yang & Lee (2019) and Gannon and Hieker (2022) that values are a significant factor for innovation, attracting investors to fund the business and individual decision making. CEOs' decisions are not limited to Fintech financing decisions but also to other matters that contribute to the long-term success of their organisations. In these perspectives, when it comes to values, CEOs are recommended to consider aligning their personal values with organisational values to guide their professional decision-making in their organisations. Most CEOs work in the board level of their organisation to make collective decision making. Aligning personal values to the organisational values will enable CEOs to work for the common organisational goals that will ultimately promote the healthy working environment to promote stakeholders' interest in the organisation.

5.1.2.4. *Family members*

The research's findings revealed that the majority of CEOs' decisions regarding Fintech financing are influenced by their family members. When it comes to the major decisions making in the organisation, CEOs require confidence and emotional support and due to those reasons, they consult such important matters with the family members. Discussion with the family not only provide them emotional support, but also help CEOs to feel confident that their

family stands by their major decisions in the workplace. Discussions with the families add self-confidence to the CEOs' Fintech decision-making, and such consultations give them direction and guidelines for making confident decisions. Even though the empirical evidence (Anderson & Reeb, 2003; Chrisman et al., 2004; Jonathan, 2021; Buchanan et al., 2022; Irdiana et al., 2022) confirm that families involvement has a significant impact and the role in business and decision making. It was not known whether they could contribute to CEOs' decision-making regarding their SMEs' financing options.

When the CEOs were asked to confirm whether the family's discussion or contribution influenced their Fintech decisions, 65% of participants responded positively, while 35% denied the family's influence on their decisions. The finding confirms that inputs from the family are useful advice and mostly related to emotional support, which contributes to CEOs' decisions regarding Fintech financing. The study also reveals that CEOs who don't discuss professional matters with their family have issues of work privacy, where they are bound not to share financing matters. The other issue is the conflict of interest of not including those people who are not a part of the organisation in the major decisions.

5.1.2.5. *Personal beliefs*

The finding shows that CEOs refer to their personal beliefs as opinions, perceptions, or even ideas about which they have faith to make decisions. CEOs were asked to confirm if their personal beliefs affect their decisions, the statistics confirm that 95% (n=19) believe that their personal beliefs contribute to their Fintech financing decisions while only 5% participants denied. The follow up questions confirm that CEOs have faiths that their decisions are dynamic – it means they change them if they have the perception that the outcome of their decision is not in their favour or make decision if it gives them a good value of money or a hope that their decisions would favour their organisation to involve in the ethical or moral transaction of funding. It further implied that they look for the risk of their decisions which influence their financing decisions. These risks could be the financial or operational risks. For example, the

risks are particularly concerned with regulations and security issues, monetary losses and fraudulent activity, and the manner in which funding by FinTech companies respond when a financial loss or financial information is disclosed. The findings at the micro level are congruent with Baxamusa & Jalal (2016) that the religious beliefs have effects on the human decision making. However, these are consistent with the findings of Setiawan et al. (2021), Mascarenhas et al. (2021), Abdul-Rahim et al. (2022), Gupta et al. (2023) that the personal beliefs of the consumers based on trust including perceived risks and benefits to affect the perception and intention to accept FinTech solutions.

Therefore, based on the trust to enhance CEOs' belief on Fintech, it can be inferred that appealing to the trust is important to enhance their personal belief in the adoption of FinTech. Elements of safety, privacy, regulation, ethics and morals, and authenticity in digital solutions enhance their confidence to use Fintech funding options. Therefore, the findings suggest that the individuals involved in FinTech actively evaluate and resolve the perceived risks while enhancing the perceived benefits of SMEs. However, to increase CEOs' belief and their trust in Fintech financing, Fintech funding firms should use different strategies to attract SMEs towards FinTech financing. These strategies should link to literature for CEOs' information that funding through Fintech is less risky, safe, secure and more beneficial than traditional sources of funds. These companies can arrange workshops to train and sensitise their existing and potential clients on their services and funding options.

5.1.2.6. Education

Education is a crucial factor for CEOs to make professional decisions. Through education, CEOs acquire domain-specific knowledge and skills to make decisions in their respective professions. The first question was if education contributes to CEOs' Fintech financing decisions. The sample statistics confirm that the 95% (n=19) believe that the education is a significant factor to positively influence their Fintech financing decisions. 5% (n=1) contradict with the education factor to contribution in their Fintech decisions. The result of this research

produces valuable knowledge that higher knowledge through formal or informal vocational or professional development education contributes positively to CEOs' making Fintech decisions. Expertise improves the capacity to identify patterns, assess risks, and generate innovative solutions. Education impacts CEOs' decision-making as well. Formal education equips individuals with foundational knowledge, critical thinking skills, and broader comprehension of their field, allowing them to make skilled decisions. In professional contexts, higher levels of education develop their critical skills in their complex decision-making. The sample of this research includes CEOs of SMEs who are highly qualified people and 90% holds higher level degrees while others substantial experience.

The results of this micro level are consistent with the findings of Norburn & Birley (1988), Garnier (1982), Hambrick (2007), Xiaowei & Zhang (2010), Soriano & Castrogiovanni (2012) and Herdinata, et al. (2019). Education level of CEOs helps them to evaluate all alternative funding options, bring innovation in the organisation, and enable CEOs to understand regulations, cost and benefits, advantages and disadvantages as well as improve their decision making. The higher level of expertise through education also increases CEOs productivity in the organisation.

5.1.2.7. Experience

Experience is an additional crucial factor in professional decision-making. CEOs acquire tacit knowledge and develop intuition through experience, enabling them to make quick and accurate decisions. In this study the 95% CEOs confirm that experience is vital and a significant factor to contribute in their Fintech financing decisions while 5% CEOs have opposite views. Their experience includes the knowledge of bank loans and the knowledge of block chain and the Fintech funding platforms. In the findings of the current study regarding experience at the micro level of CEOs to influence their Fintech financing decisions are consistent with Xiaowei & Zhang (2010), Moritz, et al. (2015), Zheng & Piao (2019), Mohd Thas Thaker (2019) and Duréndez, et al. (2023) that experience is vital to make good

decisions. Experience enables CEOs to recognise the best possible funding solutions and anticipate potential outcomes of FinTech, thereby enhancing their decision-making abilities. As Fintech is an emerging field in the financial sector, CEOs' experiences increase with time, enabling them to make good funding choices. This is because 35% of the current sample's CEOs have limited knowledge of using Fintech, but all of them are experienced CEOs with years in their current roles. In addition, there is significant gaps of regarding Fintech knowledge. 50% of CEOs have little knowledge of Fintech, and they are seeking ways to improve them. To bridge this gap, professional bodies, education institutes and online learning providers can develop training or even degrees to complement knowledge. These training can also include practical elements to enhance CEOs' experience. As a researcher, I would also suggest that there should be an independent body to validate each crowdfunding, P2P, and Crypto platform in the UK so CEOs will have high confidence in using them. Such an independent body should also work in collaboration with education providers to develop knowledge and skills-based training for investors, borrowers, and CEOs.

5.1.2.8. Risk attitude

The risk attitude is a micro factor to influence CEOs' decision making. As per the findings of this research, the risk taking attitude is linked to CEOs' beliefs and personalities and they think that the riskier decisions have greater returns and more benefits. According to CEOs, FinTech market is *volatile, uncertain, and unpredicted*. The sudden and unexpected change in the cryptocurrency is due to factors of the demand and supply, government support, investors' attitude, and risk factors associated with it (Koutmos, 2020; Delfabbro, et al., 2021; Smutny, et al., 2021; Khan & Hakami, 2022). Because the Fintech financing is comparatively new as compared to the traditional financial market (Ryabova, 2015; Gulamhuseinwala, et al., 2015; Moro-Visconti & Moro-Visconti, 2021). These are the main reasons for CEOs to have a risk avoider approach towards FinTech financing.

While taking into the account the findings of existing research that younger people are more risk taker (Jianakoplos & Bernasek, 2006; Steinberg, 2007; Mitsopoulou, 2019; Breivik, et al., 2020; Gunier, et al., 2022), the outcome of the current study produce opposite results that middle-aged CEOs are more risk taker than young CEOs because they have more experience of using Fintech. The level of experience is relating to the confidence which enable them to make innovative (Galasso & Simcoe, 2011; Berson, et al., 2008) and rational decisions (Gray & Carlisle, 2013). The findings are also similar to the results of Melović, et al. (2022) that experienced entrepreneurs are more risk takers to make rational decisions. A risk-taking attitude is a personality trait of CEOs; the literature shows that a risk-taking attitude positively impacts the company with higher returns (Galasso & Simcoe, 2011; Cain & McKeon, 2016; Bean, 2018). In addition, the risk-taking attitude of individuals is also related to their transformational leadership styles (Wansink, et al., 2008; Konorti & Eng, 2008; Gaan & Gaan, 2014; Alqatawenh, 2018; Buchholtz, 2021).

These findings suggest that CEOs' micro factors include their leadership traits, values, personal beliefs, education, experience, family and the risk attitude. These micro factors influence CEOs' decisions making relating to Fintech financing. FinTech companies should consider the main challenges associated with the above factors when encouraging and persuading CEOs to use FinTech funding options. CEOs in SMEs make decisions and evaluate all possible sources of evidence before they reach Fintech-related decisions that include their long-term visions, personal beliefs, expertise and support from the family. Their leadership style is more transformational due to their innovative approach and risk-taking attitude. Additionally, the findings revealed that earning the trust in technology e.g. Fintech increase beliefs and confidence to enhance the positive perceptions about FinTech. Thus, factors that affect trust, such as privacy, ethics, morals, security, fraudulent activities, and monetary losses during financing transactions, should be addressed and considered to enhance CEOs' confidence in adopting Fintech. Addressing these issues reduces risks associated with FinTech and helps to improve CEOs' perceptions of being able to use FinTech financing with confidence.

5.1.3. Research Question 3 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level?

The third research question was addressed to explore the influence of meso factors such as professional networking, board of directors, and organisational structure in CEOs' Fintech financing decisions at the UK SMEs. The themes that emerged were incorporating advice and contributions from other professionals, consulting with the board while making Fintech decisions and the effects of the organisational structure to make Fintech decisions.

5.1.3.1. Professional networking

Professional Networking in the finance industry is important in improving the adoption of digital and Fintech solutions due to their feedback and contributions. The results of the current study confirm professional networks influence 85% of CEOs in their Fintech financing decisions, while 15% of CEOs have the perceptions that there is no contribution of their professional networks in their financing preferences. Professional Networking helps to increase awareness of Fintech solutions as well as provide contribution among peers and professionals in a dynamic business environment that can be incorporated to enhance its outcome. According to Tajeddini et al. (2020), the networking fosters strong communication that is associated with developing and sharing novice ideas and insights, as well as effective communication and collaboration. Strong relations are also associated with improving innovation and balancing business operations, resulting in strategic and effective developments based on a web of actors and activities (Tajeddini, et al., 2020). These results suggest that networking platforms, including investors from the finance and technology sectors, should be conducted regularly to provide feedback and make contributions to Fintech. The finding of the research confirm that the most CEOs believe the positively contribution of their professional networking in their

Fintech financing decisions. This is consistent with the research by Xiaowei & Zhang (2010), Wang & Tu (2016), and Eze, et al. (2018) that professional networking helps CEOs to seek knowledge through opinions and that also help them to make decisions. The findings suggest the importance of networking in promoting a FinTech through providing feedback, interactions, effective communication, and peer referrals.

Additionally, CEOs also have professional networking with their organisational staff to build a strong organisational culture. Organisation culture is made up with the group of people who share their norms, beliefs, understandings and values in line with the organisation policies and rules, interact with each other's and with their external environment (Aquinas, 2010). Organisational culture exists within the internal business environment (Janićijević, 2013) where people share their thoughts, attitudes and learn from each other's behaviour to solve complex business problems (Schein, 2017). People's own ideas, feelings and attitudes are guided by shared cultural values and norms (Alvesson, 2013) and they work collectively to deal with the organisational external environment (Schein, 2017). CEOs know the credentials of all individuals working for their organisations such as background, social networking, education and other situational factors on behaviour (Kondalkar, 2007) that help them to develop their professional network with similar interests. This helps them to act as a leader to direct their subordinates' ideas and understanding while promoting ethical culture in the organisation. Therefore, networking within the organisation is highly significant of how SMEs operate in the competitive business environment and how their CEOs interact with their employees (Alvesson, 2013) and external competitors, suppliers, and customers (Daft, 2008) which ultimately influence their Fintech financing decisions. Therefore, creating strong relations promote innovation in the business which is facilitated by networking that can propel the adoption of Fintech. Hence, organisations which provides funding through FinTech should prepare and conduct workshops and seminars for stakeholders, investors, business owners, partners, clients, and customers in the finance and technology industry to interact and provide feedback on digital options and their benefits and advantages. In addition, networking forums

should be conducted often to increase new customers and ensure the continued use of existing clients.

5.1.3.2. Board

The second theme was consulting with the board members while making the Fintech decisions. All CEOs in this project confirmed that they have a board where non-executive and executive members play a major role, and that affects their decisions. That results in their collective decisions to make Fintech financing decisions. Having a board in the SMEs leads to corporate governance. Corporate Governance enables and protect all shareholders interest and safeguard proper conduct within the organisation. Effective governance for SMEs is crucial for their success, competence, sustainability, and growth in the competitive business environment (International Finance Corporation, 2019). The need for Corporate Governance has increased tremendously in the past decade because of the collapses of corporate organisations worldwide. This collapse generated much focus to other issues of Corporate Governance. The role of the Board is a combination of skilled people selected via voting or nomination based on their credentials, cultural knowledge, age, gender and others. The Board leads the organisation to success and ensures that there is risk management in decision making. The major strategic decisions for their organisation are led by the chairman on the board. The results of this study are somehow consistent with the findings of Gurdgiev and Ni (2023) that the diverse board plays an important role to moderate CEOs' financing decisions. Further, results are also consistent with research by Croci, et al. (2011) and Xiang, et al. (2018) that CEOs of micro SMEs avoid Fintech adoption due to their size and high risk, while CEOs of large, financially healthy SMEs with effective governance accept Fintech financing decisions. Additionally, the results are consistent with the findings of Abor and Biekpe (2006) that the corporate governance structures influence the financing decisions in the SMEs. Having the board in the SMEs overall reduces the risk to make the wrong decisions. The diverse board with independent experts as non-executive directors and skills executive

directors manage the best decisions to meet the organisational long-term strategy. The diverse board with expertise also improves the organisational performance. It is advised that the SMEs board should have a clear composition of the board members with job responsibilities. They should have policies, procedures and systems in place for the flow of information from the CEO to the board, decision making tools and also a conflict of interest system in place to ensure the integrity, validity and unbiasedness in the financial decision making to meet their stakeholders' interest. The Board role is to negotiate, protect and represent the shareholders interest in the organisation through accountability, control, strategic direction, and transparency while ensuring that they can contribute to the major decisions including FinTech. The findings confirm that CEOs consult with their respective boards while making FinTech-related decisions and protecting the interests of their shareholders. The findings also conclude that shareholders appoint the board for good governance and that the board oversees and ensures that CEOs' FinTech decisions benefit shareholders. However, having the board in the SME also increases the challenges of mitigating the conflict of interest and incurs agency costs.

5.1.3.3. *Organisational structure*

The third theme at the meso level was the effects of the organisational structure on the flow of information within the organisation, which is crucial for CEOs to make Fintech decisions. The study reveals that the different organisational structure exists in the SMEs regardless of their size. Most of the work in these SMEs are collective and that is led by CEOs. The study further reveals that the flow of information from different organisational structures affects CEOs' Fintech decisions and organisations' ability to accept change. The results are consistent with the study by Chehade and Vigneron (2007) findings that the complex organisational structures SMEs face more credit restraints. That is because of the decentralised organisational structure. The result of this study confirm that the organisational structure with many levels or departments have barriers for CEOs to make Fintech decisions

and further, the level for departments within the organisation reflect that the organisational structure is complex. Also, if the structure is considered as complex, it creates any barriers for affects CEOs to make timely fintech decisions. However, it influences CEOs' FinTech-related decision-making. These results are consistent to the study by Worthy's in 1950 as cited in (Carzo & Yanouzas, 1969) that decisions of CEOs are less productive if the organisational structure is complex and based on number of departments.

The outcome of the study at the meso level of the organisational structure align with the theory of the organic structure. Because Fintech is the financial innovation and that the organic organisational structure SMEs promote innovation (Saleh & Wang, 1993; Hage, 1999; Jenssen & Randøy, 2002; Camison & Villar-López, 2012; Gaspary, et al., 2020). The less barriers in the organisational structure enable CEOs to make innovative and timely Fintech decisions which is consistent with the findings of Chaston (1997), Bai et al. (2017) and Su et al. (2019). The study further reveals that the use of software such as CRM, daily meeting with staff, and effective networking are main factors in the organisational structure to assist CEOs to have timely information for their Fintech related decisions.

5.1.4. Research Question 4 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?

The fourth research question was used to explore the complexity of macro factors that navigate CEOs making Fintech financing decisions at SMEs. The themes that emerged included (a) aligning Fintech decisions to government policies, (b) insufficient information and policies about Fintech limits decision making, (c) using UK laws to guide decision making, (d) negative political and economic situations necessitate Fintech options, (e) some laws impede Fintech decision-making, and (f) making Fintech decisions to align with the emerging technologies.

The findings align with Dwivedi et al. (2021) and Ng and Pan (2022), who indicated that aligning the Fintech solutions with governmental regulations and policies was a determining issue in its adoption. Therefore, Fintech solutions should align with governmental regulations and policies, which will help increase their popularity among CEOs. Excessive regulations negatively impact on innovation and the growth of Fintech (Goo and Heo, 2020; Zarrouk et al., 2021; Ahern, 2021). The government support is necessary (Yee-Loong Chong et al., 2010; Kiwanuka, 2015; Hu et al., 2019; Owen et al., 2019) in building trust (Marakarkandy et al., 2017; Rosavina et al., 2019; Rosavina & Rahadi, 2018) and awareness (Ghazali & Yasuoka, 2018) for the fintech adoption. Comprehensive, standardised, and consistent Fintech policies and regulations could improve CEOs' Fintech financing decisions. The findings confirm that UK laws, regulations, and government policies support Fintech.

However, there is no particular Fintech legislation and a particular regulatory framework to govern FinTech in the UK. That means that the Fintech sector is liable to follow the established legislations (not an exhaustive list) such as anti-money laundering, anti-fraud, know your customer, counter- terrorism financing, data protection and UK GDPR, and Computer misuse act. Takeda and Ito (2021) found that aligning Fintech with regulations and policies is important in promoting its effectiveness, increasing its acceptability in society, and value addition. Hence, FinTech solutions should collaborate with governmental institutions to align their policies with governmental regulations and ensure that they address all issues with regard to privacy, possible threats, and customer protection (Takeda & Ito, 2021). The results indicate that the majority of CEOs expect a substantial government support on Fintech, particularly relating the information to support their Fintech financing decisions. The government are recommended to establish a financial innovation hub to promote UK Fintech.

The research's findings suggest CEOs are concerned about the tight financial credit terms due to the high interest rate and the current negative political and economic crises. The economic crises in the UK are getting worst due to the high inflation which is currently 6.9%, the highest since 1992 (Office for National Statistics , 2023) and that also increased the cost

of living due to the fall of 4.3% fall of the household income, the highest since 1956 (Parliament, 2023). The political and economic crises severally affect SMEs cash flow due to Covid-19 and fallout from Russian war with Ukraine (OECD , 2023). To cater with these negative effects and for CEOs to make the better financial decisions, the banking sectors are advised to establish a partnership with Fintech companies to design innovation applications. These applications should have transparent and accessible features to categories income and expenses for better budgeting and cheaper access to the financial credits.

The findings obtained revealed that the benefits and abilities of the FinTech options to address the demerits of traditional methods can be regarded as determining factors in the perception and adoption of digital solutions. Therefore, it is important to ensure that the FinTech solutions are superior to the current traditional methods and can resolve existing and emerging issues in the finance sector. Companies that provide FinTech funding solutions to SMEs should adhere to and meet the legislative regulations and policies within the country to increase the possibility of adoption and application among SMEs. CEOs consider FinTech-related funding options if the country's regulations support them. Therefore, FinTech service providers should ensure that their respective countries' legislative requirements are met and observed in every stage of the digital options, from development to dissemination to the market and their clients. Based on the findings obtained in the study on the factors that affect the perception of the CEOs in adopting and using FinTech financing, a detailed conceptual framework or model is developed to guide CEOs' decision-making on Fintech financing. This study emphasised how factors at the micro, meso and macro interact to affect intent to utilise FinTech as financial solutions for their organisations. CEOs make decisions for their financing preferences whether to go for the traditional financing options or Fintech. Their decisions are based on their perceptions and factors to influence their decisions to what portion of their organisation should be financed by the debt or equity or the combination of both. CEOs' decisions making is based on different decision making theories such as rational models, bounded rationality models, naturalistic decisions, the casual decision, game, evidential decision, Bayesian theories and the cogitative decision making models to make operations or strategic decisions. The decision-

making theories and models guide their decisions and factors such as micro (personal leadership, vision, values, education, personal beliefs, and risk taking attitude), meso (networking, governance within the organisation and the organisational structure) and macro (government and laws) contribute in their financing decisions. Therefore, the model used in the study is multi-layered, and it examines their factors to determine risk, benefit, and trust to make their financing preferences. The study reveals that CEOs have transformational leadership styles. They work for the best interests of their shareholders, work collectively on the board and in the organic structure of their organisation, promote innovation through their decisions, and obtain funding through FinTech as preferred financing for their SMEs. However, issues relating to trust, confidentiality, privacy, cost, awareness and regulations should be addressed by the government to enhance CEOs' confidence to accept FinTech.

5.2. Conceptual Framework

Besides the main findings, the data adds three more factors to the research framework developed in the literature review that significantly navigates CEOs in their decision-making regarding Fintech financing. These factors are age and gender at the micro level and the role of the chairman in the board of directors at the meso level.

5.2.1. Chairman

The chairman is the position in the organisation which is specifically related to the Board (Lechem, 2003; Kakabadse & Kakabadse, 2007; O'Higgins, 2009; Liao, et al., 2015; Naciti, 2019) to provide leadership (Institute of Directors, 2017; Harper, 2007; Pettigrew & McNulty, 2019; Corporate Governance Institute, 2023). The chairman is usually elected by the board, while the shareholders hire the CEO to oversee the management (Crocì, 2018; Graham et al., 2020; Chatjuthamard et al., 2022). Having a board in the organisation is specifically related to achieving good governance (Tricker, 2015; Mallin, 2016; Baysinger & Butler, 2019). The

theme that emerged during the analysis was the factor of the chairman on the board at the meso level contributing to the CEO's fintech financing decisions. For example, P2 highlighted the position of chairman on the board

We all work collectively when we have to make decisions such as Fintech finances. We talk to each other, we have a lot of information from management, we use scenarios based on decisions making tools, we evaluate risks, and then our chairman makes decisions.

According to P2, their SME has an independent board that depends on management to seek information relating to Fintech financing. Further, they work collectively on the board. That means the CEO is also part of the board. The board members work collectively and use decision-making tools, which could be based on the information they receive from their management regarding traditional or fintech financing. The more important part is that their chairman makes the final decisions. Similar to P2, P5 also highlighted the role of the chairman by stating

*We just recommend the project but the final decision is the chairperson.
The chairperson issue agenda on the potential project and we make our paperwork and contribute.*

While discussing the board's role, the P5 provides valuable information that their SME board has a separate chairman role, who issues the agenda to all members, including the CEO, for projects. The CEO and other board members prepare for those projects and report to the chairman, who makes the final decisions, e.g. whether the project should be financed through fintech or conventional financing.

It is important to note that in the UK there are no regulatory requirements for SMEs to have a separate board, even not a requirement to have a separate role of the chairman in the board. These SMEs strive to achieve good governance by having a board in their organisational structure. Further, the corporate governance code, which is a regulation for only listed

companies in the London Stock Exchange to either comply or explain good governance (Financial Reporting Council, 2024), does not apply to SMEs (Institute of Directors, 2024). The powers and responsibilities of the board, including decision-making and chairing the meeting, are determined through the legislative requirements of the Companies House Act 2006 and the Articles of Association (Tricker, 2015; Hannigan, 2018; Davies, 2020). One of the principles of the UK corporate governance code is to distinguish the role of the chair and the CEO on the board (Financial Reporting Council, 2024). Having a separate role of the chairman and CEO on the Board reflects their voluntary practice; however, it is good enough to bring accountability and transparency in their systems to achieve good governance.

When asked about the decision-making on the board, P19's opinion about the chairman differed from P2 and P5 because of the duality of the role of a CEO and Chairman. According to P19

I believe in working as a board I'm the chairman of that board , you know , I will listen to everyone with which with the give me the idea, you know what decision I should make , you know , because everyone got their own opinions and when I will be , I will be in unless they analyze their opinions. You know, I always learn something new and which will help me to make decision.

P19 works with the board members in his dual roles. The duality of roles exists for organisations where CEOs work as a chairman on the board and simultaneously perform their CEO role (Palanissamy, 2015; Tang, 2017; Alves, 2023). For example, Nguyen et al. (2020) found that the duality of CEOs provides effective governance with the benefit of reducing agency costs. Agency cost is the expense which is incurred to resolve the conflict between management and the shareholders (Florackis, 2008). The agency cost associate in the organisation when directors or appointed CEOs controlling the company work for their own interest rather than the interests of their shareholders – agency theory in governance (Bosse & Phillips, 2016; Zogning, 2017; Schillemans & Bjurstrøm, 2020). Therefore, the chairman's

role on the board significantly impacts the organisations in achieving governance by reducing agency costs. The chairman factor is an independent element in the board to ensure the shareholder's interest is protected in the organisation. The findings of Tibiletti et al. (2021) indicated that the highest number of independent directors on the board provides more protection for shareholders' interests. Naciti (2019) found that the separation of the CEO and chairman role in the organisation creates the highest sustainability for the organisation. Further, the duality of the CEO in the organisation leads to inefficient investment decisions while lowering the firm's value (Aktas, et al., 2019). Renders & Gaeremynck (2012) also found that good governance practices minimise agency conflict and lead to higher firm value. Further, a small board with separate roles of CEO and chairman results in higher performance for the firm (Azeez, 2015). The above evidence from the literature suggests that there are significant benefits of having the separate role of the chairman and CEO in the board for effective governance and that also results in minimising the conflict between the shareholders and the management. Further, having a chairman on the board reduces the agency's cost.

5.2.2. Age

The demographic data of the participants in this research is categorised into young CEOs (ages 18-25), middle-aged CEOs (ages 36-55), and older CEOs (ages 56+). Most respondents are in the age group of 36-55 years, representing 60% of the sample, while 25% represent 18-35 years and 15% represent 56+.

Table 6 Demographic Age Group Financing Preference

Financing Preference	Age Group		
	18-35 Years	36-55 Years	56+ Years
Prefer to use Fintech	45%	15%	5%
Prefer traditional financing	15%	5%	5%
Prefer both financing	0%	5%	5%

The current statistics confirm that 45% of young CEOs, 15% of middle-aged CEOs and 5% of older CEOs prefer Fintech financing. The CEOs' preference for traditional financing includes

15% young CEOs, 5% middle-aged CEOs and 5% old CEOs. In addition, some CEOs prefer both traditional and Fintech financing, regardless of the reasons, including 5% of middle-aged and 5% of old CEOs. This demographic representation of the data does not imply that the CEOs' financing preferences are solely due to their age. However, it only represents the descriptive demographic statistics that age could be a significant factor in influencing CEOs in their financing preferences. There is a general lack or absence of empirical evidence to confirm CEOs' decision-making regarding accepting Fintech due to their age group. The closely related evidence confirms that age contributes to decision-making. For example, de Acedo Lizárraga, et al. (2007) found that age is a human factor contributing to their decision. They found that human makes decisions depending on their age group, which is relevant to the tasks and depends on the different social and work-related environmental factors. The age can be linked to the flexibility of the CEO in their SMEs in adopting new and emerging financing models, with younger CEOs having a greater affinity and flexibility to adopt new funding and financing models, including Fintech, compared to older CEOs. This contradicts the findings of Bruine de Bruin et al. (2012), who indicated that decision-making skills increase with age. Similarly, an empirical study by Dror et al. (1998) explored the cognitive processes based on age group and found that old and younger people use systematic approaches to make decisions, and there are no differences in decision-making based on their age group. Some studies confirm that CEOs' age significantly impacts firm performance; for example, Serfling (2014) found that older CEOs invest less in research and development, which affects their financing decisions to lower risk for the firm. Evidence from Osei Bonsu et al. (2023) also indicated that age is an attribute of CEOs that influences their corporate financing decisions and determines the firm's performance. Further, with the increase in age, CEOs' experience enables them to make confident and aggressive decisions for more proper financing options in their organisations (De Silva & Banda, 2022). Also, older CEOs rely more on debt financing (Loukil & Yousfi, 2023). This evidence confirms that CEOs' age is one of their attributes to contribute in different situations, e.g. in decision-making relating to financing, either to take debt or equity or use a mix of both. However, in this research study, age is linked to factors

such as experience and Fintech knowledge that influence CEOs' decisions. For example, older CEOs above 55 have longer tenures and are well-equipped with the knowledge and experience to make the right financing choices. Therefore, they have mixed opinions about not supporting Fintech or traditional but using any financing option suitable to their organisational funding needs. Similarly, younger and middle-aged CEOs prefer fintech because of efficiency, more funding options and lower regulations, which is already evident from the research findings. It can be implied that age enhances CEOs' experience as decision-makers and knowledge of Fintech in emerging and developed markets. Younger CEOs are more likely to explore riskier strategies, including capital structure financing strategies, compared to older CEOs (Yeoh & Hooy, 2022) to accept Fintech financing. The discussion revolves around the question of identifying the significant relationship between the CEO's age and the adoption and pursuit of innovative strategies in SMEs, such as the adoption of Fintech financing. Therefore, the younger CEOs' financing preferences towards Fintech bring innovation to their organisation with new financing options. That is also evident from the findings of Chen et al. (2015), Garcés-Galdeano & García-Olaverri (2019), Yim & Kang (2020) and Oliver (2023) that the younger CEOs are more likely to participate in the firms' innovation, including research and development with their decisions than older CEOs.

5.2.3. Gender

Gender is a term to identify the differences of feelings, mind-sets, interests and behaviour between male and female (Powell & Graves, 2003). It is related to the biological characteristics of individuals as a sex difference in leadership styles within the organisation. The biological differences between person are sources of their recognition such as face, finger prints, hand-geometry, voice, ear, palm print, blood and deoxyribonucleic acid (DNA) and that ultimate influence their approaches and behaviour (Mordini & Green, 2009) in the social context (Voskoboynikov, 2017). Human beings either males or females have biological and social components in their personality. Biological components relate to their inner physical, mental,

cognitive and spiritual characteristics while social components are acquired from the environment (Voskoboynikov, 2017) such as education, experience and professional skills. Gender differences, therefore, exemplify of how a group of people within the society think, learn, remember, behave, make decisions and show attitude towards other group of people (Powell & Graves, 2003). People with different sexual orientation also distinguish themselves in their grooming style, hobbies, clothing, music, activities, friendship, professional association and opinions in the workplace (Powell & Graves, 2003). There is lots of literature about the male or female dominance in the workplace, especially for the position CEOs or directorship. For example, women in Fintech are 29% of total employees while men 83% at the leadership role with 71% at the directorship of FTSE companies (Souliman, 2019). Even though there is variation in numbers at the top of firm leadership, the gender factor is still essential for this research to identify whether it contributes to CEOs' decision-making regarding their financing preferences. In this research sample includes the demographic gender statistics relating to their decision to accept Fintech, traditional financing or both. The significant of current research is that mixed gender views and perceptions are associated to the financing options, leadership styles within the organisation and the decision making at the organisational and board level.

Table 7 Demographic Gender Financing Preference

Financing Preference	Gender	
	Males	Females
Prefer to use Fintech	64%	67%
Prefer traditional financing	14%	17%
Prefer both financing	21%	17%

As indicated in the above table, demographic information shows that 64% of males and 67% of females prefer Fintech as their preferred financing option. 14% of male CEOs prefer traditional financing, which is lower than 17% of female' views. At the same time, female dominance for Fintech and traditional funding is slightly higher than males. On the other hand, males' and females' preferences for both financings do not have significant differences. 21% of male CEOs don't prefer any financing methods but prefer both, whichever is convenient for

their organisation. Similarly, 17% of females don't prefer any specific financing option. In summary, the statistics confirm that female CEOs' intention to use Fintech financing is higher than that of males.

Empirical evidence from Obamuyi (2013) to identify factors which influence the investment decisions of individuals indicated that the gender factor influences managerial decision-making in organisations. Results of the study showed that gender is one of the influential factors in investment decision-making. Marta et al. (2008) also concluded that female managerial decision-making processes in small businesses differ from male managers. Missioura (2014), in their study of decision-making and gender differences, indicated that male and female directors' norms, attitudes, and behavioural beliefs are significantly different in their decision-making regarding strategy, future planning, and financial targets. Females are more interested in the future of SME targets and rely on outside organisations' suggestions in their decision-making than men (Missioura, 2014). The results of MacGregor (2004) are evidence that gender differences influence managerial decision-making in accepting technology in an organisation, such as e-commerce. E-commerce is a term used to describe financial transactions over the Internet (Laudon & Traver, 2020). Financial transactions through electronic platforms include taking and making payments for the business over the internet and accepting different forms of currencies, including cryptocurrency, bitcoins and other forms of digital currencies from customers. The study results are consistent with the results of MacGregor (2004), Missioura (2014), and Obamuyi (2013), which confirm that gender, among other micro-level factors, influences CEOs in their financing preference.

Therefore, the conceptual framework is established in the following figure 15. The conceptual framework confirms that CEOs lead their major financing decisions due to their unique leadership style and decision-making skills. Several factors at the micro level, such as their leadership traits, vision, values, support from the family, education, experience, risk-taking attitude, gender, and age, contribute to their financing decisions. At the meso level, CEOs work in organisations with different organisational structures. These structures, if adaptive to

their business environment, such as organic structure, facilitate the smooth flow of information without any barriers from the management team for CEOs' timely decisions, leading to innovation such as the acceptance of Fintech financing. Their networking with professional experts, including members of the board or the management, significantly contributes to their financing decisions. CEOs consult with the government policies and laws at the macro level and ensure their SMEs comply with relevant legislation. They also seek support from the government to create enough awareness for them for Fintech financing.

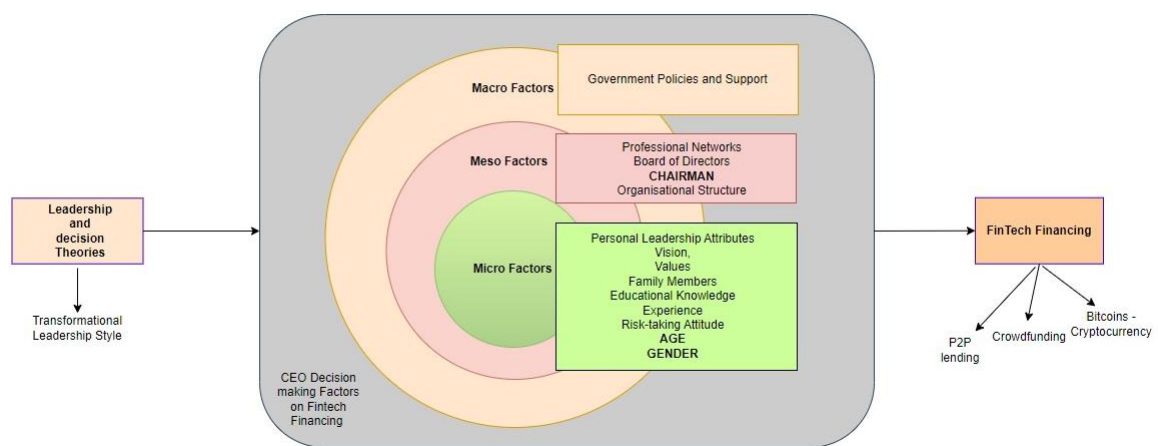


Figure 15 Conceptual Framework: Micro, Meso and Macro Factors

6. Conclusion

6.1. Summary of findings

This study aimed to understand the CEOs' decision making relating to Fintech financing in UK SMEs. In this study, the researcher developed four key research questions based on the research objectives to explore the research phenomenon. The conceptual framework was developed to explore how CEOs perceive the influence of factors (micro, meso and macro) to navigate their Fintech financing decision. The first research question established that CEOs prefer Fintech because it provides more financing options, the cost of financing is lower than traditional financing through banks, and there are fewer regulations. CEOs mentioned many financing options through technology-enabled platforms such as *Seedrs*, *GoFundMe*, *Indiegogo* (P11), *Kickstarter* (P9), and *Crowdcube* (P6). Crowdfunding, P2P lending and cryptocurrency are prominent financing options. CEOs obtain funding of any amount from these financing options; either they need funds for equipment (P11), project (P5), open a franchise (P9) or business support (P10). More financing options enable CEOs to get funds from investors (P5, P6, and P10) by negotiating repayment terms (P6). Fintech's financing supports SMEs through equity or debt from investors. To avoid high costs of financing, CEOs avoid taking debt from banks due to higher interest rates (P5, P18, P6, P14) because of inflation, the disruption from COVID-19 (P5) and the economic crises due to war (P3, P7). They prefer to invite investors (P6) to negotiate cheaper lending rates (P9, P6, P5, P15, and P11). Further, CEOs' preference for Fintech is fewer regulations (P19, P20, P18, P7, P3, P6, P1) because the banks have strict (P6, P7), complex and lengthy lending criteria (P3). Due to the fewer regulations, CEOs find that Fintech offers quick finance with flexible repayment terms. In the presence of Fintech financing options, CEOs' decisions for lending through banks is their low awareness of Fintech (P13, P2, P9, P8, P5, P1, and P2).

The second question was about how micro factors contribute to CEOs' Fintech decision-making. CEOs' leadership traits help them to find the best financing source (P1, P15, P19,

P12), and that includes leading the organisation with effective communication (P9, P20), dedication (P14, P11), and ethics (P11) to promote the culture of accountability (P12) with innovative decisions. CEO vision is more strategic, and they work within the values of integrity and transparency (P10, P14) to make FinTech decisions. CEOs' perceptions about the family contribution to their financing decision are that it provides them with ideas and emotional support. Their belief also contributes to their decisions, especially their trust in Fintech, which increases if it gives them more benefits and less risk. Education and experience provide them with knowledge and skills to improve their decision-making. Experienced CEOs consider themselves risk-takers because they anticipate a good return on their decisions. The result of this study further reveals that experienced CEOs are more risk taker, and that is because of their experience and knowledge of Fintech. However, that does not conclude that CEOs prefer Fintech financing. Younger CEOs are risk avoiders because they feel financing through Fintech is risky, and no regulatory body oversees their transactions. Younger CEOs need assurance despite their awareness that Fintech financing has more benefits than traditional financing through banks and is secure due to blockchain technology.

At the meso level, CEOs' professional network, board, and organisational structure significantly influence their Fintech financing decisions. CEOs build their professional network with staff (P10, P7, P6, and P13) and experts (P2, P1, P18, and P3). The information they need to make finance decisions depends on their organisational structure to collect from the relevant departments (P6, P10) or their subordinates (P2, P12, P14, P20). However, their decisions are also influenced by the board's collective decisions led by the chairman (P1, P3, P8, P9, P2, P13, P4, and P7).

At the macro level, CEOs consult with the government regulations (P1, P5, P7, P8, and P19), legal staff (P1, P10, and P14) and regulators (P9, P13) that influence their Fintech financing decisions. Further, there are no specific Fintech laws and even less support from the government to create awareness.

6.2. Contributions of the Study

Money-related services are accessed in today's dynamic business environment via FinTech financing and traditional banking financing. Fintech can be leveraged to improve SMEs' financial services, profitability, and organisational capacity to be competitive. For example, organisations adopting Fintech can distinguish themselves from their competitors and boost their capacity to retain and attract new customers (Alkhawaldeh, et al., 2023). As a result of Fintech's proliferation, SMEs now have access to several new avenues for securing funding (Ferrarini, 2017; Temelkov & Gogova Samonikov, 2018; Giglio, 2021; Kumari & Devi, 2022). These include various digital platforms, online lenders, crowdfunding, peer-to-peer lending networks and crypto assets. Fintech has revolutionised the financial sector by offering efficient, cost-effective, scalable, stable, reliable, easy, and convenient innovative financial alternatives to traditional systems (Suryono et al., 2020; Kou et al., 2021; Kumari & Devi, 2022). Fintech has improved the delivery process, quality of financial services, and customer satisfaction and created a more diverse financial landscape (Mention, 2019; Kou et al., 2021). The study revealed different insights that would have notable contributions to knowledge and literature, practice, and policy changes.

6.2.1. Contribution to Knowledge and Literature

6.2.1.1. Transformational Leadership

. There is no prior research in this field; hence, this project contributes to the extant literature on CEOs' decision-making in Fintech financing. The study results show that CEOs have various functions to perform and consider their leadership traits crucial for their Fintech financing decision-making. CEOs work in a competitive organisational environment and respond to change with innovative decisions. They work with their team at the management level and board members at the Board level to promote collective decisions for shared organisational goals, such as financing decisions for their organisation's specific funding needs. Their vision enables them to compete with their competitors, based on their

organisational vision as a set of directions set by the Board and per shareholders' requirements, ensuring their decisions benefit their organisation. The study contribution to the existing literature includes CEOs' leadership traits, beliefs and values, enabling them to make independent financing decisions by inspiring and motivating their team for the long-term vision of their organisation (i.e., contribution to Bass & Riggio, 2006 and Baškarada, et al., 2017) by seeking emotional support from family and knowledge through their professional networking. They engage with their team and work towards their development by listening, inspiring and encouraging them towards their organisational long-term vision. Further, they also contribute positively to the board meetings for collective decisions. That promotes integrity (Liborius, 2021) in financing decisions for long-term organisational financial stability (Gannon and Hieker, 2022).

In addition, the researcher contributes to the extant literature by providing empirical evidence that family members improve CEOs' confidence and provide emotional support to proceed with crowdfunding, P2P lending, or financing through crypto assets. The discussion with the family enhances CEOs' emotional intelligence. The positive benefits and lower risk impact their CEO's beliefs to gain trust in the Fintech financing, enabling them to make decisions confidently. CEOs actively seek to develop their knowledge and experience for personal and professional development through formal and vocational education, which the researcher believes enhances their decision-making skills. They maintain that higher knowledge of Fintech financing options contributes to their funding decisions. The practical knowledge is significant in this study because CEOs believe that professional networking contributes to developing their knowledge. They practically develop networking within their organisation and outside by joining experts. CEOs also learn from their experience and promote high-performance teams by ensuring that their organisation, due to its complex hierarchical structure, doesn't create barriers to information from their subordinates, which helps them make timely decisions. Especially during the pandemic, Brexit and the current era of higher inflation, where the cost of living has tremendously increased in the UK, CEOs ensure that

their organisation doesn't pay much debt, so they collectively work with the board to get technical support from other directors and management team for better decisions especially in the interest for their organisation stakeholders without promoting their self-interest. Experience enables them to evaluate all possible sources of funds from traditional and Fintech financing and make rational decisions for their SME's benefits to avoid higher funding costs. Rational decisions include the evaluation of all evidence relating to the funding, including their feasibility and acceptability and the long-term impact on their SMEs to make the best choice. In making rational decisions, CEOs' decisions are based on the cognitive theory of decision-making. They consider their vision, beliefs, family, and expertise as contributing factors in addition to the organisational factors where they work to shape their financing preferences. The researcher contributes that CEOs prefer Fintech because the benefits of technology-enabled funding are higher at lower costs and fewer regulations. Even though Fintech is new in the UK, it has not fully evolved as the traditional financing method for funding. However, preferences towards Fintech suggest that they take risks to make innovative decisions, which is also a characteristic of transformational leadership. Therefore, the influence of micro-level factors such as having a long-term vision, working collectively with the board without relying on their self-interest for their organisational benefits, inspiring and motivating their teams towards shared goals, working within their values of integrity and beliefs, consulting with the family for emotional support and professional support from networking, using their expertise, and a risk-taking attitude towards innovative decisions are more aligned with the transformational leaders.

6.2.1.2. *Organisational Structure*

The study contributes to prior studies, i.e., Chaston (1997), Bai, et al. (2017) and Su et al. (2019) with the significance of the organisational structure, which influences CEOs in their financing preferences. Chaston (1997) identified the entrepreneurial marketing styles of small and medium-sized companies and the influence of the organisational structure for the

entrepreneurial orientation on the firms' performance. They found that the overall performance of UK SMEs can be improved by becoming entrepreneurial with an organic structure. This research contributes that organic organisational structure in SMEs leads them towards innovative financing decisions due to fewer barriers to the flow of information to CEOs when making financing decisions. Su et al. (2019) research confirms that there is a positive relationship between the organic structure of the organisation and managerial innovation. The contribution to the extent of this research is that CEOs' innovation increases with their Fintech financing due to the organic structure, which is suitable to respond quickly and timely to their external environmental demand to accept innovation i.e. Fintech. Similarly, the research of Bai, et al. (2017) was focused on the impact of the organisational structure on the performance of a new product development team and found that organic structure leads towards innovation and is positively linked to the performance of a new product development team by reducing the barriers of cooperation and knowledge sharing. In the research, the researcher found that the organic structure of SMEs leads their CEOs to have information from their management team without barriers that encourage their innovative decisions by meeting their SME financing needs with Fintech effective improved teamwork. It is because CEOs are responsible for setting the company's overall vision and strategy. They decide what they want, take steps to identify the areas of improvement, and then plot a course of action to achieve the organisational goals. Being transformational leaders for their organisation, their ability to unite and lead their team around their vision, shared goals and inspire their subordinates is crucial to the company's success (Stoker et al., 2012; Latham, 2013; Saeed & Ziaulhaq, 2018; Alblooshi et al., 2021). The study concluded that micro- and macro-sized SMEs represent their organisational structure as organic because they work collectively in their organisation, the flow of information for CEOs to make decisions is efficient without any structural barriers, and due to this, they respond to innovation and accept Fintech financing by prompt responding to their environmental factors. In contrast, large-sized SMEs with complex organisational structures tend to favour conventional funding.

The choice of the preferred financing for their SMEs is a critical role of CEOs. Because the CEOs of SMEs ensure that the best financing options for their organisations bring innovation, create strategic alliances, and confirm their organisations' market dominance. SMEs are challenged by their internal and external environmental forces, which pressure CEOs to make reliable financing choices. Their internal organisation environment includes tangible or intangible factors in the company's control, such as plans, policies, values, human resources, financial resources, brand, identity, fixed assets, current assets, relationships between employees, and in-house technology. Internal factors influence CEOs' decisions to identify business opportunities by using their resources and help them deal with external threats. The external environmental factors include intangible and tangible factors that are not in the company's control. Still, they impact the organisation, such as requirements from the customers, suppliers, public, competitors, media, external talent, external technology and government policies (Nieuwenhuizen et al., 2012). The CEOs' Fintech decision-making in SMEs is significant in having the suitable organisational structure to accept innovation and change while dealing with challenges of internal and external environmental factors. The study found that CEOs often have the last say in financing decisions if rigid hierarchies characterise their organisational structure. Because numerous levels of clearance are required at the different departmental levels of the structure, their financial decision-making is frequently slow. Those CEOs who prefer traditional financing, such as funding through banks, respond less to their organisational external environment, and their organisational structure is based on a number of departments. That also leads to significant paperwork and time-consuming decision-making procedures for CEOs. These conventional finance methods are formal and procedural and fit perfectly with the mechanistic organisational structures. Mechanistic structures' complex hierarchical structure can be both a strength and a weakness. While it guarantees distinct lines of power and responsibility, adjusting to quickly shifting market conditions may make it more difficult. As a result, mechanical organisations overlook innovative prospects and react more slowly to arising financial issues. In this project, most CEOs have organic organisational structures in their SMEs, and they work with their team to

get quick information to share so they can make financing decisions. Decision-making is frequently collaborative in these environments, and quick response to market dynamics are highly valued. CEOs of SMEs prefer Fintech financing alternatives like funding through cryptocurrency, crowdfunding, or peer-to-peer lending, which require timely information from their team. Organic structure in SMEs encourages CEOs' innovative decisions through their collaborative working with the board and staff, allowing them to grab opportunities better and respond effectively to the challenges of the organisational environment. Therefore, CEOs assess their organisational factors and then make Fintech-related decisions to ensure they meet the internal stakeholders and external challenging requirements of laws, regulations, technological innovation, and economic conditions. Therefore, the study contributes to the theory of organisational structure that impacts UK SME CEOs Fintech financing decisions by responding to their organisational environment.

6.2.1.3. *The Significance of the Pecking Order Theory of Financing*

The study contributes to the findings of the discussion paper of Degryse et al. (2009) in the European Banking Centre, with practical implications for SME financing decisions. Degryse et al. (2009) found that Dutch SMEs' capital structure decisions support the Pecking Order Theory. Dutch SMEs prefer to use profit in their first step to lowering the need for short-term debt, whereas, for growth, these organisations use long-term finances. This study found that UK SMEs prefer to use their internal funds from equity and retrained earnings to meet the demand of their financing requirements. In addition, the results show that most SMEs prefer to use alternative modes of funding through Fintech, which is consistent with the Pecking Order Theory. The main reasons this study has found are that UK SMEs prefer to use alternative modes of funding, such as Fintech, which supports the Pecking Order Theory of financing, including the lower cost of financing, fewer regulations, and more funding options. The lower cost of financing is due to the efficient blockchain technology, which lowers transaction costs due to the exclusion of intermediaries such as banks and SMEs' access to

interested investors across the globe. These investors can fund the SME's projects or their financial needs in flexible and negotiable terms with less regulatory compliance to maintain and offer quick transactions. Banks are regulated by the Financial Conduct Authority, and these financial institutions have the regulatory burdens to support anti-money laundering and anti-terrorism in financial transactions, which increase the cost of funding. SME CEOs can also access various funding platforms without going to the banks, which have strict lending criteria and higher interest rates on loans. These platforms include Neobanks, cryptocurrency, crowdfunding, and P2P lending, which provide them with multiple options to get cheaper and negotiable rates.

6.2.1.4. *Agency Theory in the Governance*

The study contributes to the extend the governance literature of Samuel (2013), Renders & Gaeremynck (2012), Nguyen et al. (2020), and Tibiletti et al. (2021) that governance is a significant factor in CEOs in SMEs to influence their financing decisions by reducing agency cost and bringing expertise to the Board with the inclusion of independent directors. In this study, SMEs have a board, which is a separate body from the management, to achieve good governance. Most of the significant financial decisions that impact the SMEs are led by the board's chairman, with support from the executive and non-executive members who are directors. Most SME CEOs believe in working collectively with other Board members to reach Fintech financing decisions. Effective corporate governance practices favour the performance of their organisations and enable CEOs to make consistent, valuable, and best financial decisions in the interest of their stakeholders. However, the Board's arrangement depends on the organisation's size. The board is arranged for various purposes in SMEs. It could be one transparent way to show lenders that they have good governance by adding independent factors of non-executive directors. Even though there are no regulatory requirements for SMEs to follow the UK Quality Code for Governance, the main aims of the governance could be, for many reasons, to demonstrate to outside lending organisations that they have an effective governance arrangement similar to that of large-sized organisations. Because banks have a

history of granting less funding to SMEs, e.g. evidence confirms that SMEs receive approximately 17 per cent of the total loans from banking institutions (Lu, 2018). Conversely, large business organisations receive a large portion of these loans. This indicates limited lending to SMEs from traditional financing organisations. Today, banks are more risk-averse in the face of major financial crises (Lu, 2018). In addition, increases in inflation and interest rates caused SMEs to find it challenging to obtain funding from banks. It also poses a risk for lenders to have strict lending criteria. Consequently, banks are only comfortable with financing corporations with colossal potential to repay the loan plus interest. This is because large-sized organisations have effective governance systems to allow the transparency of transactions and the confirmation of the loan's payback. Similarly, traditional financing organisations, such as banks, often require collateral before providing loans to organisations (Lyon & Owen, 2019). However, UK SMEs may lack collateral and steady income sources to acquire loans. Consequently, CEOs in UK SMEs seek other forms of financing, such as Fintech, to ensure their businesses continue to survive and grow amidst challenging economic times. This could be achieved by having an effective governance system that allows for the preferred financing choice. The significance of corporate governance in SMEs is that it promotes collaborative working on the board to provide confidence to CEOs to make the right financing decisions. This is evident from the current study, which confirms that the governance arrangement influences the CEOs' decisions. Before making the Fintech financing decisions, CEOs consult with their board's executive and non-executive members. Consulting with the board members means experts back CEOs' decisions to reflect the transparency of their decisions. The study confirms that CEOs are part of their board, which the chairman leads. The Board members work collectively for effective financing decisions. The diverse and expert board ensures effective governance that benefits SMEs in representing their organisation to potential lenders to acquire funds. CEOs are appointed by their shareholders, work as board members, lead the operational part of their organisation, and represent their board to external stakeholders. Having a board in the SMEs and the role of CEOs in financing decision-making ensure the

protection of their shareholders and support the foundation of the agency theory of governance.

6.2.2. Contribution to Practice

The findings of this study revealed different practical implications that can be used to improve the adoption of Fintech to leverage associated benefits such as efficiency and accessibility of financial services. For example, it was apparent that government laws and regulations significantly impact Fintech decisions, as evidenced by how CEOs considered them while making financial decisions. The interviewed CEOs indicated they comply with government laws and regulations when making Fintech decisions. That contributes to the current literature (Chen et al. 2014; Kiwanuka, 2015; Rosavina & Rahadi, 2018; Ghazali & Yasuoka, 2018; Owen, et al., 2019; Rosavina, et al. 2019; Goo and Heo, 2020; Ahern, 2021; Zarrouk et al., 2021; Makki and Alqahtani, 2022; Ng and Pan, 2022) that the government policies and support are linked to the greater levels of adoption of Fintech financing. Aligning Fintech decisions with governmental laws and policies significantly influences adoption (Dwivedi et al., 2021; Ng and Pan, 2022). Most SMEs have their legal department to work on the lawful aspects and adherence to rules, regulations and standards to practice in the sector. Therefore, CEOs ensure they comply with government laws and regulations to avoid legal consequences for non-compliance. The CEOs should collaborate and align Fintech decisions with governmental rules and ensure they address all privacy issues, possible threats, and customer protection (Takeda & Ito, 2021).

Another practical implication of the results of this study is that they can be used to improve awareness about Fintech services to enable SMEs to leverage benefits associated with the technology. Lack of Fintech awareness was a notable reason CEOs indicated for opting for traditional financial services. As such, Fintech companies and other stakeholders can improve awareness about Fintech to support its adoption. CEOs' Fintech competencies can be

enhanced through training and education, which has been proven to increase Fintech adoption (Niu et al., 2020).

One of the reasons for the SME CEOs' preference for Fintech was the increasing demand and challenges associated with traditional financing options. Fintech options can be used to address the challenges associated with traditional financing options. For example, Fintech services enhance the customer experience and enable firms to build and maintain competitive advantage, lower costs, minimise risks, and increase efficiency (Restoy, 2020; Martinčević et al., 2020; Alkhawaldeh et al., 2023). Therefore, Fintech options can be used as alternative practical approaches for addressing SMEs' financial challenges associated with traditional financing methods.

According to Kvasov et al. (2021), experts play a crucial role in Fintech decision-making. At the meso level, CEOs' professional network within the organisational culture and outside through professional membership increases their Fintech knowledge and influences their funding choice. However, the current study confirms that CEOs are willing to be part of professional networking if it solely rates FinTech. Due to the lack of professional networking opportunities in England, CEOs have barriers to having sufficient knowledge to make FinTech decisions. SME CEOs can, therefore, improve their Fintech decisions by forming professional networks to share their expertise and emerging knowledge about Fintech developments.

Globally, SMEs represent 90% of businesses and contribute over 50% of employment opportunities (Sharma, et al., 2023). SMEs contributed approximately 50% to the global gross domestic product opportunities (Sharma, et al., 2023). Considering the significant contribution of SMEs to the countries and global economy, there is a need to optimise their operations and address the associated challenges. SMEs can leverage benefits related to Fintech, such as improved access to cost-effective, scalable, stable, reliable, and innovative financial options (Suryono et al., 2020; Kumari & Devi, 2022). However, unlike large enterprises, there is low adoption of digital technologies such as Fintech in SMEs (Moreira-Santos, et al., 2022). The study's findings on challenges impeding Fintech adoption in SMEs, including limited awareness of associated benefits and insufficient information and policies that limit decision-

making, can be used to improve its adoption. Fintech firms should create awareness among SMEs of the available risk mitigation strategies and their effectiveness to improve their adoption. Fintech firms should also conduct regular assessments to understand SMEs' preferences and the unique challenges they face to facilitate prompt measures to address their concerns.

SMEs can adopt Fintech options to improve their financial viability. Cost savings, fewer regulations and more funding options accelerate SMEs' preference for Fintech financing. More funding options through Fintech can also help SMEs evaluate various financing platforms. For example, through crowdfunding, P2P and cryptocurrency, SMEs can get funding ideas for any financing needs by analysing funding data through various Fintech financing platforms. This will enable them to be better positioned for short- and long-term financial decisions. On the other hand, Fintech companies should conduct a survey and research in the market and industry to determine the rising demands and financing needs to attract SMEs so they can resolve their financing needs. Fintech financing providers can also arrange workshops to educate their clients on the benefits, advantages, effectiveness, accuracy, and convenience of using and applying digital solutions in the market. These funding providers can use social media for Fintech campaigns. This will improve their product awareness through customer engagement and marketing, increasing their chances of success. Social media has become the most significant communication tool for Fintech companies to attract SMEs. This is because millions of users worldwide interact with their friends and family through mobile-friendly social media applications. DenizBank in Turkey and Amex worldwide have integrated Facebook and bank accounts to run all their online financial services (FinTech Futures, 2018). Similarly, banks can use Fintech features in their services to provide improved solutions for SMEs.

6.2.3. Contribution to Policies

The findings of this study can also be used to inform policy changes about government laws and regulations on Fintech technologies. Some CEOs indicated that some government laws and regulations about Fintech impede their financial decisions. This finding calls for a more favourable and fairer legal environment that supports SMEs' adoption and use of FinTech technologies. For example, the government can develop laws and regulations that give more freedom and protection to SMEs regarding the adoption and use of Fintech technologies while not compromising other crucial implications, such as security and fraudulent activities. Through policies and regulations, government support can enhance the development of favourable Fintech ecosystems through regulatory sandboxes, legislation, infrastructure development, and regulations promoting Fintech services (Nugraha, et al., 2022). Widespread adoption of Fintech technologies requires regulatory support and consistent policies to ensure the security and privacy of financial transactions (Moreira-Santos et al., 2022; Rehman et al., 2023). As such, the government should develop laws and regulations that balance the potential benefits of Fintech technologies and associated threats.

To promote knowledge and expertise, the government can establish a financial innovation hub that could bring experts from financial and non-financial sectors and countries to promote UK Fintech. The proposed financial innovation hub should have a membership for SME CEOs to establish professional networking opportunities and an education support service to guide them practically on Fintech and further laws and regulatory guidance to streamline their Fintech-related decisions and organisational compliance. Lastly, even though the IMF and World Bank endorsed the financing through Fintech, the fact that cyberattacks have increased on Fintech firms can't be ignored. There is a need for a discussion involving participants from experts from the legal, IT industry, financing and Fintech institutions to introduce measurements to prevent cyberattacks.

6.3. Limitations

The research has several limitations because it is based only in England and the UK. Results could be generalised to other parts of the world but with caveat because rules, regulations, and laws are different as the sample is taken based on the participant recruitment criteria in which an SME from the non-financial sector should be established under the Companies House Act in the UK. Therefore, we must consider the Article of Association of how the organisation should govern and operate under a set of rules per the Companies House Act 2006. These incorporation rules may be different to the other parts of the world. The other participant recruitment criteria include getting the views and opinions of working CEOs in SMEs. These SMEs are more than a year old and contain at least two people. A slight change in the participant recruitment criteria may bring a different outcome. The study has a sufficient sample size due to the nature of the research methodology to get a detailed description of CEO factors for their financing preferences and how these factors influence their Fintech financing decisions. As such, the findings of this study are limited to working SMEs and may not be generalised to those who have already worked and have a wealth of knowledge to provide detailed insights due to their experience. The number of participants can be extended to enhance the research scope, including their location in other parts of the UK and overseas. Other limitations are that the research is qualitative which may include the potential bias with the interview data, and as an interviewer, the researcher's value and interpretation of the CEO's opinions may be reflected in the study. The researcher ensured to work within the ethical guidelines and analysed the CEOs' views and opinions of their financing preferences to report unbiased results.

6.4. Reflection

First, I would like to start with the Covid-19 pandemic which was the most challenging period. Despite the intense preventive measures, the researcher was affected twice with Covid-19 in 2020 and 2021. It affected the researcher's memory for a shorter period of time. However,

frequent online meetings with the supervisor helped the researcher's motivation and concentration during the recovery period. Second, while interviewing the participants, specific valuable insights emerged that were not explicitly conveyed in their responses to the interview questions. These subtle insights provided a deeper understanding of the participants' thoughts, opinions, perceptions, emotions, and motivations regarding different aspects of Fintech. For example, through observation during the interviews, it was apparent that the participants were optimistic about the impacts of Fintech financial services. Participants' optimism was evident in their body language and enthusiasm as they discussed different aspects of Fintech, including its potential and anticipated positive impacts of their decisions. In addition, from their personal views, some participants expressed how Fintech had improved their financial situations, underscoring their optimistic perspective on the sector.

From the interviewing questions, it was found that CEOs are very educated and have a wealth of experience. They have busy schedules and holding them at a certain time for a volunteer interview was very difficult. Their answers were to the point, and they avoided over-justifying their views, sometimes used complex business terms which could have various meanings for an interpreter, and avoided releasing their personal story for micro and meso questions where they felt their answers could compromise their personal and organisational confidentiality. The researcher understood that their position in the organisation was not equal to those participants who had an exploratory storyline to tell of each question. However, from their listening skills, how they responded to interview questions, and the compliments provided to probing questions, most participants indicated their great interest in the topic of their decision-making factors for the Fintech financing. Also, participants' interest was evident in their eagerness to engage in discussion. CEOs' curiosity and desire to deepen their understanding of the factors in their decision-making for the Fintech options demonstrated their genuine interest in the research.

6.5. Further Research Agenda

The recommendations made are based on the findings obtained in this study. The research has already reported a significant contribution to the theory, practices, and policies about the CEOs' financing preferences and the contributing factors that influence their Fintech financing decisions. However, it is not known whether their financing preference supports the pecking order theory of financing or the trade-off theory of financing. In these theories, SMEs choose debt or equity, equity over debt or debt over equity, or a combination of debt and equity. What is its sequence, and how is it related to the pecking order or the trade-off theory of financing? For this purpose, the researcher can take the evidence relating to the dates of the actual Fintech Financing decisions by CEOs, the company's financial strategy of what they prefer (debt/equity or both) and historical financial records.

Second, the same research can also be extended by collecting evidence relating to one or more Fintech financing options. It can be P2P, Crowdfunding or Cryptocurrency. For example, the potential research could be the impact of CEOs on Fintech Financing: Evidence from P2P on UK SMEs. In this case, the researchers will have to amend the participant recruitment criteria to include only CEOs using the same Fintech option.

Third, the same research can also be sector-specific in SMEs. For example, potential researchers can find relevant non-financial sectors such as construction, health care, education, manufacturing, or even technology. In this case, the researchers will have to include one more participant recruitment requirement criteria relating to the sector. For example, the potential research could be the impact of CEOs on Fintech Financing: Evidence from UK manufacturing SMEs. In addition, this study did not compare data between participants from rural and urban SMEs. According to Nugraha et al. (2022), a significant gap exists in Fintech adoption among SME businesses in rural and urban locations. As such, it is recommended that future researchers compare if there are differences in how micro, meso, and macro factors influence CEOs' Fintech financial decisions in rural and urban SMEs. In this

case, there will be a slight change in the participant recruitment criteria while everything else will remain the same.

Fourth, further research should be conducted to obtain empirical evidence on the relationship between CEOs' perception of adopting FinTech financing and the factors that affect their intentions such as (not an exhaustive list) personal beliefs, alignment with policies and regulations, advantages, networking, and superiority over traditional methods. For example, a quantitative methodology with quasi-experimental designs can be conducted to determine the relationship using statistical means such as regression analysis. Future researchers can distinguish the difference between SMEs who use FinTech and those who apply traditional financing on factors such as customer satisfaction based on speed, accuracy, and efficiency. An analysis of variance (ANOVA) or independent t-test for new adopters can be applied to ascertain if there is a statistically significant difference between traditional and Fintech solutions. Future researchers could assess the impact of knowledge on the adoption and usage of FinTech solutions in an empirical or mixed-method study to establish if creating awareness of digital solutions can impact the decisions of entrepreneurs. Specifically, considering the associated benefits, it is recommended that future researchers should explore how Fintech financing options can be sustained in SMEs. Future studies on financial performance and efficiency between Fintech and traditional financing are also recommended to facilitate a holistic understanding of the best options for different financial decisions facing SMEs. Through a holistic comparison of Fintech and traditional funding, SME CEOs can make informed decisions about other financial options that optimise the best interest of their businesses.

Additionally, the benefits associated with FinTech include enhanced customer experience, building and maintaining competitive advantage, lowered costs, minimised risks, and increased efficiency (Martinčević et al., 2020; Restoy, 2020). Besides the associated benefits, Fintech can create risks such as data privacy issues, cybersecurity threats, and regulation uncertainties (Jawarneh, et al., 2023). As such, there is a need to explore SME CEO's understanding of Fintech's potential challenges and risks. There is a need for understanding

strategies specific to SMEs that can be used to mitigate Fintech risks and address associated challenges. Therefore, future research on SME CEOs' awareness of Fintech risks and challenges and potential mitigation strategies based on their experience is recommended. Such understanding will form a basis for developing appropriate strategies and approaches to address underlying Fintech challenges and risks to improve its adoption in SMEs. According to Thomas (2023), financial and economic crises have always negatively affected SMEs' availability of financing options. Researchers could also explore feasible and effective approaches that CEOs use to overcome financial challenges associated with economic and financial crises. Those approaches would help novice SME CEOs and other business leaders ensure businesses' sustainability in times of crisis.

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8. Appendices

Appendix 1 – Sources for funds for SMEs

Type	Sources	Characteristics
Internal	Owner's investment	This is an investment which comes from the owner's own savings. It has a main advantage of no interest.
	Friends and Family	This type of finance is arranged through friends or family savings. SMEs can agree time frame to pay back funds with additional financial benefits or it can be retained as an equity if friends or family member invest in a business as an investment or for the purpose of partnership or ownership.
	Retained Earning	This is an earning after profit (usually happens after one year of successful trading) that can be used as an investment back for business growth. It has a main advantage of no interest
	Sales of stock	SMEs can sell their unsold stock and inject money to the business growth. By selling off stock, the company reduce its cost of holding unnecessary stock.
	Assets financing	SMEs can sell its unused or surplus machinery to raise finance. It helps in reduction of maintenance cost and space.
External	Bank finance	SMEs can raise funds by agreeing to bank terms of loan including interest rate. Organisations normally pay back loan in monthly instalments over an agreed period (short or long-term) which is good for budgeting. Business loans are secured and unsecured. In the secured business loans, borrowers put some collateral such as house while unsecured business loans are offered based on credit history.
External	Crowdfunding	Crowdfunding lending is a FinTech help to raise funds from a group of individuals such as investors. Investors earn return on their investment.
	P2P Lending	Peer to Peer lending is one of the applications of the FinTech to unite lenders and borrowers in online platforms to offer the financial solutions.
	Cryptocurrency	Money is raised through digital currencies which operates on blockchain - a digital ledger for a secure transaction to gain borderless financing access.

Appendix 2 – Fintech development in the UK and EU

In the UK, there are around 788 high grown FinTech companies, out of which 71% companies operate from London (Michel, 2019). In 2017, around £2 billion was raised by FinTech Companies and they are continuing to grow (Michel, 2019). According to standard industrial classification, FinTech includes different sectors and industries such as retail, education, fundraising, non-profit and the only few are classified as Banks. Companies like Visa, MasterCard, PayPal, and Stripe all revolutionised the payment systems in the UK. Small and medium sized companies are adopting new opportunities and models as opposed to traditional facilities provided by high-street banks. These enterprises are using FinTech for payment and lending. More consumers are securing financial services for free or at low cost. According to Bloomberg Intelligence report of emerging FinTech markets, the adoption rate of FinTech amongst consumers in the United Kingdom is 42% after China and India. This adoption rate is higher than any EU countries such as Spain 37% and Germany 35% (Bloomberg News, 2019) . In the UK, around \$16 billion were invested on FinTech in 2018 and it is likely to grow in the subsequent years (Warner, 2018). The same trends are evident in the EU where businesses have invested \$22 billion in 2017 and \$57 billion in 2018 (KPMG, 2018).

Appendix 3 – Fintech development in the USA

FinTech revolution is a global movement in this new digital age and its impact have been seen in the United States over the years. It encompasses the introduction of FinTech in start-ups, small businesses and large financial institutions to integrate new technology in their existing services to remain competitive. FinTech is growing in the USA due to its competitive models, great customer experiences and less regulations. The adoption rate of FinTech in the United States consumers is 33% as per Bloomberg Intelligence report published in 2019. According to the Business insider report, FinTech secured \$59 billion only in the first quarter of 2018 as compared 2015 (\$59 billions), a target set in 2015 (Nonninger, 2019). SBI Holdings, Standard Chartered and BB&T are the biggest investors to revolutionise the FinTech. FinTech firms are growing faster in the USA and they have attracted over \$12 billion of investment in 2014 and \$4 billion in 2013. The same trends are seen in the period 2015-18. For example, the US most prominent Firms in FinTech like US insurtech Root, US pay check, advance FinTech Earnin and Coinbase have raised over \$100 million in 2018. The main reasons for these revolutions in the USA are the quality of financial services, efficiency, low cost, legacy of IT systems, unburden financial regulations and the public confidence (Economist, 2015). It is more likely that more firms in the future will get benefits by engaging with FinTech in different sectors (Nonninger, 2019).

Appendix 4 – Fintech development in the ASIA

Asian market seems to be more prominent market to adopt FinTech. When it comes to the innovation in Asia, the world has evident that the China is one step ahead from the rest of the world with 69% adoption rate by Chinese (Delacharlerie, 2018). FinTech is the biggest to the financial service providers in the ASIA. The revolution in the Asia started in 2004, when Alibaba adopted this technology in its platform with Alipay (a PayPal type service) to facilitate financial transactions through its e-commerce platforms. After initial success, Alibaba started to lend, provide insurance and micro-financing services. Other Tech giants like Baidu and Tencent also use Blockchain in the similar fashion as Alibaba.

According to (Bloomberg News, 2019), Indian market is also one of the earlier adopters of FinTech services in Asia with 52% adoption rate after China. In 2016, India has introduced the concept of digital banking, a new model of the traditional banking, for example, Paytm. Paytm in India use Alibaba backed mobile block chain payment solutions which has achieved the status of the bank with a facility to accept restricted deposit and introduction of banking touchpoints. Touchpoints are web-based interfaces or it can be a mobile application with integration of organisation services to facilitate consumers with its products and services. It is also used to collect feedback. Alipay, Tenpay, Chinapay, UnionPay, QQ Wallet, Redpocket products have revolutionised the Asian market. Their market shares are more than 66% in the digital payment systems and many financial institutions have started to integrate these FinTech facilities in their products and services. Hong Kong's FinTech investment was doubled in 2017 which was \$546 million as compared to \$216 million that is significantly higher than investments in Australia (\$321 millions), Singapore (\$180 million) and Japan (\$105 million).

The reasons why ASIA market is more prominent to adopt FinTech are friendly government policies of ecosystems, less financial regulatory requirements and more consumers' inclination to use user friendly IT interfaces. Other reasons are FinTech companies target low-income consumers in Asian countries with their convenient, low-cost, and well-interconnected financial solutions such as savings, payment and lending as compared to traditional banks. This has been evident from the recent survey by EY Global FinTech Adoption Index in 2019 which considered 27000 digitally active consumers in 27 markets to identify international consumers' adoption rate and results showed that Asia is a global leader in FinTech adoption (EY, 2019).

Appendix 5 – Fintech development in Rest of the world

The global trend of FinTech adoption and investments on FinTech has increased over the years. According to (Statista Research Department, 2019) which is a leading provider of market and consumer data, the last year FinTech investment was eight billion U.S. dollars as compared to three billion U.S. dollars in 2013. FinTech adoption rate amongst consumers from other part of the world has increased significant, for example, Brazil is now the fourth largest country of early adopters of FinTech after China, India and UK with 40% share of users who are active online, Mexico 36% and South Africa 35% (Bloomberg News, 2019).

In Brazil, the central bank aims to encourage new technology and innovation in the tradition financial services by allowing Peer to Peer Lending and Direct Credit to Borrowers to target almost 35% adults' population who have never used bank accounts as a new way to deliver financial services to them. The growth of FinTech companies in Brazil has increased in the last decade in lending, investment, payment, insurance, trade in cryptocurrencies and it is anticipated that FinTech companies will generate \$24 billion in the next decade (TMF Group, 2018).

The same sentiment is evident in Mexico where approximately 37% of Mexican have access to an official bank accounts (World Bank, 2018) while unbanked consumers and SMEs are main targets of FinTech. It is also worth to mention that \$89 million round were raised in 2017 by FinTech Konfio in Mexico.

According (Finnovista, 2018), statistics of FinTech in Latin America in 2018 was 51% in Brazil, 40% in Mexico, 52% in Colombia, 56% in Argentina and 22% in Chile which significant higher than previous years. Apart from Latin America, FinTech market in the other part of the world such as Africa is generating \$200 million, and it is likely to grow up to \$3 billion by 2020 as per EcoBank – a leading independent pan-African banking group. Jumo is a leading a mobile platform to provide credits and savings has served over 25 million consumers in Africa and generated over \$700 million (Reuters, 2018). Tulaa, Ecocash, Zoon, and Cellulant are most prominent FinTech companies in African countries (Tsan, et al., 2019) to disrupt financial industry with their efficient and effective low-cost financial services to consumers.

Appendix 6 – Types of crowdfunding

There are different crowdfunding options for individuals, investors and businesses. Each type has its own unique features, benefits and rights to parties involved.

Equity based Crowdfunding

The equity-based crowdfunding market in the UK, as of 2015, was valued at approximately £332 million (Adhikary, et al., 2018). In terms of size, P2P lending is larger than equity-based crowdfunding market in the UK. However, the market has recorded significant growth of approximately 300 per cent between 2014 and 2015 and the UK has the fastest growing equity-based crowdfunding market in Europe (Zhang, et al., 2015). The first equity-based crowdfunding platform developed in the UK was Crowd cube; launched in 2011. However, the first platform of equity-based crowdfunding to be regulated by the FCA was Seedrs. The research in the UK indicates that the majority of the equity-based crowdfunding financing for the SMEs in the UK have occurred at the seed stage (British Business Bank, 2015)). The above finding indicates that online equity-based crowdfunding offers an alternative to the traditional seed-stage capital that has been sourced from personal savings and loans from friends and families. The market also covers early stages as well as start-up, with some business angel investors choosing to invest in the SMEs in the UK through the online platforms. An example of an equity-based crowdfunding platform that particularly targets the angel investors is the Syndicate Room; thus, the financing is more relevant to the innovative SMEs that have high growth potential.

Equity-based crowdfunding is mostly used by the SMEs in the UK for capital expansion, start-up or seed capital; an indication of the breaking of the pecking order theory of funding preferences (Baeck, et al., 2014). The theory holds that SMEs would traditionally prefer internal financing from family, friends and founders before the SMEs can even consider the use of external financing. In the traditional sense of SME financing, the SMEs would first make use of loans from the banks before they can even consider the use of equity. Since equity-based crowdfunding uses a distinct model from the established equity market (Brown, et al., 2015), it requires less information from the SMEs and little time in the contract negotiations (Macht & Weatherston, 2014). Since the financing model focuses on financing the SMEs from the crowd, the individual investors from the crowd do not have a big stake that can allow a single investor to exert control on the SME's management.

The UK SMEs have been attracted to the equity-based crowdfunding as it allows the firms to obtain financing more quickly without reducing their autonomy or ownership stake. Therefore, it offers a bridge for the SMEs, especially the firms that have high growth potential and are still in their infancy (Baeck, et al., 2014). The main advantages for the equity crowdfunding for the

financing of the SMEs in the UK include online access, less dilution of the company in terms of limited changes to the ownership structure, as well as the speed of access to the financing and the potential to overcome regional barriers to information access. However, despite such advantages, there also exist some disadvantages, such as low business awareness of the available crowdfunding companies.

Loan based Crowd funding

In this type of crowdfunding, fundraisers follow lending based funding model. Instead of going to the financial institution, they borrow money from peoples by using crowd funding platforms (Adhikary, et al., 2018). The main benefits of investors are the financial interests on their investment.

Reward Crowd funding

There are many purposes of reward-based crowd funding, for example, it is used for invention, software development, research, and projects. In this type of crowd funding, fundraisers offer rewards (Gupta, 2018) in the share of voucher, gift or an event ticket to investors. Vemagnet, Kickstarter and Indiegogo are examples of reward crowdfunding in the UK for SMEs.

Donation Crowd funding

In this type of crowd funding, fundraises are mostly charities or individuals collect funds for specific charitable causes (Gupta, 2018). JustGiving and Kickstarter are most commonly platforms for donation crowdfunding.

Pre-order Crowd funding

In this type of crowd funding, fundraisers collect funds for projects that are still in the process and allow investors to fund for pre-order a product or service for later delivery (Van Looy, 2016). Kickstarter and Indiegogo are platforms for pre-order crowdfunding.

SME in the UK can raise funds through above crowdfunding platforms to revamp their businesses by injecting the needed capital to improve the business operations. Equity-based crowdfunding is a method used to raise money for small businesses to expand their businesses. An investor will receive a certain percentage of equity invested in a given company as a return on investment. The contribution made is in the form of equity to the

business that sought the funding (Chu, et al., 2017). Crowdfunding can be in form of Loan-based crowdfunding. The contribution is made by the investors and the money is lent out to a business just like a bank loan for start-up or expansion. This method of funding is faster as compared to bank process of accessing funds. It also creates awareness on the untapped funding resources available in the economy depicted through the voluntary contributions. Crowdfunding can be riskier in the case of equity-based funding or loan-based funding especially for start-up businesses since the money invested might not be ploughed back.

Appendix 7 - The impact of Fintech on financial services from traditional banking perspectives

The use of Technology and Social Media

Information Technology is so much embedded in our daily life that it has been impossible to live without technology these days. The main triggers of FinTech are the excessive use of technology, communication systems and less regulations in this digital world (Thornton & Stone, 1992) to deliver financial services (Natarajan, et al., 2017). The challenges experienced during the global financial crisis were addressed by FinTech. The e-commerce platforms came up to offer convenience to customers while performing online purchase needs. Barclaycard developed a contactless payment solution in 2007 to enable the customers to get contactless credit cards in the UK (Goldfinch, 2018). Bitcoin was developed in 2009 as a new digital currency solution. In 2013, google introduced a google wallet that allowed the customers to perform transactions through mobile phones using the near-field communication technology. FinTech has developed a new way for financial transaction and management through platforms such as online banking, automated payment platforms, smartphones payment solutions, and online trading sites.

Social media has become the most significant communication tool by Fintech companies to attract and market its customers in the 21st century. It is because there are millions of users around the world interacting with their friends and family through mobile friendly social media applications. DenizBank in Turkey and Amex worldwide have integrated Facebook and bank accounts to run their entire online financial services (FinTech Futures, 2018). Now, the Facebook is working with three FinTech companies to launch mobile payment services in South Asian countries where it has more than 100 million users (Reuters, 2020).

Companies have started to provide their products and services online to their customers and they are spending a lot to attract customers from all over the world in this digital global age. Due to Coronavirus outbreak in the world, the use of social media has increased in the UK and Europe as compared to previous years (Johnson, 2020). Social media such as Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn and many more provide social interactive platforms to people to interact with buy and sell options. Social media is a place to connect people with features to share posts, ideas, pictures and transform customer-to-customer and customer-to-business relationship. People share ideas with each other's, compliment or complain against the products and services offered by companies. Companies such as Olarisbank, Citibank, NatWest and American Express are using social media to spread news, updates, links, and tweets to influence customers. In the social media, Fintech Marketing has become popular these days. Marketing experts from Banks use social media platforms and applications to

analyse customer behaviours and trends with their customer engaging and product selling strategies. That not only increase sales but also provide a competitive advantage to maintain their customers' satisfaction. These days UK' Barclays, US Bank of America, HSBC, Santander and Germany's Deutsche Bank have their own downloadable apps, Facebook and twitter accounts to collect feedback from customers, analyse their behaviour and then market their products and services to them.

Now people from all over the world have access to high-speed Computers, Android and Apple mobiles, a technology which was not available a decade ago. Customers can download Mobile applications and make/lend payments. In the recently report published by (eMarketer, 2018), there are estimated 2.55 billion users use social media and mobile applications and due to this, mobile commerce is estimated to reach \$278.9 billion in 2018. These applications get customers data and key information such as salary, job, buying preferences and education history to be used by FinTech companies to analyse customers' preferences, behaviours, likes/dislikes and future needs and then by using social media platform they promote their services to them. It is also anticipated that the global social networking users will grow more than 3 billion in 2020 (Abrams, 2019). Small businesses, Lending Club and Prosper user online and social media as a core marketing channels. Banks such as Barclays and Rakuten introduced new way of payments routes using Facebook and Twitter.

Platforms such as Dwolla, Fastacash and Wraps have enabled opportunities to customers to give and take money from friends and relative using social media. Facebook peer to peer payment enables friends to exchange money via Facebook message app. On the other hands, application like Venmo is integrated to bigger platform with payment integrated features to pay and lend money features which is same as sharing photos. Small businesses use these technologies to facilitate customers' life in the 21st Century.

Payment and Lending Innovation and its importance to the society

FinTech has become a threat to the financial services systems in the UK. It creates better and efficient products and services for customers, offers competitive pricing, targets untouched geographical locations, improve customers' satisfaction and experience, and use innovative solutions to meet customers' demands.

Technological advancement such as Automated Teller Machine, mobile and online banking, and application payment have enhanced customers' satisfaction and experience in the lending and payment systems. FinTech is automated financial service with an innovation to address customers' needs. FinTech has a key advantage of being a non-regulated as compared to traditional financial organisations. Due to advancement in Information Technology, FinTech systems and processes are more efficient to provide on spot or faster solutions to customers.

Financial service sectors believe the FinTech as an unavoidable a threat to their market share. To cope with this threat and to remain relevant in their target market, they have started to include FinTech features in its products and services. Companies in financial service sectors such as banks are making FinTech partners without relying on heavy investments to overcome their existing hurdles. For example, in 2018, Barclays (UK) bank which has a history of 325 years, become a key partner with an EU leading FinTech business MarketInvoice so that Barclay's SME's clients will use MarketInvoice online invoicing platform to manage their cash flow and growth. In 2014, Santander Bank allocated \$100 million funds in FinTech to meet its 107 million individual customers and \$3 million corporate customers worldwide.

In 2017, HSBC UK has partnered with FinTech Buds to provide an integrated selection of financial services to its individual and corporate customers. This shows that Fintech has started to show its strength, relevance and impact in the society. Now in the UK, all financial institutions and other financial service providers are providing services such as online, mobile banking and same trends is going on in the emerging economies. These trends are new and will continue to grow with more features. In 2018, UK banks and financial technology firms have launched a toolkit to develop partnership with sponsorship from the government-backed Fintech Delivery Panel as part of HM Treasury's Fintech Sector Strategy. That toolkit will help partner organisations to identify key issues and resolve them in line with applicable legislation and according to customers' requirements.

In 2019, smartphone, Apple Pay, Mobile banking and raising money for specific needs via crowdfunding has grown a lot as compared to last few years.

Reshaping Financial Service Sector and Regulations

Financial sector executives believe that consumer and commercial banking are disrupted by FinTech. Banks feel threats in their market shares, sales, customers' preferences, and information security/privacy. These financial institutions are still in their early stage of innovation as compared to what FinTech proposes. It is because FinTech are offering flexible Peer to Peer marketplaces to its customers to secure loan even with no or poor credit history, personal financial management tools and platforms like crowdfunding to raise money. To deal with threats of FinTech, banks have started to use software solutions offered by FinTech which are easily integrated by application program interfaces (API). API enables financial institutions to develop interactive and value-added solutions in the banking platforms.

Other triggers are introduction of new regulations for financial institutions to remain solvent, capital regulations, and many structural reforms (Nicoletti, 2017). Further, the governments initiated several bail out measures to keep the industry afloat (Hanna, 2019). Banks were reluctant to lend out money to the customers by coming up with stringent precautionary tactics.

The banks were on recovery plans and compliance with the statutory and regulatory requirements and they never wanted to initiate any change to their system of operation. FinTech capitalised on the gap created by the reluctance of the banks by developing a responsive financial platform created on the internet to offer an interactive, faster and cheaper access to financial services to the customers (Goldfinch, 2018). The need for a safer financial solution was on demand. FinTech entirely disrupted the traditional financial service models. The financial intermediaries were completely removed by the FinTech's robust revolution in the financial industry.

FinTech put the benchmark at higher levels. These days FinTech is an industry made up of organisations that use technology with efficient processes, attract customers with innovative techniques to provide financial solutions (Nicoletti, 2017). Banks realised the ever-growing acceptance rate of the financial technology service models to initiate a catch-up approach to remain relevant in the provision of the financial services.

Changing Consumer Behaviour

FinTech gained popularity after the financial recession period because of the widespread mistrust in the banks after the financial crisis. For example, customers especially young generation started to have less faith due to rationale that if the financial institutions are unable to cope in managing risks so how can advise them for services and savings (Nicoletti, 2017).

FinTech has been expeditiously cruising into financial marketplaces and filling the product gaps (Koenigsberg, 2017) left by financial institutions, substantially enhancing the users' satisfaction. The massive progress of internet usage across the globe has created a profound basis for FinTech companies in the foreseeable future (Desai, 2015). FinTech is perceived to have improved by creating new features that help clients in solving obstacles and challenges, particularly, relating to financing matters. For example, PayPal was a typical example in financial technology companies, laden with innovative measures such as changing the form of transactions and also the management of funds (Dudkowski, et al., 2016).

FinTech products and services have immensely influenced customers' behaviour in relation to managing personal finance, savings, investment, wealth management, and mortgage, insurance and so on. People around the world use mobile apps to provide efficient and cost-effective payments services to customers and businesses without relying on cheques or ATM withdrawal options. New era of Fintech is still growing with services of digital currency, invoice trading and real-time payments. It is because people found that new financial technologies are easier to use, secure, quick and effective.

FinTech today has changed financial world through innovative financial technologies dramatically, from finance and investment via alternative finance such as peer to peer lending, crowdfunding and cryptocurrency.

Appendix 8- Research Questions and Interview Questions

RQ 2 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs perceive the influence of micro-level factors, such as personal leadership traits, vision and risk-taking attitude on their Fintech financing decisions? Interview Questions:	
Definition of Fintech: Fintech is innovation in finance due to technology providing financing through P2P, Crowdfunding, Cryptocurrency, etc., rather than relying on banks.	
1.1. How do personal leadership attributes affect CEOs making Fintech financing decisions?	
1.1.1. What do you think about your personal leadership attributes? How do you think your leadership attributes contribute to your fintech financing decisions? Why?	
1.1.2 What do you think about your vision? How do you think vision will affect you in making FinTech Financing decisions? If they are relevant, how?	
1.2. How do personal values, family, and beliefs affect CEOs' decisions to make Fintech financing?	
1.2.1 What is your opinion about Fintech decisions guided by your values? How do your values affect your Fintech financing decisions?	
1.2.2. What are your personal beliefs? How do your beliefs impact your Fintech financing decision? Only if it matters.	
1.2.3 What do you think about your family members' contribution towards your FinTech financing decisions? How would you like to explore the impact of family and its role to influence your FinTech financing decisions?	

<Ask example?>	
1.3. How does educational expertise affect CEOs making Fintech financing decisions?	
Does education affect your FinTech financing decision making? How can it affect and probably influence your fintech financing decisions? Can you explore this?	
1.4. How does experience affect CEOs making Fintech financing decisions?	
Do you have any experience using FinTech? How do your experiences influence your FinTech financing decisions? Can you explore this?	
1.5. How does the risk-taking attitude of CEOs affect them in making Fintech financing decisions?	
What is your risk-taking attitude? Do you think you are a risk taker or risk avoider? How can your risk-taker or avoider approach affect your Fintech financing decisions? Do you think your approach has (positive/negative or any) impact on your company? Why?	
RQ 3 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs make their decisions on Fintech financing through professional networking, board of directors and organisational structure contexts at the meso level? Interview Questions:	
2.1. How do your professional networks affect your Fintech financing decisions?	
What is your professional networking involved? How does your professional networking affect and contribute to your FinTech Financing decision? <Explain>	

2.2. How does the board of directors affect CEOs making Fintech financing decisions?	
Do you have a board in your company? Are you a part of that Board? Do you make collective decisions? How many executives and non-executives (directors or senior officers) work in your company? Do you enjoy working with other board members? If yes, how the board influence your fintech financing decisions?	
2.3. How does organisational structure affect CEOs making Fintech financing decisions?	
<i>[The following question is related to your company/organisation where different people work in different departments]</i> What is the size of your company? Do you have a number of departments in your company? (line of accountability) Are you all sitting in the same floor to work together? Is your organisation structure complex e.g. whether you have number of departments? How can you explore your organisation structure to facilitate the flow of information for CEO to make FinTech financing decisions? How does the flow of information affect your organisation to accept change? Does it influence your Fintech financing decisions? If it does not influence you, then what are the barriers? Do you think the complex organisation structure could deter FinTech financing?	
RQ 4 - How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate the complexities of macro-level factors, including government support and laws, when making Fintech financing decisions?	
Interview Questions: How do government policies affect CEOs making Fintech financing decisions?	
Do you follow up with the government policies frequently to help you make financing decisions? What is the impact of government support and its policies on your FinTech financing decisions? Do you think the government is supportive to SMEs (small and medium enterprises/companies) in Fintech financing? Up to which level? How does it contribute to your fintech financing decisions? What is your opinion about the role of the government in creating awareness of FinTech Financing? How do you think UK laws facilitate FinTech financing?	
RQ 1 – How do CEOs of UK SMEs navigate their financing choices in the context of a rapidly evolving economic and financial technology environment?	
Interview Questions:	

What are your financing preferences in the current economic environment, for example, traditional financing or Fintech financing? Why? How do you explore the fitness of your preference and its relation to the current digital age and economic situation? how or why? What factors would encourage your business to adopt Fintech financing? What factors, if any, are preventing your business from using Fintech financing?	
Do you want to add anything relating to the current situation e.g. COVID-19 which may affect you making Fintech decisions?	

Appendix 9 – Research Ethics Approval

1451174 - Ethics decision

Kucharska, Agnieszka <Agnieszka.Kucharska@aru.ac.uk>

on behalf of

BL Ethics <BL-ethics@aru.ac.uk>

Fri 12/02/2021 17:29

To: Iqbal, Arsalan (Postgraduate Researcher) <MAI149@pgr.aru.ac.uk>

Cc: Wang, Ying <Ying.Wang@aru.ac.uk>

Dear Muhammad,

I am pleased to inform you that your ethics application has been **approved with amendments** by the School Research Ethics Panel (SREP) under the terms of Anglia Ruskin University's Research Ethics Policy (Dated 8 September 2016, Version 1.7). Approval was ratified by FREP.

Please action the points below and submit to your academic supervisor for them to review:

- ***Gatekeeper letter needs to be submitted***

Ethical approval is given for a period of 1 year for undergraduate/masters students or 3 years for doctorate students and staff from the date of this letter.

It is your responsibility to ensure that you comply with Anglia Ruskin University's Research Ethics Policy and the Code of Practice for Applying for Ethical Approval at Anglia Ruskin University available at www.anglia.ac.uk/researchethics including the following.

- The procedure for submitting substantial amendments to the committee, should there be any changes to your research. You cannot implement these amendments until you have received approval from SREP for them.
- The procedure for reporting accidents, adverse events and incidents.
- The General Data Protection Requirement and Data Protection Act (2018).
- Any other legislation relevant to your research. You must also ensure that you are aware of any emerging legislation relating to your research and make any changes to your study (which you will need to obtain ethical approval for) to comply with this.
- Obtaining any further ethical approval required from the organisation or country (if not carrying out research in the UK) where you will be carrying the research out. This includes other Higher Education Institutions if you intend to carry out any research involving their students, staff or premises. Please ensure that you send the SREP copies of this documentation if required, prior to starting your research.
- Any laws of the country where you are carrying the research and obtaining any other approvals or permissions that are required.
- Any professional codes of conduct relating to research or requirements from your funding body (please note that for externally funded research, where the funding has been obtained via Anglia Ruskin University, a Project Risk Assessment must have been carried out prior to starting the research).
- Completing a Risk Assessment (Health and Safety) if required and updating this annually or if any aspects of your study change which affect this.
- Notifying the SREP Secretary when your study has ended.

Please also note that your research may be subject to monitoring.

Should you have any queries, please do not hesitate to contact me. May I wish you the best of luck with your research.

Yours sincerely,
Naowarat Lewis

SREP Chair

Agnieszka Kucharska
School Administration Co-ordinator

Appendix 10 – Participant Information Sheet

The Research Project

Title of project: Exploring CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing: Evidence from UK SMEs

Purpose of study

This research aims to explore the phenomenon of CEOs decision making to finance their SMEs business operations by using alternative sources of funding options; how their financing decisions are influenced by their leadership qualities, age, gender, professional networking, values, organisation structure, culture, governance, and government policies, which ultimately impacts on SMEs performance. By participating this interview, you are helping the researcher to unveil unexplored realities of your Fintech decision making e.g. the acceptance of crowdfunding, P2P or cryptocurrency for the SMEs performance. This will also create a platform for other SMEs, decision makers, policy makers and future researchers to learn from you and further strengthen Fintech financing in the UK.

Research Team:

Arsalan Iqbal Postgraduate Researcher Faculty of Business and Law Anglia Ruskin University	Dr Ying Wang Senior Lecturer in Finance Faculty of Business and Law Anglia Ruskin University
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1. Do I have to take part?

The interview will last up to 50 minutes via online platform. Participation is voluntary. The participants can refuse to take part without giving a reason. The participant can leave the study at any time, even after consenting to take part by emailing mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk

2. Has the study got ethical approval?

This study has received ethics approval by the School Research Ethics Panel (SREP) and ratified by the Faculty Research Ethics Panel under the terms of Anglia Ruskin University's Policy and Code of Practice for the Conduct of Research with Human Participants.

3. Legislation relating to this study

This research will comply with the Data Protection Act 2018. The records from this study will be treated and kept as confidential. Only the research team will have access to the files and any audio recording. No data will be used to personally identify any person or organisation.

4. What will happen to the results of the study?

The fully anonymised response will be used in the project report in aggregated formats. It is anticipated that the findings of this study might result in articles, books, industry reports and peer-reviewed journal papers. These publications will not disclose any personal or organisation identification information. The anonymised derived data and findings of this study could be further utilised in the other studies.

PARTICIPANT CONSENT FORM

Project Name: Exploring CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing: Evidence from UK SMEs

Main researcher and contact detail:

Arsalan Iqbal (mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk)

Members of the research team:

Dr Ying Wang (Ying.Wang@anglia.ac.uk)

1. I agree to take part in the above research. I have read the Participant Information Sheet that has been provided. I understand what my role will be in this research, and all my questions have been answered to my satisfaction.
2. I understand that I am free to withdraw from the research, for any reason and without prejudice. I understand that due to the nature of the interview discussion that it is not possible to withdraw my data after taking part.
3. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded, and I consent for my participation to be audio/video recorded.
4. I am free to ask any questions at any time before and during the study.
5. I have been provided with a copy of this form and the Participant Information Sheet upon request.

Data Protection: I agree to the University's processing personal data which I have supplied. I agree to the processing of such data for any purposes connected with the Research Project as outlined to me.

This study has received ethics approval by the School Research Ethics Panel (SREP) and ratified by the Faculty Research Ethics Panel under the terms of Anglia Ruskin University's Policy and Code of Practice for the Conduct of Research with Human Participants.

Please complete the following information, sign and return the consent form electronically to the research team via mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk if you agree with the above.

To help the project team prepare for the interview, please delete irrelevant information in the following form:

Your Name	
Gender	Male Female Prefer Not to disclose
Age Group	18-35 36-55 56+
Education Level	High School Certificate A Level or Equivalent Undergraduate (Level 4-6) Postgraduate Taught (Level 7) Doctorate (Level 8) Others – Vocational skills related training
Experience within the Industry	1-3 Years 4-5 Years 6-10 Years 11-20 Years 20+ Years
Experience as a CEO / Senior Officer	1-3 Years 4-5 Years 6-10 Years 11-20 Years 20+ Years
To what extent you were informed about Fintech?	None Little Some A lot
What experience have you had of trying to use Fintech finance	None Little Some A lot
Company Details	
Sector	Manufacturing Construction Trade Property / Accommodation Health and Social Care Education Hospitality and Leisure Art, Entertainment and Media Retail / Wholesales Professional services (including consultancy) Personal services (beauty and wellness etc.) Others – specify below
Location	South East London North West

	East of England West Midland South West Yorkshire and the Humber East Midland North East Not Applicable
Did your company use Fintech finance before?	Yes No
Number of Employees	1-10 11-50 51-250
Turnover range	Under £50000 £51000 - £85000 £86000 - £500,000 Above £500,000 – below £50 Million
Number of Directors/Senior officer in the company?	
How many years has your company been trading?	
Do you have a board or similar governing body?	
Number of people in the governing body or the board to make collective decision?	

Name (please print): _____

Signature (type name): _____ Date: / /

I WISH TO WITHDRAW FROM THIS STUDY.

If you wish to withdraw from the research, please speak to the researcher or email them at mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk stating the title of the research or send them this withdrawal slip.

You do not have to give a reason for why you would like to withdraw.

Please let the researcher know whether or not you are happy for data that has been collected up to this point to still be used. You are completely free to ask for any data to also be removed should you wish it to be, as long as the data is not anonymised. When data is anonymised, it means personal data relating to it has been permanently removed, so the researcher will not know which belongs to you.

Participant Debrief Form

Project Name: Exploring CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing: Evidence from UK SMEs

Thank you for participating in this study.

If taking part in this study has caused you to feel distressed or worried, then please make use of these support services below.

Samaritans Freephone 116 123

Citizens advice bureau advice line 03444 111 444

Thank you once again for your time in completing this study. Please contact mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk if you have any further questions about the research.

This study has received ethics approval by the School Research Ethics Panel (SREP) and ratified by the Faculty Research Ethics Panel under the terms of Anglia Ruskin University's Policy and Code of Practice for the Conduct of Research with Human Participants.

Date 17 September 2019
V1.15

Appendix 11 – Invitation Letter to Participant (Email – Correspondence Example)

Email - Iqbal, Arsalan (Postgraduate Researcher) - Outlook

Interview invitation

Iqbal, Arsalan (Postgraduate Researcher) <MAI149@pgr.aru.ac.uk>

Mon 22/03/2021 22:46

To: [REDACTED]
Cc: Wang, Ying <Ying.Wang@aru.ac.uk>

1 attachments (101 KB)

Participant Information Sheet_FinTech.docx

Dear [REDACTED],

Thank you for reading this email.

I am a postgraduate researcher at Anglia Ruskin University, Cambridge Campus. Currently, I am working on a research project with Dr Ying Wang, exploring the CEOs' impact on UK SME Financing using FinTech, such as crowdfunding, P2P and cryptocurrency.

This research supports innovation in Finance with a focus on SMEs in the UK. The findings will be useful for policymakers to help businesses and are equally beneficial to SMEs to finance their business operations in this credit slump period through Fintech financing.

To make an insightful recommendation to the policymakers, I would like to invite you for an interview as a participant and if you can make it on **25th March 2021 at 12:00**, please.

The interview will last for 50-minutes via the zoom platform. The participant information sheet is attached. I'll be very grateful if you can complete and return the attached form at any time before the interview.

I would also like to draw your attention that the University's ethical committee has approved this research within the highest ethical standards. All information will be maintained as confidential information and the CEO privacy before, during and after the research study.

Should you require more information, please contact me via mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk.

Arsalan Iqbal | PhD researcher
Faculty of Business and Law, ARU, East Road, Cambridge, CB1 1PT
T: 07401111611 | E: mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk
W: www.aru.ac.uk

ARU Cambridge | ARU Chelmsford | ARU London | ARU Peterborough

Appendix 12 – Gatekeeper Letter

Dear Sir/Madam,

I am a postgraduate researcher at Anglia Ruskin University, Cambridge Campus. Currently, I am working on a research project with Dr Ying Wang, exploring CEOs' decision making in Fintech Financing: Evidence from UK SMEs.

This research supports innovation in Finance with a focus on SMEs in the UK. The findings will be useful for policymakers to help businesses and is equally beneficial to SMEs to finance their business operations in this credit slump period through Fintech financing.

To make insightful recommendation to the policy makers, I would like to invite the CEO in your company to participate in this research so we can understand what influence his/her leadership and decisions for Fintech financing. If possible, please let me know his/her availability for a 50-minute interview via an online platform.

I would also like to draw your attention that the University's ethical committee has approved this research within the highest ethical standards. All information will be maintained as confidential information and the CEO privacy before, during and after the research study. If you require more information, please contact me via mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk.

I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Kind regards,

Arsalan

Arsalan Iqbal | PhD researcher

Faculty of Business and Law, ARU, East Road, Cambridge, CB1 1PT

T: | E: mai149@pgr.aru.ac.uk

aru.ac.uk

ARU Cambridge | ARU Chelmsford | ARU London | ARU Peterborough